practise makes perfect

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practise makes perfect

by arlelynx

Summary

“Teach me how to kiss.”

Mydei’s jaw drops.

“It's a win-win, right? You get to… I dunno, yell at me when I mess something up - which, let’s be honest, you *love* doing - don’t even try to deny it,” Mydei sneers but stays silent, which Phainon takes as a victory. “And as a cheeky bonus,” He continues, throwing in a wink as he puffs up his chest and puts his hands on his hips. “You get to make out with one of the top three most handsome guys on campus… *me*!”

Mydei stares at him, wearing an expression so twisted Phainon could’ve mistaken it as him finding out he’d stepped in a pile of shit.

Chapter 1: chapter one

Chapter Notes

> the most ironic thing about this is that i'm an asexual lesbian who DESPISES kissing irl. i also hate writing kiss scenes, they're the bane of my existence. yet, somehow, i'm here... writing a KISSING FIC????? phaidei really has taken over me huh. but because of this, i'm not entirely sure if this is any good HAHA i was working with vibes only...
>
> anyway, happy reading everyone! unbeta'd but haphazardly edited by me, so there will probably be some mistakes.
>
> p.s thank you to midnight for putting the idea of rugby player mydei and football player phainon into my head
>
> enjoy (´▽`ʃ♡ƪ)
>
> -
>
> This fic is now being translated into Russian!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Phainon slouches on the sofa, his legs stretched out over the coffee table, attention flickering between the sappy romance film playing on the screen and the almost empty bowl of popcorn on his lap. He *knew* he should've made more before they started - Mydei always says he won't touch it because it's 'too sweet', but within minutes of their film starting he's already rifling around the bowl for a handful. Phainon's gotten used to it by now, secretly microwaving two packets of popcorn instead of one. However, this time he'd only had a single bag left in the cupboard. He should've gone ahead and bit the bullet and run down to the corner shop to pick up some more to avoid this predicament. Alas, he assumed that tonight might go differently in regards to the popcorn theft.

He glances at Mydei out of the corner of his eye, watching as he munches away on the stolen popcorn, wholly focused on the screen where the couple are practically devouring each other, literal explosions of fireworks going off and spinning camera zoom-ins surrounding them. Phainon snorts at how dramatic it is, scooping up the last few kernels to chew on to give himself something to do. It doesn't help the sneer on his face, but at least he got the final bits of popcorn and not Mydei.

"They're acting like they're drunk off it," Phainon mutters, gesturing to the television where they're *still* kissing. It must've been at least 5 minutes by now. "Kissing can't be that good."

Mydei looks at him then, eyes narrowing slightly. The soft light from the screen flickers over his face, casting dark shadows across his features that only make them more prominent: his sharp eyebrows, the slope of his nose, and the way his bottom lip is thicker than the top one all standout, catching Phainon's attention more than the film ever did. Mydei reaches out for the popcorn bowl, scowling when he finds it empty. Phainon snickers, leaning forward to place it on the coffee table.

"Have you never kissed anyone before?" Mydei asks, his voice deep but casual, although there's a hint of curiosity to it that makes Phainon feel a bit weird.

Phainon's shoulders hunch inwards at the question, the warmth of embarrassment creeping up his neck. He's not sure why it feels like a challenge, but it does.

He and Mydei are friends - *best friends*, actually, something Phainon has proudly declared to anyone who will listen. But this? Talking about kissing? That's never come up before. Their conversations usually stick to familiar ground: household chores, their classes, and sports, mostly. For Mydei, it's rugby. He's on the university's team, always parading around in their uniform which consists of a skin-tight t-shirt and a tiny pair of shorts. For Phainon, his passion is football, the sport that gets him excited in a way nothing else can. Well, maybe except when Mydei offers to bake sweet treats for a change. That's pretty exciting because he loves Mydei's baking as well as his cooking.

They clash over their favourite sports all the time, each one firmly convinced that theirs is superior. The debates are long and loud, often ending in teasing jabs and a mutual agreement to disagree. It's never about winning, not anymore, especially considering there's no real way to prove one sport is better than the other when each one has its own set of rules and charm. It's simply a part of their friendship, the banter keeping things easy and comfortable between them.

If they're not debating sports, their conversations turn to other random things like life in general. Nothing too deep, but enough to pass the time and keep the space between them alive with chatter. They've been roommates now for almost a year, having decided to share a flat to save on rent. The arrangement was meant to be nothing but practical at first, yet it somehow worked out better than either of them expected. They split everything 50/50: the bills, the chores, and the shopping. It's a simple yet fair system that's kept them both content and avoids any arguing over who does what.

They’ve fallen into a rhythm over time, their lives weaving around each other in a way that feels practically effortless. There’s an unspoken understanding between them - who’s better at cooking, who’s more likely to leave clothes on the floor, and who remembers to take out the rubbish. It’s the little things, the small routines, that make it easy. Mydei’s always the one who remembers to pick up more eggs right before they run out, and Phainon’s the one who makes sure the lights are all turned off and the front door is locked at night.

In many ways, it’s comforting. There’s a quiet sort of security in knowing the person you’re living with is someone who gets you - someone who’s seen you in the pits of heavy workloads and deadlines and still sticks around. Phainon’s never had a roommate before, always bunking on his own in student accommodation until he had no choice but to leave, and having Mydei hovering around in his stratosphere feels undeniably… *right*. There’s no pretence, no pressure to be anyone but himself. He doesn’t have to explain things or hold up a façade, Mydei always seems to know.

This is why he can’t help but answer Mydei’s question truthfully, sticking his nose in the air and sniffing haughtily. “No, I haven’t.” He pauses, a thought rolling into his brain like a tumbleweed. “Wait, have you kissed anyone before?”

Mydei stares at him blankly before turning back to the television. Phainon whines petulantly at the dismissal, digging his elbow into Mydei’s side to get his attention back, “C’mon, spill the beans! Who have you kissed?!”

“Stop it!” Mydei exclaims, smacking Phainon’s arm. It doesn’t stop him, he only elbows him more, leaning over into Mydei’s space to shove him up against the far end of the sofa.

“Tell me!” Phainon rakes his fingernails across Mydei’s abdomen over his thin tank top, tickling him mercilessly. He watches with glee as Mydei’s legs kick out, his whole body jerking at the touch. Phainon’s laughter rings out evilly, delighted by the way Mydei wriggles beneath him.

“You are -” Mydei cuts off, his voice strained as he tries to squirm away, futilely shoving him off and sticking his hand in Phainon’s face to get him to stop. That only makes him laugh harder, the sound drowning out the film still playing on the television. “- So fucking annoying!” Mydei twists his body away from Phainon, swivelling around on the cushion, leaning back against the arm of the sofa and bringing both legs up to his chest to defend himself. “I’ve only kissed one person before. There, happy?” He finishes by clicking his tongue in annoyance.

Phainon’s laughter halts abruptly, the sound catching in his throat. The atmosphere between them thickens, the words that had seemed so casual falling into silence without Phainon to catch them. Phainon blinks, his thoughts grinding to a sudden stop. His chest tightens, stomach flipping uncontrollably, as the meaning of Mydei’s words begin to sink in.

For a second, it feels like the room tilts slightly with the weight of this new knowledge. The rush of emotions is instant, although unexpected and heavy. His pulse quickens, a sharp pang hitting him somewhere deep inside. It’s not that he’s jealous, right? No, *no*, it’s not jealousy. It’s something else - something that catches him off guard. He hadn’t even considered the possibility that Mydei had kissed anyone before, and now that it’s out there, looming over him like a dark cloud, the thought is truly unsettling.

Phainon’s throat tightens as he searches Mydei’s face, looking for some sort of clue, something beyond the offhand comment. But Mydei’s expression is nothing more than an arched eyebrow at his sudden silence. It’s true then, a fact: Mydei has kissed someone. Phainon’s mind races, his thoughts scattering. He wants to ask more. He wants to know who it was, how it happened, and what it was like. He wants to know everything about it. However, the words won’t come out, building and building yet somehow not threatening to spill over.

Instead, thorns form over his heart, ugly and prickly. “Seriously?” Phainon says flatly before he can stop himself. “Who was it?”

Mydei glares at him sceptically, clearly still on guard. “Someone from the arts department. I don’t know, I didn’t get his name.”

“*His*?” Phainon repeats.

Mydei looks at him like he’s stupid. Maybe he is because he feels like it. “...Please don’t tell me you’ve not known I’ve been gay this whole time.”

“No, no!” Phainon waves his hands in the air, “I mean, I didn’t *know* exactly, but I guessed. I’m bi, so, like,” He points his index finger at himself before directing it at Mydei, “I get you.”

“You really are stupid,” Mydei confirms Phainon’s thoughts under his breath, finally relaxing his posture to sit upright on the sofa again. “Who have *you* kissed?”

“I told you, no one,” Phainon replies.

“I thought you were lying,” Mydei says, looking at him like he’s a strange specimen underneath a telescope.

Phainon scrunches his face up in confusion, “Why would I lie about that?”

Mydei shrugs, crossing his arms over his chest, “You seem the type to be… *proficient* in that area.”

Phainon gasps dramatically, placing a hand over his heart. “Are you calling me a playboy, Mydeimos?”

A cushion is thrown at his face, bouncing off and landing on the floor. “Be quiet and watch the film.”

“Aye, aye, Captain,” Phainon salutes and turns around to watch the screen.

He has no idea what’s going on anymore. They seem to be at a rave, bodies packed into a small space as they all jump up and down in lieu of dancing. It’s a mess; loud, booming EDM music coming through their cheap speakers as the two main characters are lost within the crowd, completely

consumed in each other as they sway side to side with their arms wrapped around the other.

Phainon tries to concentrate, he really does, but it proves futile when every second that passes he can't help but look at Mydei as subtly as he can.

"I can feel you staring," Mydei declares curtly.

"Sorry," Phainon immediately replies. "I just…"

Mydei sighs and grabs the remote control off the coffee table, hitting pause. He chucks it back onto the surface and turns to face Phainon, one leg tucked up underneath him. "Just what?"

Having Mydei's full attention on him while he's still floundering for something to ground himself with feels far too much. Mydei's amber gaze is unwavering, patient as he watches him, almost like he's waiting for Phainon to catch up. Those eyes, always so brazen, so steady, make Phainon feel both exposed and safe. Mydei's always been like that - quick to irritate at first, always ready with a snappy remark, but beneath that sharpness, there's an endless pool of calm and tolerance. Phainon feels it now, like a lulling current beneath the surface of the room. It's unsettling, this quiet patience he isn't sure he deserves considering how twisted up he feels over Mydei having kissed someone (someone that isn't *him*, his brain unhelpfully supplies).

Even worse, Mydei doesn't scoff at his silence. He doesn't throw out a cutting comment and walk away, leaving Phainon to stew in his confusion. Instead, he waits. No judgement. No rush. Just that solid presence, the quiet expectation that Phainon will eventually find his way through in his own time. And for the first time, Phainon's not sure whether to be grateful for that or be completely terrified by it.

Phainon shrugs, "Was it good?"

"The kiss?" Mydei asks, humming when Phainon nods. "It was… fine."

"*Fine*? That's it?" Phainon scoffs, offended on Mydei's behalf that his first kiss could only qualify as a measly *fine*. "I bet I could do better than him."

"Do better… at kissing me?" Mydei questions, speaking each word very slowly.

Phainon bristles, speaking before he can fully process the weight and meaning of his words: "Of course, I can!"

"Phainon, do you realise what you're suggesting here?" Mydei sighs audibly, looking as though he's dealing with a small child.

The frail beginnings of an impending roaring fire begin to burn in his chest, each word a spark, each breath coming a little quicker as his mind spirals

into chaos. Phainon feels the heat spread from his chest down to his fingertips, his hands suddenly clammy, slick with the sweat of how his words came out. He could say no. He could back out right now. He knows Mydei wouldn't push him, wouldn't make him go through anything he didn't want to. If anything, considering how absurd this whole thing is - the topic of kissing suddenly morphing into *them* kissing - it'd be easy to laugh it off, change the subject and move on. Phainon hasn't made a complete fool out of himself quite yet.

But then the thought of some faceless man - someone who's *kissed* Mydei, held him, touched him - bursts into his mind uninvited, and the sense of control evaporates in an instant. A hot wave of jealousy (because that's what this is, pure, unadulterated jealousy) crashes through him, swift and blinding. The idea of anyone else having that privilege of being so close to Mydei in a way that Phainon's never experienced but so desperately wants drives something primal deep within him wild. His chest tightens with each inhale, his throat constricting as the thought eats at him, bitter and sour.

Everything so simple a moment ago, the casual challenge and banter, suddenly feels like a thousand-tonne weight on his shoulders. All the words he thought he could say, all the reasons to step back, vanish into thin air. He can't stop picturing it - Mydei, crowded into some dark corner of a dingy house party, lips on someone else, that someone else touching him the way Phainon has never even allowed himself to think about in fear of crashing and burning like he is right now.

There's no turning back now. No more playing it cool and shrugging it off. His body tenses, aware of how little space there is between them. Mydei's knee is pressed into his thigh, the heat of his body radiating enough that it fractures the ice surrounding Phainon's muscles. He breathes out as much tension as he can, allowing his body to relax, his hands flexing with how

stiff he’d been holding them until he feels nice and loose, able to move again without locking up.

He’s not only jealous - he’s furious. Furious at the thought of someone else being in Mydei’s orbit like that and only leaving it classified as *fine*. That means it was forgettable and replaceable. The mere idea makes his blood boil. Mydei deserves more than that. He deserves someone who *sees* him - someone who truly wants him and makes it known, someone who will do better than ‘fine’.

Someone like him, someone like Phainon.

Phainon finally nods, quick and confident. “Yeah. To kiss you.” He scoffs, adding: “And to do it better than that idiot did.”

Mydei’s eyes narrow even further, turning into slits that barely show the bright colour of his eyes. Phainon can’t read him, and he can’t tell if he’s pissed off, amused or something else along those lines.

“You’re serious, aren’t you?”

Phainon meets his gaze head-on, refusing to look away and back down. If he does, then he might be letting his only chance slip away right through his fingers.

“I’m serious. I could do better. I *know* I could.”

The air between them turns electric, crackling with an unfamiliar tension.

Mydei tilts his head to the side slightly, studying Phainon with a mix of curiosity and wariness. “And why exactly do you think you could do better? You’ve not even kissed anyone before.”

Phainon opens his mouth to reply, but the words get trapped in his throat. *Can* he do better? He doesn’t have a choice anymore, too deeply entrenched in this back and forth, with his pride and word on the line.

He swallows hard, his throat clicking audibly in the silence. “I dunno… I just do.”

For a moment, Mydei doesn’t speak. The silence stretches thick and taut like they’re standing on the precipice of something neither of them is quite ready for. Phainon thinks he’s well and truly fucked everything up, and he’s ready to make a break for it, run into his bedroom and slam the door shut. Then, with a slow, deliberate movement, Mydei shuffles closer, resting his arm on the back of the sofa as he leans forward.

“Alright, Phainon,” Mydei begins, his voice low and steady, paired with a smirk laced with something dangerous. “Prove it. Kiss me.”

Phainon’s breath hitches, his entire body freezing. Mydei’s words settle over him like a dare he’s desperate to accept without thinking of the consequences. As the distance between them narrows, Phainon realises that whatever happens next, things are about to change - whether he’s ready for it or not. His bravado is still there - somewhere buried deep down - but it wavers, flickering like a candle threatened by a sudden gust of wind. Mydei is watching him too closely now, too knowing, eyes gleaming in the dim lighting of their living room.

He won’t back down, he *won’t*. Phainon readjusts himself, straightening his spine as he tries to remember how to breathe.

“Fine,” Phainon says, voice a little rougher than usual.

He’s already stumbling at the first step. He doesn’t know what to do with his hands. Should he place them on Mydei’s shoulders? Cup his face? Or would that be too much too quickly - too familiar, too intimate? Maybe he should keep them to himself, after all, let them rest limply in his lap or clench them into fists. But then in turn, would that be too little, too hesitant? This is about *proving* something - proving *himself*. It should be easy. It’s only a simple little kiss, right?

But it’s a kiss that has to be *better*. One that erases everything that Mydei’s first kiss had left behind. Phainon has an invisible person to catch up to and kick him out of the top spot, all so he can sit on that throne himself. Phainon’s not a child, and he’s certainly not naïve. He’s seen people kiss and make out before plenty of times, it’s just the fact that he hasn’t done it himself that’s the issue. The basics should be simple enough: put their lips together, move them in sync, and then pull back. That’s all it takes. Yet, it feels so much bigger than those three steps.

“Chickening out?” Mydei’s voice spears through his internal thoughts, shaking Phainon out of them.

“Nope, just thinking,” Phainon replies honestly.

Myde sighs through his nostrils, “If you take much longer, I’m going to leave.”

“No, wait! Hang on,” Phainon moves so he’s mirroring Mydei’s position - one leg tucked underneath him, and an arm slung over the back of the sofa for balance. Their kneecaps bump against each other, almost a little uncomfortably, but he won’t let that stop him now.

He’s ready.

Mydei doesn’t move, doesn’t so much as blink. He’s waiting; letting Phainon be the one to close the distance, to commit to whatever this is. It makes Phainon’s skin prickle with awareness, his stomach coiling tight as he realises he’s going to have to brace himself and dive straight into the deep end. Phainon breathes out sharply, his body thrumming with tension. Before he can think much more about it, he leans in.

The first brush of his lips against Mydei’s is barely there, tentative and gentle as if testing the weight of something fragile. Mydei doesn’t pull away, nor does he recoil in disgust. He just waits, holding his head still as

his warm breath fans against Phainon's face. It sparks something reckless inside of him, that gaping maw of desire he's kept locked up since they first met is *alive*, starving and hungry for more. Phainon pushes in further, angling his head slightly, slotting their noses and fitting their mouths together properly this time.

Mydei's lips are soft, warmer than he expected, and the space behind Phainon's navel twists and pulls sharply at how easily he sinks into the sensation. He realises his eyes are still open - staring blankly at Mydei's closed eyelids and blonde lashes, so with a slow exhale, Phainon allows his eyes to flutter shut, swept away in the oceanic waves calling him in. He's supposed to be proving a point, pulling out all the stops as fast as he can to one-up that art department guy, yet all he can think about is how much he still wants. He wants to press their chests together, to feel the heat from Mydei's body melt into his, to cup his cheeks and haul him in closer. Phainon doesn't know how to do that, though, doesn't know how to ask and how to *do*, so instead he loosens one of his fists on his lap and places it over Mydei's knee. It sets something off, a chain reaction: Mydei jumps, a tiny, minute action, and it's enough to make Phainon panic.

He goes to pull away - truly, he does. However, the thought of doing so when they've only barely begun makes him panic even more. His hands move by themselves, shooting out to frame Mydei's cheeks, the tips of his fingers burying in the roots of his hair, the gesture locking them in place as Phainon moves his lips against Mydei's. He has no idea what he's doing, if he's being too harsh or too hesitant, or if this even feels good when it's this chaste. Phainon's too scared to deepen it, and the mere idea of tasting inside Mydei's mouth makes him groan. It feels good for him, unbelievably so. Mydei's cheeks are blazing hot and full under his palms, and the wisps of hair he can feel are silky soft. It's made so much better because he's been wanting to kiss Mydei since they met in their first year of university when they were wide-eyed and still finding their footing in unknown territory, and now he finally is. The reasoning may be a bit skewed - Phainon had

always hoped he'd kiss Mydei after a grand declaration of mutually assured love, and not due to a stupid bet they've unofficially made.

To his delight, Mydei begins kissing him back, a delicate exchange of their lips moving against each other, ebbing and flowing softly. There's no burning fire igniting their pace, as in its place is something small, an ember that's only barely beginning to glow brightly in the night, fanned by their intermingling breaths. Phainon's stomach swoops, a weightless feeling making it as though he's drifting in midair rather than sitting down on their worn-out sofa.

Phainon loses himself in it, unsure of how much time has passed until he remembers that he needs to breathe to keep going, pulling back just enough to detach their lips in favour of putting their foreheads together, panting hotly against each other's mouths. Phainon opens his eyes, his sight slightly blurred as the dark turns into light, and the first thing he sees is the honeyed gaze of Mydei already looking at him. That - that *look* - is enough to make his fingers curl, fuelling the desire to go all in and thread them through Mydei's hair and rake his nails against his scalp to see how he reacts.

Before his thoughts can derail anymore, Mydei pulls back completely and becomes out of reach, leaving his hands holding onto nothing but air. Phainon immediately drops them, and he feels strangely bereft, empty from the inside out. His lips are still warm, tingling with activity, his heart thudding steadily against his ribcage. Mydei's eyes aren't on him anymore, cast to the side to look at the coffee table. Even in the low light coming from the television and lamps, Phainon can see how red Mydei's face is. His cheeks are flushed, even down to his neck and the sliver of collarbones he can see are lit up.

“How was that?” Phainon murmurs breathlessly.

Mydei glances at him out of the corner of his eye before quickly looking away again, “Satisfactory.”

“Sa- satisfactory?!” Phainon stutters, “Is that it? Does that rank higher than *fine* or lower?”

Mydei clears his throat, rolling his eyes and standing up from the sofa. Phainon lets out a garbled noise, sitting up properly as he flings his arms out to grab at Mydei’s wrist so he can’t move any further. He tugs at him, urging him closer until Mydei is standing right in front of him, legs wedged in between Phainon’s open thighs. Phainon rests his chin on Mydei’s stomach, looking up at him with what he hopes are big, imploring puppy dog eyes.

“Don’t run away from me,” Phainon pouts. “Was it really that bad? I’m sorry.”

Mydei bristles, flicking Phainon right between his eyebrows. He scowls but doesn’t let go of Mydei to rub at the sore spot.

“It… wasn’t bad,” Mydei replies gruffly.

“But it wasn’t good either?” Phainon fills in helplessly.

The sinking feeling in his chest is undeniable, heavy and aching as it bogs him down. The way he still wants to kiss Mydei breathless all over again - that's painfully real too, settling in his gut like a cruel reminder. But what lingers and what hurts the most is the *shame*. The bitter sting of not living up to his own bravado, of falling short when it really mattered. That's what cuts deepest; jagged and merciless, dragging violently through him as the realisation settles in: he wasted it. Phainon's one chance to show Mydei something *more*, and now it's gone. Not in flames, nor in a major disaster, but reduced down to *satisfactory*. He doesn't know what's worse - that he failed, or that his failure will probably be classed just as forgettable as Mydei's first kiss, an unmentionable thing.

"Hey," Mydei says gently, raking his fingers through Phainon's hair until they're settled at the base of his neck, encouraging him to look back up.

Phainon doesn't really want to. His eyes burn as he chews the inside of his cheek to stop anything else from coming out that could humiliate him anymore.

"Don't sulk," Mydei chides, tugging at Phainon's hair gently, "I need to go meal prep for tomorrow. Let go -"

A thought. A plan. A suggestion.

Phainon stares up at Mydei with a newfound determination, "Teach me," He cuts in.

“Teach you?” Mydei echoes, his brow creasing.

“Yeah,” Phainon lets go of Mydei, standing up so they’re face-to-face, entirely too close. Mydei blinks in shock, taking a step back. That doesn’t deter Phainon, he can’t allow it - not that now he’s got a *plan*. “Teach me how to kiss.”

Mydei’s jaw drops.

Phainon pats Mydei’s shoulders, nodding sagely as he speaks: “It’s a great idea! Since I suck at kissing, you can give me pointers. Then, when I get a partner, I’ll be prepared and won’t make a fool out of myself like now.”

Mydei’s jaw slams shut with an audible *clack* of his teeth.

“See, win-win, right? You get to… I dunno, yell at me when I mess something up - which, let’s be honest, you *love* doing - don’t even try to deny it,” Mydei sneers but stays silent, which Phainon takes as a victory. “And as a cheeky bonus,” He continues, throwing in a wink as he puffs up his chest and puts his hands on his hips. “You get to make out with one of the top three most handsome guys on campus… *me*!”

Mydei stares at him, wearing an expression so twisted Phainon could’ve mistaken it as him finding out he’d stepped in a pile of shit.

“You’re forgetting something,” Mydei begins, shoving Phainon hard enough to knock him back onto the sofa and take his peacocking away with it. “*You’d* be making out with the number one most handsome guy on campus.” He smirks down at him, triumphant. “*Me*.”

With that, Mydei turns on his heels and makes his way over to their kitchen. Phainon bounces up off the sofa, running after him to launch himself onto his back. Mydei instantly catches him, hooking his arms under his knees while Phainon wraps his arms around his neck to stay glued to him.

“Please, Mydeimos! It’s a great idea and you know it!” Phainon yells directly into Mydei’s ear, causing him to flinch and almost drop him.

“Stop yelling!” Mydei shouts, carrying a wriggling Phainon with him to the kitchen. “Why would I even want to kiss you again, huh?”

“Don’t be like that,” Phainon whines, burying his face into the nape of Mydei’s neck, and rubbing his forehead back and forth there. He completely wraps his legs around Mydei’s waist, securing himself like a limpet on his back. No amount of pushing or shoving or attempts to drop him will work now, much to his own delight. “Give me one more chance!”

“No,” Mydei says, dropping his grip underneath Phainon’s knees to gradually waddle over to the fridge. “Now get off.”

“I’ll make a list, and I’ll have so many reasons on there that you’d be stupid to deny them,” Phainon replies excitedly, letting go of Mydei once the new idea springs to mind. Mydei glances at him over his shoulder, staring unimpressed at the finger now pointing at him. “Wait for me!”

It was all well and good telling Mydei to ‘wait for him’, but when confronted with a blank notebook situated on his desk days after their first kiss, reality sets in. He taps the tip of his pen rhythmically against the edge of the page as if that’ll magically make words appear on the paper and save him the trouble of battling against his heart and his brain.

His brain tells him to throw in the towel and let things lie. It’s no use coercing Mydei into this when it was made rather clear how little interest he had in continuing it. Since they kissed, neither of them had brought it back up, carrying on as usual. Normally, Mydei makes them protein shakes and bowls of porridge for breakfast, meal-preps their lunch and tosses something quick and easy together for dinner, which is exactly the routine he’d still been following since the incident. And, continuing with the normality, Phainon has been doing the dishes, putting everything away afterwards and wiping down the countertops to make sure they’re sparkling clean for when either of them wants to use the kitchen again. Their conversations have been laid back and general, going from chattering about the impending warmer weather the closer it gets to exam season, to how much they have to try to organise a get-together with the rest of their friendship group while simultaneously not doing anything to sort that out.

On the other hand, his heart is telling him a whole different story. Mydei hasn’t pushed him away or avoided him, hasn’t alluded to how much he might’ve hated their kiss, nor outright told him not to bother trying to

convince him otherwise. It makes something small and fragile buried deep within him want to bud into something that flourishes and blooms under the right conditions - like sunlight through a half-drawn curtain, slow and gentle but persistent enough to warm everything it touches - which is just like how Mydei treats him.

Phainon clings to that hope, as delicate as it is. He doesn't have a concrete plan, no grand gesture up his sleeve, but maybe - just maybe - this list is a start. A way to say the things he's too much of a coward to voice aloud. A way to bridge the terrifying distance between *wanting* and *asking*.

He stares at the page again, then finally puts his pen to paper with more certainty than before. It doesn't need to be perfect, it only needs to be honest.

Phainon starts with a title: *Reasons We Should Practise Kissing*. He underlines it twice, once in blue ink and the second in red ink. He thinks it adds a nice touch and dramatic flair, if nothing else. The moment he reads it back though, he wants to tear the whole thing out and burn it. It looks like something a teenager would scribble in secret at the back of their maths book, not something a twenty-three-year-old man writes for his best friend - especially the best friend he's been pining over for the past two years - and who coincidentally shares a flat with. A best friend who's seen him at his lowest, at his best and his worst, who knows exactly how he likes his tea, and yet has somehow never realised that Phainon is quietly and irrevocably in love with him.

Phainon presses the pen to the page again, then scrawls the line: *We've already started, so we might as well keep going. We're not the type to quit.* Is that too casual sounding though? He supposes it's best to remain like

that, detached and holding this situation at arm's length, but the thought of even potentially treating this as a situation where he comes across as not caring about Mydei doesn't sit well with him. With a few scribbles, he's blacked the entire thing out.

Underneath, he writes: *You looked like you enjoyed it*. That one doesn't even last two seconds before he's furiously crossing it out again, heart pounding with second-hand embarrassment and the memories of their kiss flooding back in. Mydei *did* look like he enjoyed it, despite his less-than-raving review on the whole situation. Phainon nibbles at his bottom lip, gripping his pen tightly as he remembers how flushed and pretty Mydei looked when they pulled away, how much he seemed to lose himself in their kiss too, all the small sounds he made - not quite moans, not enough to be whines either - but tiny, inaudible breathy noises that he felt more than he heard. He also smelled incredible. Sweet and slightly musky; it's a scent Phainon's more than accustomed to after knowing Mydei hasn't changed the cologne he wears since they met. It's not the full-blown masculine profile like people would expect knowing Mydei at face value, but Phainon thinks the sweet undertones suit him best.

He physically shakes himself out of it, clearing his throat and focusing back on his notebook. The pen hovers uselessly over the paper while his thoughts spiral. Phainon still can't believe that his first kiss had been with Mydei, a fact that has completely unmoored him. It's been days and he still feels it like a phantom echo across his mouth and in his chest, catching himself thinking about it and tracing the pad of his finger across his lips as if that'll imitate the sensation once more at the worst times like when he's meant to be studying or waiting for the kettle to boil.

Letting the pen drop onto his desk, he leans back in the chair with a heavy sigh. Maybe this whole thing *is* ridiculous. Maybe it's already too far gone to salvage. But he also can't stand the idea of leaving things like that - of

letting that kiss be the start and end of whatever this could be between them. Phainon knows it'd tear him up, starting small at first like it's doing now, not enough to truly impact him past a few idle thoughts. Then, however, it'd get worse: it'd weigh him down, be the only thing he can think about until he's obsessing over it, picking it apart until there's nothing left. He doesn't want that at all. As much as he wants to kiss Mydei, he doesn't want to ruin what they already have. Yet the only way to fix this seems to continue - or at least get more closure than before about this whole idea.

If he can just get the words right and put them down on paper, maybe Mydei will kiss him again. Or maybe he'll well and truly cut Phainon's dream short. No matter which option, he wants to know.

With a deep breath, Phainon picks up his pen again and stares down the page like it's an opponent on the pitch. He's not been nicknamed *Deliverer* for no reason - it's all about the fact he can deliver the football to wherever it needs to be; whether it's to a teammate or scoring a goal. He'll 'deliver' this too, a plethora of ideas sprawled out across the paper, enough that Mydei will accept them all. His fingers twitch with uncertainty, but he forces them to move to form words and not anxiety. Overthinking is going to get him nowhere, only getting him stuck in a rut he can't get out of.

He writes slowly and as precisely as he can, forgoing his usual cursive to make the letters bold and individual.

Reason #1: Help me get better at kissing. Do you really want me to embarrass myself in front of future partners?

He pauses, chewing on the inside of his cheek. It’s light, almost jokey, but there’s a layer of honesty underneath that he hopes Mydei will take pity on him for. He doesn’t think their kiss was bad at all, far from it, but he’s definitely open to improving his technique until it’s something that Mydei will approve of. The mention of *other partners* makes him snort. He hasn’t looked twice at anyone else since meeting Mydei, no one even remotely catching his eye or tempting him. It feels impossible to consider anyone else: back then, now, or in the future, it’s always Mydei - but he has to keep at least a few cards of his deck close to his heart.

Reason #2: It didn’t feel weird. And since it didn’t feel weird (at least for me) then maybe that means we can keep going.

This reason feels riskier. He hesitates for a moment but chooses not to cross it out. Sometimes the only reason to keep doing something is because it feels good. That ideology leads to things - dangerous, harmful things that end in dire ways, and maybe this is Phainon’s version of that. However, it’s the truth, and if he’s going to actually offer this mess of a piece of paper over to Mydei, he has to commit to saying things that matter. He taps his pen again, eyes flicking across the lines. Something is grounding about it now, like each sentence helps him breathe a little steadier, the truths he’s been keeping hidden finally spawning into reality. For the first time in days, his thoughts start to organise themselves into something tangible.

Reason #3: I really want to kiss you again. I haven’t been able to stop thinking about ~~you~~ it.

The final full stop feels like a dare. Perhaps this reason is putting too much of himself on the plate, ready to be ripped apart. Phainon relaxes back into his chair despite that, staring at the page, heart racing. He knows the list

isn’t finished, but it’s a start. And right now, that’s enough to keep the fragile thing inside his chest - *hope*, or maybe another thing he can’t quite put a name to - from collapsing completely.

If nothing else, he’ll at least try and say these three things to Mydei.

The weekend finally arrives with a welcome break from the usual chaos of classes, football practice, and - best of all - finished coursework. For once, there’s nothing pressing to do. No deadlines hanging over him, no early alarms to ruin the mornings. Just a slow, lazy Saturday that seems to stretch on endlessly with the sun still high in the sky. Phainon enjoys spending time like this, sprawled across the sofa, laptop balanced haphazardly on his knee while a documentary plays on the television, completely ignored.

It’s nearly two in the afternoon when Mydei wanders into the living room, yawning widely like he’s had the best lie-in of his life. He’s still in his pyjamas - a baby tee stretched just enough across his chest to leave little to the imagination and a pair of joggers that sit low on his hips, the fabric rumpled from a long night of sleep. Mydei’s hair is a mess, the layers flick and stick up at odd angles, the ends wild and untamed. The portion that’s usually braided now falls loose and wavy slightly below his shoulder, still bearing the faint mark of the plait’s imprint. Phainon can’t help but smile, a fond grin tugging at the corners of his mouth as he watches Mydei shuffle across the room, looking like a drowsy kitten.

“Good morning, sleepyhead,” Phainon calls out, laughing when Mydei levels him with a bleary half-hearted glare.

Mydei scratches absentmindedly at the strip of bare skin between the hem of his t-shirt and the waistband of his joggers, “How long have you been awake for?”

“Since ten,” Phainon replies, eyes immediately locking onto the brief glimpse of Mydei’s happy trail before focusing back on his face.

He brings his legs up when Mydei flops down beside him and nudges his feet, wordlessly asking for more room. They settle in easily next to each other like they always do, except Phainon has the horrible urge to ruin the peace by uncovering his notebook and shoving it in Mydei’s face, forcing him to read it just so he doesn’t have to agonise over it anymore.

Phainon wriggles in his spot, restless. The incriminating notebook is still in his room, top drawer, placed carefully beneath a stack of old handouts in the hopes of avoiding the embarrassment of anyone somehow stumbling across it. He’s spent the whole week thinking about finally showing Mydei - or at least dropping a hint - that he wants to try kissing him again. Even if he can just manage to hand the damn thing over and leg it out of the flat to take cover from the impending humiliation, that’d be better than nothing.

Now that they’re alone, and now that a possible moment is actually here to reveal his plan… his heart feels like it’s going to explode out of his chest. He’s never had trouble talking to Mydei before, even when they first met and Mydei acted like he’d rather be anywhere else than around Phainon. It’d taken a lot of wooing, hard work and persistence to get where he is now, and he cherishes every moment he has of Mydei’s attention. But he’s still greedy and wants *more* in every form that he can obtain it. Yet with this

situation, he’s suddenly a coward who can barely meet Mydei’s eyes without wanting to dig himself into a hole.

They sit in silence for a bit, and Phainon offers Mydei the rest of his cup of tea to sip in hopes of helping wake him up as they watch the documentary. Phainon still has no idea what it’s about - something to do with penguins, he supposes, watching them waddle across the icy snow plains. The kind of quiet settled between them is usually comforting, one that Phainon revels in as he relaxes and feels their companionship, but today it has its edges that dig uncomfortably into his ribs.

Eventually, he closes his laptop lid and places it on the coffee table, standing up and stretching before he speaks.

“Be right back,” He mutters, just about catching Mydei’s answering grumble of approval before he hightails it back into his room.

Phainon storms over to his desk, yanking the top drawer open so forcefully it nearly falls out, and pulls the notebook from its hidden spot. He holds it with both hands, the weight of it feeling heavier than it should. His fingers hesitate on the cover, the edges slightly crinkled from where it’s been tucked away. Phainon stares at it for a long moment, the paper inside mocking him with its rawness splayed across the paper. It feels too personal, too real, like it’s a page from his diary and not a bullet-point list of reasons to kiss someone. His breathing hitches, fingers curling around the spiral spine like it might slip from his grip and disappear. Every word on those pages is stitched together with nerves and unspoken hopes - hopes that now he thinks about it, are far too exposing.

He flips the notebook open, rereading the bullet-points once more. He’s gone through them countless times over the past week, the words becoming familiar in their strangeness. Yet each time, they still unsettle him. The idea of showing it to Mydei, of letting him see this side of him, feels rather overwhelming.

What if he laughs? Phainon thinks, then shakes his head. Mydei wouldn’t do that - if anything, he’d get the thing handed back to him with nothing but a cold glare of disapproval.

What if he thinks I’m ridiculous? Is his next thought, but that is instantly squashed by the fact that Mydei *always* thinks he’s bordering on ridiculous. It’s what simultaneously made it so easy and hard to befriend him.

However, there are still doubts that creep in, suffocating his previous burst of confidence. He can’t help but think of what it would feel like to just hand it over and get it out in the open. Don’t ask, don’t get, and all that. With a reluctant sigh, he closes his drawer and leaves his bedroom, going back out into the living room.

Mydei isn’t where Phainon left him on the sofa. Instead, he’s standing at the kitchen sink, scrubbing at their blender with swift and practised movements, the sound of water splashing softly filling the quiet room. Two glass cups sit on the counter next to him, filled to the brim with a thick pink liquid. Phainon’s heart gives an uninvited flutter at the sight. It’s such a simple thing, but it always gets to him how Mydei always makes him a drink whenever he’s making one for himself. Whether it’s a protein shake, a cup of tea, or in this case, a fruit smoothie, Mydei always thinks to hand him the second cup, no questions asked.

Phainon stands frozen in the doorway, watching him. Mydei hasn't noticed him yet, still focused on scrubbing the last remnants of fruit out of the blender, his back to him. Phainon lets himself take this small moment - only a quick glance, really, he swears, to allow his eyes to trace over the way Mydei's muscles shift beneath his skin, the subtle flex of his shoulder blades moving with each motion. It's impossible not to notice how the tightness of his t-shirt accentuates the width of his shoulders, how his broad back tapers down to a mouthwateringly slim waist. The sight makes Phainon's chest tighten, his pulse quickening as he swallows down the sudden urge to reach out and place his hands over the curve of his hips.

He's always been aware of Mydei's body, but today, it feels like he's seeing him in a new light - how the edges of the tattoos on his torso peek just beneath the hem of his shirt, those sharp red patterns acting like they belong to a different version of him, one Phainon's still trying to figure out. Every inch of him pulls Phainon in, and he can't look away no matter how much he should.

He remains standing in the doorway, clutching onto his notebook like a lifeline as he watches Mydei go from washing to drying until he finally puts the blender away back in the cupboard. Phainon's caught between the warmth of the moment and the weight in his hands.

"Hey, Mydei…" Phainon says, his voice a little quieter than he intends. He's made very aware of how nervous he is, clear as day in his tone.

"What do you want?" Mydei replies bluntly, turning around to face him.

Phainon winces, even more demotivated to share his secrets. “Nevermind.” He’s a coward. A big, giant, massive *coward*. He spins around on the tiled flooring to leave and head back into his room, but Mydei’s voice brings him to a stop.

“Spit it out. You’ve been hovering around me for the last few days like a lost dog.”

Phainon laughs nervously, poorly covering up how shocked he is that Mydei had him clocked so far back. He thought he’d done a good job of hiding his feelings, but he guesses he wasn’t as slick as he thought. Phainon shouldn’t be too surprised - he and Mydei have spent the last two years basically attached at the hip, taking the same classes and living together, so if anyone knows him better than himself, it’s Mydei.

“It’s really nothing,” Phainon says, looking at Mydei again. He seems hesitant, eyebrows pinched and lips pursed in thought.

Mydei clicks his tongue, disposing of the towel in his hand behind him and rests against the lip of the countertop, crossing his arms over his chest. “Is this about the kissing thing?”

Phainon goes red, spluttering out a mixture of words and gasps.

Mydei huffs, “I knew it. You’ve been weird since then.” He jerks his chin towards Phainon, “Does that hold your grand plan on convincing me to help you out?”

“Wh -!” Phainon startles, looking down at his notebook as though it betrayed him. Its cover is closed though, and the writing that lays beneath is still hidden away.

“I thought the deal was off,” Mydei says when Phainon doesn’t offer anything else.

“Why?! I told you to wait for me!” Phainon hates how whiny and desperate he sounds, cringing internally.

“You were taking forever,” Mydei sighs and walks up to Phainon, plucking the notebook straight out of his hands with ease. He doesn’t even grace it with a second glance, chucking it onto their dining table and out of reach for the both of them. “I don’t need to hear whatever rubbish you’ve come up with to try and convince me.”

“Oh,” Phainon says simply, deflating. There it is, clean and simple, Mydei’s answer. He should’ve guessed that it would’ve been a resounding no, that Mydei truly did hate their kiss and wouldn’t want to do it again. Phainon feels totally, completely and utterly silly, and -

“Because I’ve already decided that I’m going to help you.”

Phainon immediately perks up again, thoughts screeching to a halt. His heart skips a beat, his entire body going still. His eyes widen, mouth hanging slightly open in disbelief. For a moment, he’s rooted to the spot, unable to move and barely able to breathe, his mind scrambling to catch up with what was said. Phainon thought he’d have to go through the entire list, nervously stammering through each point, exposing himself to ridicule and, most likely, a true blunt rejection. But this - this wasn’t what he expected at all.

It’s like a flip switches in his brain, his pulse quickening and rushing in his ears as he slowly begins to accept the fact that Mydei is actually agreeing. No questions, no hesitations - a simple acceptance of something Phainon thought would be impossible. He’d never imagined this would be how it went down; Mydei clearly having done some thinking of his own on this situation, enough to have an answer prepared when needed. It takes another second for that to register, and when it does, it sends a warm shock of excitement through Phainon’s chest.

His stomach flips with a mix of nerves and anticipation. Mydei’s willingness to help has to mean *something*, right? Surely he wouldn’t have agreed so quickly if he didn’t feel at least a little bit the same, or maybe Phainon is reading too much into it and it’s truly just a thing that ‘good bros’ do: help each other out in their times of need. Either way, he can’t help the beaming grin stretching across his face.

Phainon steels himself quickly, forcing his expression into something serious, “I would be honoured.”

Mydei huffs a laugh, “Finally got your courage back, Deliverer?” The mention of his football nickname sparks a *zing* through him, a storm of butterflies erupting in his belly. They feel tender and warm, their wings fluttering dangerously powerfully as they band together. “Don’t back down this time, alright?”

Phainon’s breath falters, sharp and unsteady. Without a second thought, he grabs Mydei by the shoulders, his fingers gripping tight, and pulls him in. There’s no hesitation now, no time for second-guessing. The moment stretches impossibly long, the air thick with anticipation as he feels the pressure of Mydei’s body against his. Their chests collide with a quiet thud, a jolt of surprise running through both of them. Mydei stumbles forward, caught off guard, and leans into him, his weight fully pressed against Phainon.

For a split second, it’s all awkwardness - the suddenness of the movement, the way their bodies don’t quite sync. Phainon can feel the heat of Mydei against him, his muscles working as he tries to regain his balance. It’s enough to rattle him, a sharp onslaught of adrenaline floods his veins, but he steadies himself, legs planted firmly as he absorbs the impact. The intensity of their closeness overwhelms him, transforming into a euphoric rush, and before Phainon can think any more, his lips are against Mydei’s.

The moment they connect, it’s like a shock of electricity courses through him, so intense it nearly steals all the oxygen from his lungs. He’s not prepared for the immediate intensity. His fingertips tingle, the heat that blooms between them acts as if every inch of his skin is awake and alive. His heart races wildly, his pulse pounding through him as Mydei’s hands come to rest on his hips to deepen the kiss, and then Phainon’s mind goes blissfully blank. All he knows is the softness of Mydei’s lips, so familiar and yet unfamiliar at the same time, the weight of his hands on him, and the

sensation of being so close. It’s dizzying, confusing and elating, and the world narrows down to this single point in time, shared only between them.

His hands, still gripping Mydei’s shoulders, tighten reflexively, anchoring himself to this moment, afraid that if he doesn’t, he might float away. He doesn’t want to let go, not just yet, not when Mydei is *kissing him*, holding onto him, meeting each press of his lips with equal vigour. Phainon sighs dreamily, relief washing over him, feeling everything slowly slot into place. It’s as slow as their first kiss was, a chaste exploration of the feeling of each other’s lips against their own. Phainon gets a little clumsy, his canine catching on Mydei’s plump bottom lip by accident. Instead of jolting away like he expected, Mydei makes a tiny sound. It’s quiet, but it’s there - a *moan*. For Phainon, because of Phainon. Suddenly, his knees feel weak enough to let him collapse onto the floor.

Phainon pulls away, staying close and using his grip on Mydei’s shoulders to move them, their feet stumbling over each other as they go backwards until Mydei hits the edge of the countertop. He doesn’t care if it digs in painfully, not when Phainon is rejoining their mouths together, groaning immediately as though he’d been starved of it. He squeezes his eyes shut until all he can see is a kaleidoscope of shapes and colours, all while flattening his palms against Mydei’s shoulders and dragging them down his biceps, gently scratching his nails along bare skin until they reach his elbows, cupping them. Phainon doesn’t think it can get any better until Mydei tilts his head just *so*, enough that their noses slot perfectly together, chests pressed tightly against each other, plastered from shoulder to thigh without an inch between them.

Fuck, it’s not enough. Phainon still doesn’t feel close enough, doesn’t feel like he’s kissing Mydei hard enough, doesn’t feel like this is really *it* - like he’s getting what he’s wanted for so long. Phainon feels himself changing, morphing and forming into something else, something that’s barely human.

A creature only made up of desperation and greed, a yearning for *more*, as much as he can possibly get.

His heart thunders in his chest so much that there's no way Mydei can't feel it. After all, he can feel Mydei's heartbeat echoing against his, quick and fast as though he's running a marathon. The heat of Mydei's skin seeps through their clothes, the thrum of his pulse beneath his fingertips, and it only makes Phainon crave more.

He wants to feel everything. Every inch, every breath, every gasp and every spark between them. So he takes, swiping his tongue against Mydei's lips, hoping and praying to be let in. Mydei shivers, and Phainon has to hold himself back from bending him all the way back over the counter, not caring if he knocks over their now room-temperature smoothies. In fact, he'd enjoy it, hearing the crashing of glass and the dripping of liquid onto the floor, making a mess of them both as he indulges in taking more and more of Mydei. Finally, Mydei opens his mouth, not too much, but it's enough for Phainon to lick straight in, tasting the freshness of toothpaste still lingering there and the sweetness of stolen strawberries tucked between his teeth. Phainon tastes it all, lavishing and caressing with each swipe of his tongue against Mydei's, choking down whines and accidentally letting moans be voiced.

It's not until Mydei's grip on his hips becomes bruising that he pulls back, their lips parting with a slick *pop*. They're both panting, chests heaving up and down, gulping down extra saliva as they gain their bearings again.

"Mydei -"

“Better,” Mydei says, the word rough and hoarse.

Phainon feels his stomach twist and bottom out, his eyes instantly drawn down to Mydei’s lips. They’re so *swollen*, red and wet. Wet from *his* saliva.

“Better than *fine*?” Phainon asks, because he has to. He has to know if he’s beaten that guy for the top spot.

Their foreheads touch, the tips of their noses brushing against each other, so close, drawn in even more by this magnetic force. Phainon swallows thickly, looking up through his eyelashes to catch Mydei’s gaze. But it’s elsewhere, further down, already staring at his lips, syrupy and honeyed.

“I’d rate it a C,” Mydei says, each word ghosting across his lips.

He’s right there. Still within Phainon’s grip, still within reach, merely atoms away, but Phainon won’t let himself take anymore.

Phainon laughs, dropping his grip on Mydei’s elbows and stepping backwards, the heat of the moment passing by as though it’d never been there in the first place. He feels vaguely nauseous, a sick feeling turning his stomach inside out at being so far away from Mydei, but he can’t let himself get swept up again so quickly.

“Only a C? Damn, I really need to step up my game,” Phainon scratches the back of his head to release some nervous energy. “You’ll have to think up some lessons for me, *Teacher Mydeimos*.”

“Don’t call me that,” Mydei snaps, although he’s so red in the face Phainon can hardly take him seriously.

“Sure thing, *teach*,” Phainon teases, easily dodging away from the swipe of Mydei’s hand coming towards him.

Mydei slumps against the countertop, pressing the heels of his palms against the edge of it as though it’s the only thing holding him up. “I made you a smoothie.”

It’s a sharp U-Turn from what they were just doing, but Phainon latches onto it, nodding happily as he gestures to the cups beside Mydei. “Strawberry flavour?”

“How did -” Mydei stops, face flushing an even deeper shade of red that practically matches the ends of his hair. He clears his throat, “Yes. Strawberry and raspberry.”

“Funny,” Phainon leans in, hands behind his back as he smirks. “I didn’t get a hint of raspberry from you.”

“Run now or you’ll get a fist in your face.”

“Kinky!” Phainon laughs loudly, ignoring the warning as he reaches out to grab the glass, taking a swig of it while keeping his eyes locked with Mydei's.

It tastes good, but not as good as Mydei does.

Chapter End Notes

leave a comment and/or kudos if you enjoyed! thank you so much!!! each comment truly makes my day and motivates me to write more

i have the rest of this fic vaguely plotted out, so i need all the encouragement i can get to make me finish it :") lol

-

let's be friends on twitter/x!

Chapter 2: chapter two

Chapter Summary

> “I made a list,” Phainon declares, loud enough so that there’s no chance of Mydei not hearing.
>
> Mydei hears, going by the way he splutters into his tea, looking up at Phainon in surprise. “Another one?” He asks incredulously. “What is it with you and lists?”

Chapter Notes

> yayay chapter 2 is here! thank you so much for the incredible amount of love i got on chapter 1 and on twitter, my heart is so full ♀
>
> there is no set amount of chapters for this fic anymore as i have so many more ideas for these two that wouldn't fit into the original 3 chapter slots! all this means is more content of phaidei being stupid and in love and lots more kissing ψ(` ∇ ´)ψ
>
> thanks especially to midnight for reading over the draft, and to sinn for hyping me up in general ily both loads MWAH
>
> happy reading everyone! haphazardly edited by me, so there will probably be some mistakes. sorry about that!
>
> enjoy (´▽`ʃ♡ƪ)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Phainon finishes his smoothie, drawing out each sip like it might buy him more time to get a handle on the way he’s feeling. Across from him, Mydei’s doing the same - drinking slowly, deliberately, eyes flicking up every now and then only to dart away when their gazes caught. They’re still in the kitchen, standing opposite each other with the dining table acting as a neutral zone between them. The silence stretches, not uncomfortable

exactly, but definitely not easy either. It’s taut, held in place by something Phainon doesn’t want to name, something that still hums in the air they breathe.

Phainon can feel it - the way the oxygen seems to thrum with the weight of everything that’s just transpired. His shoulders are stiff, and his grip on the glass is too tight, like if he focuses hard enough on not reacting and showing no signs of being affected, the moment might pass. But it doesn’t. The silence doesn’t bridge the gap between them, nor does it offer any peace. It lingers, thick and unmoving, a line drawn straight down the centre of the room that Phainon doesn’t dare try to breach. He’s caught standing on his side of the kitchen, aching to cross over it and too afraid to be the first one to step over.

His pulse is still drumming underneath his skin, an itch he can’t scratch. There’s more swirling beneath, pooling low in his gut that he can’t seem to put a stop to. Phainon takes the final swallow of his smoothie, the sweetness turning to ash and tasting nothing like Mydei did when they kissed and wipes his mouth with the back of his hand before putting the glass in the sink.

“Thanks, Mydei,” Phainon says, offering him a smile. It’s the least he can do, and the most he can think of to announce his departure.

The smile is not returned. He didn’t expect it to be - it rarely is - and he gets an eye roll in place of one. It’s just as good, making him smile brighter as he walks out of the kitchen, beelining straight to his bedroom. He closes the door softly behind him, flipping the lock on as he slumps against the wood, smile immediately dropping. Phainon stares out across his bedroom blankly, not even sure if he’s truly seeing anything or if he’s blinking as the only

thing he’s aware of is how diabolically *hard* he is. Even watching Mydei drink his smoothie had been enough to set him off, admiring the way his Adam’s apple bobbed up and down with each gulp. All Phainon could think about was licking a stripe up and over it, feeling it move underneath his tongue.

He exhales shakily, steepling his fingers as he rests his forehead on the tips. Phainon closes his eyes, willing for his erection to go down already. The only reason he didn’t run away immediately after their kiss was because the hoodie he’s wearing goes down to mid-thigh, enough to cover up the problem area. Now, though, alone in his room with the taste of strawberries and mint clogging up his senses and the feeling of Mydei’s strong body against his, it’s hard not to fall into the temptation of slipping his hand underneath the waistband of his shorts.

Phainon thinks. *Really* thinks, this time. If he does this, if he touches himself while still high off the feeling of Mydei’s lips and tongue, then there is no going back. Kissing is one thing - that can surely stay strictly platonic, but this? This is completely different. Phainon bites his bottom lip, noticing it’s slightly swollen, and groans low in his throat, his hand already moving to dip into his waistband, aiming straight for his cock.

The first touch is like lightning, his thighs twitching as his fingers tentatively wrap around his length, thumbing at the wet tip. He’s barely even touched himself and he can feel more precum spurting out, dampening his fingers as he shimmies his shorts and boxers down to catch around his knees. He stuffs the hem of his loose hoodie into his armpits, tensing his biceps to stop it from falling back down. It gives him more room to work without the fear of ruining his clothes as he drags his fist down his cock, smearing the clear liquid across his foreskin. His heart jackhammers in his chest, belly concaving and expanding with how deeply he’s breathing. Phainon tries to keep quiet, he has to - he can still hear Mydei puttering

around in the kitchen, the sound of glass clicking against each other, but a low moan leaves him before he can stop.

He bites down on his bottom lip, wincing at the soreness from being kissed and now bitten, yet thankfully it's just enough to quieten the noises that keep slipping through. Phainon keeps his fist fairly loose, his cock already sensitive from only lightly being touched. He can't help it, hips bucking into his own touch, fingers curling tighter around his cock, suddenly needing the extra friction, squeezing at the base before slowly tugging up until he's pumping his hand quickly. Phainon's head thunks back against the door, eyes squeezing shut as his hips meet each glide of his fist, the slide getting wetter and wetter with how much he's leaking, thoughts of *Mydei Mydei Mydei* spiralling around in his head.

Phainon can barely hear the sound of skin slapping against skin over his thoughts as he works his length harder and harder, his fist a blur as he gets closer to the edge. Mydei had smelled amazing, as usual, and oh, how he'd *tasted*, sweet and delicious. Phainon wonders how much further he can push these practise kissing sessions. It might not be realistic, but for once, he allows his mind to wander. Images flash across his mind's eye, each one dirtier and more explicit:

What if Phainon *had* bent Mydei back over the countertop, spilling the smoothies all over them? Then, of course, he'd have to get Mydei out of that scrap of fabric he calls a *t-shirt*, exposing his chest for him to see. What if Mydei had let Phainon touch him there, kiss him and trace the shapes of his tattoos, the ridges of his abs and the swell of his pecs? Even with clothes on, Mydei's nipples sometimes poke through due to the cold, and Phainon has to choke back another loud moan at the thought of kissing there, latching onto those pert nubs and working at them until they're throbbing and sore. How would Mydei react, he wonders. Would he make any noise?

Squirm, try and push him away? Or, would he pull Phainon closer, forcefully burying his face into his chest, chasing his own pleasure?

"*Mydei*," Phainon whispers, hardly any sound coming out. He doesn't want to call his name, exactly, but just the shape of it forming around his lips is enough to make his cock throb harder in his hand, so close and yet still so far.

Just a little more, anything, perhaps Phainon can stretch his imagination even further:

Maybe, after sprawling out across the countertop, after abusing Mydei's nipples and leaving as many marks dotted around as he could, he'd be allowed to touch him further down. Phainon's mouth waters so much he almost chokes on it when he breathes in, a knot forming in his throat that's constricting enough that he begins to feel lightheaded from the mixture of pleasure, arousal and lack of oxygen entering his lungs. His knees are weak, shaking, thighs tensing and relaxing as he shudders through waves of pleasure coursing through him. With his free hand, he trails it across the ridges of his stomach, taking in the bumps and dips of his muscles, splaying his palm out flat and pressing down at the base of his cock where a thatch of white hair is.

Phainon's mind swerves, a whole new scene opening up before him.

This time, instead of him touching Mydei, it's the other way around.

Mydei, on his knees, right in front of him on the scratty brown carpet of his bedroom, looking imploringly up at him as he bats Phainon's hand out of the way so he can grasp his cock instead. Suddenly, his hand doesn't feel like his anymore - callouses from handling a rugby ball begin to form in his mind, the gentle scratch of them only adding to the swell of this crescendo instead of taking away from it.

"Shit," Phainon gasps out, head lolling to the side as he cracks open his eyes, his gaze watery as he watches the painfully red tip of his cock appear and disappear again and again as he works over his length. There's drool leaking down his chin but he's too focused to bother shutting his mouth and stopping the flow.

He wants Mydei so, *so* much. He'll take anything he can get, even if it leaves him with nothing in return. Phainon would remain by Mydei's side, happy as anything, allowing himself to bathe in his mere presence like a budding flower soaking up the sun's rays. He wouldn't mind being ruined by this: by his want and obsession, by the desperation that fuels his fist flying across his cock or by the thoughts in his head becoming more and more intoxicating as each one passes. He wants Mydei everywhere, all the time - on him, to be inside of him, licking and probing, hands desperately searching for the treasure hidden amongst the atoms of his pores. Phainon isn't sure he'd ever find it, as it's buried all across Mydei - in his smile, his eyes, his soft hair and even softer lips. Everything about Mydei is something to *treasure* ; the pot of gold at the end of the rainbow, a prized possession and a chest full of priceless antiques. It's all him, all Mydei, in the way he breathes to the way he laughs at Phainon's bad jokes, at the way he kisses and holds onto him like a lifeline, to the way -

Phainon comes so hard his knees give out, collapsing onto the floor as he curls in on himself, hiccuping on sobs as his cock spurts and leaks, dirtying up his carpet and hand as it floods out. His head is up in the clouds as

euphoria sizzles along his skin, coiling tight around his organs like unruly vines, his cock jerking in his hold until he’s suddenly spent, limbs going limp. He doesn’t let go of his softening cock just yet, cradling it in his hand.

He loses track of time, focusing on getting his breathing back under control and forcing his muscles to stop spasming. Then, like a puppet with its strings cut, he slumps forward, finally letting go of his cock to plant his hands on the floor before him to keep him upright.

Phainon feels *revolting* - not just physically, but mentally as well. He’s covered in sweat and cum, drool and tears, surrounded by the proof of what he’d done sprawled across his carpet and creating burns on his knees.

Out of the two options, mentally he feels worse. What had he just *done*? In all the years he’s known Mydei, he’s never crossed that line before - always making sure to keep his brain blissfully blank while he jacked off, or pictured some faceless human-shaped person instead. He’s kept a tight leash on his thoughts, not allowing himself to get too carried away in fears of it bleeding out into real life, however, now it seems that’s inevitable since he’s finally gotten a taste of the forbidden fruit. Phainon’s head drops down between his shoulders, the backs of his eyes strangely hot. He wills himself not to cry, he *can’t*, not when he needs to get his act together and clean up this mess.

Phainon starts slow. He eventually finds the energy to untuck his legs from underneath him, shakily standing up as if he’s a baby deer on ice. Next, he walks to his bedside table, grabs a fist full of tissues out from the box and makes his way back over to the incriminating scene. He gets back down on his knees, wincing as his skin feels raw against the rough carpet, and begins

to scrub away. Phainon’s just glad that nothing is going on in his head right now - no thoughts about Mydei or about them kissing - only focusing on getting things clean. Once he’s done, he bins the tissues, using the rest in the box to wipe his hands clear of his cum as much as he can and get the drool off his chin. The rest he’ll have to take care of in the shower.

He sighs, scrubbing his unsoiled hand through his hair, not caring if it knots and gets tangled up from the action. Whatever, what’s done is done, and at least he can go ahead and ruminate over his mistake under the hot spray of his shower.

Except, he can’t stop ruminating. In or out of the shower, his brain won’t shut off anymore. Thoughts loop endlessly, dragging him in circles until he’s dizzy with it. It makes his head ache, a dull, persistent throb at the base of his neck that lingers no matter how many times he flexes his shoulders or tries to meditate it away.

He’s trying to focus on studying after his shower, hair still damp due to his laziness of not wanting to do more than roughly towel dry it. Little droplets slide down the strands and fall onto the paper in front of him. They land with soft plinks, soaking slowly into the page, but Phainon can’t bring himself to care. He swipes at them half-heartedly, the water smearing across the surface in long, glistening streaks. The ink bleeds under his fingertips, watching as the black ink blooms into illegibility. It feels oddly fitting - his thoughts are just as useless, just as unreadable and unsolvable as the words in front of him.

It’s only when there’s a knock at his door that he remembers that he’s not the only person in the world, the sudden sound feeling as loud as a gunshot through the silence.

“Phainon?” It’s Mydei - he recognises that knock, swift and sure, and the voice, deep and baritone, despite being muffled through the thick wood.

Phainon sighs, the mere sound of his name in Mydei’s voice making his cock twitch. He glares down at his crotch like it’s his mortal enemy. At this point, it definitely is.

“Yeah?” He calls out, not moving from his desk.

“Dinner is ready,” Mydei replies. “Do you want it now or should I -”

“I’m coming!” Phainon shouts excitedly, cutting him off as he jumps up from his chair without hesitating, already happily bounding over to open the door.

He rips the door open, coming face-to-face with Mydei whose expression is covered in surprise. His eyes are wide, lips slightly dropped to form an ‘o’ shape.

“You’re eager tonight,” Mydei comments, giving him a suspicious look.

Phainon chuckles nervously, scratching the nape of his neck. “You know how much I love your cooking.”

“Sure thing,” Mydei replies dismissively, walking away back towards the kitchen, expecting Phainon to follow him.

And he does. He can’t resist; from seeing Mydei’s hips sway as he walks to the offering of food that makes him suddenly aware of how hungry he actually is, it’s all equally as enticing.

The smell hits Phainon as he begins to follow behind Mydei - rich and warm, the kind of scent that wraps around him and makes his stomach growl on instinct. It’s been hours since the smoothie he’d drank, and then he’d been… occupied, to say the least, so it’s no surprise he’s starving now. The aroma in the air is all spice and heat, the savoury char of seared chicken mingling with something sweet and earthy: roasted vegetables caramelising in the oven, a touch of garlic and cumin mixed in with the fragrance. It’s mouth-watering, unfairly good, and Phainon’s already grinning like an idiot before he even sees the plates.

Mydei takes a seat at their dining table, completely unfazed like he isn’t personally responsible for making the flat smell like an actual Michelin-star restaurant. Not that Phainon would know what they smelled like specifically - he’s too poor to go to one, but he’s convinced that Mydei has the same talent as the chefs that work at them.

“The veg is almost done, they only need a few more minutes,” Mydei says as Phainon sits down next to him, looking at the chicken and potatoes already on his plate gleefully.

“Can I start now?” Phainon asks, turning to face Mydei.

Mydei gives him a flat look, “When have I ever been able to stop you?”

Phainon laughs loudly, putting an elbow on the edge of the table and resting his chin in his palm. “Maybe I should start behaving more if you’re already at your wit’s end.”

“I’ll believe it when I see it,” Mydei replies, leaning back in his chair and crossing his arms over his ample chest. His legs sprawl out underneath the table, his thigh knocking slightly into Phainon’s knee, but it’s enough to make him almost jump out of his skin.

Mydei stares at him questioningly after his reaction. “You alright?” He asks, raising a brow all while not moving his leg away.

Of course, he doesn’t. Mydei probably has no idea what caused Phainon to freak out like that. He nods, far too quickly, trying to disguise his reaction with a cough. “Yeah, fine.”

It’s a lie. Or at least, half of one. He hadn’t expected the touch, but now that it was there, now that Mydei’s knee was still pressed lightly against his thigh, Phainon couldn’t *stop* thinking about it. He can’t stop feeling it, the warmth radiating through their clothes, enough that he wants to press himself flush against Mydei’s side to feel him all over. It’s all his body wants to pay attention to now, the smell and idea of dinner suddenly disappearing from his mind in a single *poof*.

It’s not even a strong touch. It’s barely even a nudge. But it sends his thoughts straight back into dangerous territory - a territory he’d only just gotten himself out of with the help of focusing on studying - *kissing*. The way Mydei had leaned in earlier, the way he’d tasted of strawberries, the way his hands had been burning hot, the way he’d kissed back like he *meant* it. Phainon’s heart does a ridiculous little flip at all those thoughts and more, thankfully within the privacy of his own chest despite feeling as though it’s about to leap out and beat straight onto the table. He swallows past his pulse thrumming in his throat, doing all he can to try and centre himself again.

It’s so *stupid*, so pathetic - it’s just a knee. However, Mydei is so close, and he smells like whatever spices he used to cook dinner - dinner that he’s sharing with Phainon - and he’s looking at him like he’s trying to figure him out. It scares him as much as it excites him; the thought that Mydei can see straight through him, knowing how much of himself he’s keeping hidden for the sake of their friendship, and how much he wants Mydei to know and never find out all at the same time.

“I think the vegetables are burning,” Is what Phainon says instead of anything else inside of his head.

Mydei leaps out of his chair, face ashen, a plethora of foreign curses marking up the air as he grabs a heat-proof mitten to get the vegetables out of the oven.

“HKS, they’re fine!” Mydei exclaims, swivelling around to practically shove the tray in his face to show Phainon the perfectly cooked veg.

He bursts out into laughter, finally freeing himself of this internal tension, setting it alight with each chuckle and giggle. “You should’ve seen your face!”

Mydei glares at him so sternly that Phainon can’t help but laugh more despite the danger. He is, after all, going against the one so generously offering to feed him.

“So I guess you’ll have all the sprouts then?” Mydei’s voice cuts in, filled with malice.

Phainon’s laughter ceases immediately. “No, no! I’m sorry, Mydei, I didn’t mean it!”

“That’s what I thought,” Mydei throws him a fake smile and puts all the sprouts - to Phainon’s relief - on his plate, giving him a portion of carrots and broccoli instead.

After that, they eat in silence. The only sounds coming from the soft clink of cutlery and the occasional scrape of a chair leg against the tiled floor. The food is just as unreal as Phainon knew it'd be - Mydei's spiced chicken is perfectly cooked, succulent with a bit of char, and the vegetables are roasted just right, the edges crisp and satisfying as he bites down on them. Phainon doesn't say a word past a *thank you* as he tucks in, too focused on consuming as much as he can to fill his belly.

The kitchen is warm and still, lit by the soft overhead light and the gentle hum of the fridge. No television, no music, no distractions. Just the two of them sat side-by-side, elbows sometimes knocking, eating like they've done a thousand times before.

Phainon lets himself sink into it, this strange little bubble of peace. His shoulders start to loosen, and the tension and guilt of the earlier incident begin to unwind, slowly giving way to something softer and lighter. He's relieved that, yet again, their kissing hasn't made a clear dent in their dynamic. There's no need to talk, no need to fill the space, and Mydei doesn't seem to expect any of that from him as usual. He's just as focused on eating and relaxing into the quiet atmosphere.

For all the noise that's been happening in his head recently, the overthinking, the spiralling, the bad decisions - this is simple. This is good. Mydei made him food, just like he always does, and they're sharing it, just like they always do.

He's mid-bite when he realises something. Something that's missing from the dining table. Phainon swallows, fingers trembling slightly as he places his cutlery down.

His notebook is gone.

“Did you read it?” Phainon asks, breaking the quiet with his panic.

Mydei pauses, fork halfway up to his mouth. “Read what?”

“My notebook,” Phainon replies, gesturing to the spot it was earlier, void of said item.

Mydei sighs and finishes his bite, both of them now having cleared their plates. “I left it on the coffee table for you. And no, I didn’t look.”

Relief floods through Phainon at the confirmation, so sudden and overwhelming it knocks the breath out of him. Mydei isn’t the type to tell lies, not even small white ones, so his assurance is as good as a contract in blood. He really shouldn’t have written his reasoning down so earnestly in the first place - what had he been thinking, putting all *that* on paper? Out of all the points he’d scribbled, *Reason #3* haunts him the most: *I really want to kiss you again.* The memory of it makes his stomach twist, and just the thought alone sends heat racing up his neck, shame prickling at his cheeks. His fingers twitch with the urge to drag his hands over his face and disappear into the floor.

“I’m not even going to bother asking what exactly you wrote in there because you look as though you’ve seen a ghost,” Mydei says, collecting

their plates to dump them in the already filled sink.

“Hey, wait, it’s my job to do the dishes,” Phainon says, sweeping his embarrassment under the rug to trot after Mydei, hooking his chin over his shoulder to peer down. He doesn’t dare do what he usually does by accompanying the gesture by holding onto Mydei’s waist, no matter how much he wants to.

“You don’t seem very well today,” Mydei says, not shrugging him off.

Maybe… maybe a quick touch would be okay? Mydei doesn’t seem averse to it. Phainon raises his hands slowly, placing them low on the slope of Mydei’s waist, his little fingers ever so slightly slipping under the waistband of his joggers. The warmth of his bare skin is immediate, soft and electric under Phainon’s fingertips. He holds his breath, half-expecting Mydei to flinch or pull away considering how ticklish he is - but he doesn’t. Instead, he leans in just a little closer, back pushing against Phainon’s chest, making his heart stutter at the silent permission in that movement.

“I’m fine,” Phainon says, not sounding fine at all. His breath seems to rattle in his lungs, his mouth drying out at being so close to Mydei again. Clearly he wasn’t as slick at hiding how affected he is by their kissing as he thought he was. “At least let me dry up?”

“Suit yourself,” Mydei says flippantly, rinsing the now clean plate in cool water before putting it in the dish rack.

“I *will*, thank you very much,” Phainon finishes the sentence with a quick pinch to Mydei’s hip, and he barely moves away quick enough to dodge the flying elbow coming back towards him. Unfortunately, he doesn’t get off scot-free, and gets a face full of water and bubbles splashed at him.

“Surely that’s cheating!” Phainon scrubs his face, pouting when the bubbles cling to his eyelashes uncomfortably.

“How?” Mydei asks, shuffling over to the left to allow Phainon to grab the tea towel and begin drying up.

“Use of weaponry,” Phainon answers, nodding surely.

Mydei doesn’t bother deigning him with a response, which is fair enough. He simply turns back to the sink, shoulders shaking faintly with silent laughter. Phainon bumps him with his elbow, half-playful, half-defensive, yet there’s no real bite to it.

They fall into a rhythm quickly - Mydei washing, Phainon drying. It doesn’t take them long to clear through everything, but it’s still nice. It’s different from the silence they sit in when eating dinner, this one is much more full of smaller noises - the quiet splashing of water, the gentle clink of cutlery against ceramic and the shifting of the fabric of their clothes. Every so often, their shoulders bump, hips catching against each other as *space* doesn’t seem to exist between them. Phainon could take a few steps away, it wouldn’t be weird, but he simply doesn’t want to. He enjoys this as much as the time they spend together talking or doing activities.

“Do you still want to watch a film tomorrow?” Mydei asks once the final plate has been stored away safely in their cupboards.

Phainon turns to face him, eyebrows pinched. “Sure, why wouldn’t I? We always watch a film on Sunday.”

Mydei shrugs, looking off to the side. “You say that as if you don’t try and get out of it when it’s *my* turn to pick the thing we watch.”

Phainon groans, shoulders slumping. “That’s because you always pick historical crap! There’s only so many times I can watch scantily clad warriors going to war for their countries or upper-class rich people doing nothing with their time.”

Mydei shoves his shoulder, not enough to throw him off balance, but the touch alone is doing that for him. “I’ll pick whatever the hell I want. I don’t complain when you put on click flicks or rom-coms.”

“Because you like them just as much as I do!” Phainon exclaims.

“And who told you that, hm?”

Phainon juts his bottom lip out, scratching under his chin. “You always seem to enjoy them, so…”

“Because *you* like them,” Mydei mutters, so quiet that Phainon almost misses it.

“Huh?” He says anyway, blinking in surprise even though he heard it the first time. He’s not quite sure he heard it *right* though, and he doesn’t quite trust his ears, but before he can ask, Mydei is already turning away. He’s heading back into the living room like he didn’t just drop something so devastating to Phainon in such a flippant manner.

He shakes his head quickly and saves that all for later to ruminate over. “I’ll make us popcorn!” Phainon yells after him, laughing when he gets a middle finger thrown up in reply.

‘*Later*’ finds him quickly.

Phainon lays in bed, but he’s completely awake. The room is dark and quiet, save for the occasional creak of the flat settling in and the faraway sound of traffic in the distance, however, none of it helps settle him. His body might be still, tucked beneath the covers, yet his mind is anything but. It races in circles, looping over everything - dinner, the silence between them, the way Mydei dropped that he only tolerates Phainon’s choice of film because *he* likes them and not the other way around. He supposes that’s what friends do - give and take, push and pull, always trying to find that good balance between holding on and letting go, careful not to tip the scales or ask for more than they’re meant to give.

Something about that quiet admittance, though, rings far too loudly in his ears, making his stomach feel funny and his body floaty.

And that paired with the kissing. *Gods*, the kissing.

Phainon presses the heels of his hands into his eyes, groaning quietly to himself. His chest is tight in a way that feels more emotional than physical, a pressure that makes it impossible to relax. Mydei's touch lingers on his skin, the phantom feel of his lips and fingertips and warmth all refuse to leave his mind once again. It's been hours - and as the clock approaches 2am, it's been almost twelve whole hours since their kiss. If Phainon concentrates enough, he can still taste him - fruity, minty, and sweet all rolled into one.

He flips onto his side, then onto his other side, then back laying flat again. Nothing helps. He's not tired - he's *wired*. Buzzing with the memory and the taste and the touches, it's a sensory overload with nowhere to go. He refuses to touch himself again, still rolling deep in the guilt that lingers in the back of his mind over it. He hates how it'd been the best he's ever felt - an unreal high of doing something he shouldn't, coming so hard he went dizzy and had stars sparkling in his peripheral vision.

"Fuck this," Phainon mutters and kicks off his covers, getting out of bed to flop down into his desk chair instead.

The glare of his laptop screen booting up is almost blinding, and he squints past the brightness to type in his password and load up his web browser.

Phainon laces his fingers together and forces them outwards, relieved when all of his knuckles crack. *Now* he's ready to tackle this. With his trusty notebook back at his side, he flips to a clean page, grimacing only a tiny bit when he catches sight of the blue and red underlined title.

He sighs, focusing his attention on his laptop. He'll start off easy and to the point.

Phainon begins typing:

How to kiss your roommate

He cringes, backspacing before the suggested results can show up. He doesn't want to imagine what kind of nonsense would pop up then - probably hundreds of sob stories similar to him, a load of people commiserating with each other over their unrequited loves. Well, if he's going by anyone's standards, he's probably doing a lot better than those types. At least he can say he's *actually* kissed his roommate.

How to impress the guy you like by kissing him

Also no, he deletes it faster than the first one.

"Fine then," Phainon says to himself, trying one last time.

How to kiss

There - that's what he was aiming for. No frills, no extra details, just exactly what he needs to know.

He only feels a tiny bit ashamed as he scrolls through the endless search, stumbling upon scam-like programmes on '*how to keep your man with one simple trick!*' and '*this easy tip will stop your man from looking at another woman!*' Phainon huffs - what he wants to know is why there's no help for a guy who simply wants to impress his roommate with his newly found kissing prowess. He pouts, folding his arms over his chest as he relaxes back into his chair. Surely he's not the only person in the world going through this right now? Maybe he should've checked out the forum sites on the first search, hopefully they would've eventually led him to the right topics.

Phainon's eyes begin to glaze over as he continues searching, opening up a bunch of tabs that sound somewhat promising. There are barely any that seem legit - between websites wanting to track his data for whatever nefarious reasons they're keeping hidden and sandwiched between far too many 'masterclasses' on how to get the man you want, none seem of any use. That last suggestion, he supposes, isn't too far away from the truth. He'd rather not get swept up in all the excess fees they charge though, flashing promises of 'PAY ONLY 50,000 CREDITS AND WIN HIM OVER NOW WITH THESE EASY AND SIMPLE TRICKS!' startling him further into awakeness with how obnoxious they are.

Why does Phainon have to *trick* Mydei into liking him back? Can't he just… win him over naturally with his charm? Surely that isn't out of the realm of possibility, right?

Sulking, he clicks on a site that has a somewhat intriguing title: *Different Kisses to Try with Your Other Half!* How many types of kisses could there be? Phainon can't imagine any of them being better than simply kissing on the lips. It's a quaint-looking blogging type of site, one that's covered in flowers and lots of pinks and lilacs. He doesn't *hate* it, it kind of reminds him of what houses belonging to grandma's are supposed to look like. Phainon's never experienced that, so he wouldn't know personally, but he believes it as he begins scrolling. It starts with mostly a lot of skirting around the topic, describing *intimate happenings* as 'wonderful' and 'whimsical', and most distressing of all, a lot of closeup photos of red-painted lips and couples kissing. It takes a lot of scrolling to finally land on the list.

Phainon fumbles around for his pen, almost knocking it clean off the table when he finally gets a hold of it, poised and ready to take notes. Before that, he needs a title of his own:

KISSES TO DO

The capital letters feel necessary, and he does what he did before, underlining the words with blue and red ink to make it stand out from the rest. He replaces the red pen with a black ink one and starts to read through the long-awaited list.

First of all, you should start out small! Here are some sweet (but cheeky 😉) kisses to get started with. Your partner is sure to love these easy-pleasers!

- Single-lip kiss
- Forehead kiss
- Cheek kiss
- Nose kiss
- Hand kiss
- Peck
- Blowing a kiss
- Nose peck

With each kiss suggestion, he wriggles more in his seat, his thoughts overflowing as he dutifully copies each one into his notebook, still making sure to not use cursive and keeping each letter clean and easy to read.

Now, if you and your partner are more adventurous types, then I have some suggestions for you, too! These are sure to bring an extra sprinkle of spice to your lives.

Gulping, Phainon scrolls further down, heartbeat thundering in his chest at the possibilities waiting for him. He wonders if he should actually write these if they're that risky - but Mydei can easily tell him to fuck off if need be.

- French kiss
- Breath kiss
- Love bite/hickey

- Vampire kiss

“What the hell is a *vampire kiss*?” Phainon says incredulously, clicking on the hyperlink as it takes him to the bottom of the page with an explanation.

No need to fear, a vampire kiss isn’t as scary as it sounds. Definitely no Dracula’s getting involved! This is a deep and passionate kiss on your partner’s neck that involves some gentle biting. This is one to keep within the privacy of your own home rather than out and about.

“Oh,” Phainon says aloud.

Without noticing, the hand that was originally on his trackpad is now on his neck, pressing the pads of his fingers into his pulse point. That alone tickles, setting off a squirmy feeling in his stomach. He doesn’t recall his own touch feeling quite like this before, where even a gentle graze against himself makes him feel like a shaken can of soda. Phainon swallows, dragging his fingertips delicately up to the hinge of his jaw, tracing down the sharp jut of it until he reaches his chin where he pushes his fingers up until they rest on his lips. His entire body feels like a live wire, cock pulsing in his thin sleep shorts as he presses his thighs together.

He wants to do all that to Mydei - wants it with a desperation that claws at his ribs and makes it hard to breathe past. He wants to kiss him on the neck, slow and reverent and feel the way Mydei shivers beneath his mouth. He wants to trace the line of his jaw with his lips, pressing into each angle like it might reveal something secret. And then, finally, he wants to reach his mouth and *really* kiss him, slow and deep, savouring each second, every

breath, every soft part of him that he’s allowed to touch. Because whatever Mydei offers him - whether it’s strictly just his lips or free reign for more, he’ll take it all.

With that, he drops his pen and shuts his laptop lid with the browser still up, rolling back into bed and ignoring how much his heart aches for more.

Two weeks have passed now. Two weeks of no kissing, barely any touching except for a few pats on the back, and no quiet moments charged with unspoken tension. Nothing. Phainon is pent-up and antsy, pacing his bedroom like a caged animal with how every small interaction with Mydei feels heavier with the absence of what they were doing before. He can’t stop thinking about it - about *him*. Every brush of Mydei’s arms, every offhand comment, and it’s ended up with his thoughts spiralling every time they make eye contact for a second too long.

Phainon can’t lie, especially not to himself, he misses kissing Mydei. The warmth, the closeness, the dizzying high of it. He can’t find a way to ask, though, every time he tries only ends up with words sticking to his throat and trying to claw their way back down and out of sight. He wonders if Mydei feels the same as he does, waiting for the penny to drop and one of them to give in. Phainon isn’t above making the first moves, but somehow it feels like he’d be losing this stalemate they’ve found themselves in. And that’s one thing he hates - *losing*. Even to Mydei, even if it meant he could kiss him again.

So, the list he wrote a few weeks ago is sitting folded up in his pocket, ripped out of his notebook, and worn at the edges from where he's taken it out and put it back, over and over again. Phainon has added even more to the bullet points until he almost ran out of space, everything ranging from playful kisses to ridiculous ones are on there now. There's no shame left, he thinks, until the thought of having to bring it up with Mydei occurs and then he feels it all flood back in. He doesn't know when or how he'll be brave enough to hand it over to Mydei, but he hopes - *gods*, does he hope - that one of them gains enough courage to ask because if they don't start again soon, he's not sure how much longer he can pretend he doesn't need it. Doesn't need *Mydei*.

It's a Friday night, meaning that Mydei is usually sitting at their dining table studying. Phainon grips the paper in his hand and steels himself. He'll ambush Mydei when he's least expecting it, taking him off guard so much that no one will have time to feel embarrassed. That'll work, for sure. Phainon nods to himself and opens his bedroom door, storming over to the kitchen to find Mydei.

He's exactly where he knew he'd be - sat on one of the chairs, hunched over his laptop with endless amounts of textbooks and paper sprawled across the table. It's so densely packed that Phainon can't see the wood underneath an ocean of white and black ink.

"I made a list," Phainon declares, loud enough so that there's no chance of Mydei not hearing.

Mydei hears, going by the way he splutters into his tea, looking up at Phainon in surprise. "Another one?" He asks incredulously. "What is it with you and lists?"

“Yes, another one,” Phainon replies, sitting down next to Mydei who gives him a baffled look.

He holds the page up to his chest like a shield until he’s settled, shoving the mess out of the way so he can slam the singular page down, his writing all on show. There’s no backing out now. He’s going to get exactly what he wants. Phainon stares at Mydei, eyes as wide as they can go to really make sure he’s getting across his determination and earnestness on the impending matter.

“I offer you some suggestions,” Phainon says, one finger on the centre of the page as he slides it closer to Mydei. “I’m taking this very seriously. I have to improve, okay?”

Phainon ignores the long-suffering sigh from Mydei as he closes his laptop and puts it to the side. *Hook, line and sinker* Phainon thinks smarmily, smiling to himself as he watches Mydei refocus his attention onto him instead.

“You’re brave enough to actually show me this one?” Mydei asks sceptically.

Phainon waves him off, “The list before didn’t count. This one, though, *does*,” He urges the paper closer, grinning when Mydei snatches it up from under his finger to have a look. “You’ll find some stuff I wanna try on there. Except, um, I don’t know what some of them are. Like, what the hell is a butterfly kiss?”

“Where you brush your eyelashes together, or against their skin,” Mydei answers smoothly. *Too* smoothly.

Phainon freezes, eyes narrowing. “Have you done that before? With *him*?” He spits out the last word accusingly.

Jealousy begins to flare like it always does when he thinks about Mydei and the art department guy, turning uglier and uglier the more he considers it. He still doesn’t know much about it - when or where it happened exactly, the name of the guy, what he looked like, and everything else in between that he’s desperate to know. Phainon isn’t sure why he wants to know every single detail so much, it’s not like it’ll make him feel better. If anything, it’d make him feel worse, adding to that horrible squirmy feeling in his gut that eats away at him.

Mydei rolls his eyes, looking up from the list to cuff Phainon on the back of his head. “It’s common knowledge, dumbass.” He goes back to reading through the notes, “Why are you still so fixated on who I kissed? I thought this whole arrangement was about you getting better.”

Phainon frowns, eyebrows pinching in a sulk. “Because -! Because I still can’t believe your first kiss was just *fine*. Aren’t you mad that it wasn’t like it is in the movies?”

“No kissing is like in the movies,” Mydei rests his cheek in his palm, elbow propped up on the table as he scans the last part of the list. He looks

somewhat interested and disinterested at the same time, and Phainon is frustrated he can’t get a read on him.

“It is for me,” Phainon mutters. Because it’s true - their kisses *do* feel like how they seem in the movies, even though no literal fireworks are popping off and spinning cameras focusing on them, Phainon feels the equivalent in the way the floor beneath him disappears, an endless trap door that he falls through, the only thing keeping him above ground is Mydei kissing him back. Instead, it’s fireworks of pleasure that pop and shimmer under his skin, filling him with something of what he thinks starlight would feel like - powerful, burning bright and eternal.

Mydei lifts a brow, clearly having heard. “Really?”

Phainon can’t help but wriggle around in his chair, shifting side to side as he tries to find a comfortable spot again under the scrutiny of Mydei. “I mean… It feels good. For me, anyway. Like…” He mimics explosions with his hands. “That…” Phainon trails off, laughing nervously.

“Whatever,” Mydei dismisses after a brief silence between them. Phainon can’t help but feel slightly crushed that Mydei hadn’t agreed that it felt the same way for him, or at least given him a tiny bit of assurance that it felt good for him, too.

“Let’s hear it then. Which one do you want to practise first?”

Phainon clears his throat, plucking the paper out of Mydei's hands to have another look at. "Um…" Phainon's eyes slide down the suddenly endless list. He gives a small performative cough into his fist. "Number one -"

"How many *are* there?" Mydei interrupts.

"About thirty."

Mydei stares at him and then huffs, tousling the back of his hair. He's got it up in a high pony, flicks of the shorter hairs falling out around his neck. Phainon wants to run his fingers through them and see how soft they are, how they'd feel under his skin.

"Instead of that, why don't we do whatever feels good?"

Phainon's eyebrows crease, clutching at his list desperately as he looks between it and Mydei. "But, everything on here would feel good with you…"

Mydei flicks his braid over his shoulder, turning around in his chair to face Phainon fully. "*I'm* the one who's supposed to be teaching you, correct? Then just follow my lead."

Phainon nods - hesitantly at first, the motion barely there - but as the idea settles in, he finds the courage to give a firmer, more certain shake of his

head. His eyes drift down to the paper one last time, lingering on the words that had felt impossibly vulnerable just a few moments ago. Then, with a quiet exhale, he lets it go, setting it down among the other scattered sheets on the table, letting it disappear into the clutter like it was never there.

Across from him, Mydei rises and holds out a hand. Phainon blinks, caught off guard by the gesture. His brows pull together again, unsure of what exactly Mydei's asking for. But Mydei doesn't say anything - he just tips his head slightly, gaze warm and steady and patient, fingers extending in quiet invitation. Phainon reaches out slowly, then threads his fingers through Mydei's. The touch is grounding and solid, and something about the way Mydei's hand naturally curls around his makes Phainon's chest go light and tight all at once. Mydei gives his hand the faintest squeeze, so subtly that Phainon must be imagining it, before gently tugging him towards the living room like there's nothing strange about it - like it's natural for them to be holding hands.

"If we're going to do this, I don't want my ass going numb sitting on those chairs," Mydei clarifies.

"O-okay," Phainon stammers, praying to everything that'll listen that his palms don't suddenly turn sweaty in Mydei's grip.

He lets himself be guided, feet moving without thought as Mydei leads him over to the sofa. When Mydei tugs him down, Phainon follows easily, sinking into the cushions beside him. There's no space between them - not even an inch. Their shoulders pressed together, arms brushing, thighs lined up from hip to knee. It shows off the difference in their attire: Mydei in shorts that barely reach mid-thigh, and Phainon in joggers. Their thighs are about the same thickness, but Mydei's show more obvious signs of muscle,

corded lines underneath his skin shifting as they situate themselves. His tattoos even lead here, swirling and stunning as the red stands out against his tan from being outside playing rugby so often.

The closeness is immediate and overwhelming, but not in a bad way. It's comforting, being this close, like sitting next to a lit hearth and daring yourself not to lean in further. Every point of contact buzzes with quiet intensity, and Phainon finds himself hyper-aware of it all - the heat of Mydei's skin, the rhythm of his breathing, the calm steadiness of his presence and future activities that makes Phainon feel both breathless and safe.

"I'm still not quite sure why you want me to teach you when I barely know anything myself," Mydei says, sighing and pinching the bridge of his nose.

Phainon panics, suddenly feeling the situation dissolving between his fingers. He squeezes their still-entwined hands, making sure Mydei can definitely feel it, not leaving any room for debate.

Mydei blinks at him.

"I… only want to kiss you -" Phainon watches with dread as Mydei's eyes widen comically large. "Right now! Right now, of course, not… forever!" He chuckles loudly, the sounds coming out as stilted *ha, ha, ha*'s.

"So I'm convenient," Mydei summaries, voice so neutral it sounds even worse than if he was angry.

“No,” Phainon immediately says, shaking his head. His expression flattens out into something severe, placing his other hand over their joint fists, “That’s not it at all. I trust you the most. You’re the only person I trust to tell me what I’m doing is right or wrong. Which is the whole point of this.”

“Fine,” Mydei exhales, his eyes ever so slightly softening at Phainon’s words. “You better pay attention then, because I won’t be repeating anything I say.”

Phainon nods enthusiastically, sitting bolt right up, shoulders back and head held high as he awaits further instructions.

Mydei tuts, snickering, “You really are a dumb dog. If I told you to bark, would you do it?”

Phainon opens his mouth, ready to reply.

“Don’t answer that,” Mydei scoffs.

Mydei tucks a stray piece of hair behind his ear, but it’s just a tad too short and immediately falls back into place, catching on his eyelashes. He clicks his tongue in frustration, and before Phainon can think better of it, his hand is moving, drawn in like a moth to a flame. He reaches out and gently cups Mydei’s cheek, turning his head towards him with a touch that’s more tender than it has any right to be. With slow precision, he brushes the strand

back again, this time taking the opportunity to let his fingers linger. They trail over the tip of Mydei's ear, soft and smooth beneath his touch, gradually following the gentle curve downward to his earlobe. The skin begins to warm beneath his fingertips, colour blooming fast. Mydei's ear flushes such a vivid pink that it almost glows, and Phainon feels heat rising in his cheeks, suddenly very aware of how close they are and how easy it would be to close the distance right now and here.

"What do you think you're doing?" Mydei grits out but doesn't shove Phainon off.

Phainon won't kiss him just yet. Not right now, not when Mydei is offering so earnestly to teach him. He wants Mydei to offer himself up first, not take when he's not been given it.

"Ever heard of *setting the mood*, Mydeimos?" Phainon chuckles quietly, tugging at Mydei's earlobe teasingly before retreating.

"There's no need to do such a thing."

"Of course, there is," Phainon replies sincerely, face scrunching up slightly. "Just how badly did the guy who stole your first kiss treat you that he didn't even bother to make you feel good before it?"

Mydei doesn't keep his gaze, huffing and looking away to stare at the blank television. "Not terribly."

“But not great either?” Phainon fills in.

Mydei’s shoulders tense, and Phainon begins to feel wary of the territory he’s entered, the can of worms he’s so desperate to rip open.

“It was nothing. A quick kiss for New Year’s, that’s all.”

“New Year’s?” Phainon echoes, thoughts reeling backwards as he tries to remember what they were doing for New Year’s just passed.

His mind screeches to a halt when he realises that Mydei had gone out that night after Phainon had *insisted* he did because he was lying in bed with the flu. He was sick and tired, completely drained from battling his symptoms, and felt bad that Mydei had been fussing and hovering over him nonstop for the past few days taking care of him. During that time, Phainon couldn’t even lift a finger without Mydei latching onto the movement and saying crossly: “And what do you think you’re doing?”

A rush of molten-hot anger erupts inside of him, sudden and all-consuming. It coils in his chest like fire, radiating through every inch of him, and he doesn’t know where to put it - doesn’t know if he wants to punch something or curl in on himself. Because he *knows* - he *knows* - he’s the reason Mydei went to that party in the end. Alone. And if he hadn’t been so sick that he was bedbound, then maybe things wouldn’t have unfolded the way they did.

Maybe Mydei wouldn’t have been kissed by someone else.

The thought stings as it always does, but it’s made worse now. It *burns*. Phainon pictures it against his will - that same faceless stranger he always imagines leaning in, Mydei caught off guard (or maybe waiting for it?), lips meeting lips in a moment Phainon can never get back and change. And the worst part is, he doesn’t even know if Mydei truly minded. He’s too afraid to ask, too scared to breach that question in case he gets an answer that he doesn’t like. He doesn’t know if the kiss was returned with equal fervour like the way Mydei kisses *him* back now, or if it meant something - which he can only hope that it didn’t, considering Mydei hasn’t mentioned seeing the guy again - or if it still lingers in Mydei’s head the same way *their* kisses do in his.

Phainon’s jaw tightens. What if it could’ve been different if he’d gone too? What if he’d have stood by Mydei’s side when the countdown began? What if, then, when the clock struck midnight and the fireworks were all set off, Phainon would’ve been the one to watch them reflected in Mydei’s eyes as he leaned in, wrapped his arms around him and captured his lips into a kiss.

The yearning for that - of what could’ve been - nearly drowns out the rage. But it remains there, simmering beneath the want, beneath the regret, both emotions fighting for dominance until he can hardly tell them apart.

“Oh. Right, yeah,” Phainon says lamely, robotically, the one-syllable words tumbling out like he’s vomiting them up.

So that’s it then - the scene is mostly set. He wasn’t too far off from his original assumption that it took place during some dingy house party, but knowing that Mydei came home tipsy that night made his blood boil even more.

Tipsy, softened Mydei, exhausted from nursing Phainon and looking for a quick respite before he had to come back. Sweet, quiet Mydei, probably sipping on watered-down red wine that stained his lips and tongue, which made him taste slightly alcoholic and addicting. Warm, pliant Mydei, sinking into the New Year with a kiss.

Phainon doesn’t realise how hard he’s clenching his teeth until Mydei taps the side of his jaw, silently encouraging him to unlock it. “What’s going on inside that tiny brain of yours?”

“Rude,” Phainon replies, batting away the raging jealousy and possessiveness he’s feeling like unwanted cobwebs. “So, what are we doing today, professor?”

Mydei tilts his head, thinking. “What was on your list again?”

“Oh, *now* you wanna hear about my lists!” Phainon harrumphs, tapping his chin in thought. “Well, we’ve already kissed on the lips, so…” He trails off, heat rushing to his cheeks as his previous thoughts are overtaken by the memories he’s made with Mydei. “What if we tried something a bit different?” He mentally scans his list, having memorised it days ago. “The jaw one?”

“You want to kiss my jaw?” Mydei asks, voice sounding disbelieving.

Phainon shrugs, trying to keep it as casual as he can while his brain yells at him YES!!!! In big, bold lettering.

“Sure, why not? Although, if it tickles, don’t hit me, please?” He unwinds his hand from Mydei’s to clap his together in mock prayer. He tacked on the *please* in jest, but now that he thinks about it, he probably should fear Mydei’s punches if he accidentally sets him off.

“Fine,” Mydei acquiesces gruffly. “How do you want me?”

Phainon could sob. No, seriously, he could. He silently and efficiently adds that line deep into the recesses of his mind, only to be awoken in the more dire of times. Times, preferably, where he’s *alone*.

“Um, maybe, just…” Phainon twists at the waist, turning slowly until his body faces Mydei’s. He reaches out, hands resting lightly on Mydei’s shoulders, the touch careful but sure. With a gentle nudge, he coaxes Mydei to mirror the movement, guiding him into the same position. They turn until they’re facing each other fully, knees knocking against each other with the shift, eyes meeting in the quiet space between them.

“And now…” Phainon draws closer, flipping Mydei’s braid behind his shoulder, baring his jawline and neck to him. Phainon gulps. Mydei is holding himself so still that it’s almost as though he’s stopped breathing.

“Can I…?” Phainon begins, caressing his thumb over the hinge of his jaw, hoping the silence subtly fulfills the rest of his request.

“Knock yourself out,” Mydei says, but he sounds weird. Far away, tinny, as if the words are being fed to him through a speaker and not through his own mouth.

Phainon’s fingers tremble, his whole body feeling jittery as he leans forward. He practically falls into it, situating himself in the nook between Mydei’s ear and the lock of his jaw. His lips land just off-centre from the bone, more so at the top of his neck than anywhere else. Mydei jumps, hands coming up to grip at Phainon’s biceps. The touch is searing even through his shirt sleeves.

“Sorry,” Phainon murmurs against the skin, feeling his warm breath dance across his cheeks.

He doesn’t really know what to do - if he should keep it placid and delicate, or if he’s allowed to do more. What he *wants* and what he *should do* are two completely different things in this matter. He moves his hands to give them something to do, one gripping Mydei’s t-shirt at the small of his back, balling the fabric up into a fist while the other rests high on Mydei’s thigh to stabilise himself.

“It’s okay,” Mydei assures as if sensing Phainon’s hesitance.

He didn’t feel quite like this when they kissed on the lips before, too focused on taking whatever he could before they had to part for breath and the moment would end. Now he’s faced with his nose directly in Mydei’s hair, the fresh citrus scent of his shampoo clouding all his rational thoughts, the siren call of tasting his skin is right there - ready and ripe for the taking.

“Start slow,” Myde guides, voice soft with how close they are.

There’s no need to speak any louder - at this distance, even a whisper would ring loud and clear. Phainon obeys, lightly dragging his lips to rest over the curve of Mydei’s jaw. He presses a kiss directly there, fast and innocent. It’s nothing more than to test the waters. Then, going from the lack of complaining coming from his roommate, he does it again: once, twice, a third time, all in succession, lingering longer and longer each time until his lips have warmed up Mydei’s skin, his blush even reaching down to his neck, and his hot breaths leaving Mydei’s jaw feeling slightly damp.

“Okay?” Phainon asks, breathless, because he *needs* to know. He has to before he can continue.

“Yes - yeah, okay,” Mydei stutters, which is so wholly unlike him. He lets out a shaky breath, “Now…” One hand leaves Phainon’s biceps to rest at the nape of his neck, ever so slightly tangling in the short hairs there. It sends zings of pleasure down his spine, the urge to arch up into the touch and nudge into Mydei’s palm almost threatens to come into fruition. “You can kiss more. Longer.”

Phainon swallows, “Like how I kiss you?”

He hears Mydei’s throat clicking as he swallows too, “Exactly.”

With that guidance and knowledge, Phainon follows, lips touching skin once more. He mouths across the same spot, trying so hard not to stray elsewhere. It’s hard, though, when he wants to do more. Mydei tastes good even here, clean and freshly washed, so much so that it makes Phainon’s toes curl in his socks. His breathing becomes heavier, his nose squished up against Mydei’s cheek, but he doesn’t dare pull away to catch his breath. Not yet, not when he’s actually getting to experience this without being shoved away.

Phainon sighs dreamily, relishing in the tiny shiver he gets in response, and flicks his tongue out, fingers digging into the meat of Mydei’s thigh as he shuffles impossibly closer, forcing Mydei’s shoulder to dig into his sternum. He doesn’t care, nothing else exists outside of this - the wet slide of his lips against Mydei’s jaw. The grip on his hair gets tighter, punishing, enough to send another shudder down his spine and cause heat to swirl behind his navel. He’s not sure if Mydei is aware, head thrown back to give Phainon more than enough room to work with, eyes squeezed shut and body so still, that he’s tugging him even closer, forcing him even further into his body.

Wanting to push his luck, Phainon nips at the skin, barely even capturing it between his teeth before letting go. He immediately soothes his tongue over it, but he’s not expecting Mydei to *whine*, high and pitchy, loud enough to make them both freeze.

“Um,” Phainon blurts out stupidly before he can think of anything to say. “Did that hurt?”

“No,” Mydei replies quickly, relaxing his shoulders. “You can… carry on.”

“You sure?” Phainon questions.

“Quite.”

“Can I kiss you properly instead?”

“Huh?” Mydei sounds dazed, so unlike himself that it makes Phainon sit up straight, needing to get a better look.

Mydei looks completely wrecked in the best possible way. His lips are slightly parted, his bottom one plump and bright red from being bitten by himself, and his breathing is uneven, his chest rising and falling like he’s just sprinted up a flight of stairs. His cheeks are flushed, a deep, blossoming red that trails even further down the curve of his neck, down onto his chest. And his eyes - *gods*, his eyes - are glassy and half-lidded, pupils blown and lashes damp like he’s barely holding onto the moment. There’s a dazed softness to him, like the world’s gone a bit fuzzy around the edges, and he hasn’t quite landed back on his feet yet.

Phainon feels his eyes open and pupils shrink at the image before him, he lets go of Mydei’s shirt to grasp his cheek, forcing Mydei to look directly at him.

“I’m going to kiss you now,” Phainon declares and dives straight in before he can get an answer, so desperate to feel Mydei’s lips against his own.

They both groan the instant their mouths collide, and Phainon’s lips are still spit-slick enough to ease the slide as he kisses Mydei open-mouthed and pleading, licking and nipping and biting as much as he can.

More, *more*, *more*, it’s not enough, the feeling of Mydei’s lips parting just for him, allowing him entrance as his tongue touches Mydei’s, swirling and sucking. Phainon’s fingers are practically feral claws, scratching at Mydei’s face and his thigh, scrabbling for something to hold himself onto that isn’t driving him crazy out of his mind. He runs his tongue across Mydei’s teeth, not caring as saliva drips down from their open mouths, eyes so tightly pressed shut all he can see are shapes and colours flashing behind his eyelids. All he can taste is Mydei, as sweet and tart as his favourite lemon sherbet sweets that he likes to sneak in between meals. It makes Phainon’s mouth water even more, drool mixing and pooling as he’s unable to consistently swallow.

Phainon tilts his head, the wet sound of their lips parting and pressing against each other again rings loudly past the otherwise silent room, and he doesn’t notice his hand moving higher up Mydei’s thigh until he feels fabric ghosting across the tops of his fingers.

He should pull his hand back. He shouldn’t linger here, underneath the hem of Mydei’s shorts, but he’s even hotter here, burning enough that Phainon’s hands begin to feel clammy from nerves and the sensation of still kissing.

Phainon latches onto Mydei’s bottom lip, worrying it between his teeth and tugging, heart thundering in his chest when it makes him moan, his hand slipping higher and higher, daring too much, until -

Phainon touches something hard.

Mydei breaks away immediately, eyes wide and startled. He covers his mouth with the back of his hand, eyes focusing everywhere but Phainon as he gets up from the sofa, clearing his throat multiple times as he turns his back to Phainon.

“You -” Mydei’s voice breaks, and Phainon wishes he could see his face, feel his gaze and read him because all he’s getting from his back is that he’s *tense*, nervous and unsure. That’s not what Phainon wants at all. “You did well. I - need to go finish my coursework.”

“Mydei?!” Phainon calls out, going to stand as he watches Mydei walk towards his bedroom and not the kitchen where his laptop and studying materials are, but then realises with a horrible dawning feeling that he’s hard too.

He groans, listening to Mydei’s bedroom door shut as he flops back onto the sofa, shoving a spare cushion over his crotch to hide his shame.

Chapter End Notes

leave a comment and/or kudos if you enjoyed! thank you so much!!! each comment truly makes my day and motivates me to write more

-

let's be friends on twitter/x!

Chapter 3: chapter three

Chapter Summary

> Phainon kicks his legs under the duvet, thrashing like it’ll shake off the feeling, but it only makes his grin stretch wider. His frown is nothing more than forgotten, crumpling under the force of giddiness bubbling up in him. He tries to smother it, biting down on his lip and the inside of his cheek, but it’s too late. His whole body feels warm, jittery, and *alive*. The situation has well and truly settled in; he’s allowed to kiss Mydei. He’s been kissing Mydei, with varying degrees of success, but last night he’d been given a compliment in two ways: verbal and physical.
>
> “Okay, okay, calm down,” Phainon mutters to himself through his smile, rolling onto his side and burying his face into his pillow.

Chapter Notes

> hello everyone... i'm baaaack... ♀!!! i was supposed to be resting during my hiatus but, well, inspiration hit :')!!!
>
> this chapter is very much a transitional one, so it's a little different than the ones before. there's a few flashbacks in here (not trauma ones, don't worry!) and they're depicted by the divider '━━❧━━' rather than formatting it all in italics. i hope you're all ready for 9k words worth of phainon being insanely in love, like oh my god.
>
> this is completely and utterly unedited! there will be mistakes, so please ignore them ok thanks lol
>
> anyway, hope you all enjoy! (´▽`ʃ♡ƪ)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Phainon wakes up with his heart already pounding and a vague sense of dread settling low in his stomach. It's the kind that sinks in before he's even fully conscious, as though his body remembers something awful before his brain has the chance to catch up. He sighs, long and quiet, blinking through the crust on his eyelashes and the sleep still clinging annoyingly to the corners of his eyes.

His limbs feel heavy, stuck somewhere between exhaustion and restlessness. Phainon rubs at his face, wiping away the blur until the ceiling above him comes into sharp focus - plain, familiar, and yet somehow as unsettling as his racing thoughts. The early morning stillness of his room doesn't soothe him. If anything, it makes everything worse. There's no distraction here, nothing to pull his mind away from how his chest tightens at the memory of Mydei's flushed cheeks, parted lips, the way his voice had gone so quiet when he said: "*You did well*."

Phainon exhales again, this time shakily, and presses his palms to his face, willing the weight of it all to suddenly lift and disappear as quickly as Mydei did last night back into his room. He can't lie - it stung. It still does, right around his heart, creating this roiling, hot feeling that he can't get rid of. It's like he has heartburn, but no amount of rubbing at his chest or drinking water can shift it. He knows more than anyone that he fucked up last night. He pushed too far, too soon and far too quickly, acting out on a deep-seated whim at trying to consume as much as he could.

But, as much as he hates it, the guilt wrapped around the whole situation is laced with something sweet. It's the knowledge that *he* did that to Mydei. His hands, his mouth, and his presence made Mydei react like that: made him flustered, breathless, *hard*, undone in a way Phainon had never seen before and couldn't stop replaying in his head on a loop. It sparks in his chest like a struck match, and even though he knows he shouldn't enjoy it -

Mydei had clearly been uncomfortable, going by his abrupt exit - he absolutely, horribly, does.

Phainon kicks his legs under the duvet, thrashing like it'll shake off the feeling, but it only makes his grin stretch wider. His frown is nothing more than forgotten, crumpling under the force of giddiness bubbling up in him. He tries to smother it, biting down on his lip and the inside of his cheek, but it's too late. His whole body feels warm, jittery, and *alive*. The situation has well and truly settled in; he's allowed to kiss Mydei. He's *been* kissing Mydei, with varying degrees of success, but last night he'd been given a compliment in two ways: verbal and physical.

"Okay, okay, calm down," Phainon mutters to himself through his smile, rolling onto his side and burying his face into his pillow. Elation pours through him like a wave - bright and uninvited, and far too much for six in the morning. It's the kind of happiness that feels a little wrong, like laughing when you're not supposed to. It's a twisted, breathless sort of joy that leaves him feeling slightly ill with himself as he clings to it.

He wriggles around until he's on his front, hands shoved under his pillows as he kicks up his duvet, revelling in the cool air that ghosts around his overheated legs. Mydei had looked stunning last night, all glassy eyes and bruised lips, his inner thighs scorching hot from the heat coming from his - *ah*, Phainon can't even finish the thought. He squirms in his bed, hips moving side to side, the friction doing its job against his own half-hard cock to take the edge off. Even just picturing and remembering how good it felt to kiss Mydei's jaw, and then kiss him properly is enough to make desire throb in his veins.

Phainon can’t help but wonder what would’ve happened if Mydei had let him touch a little further - just a little more. The thought creeps in uninvited, slow and heavy, winding around his ribs and deep in his gut. He remembers clearly the smooth warmth of Mydei’s skin beneath his palm, how natural it felt to touch him there, how electric. The way his thigh had tensed, muscles quivering like Mydei wasn’t entirely unaffected like he was holding something back. Phainon’s fingers had flirted just beneath the hem of those ridiculous little shorts that Mydei insists on wearing to bed - barely even shorts at all, really, more *suggestion* than *fabric*. If he’d been allowed to move higher, to drag his fingertips just another inch, to map out the rest of his skin and feel what Mydei had so desperately been running away from, what then? What kind of reaction would he have gotten from that - something different to their kisses? Something more, something less? More intense, or dialled down?

“Alright, that’s enough,” Phainon says once again to himself, hauling himself up onto his knees. He glances down at the tent in his shorts, sighing as he yanks the length of his shirt over it. There’s technically nothing stopping him from jacking off again thinking of Mydei, but then he’d have to deal with even more shame than he’s already packing.

With that, he drags himself out of bed a full ten minutes after deciding to. He almost trips over his duvet still wrapped around his legs, having to catch himself by doing some hops until he’s steady again. Phainon is well and truly awake, and the panic of almost falling has settled the problem area between his legs for now. He runs a hand through his hair in lieu of doing anything useful to it, wandering over to his desk to peer at himself in the small mirror he keeps on there.

He doesn’t look terrible, but he doesn’t look great, either. His sleep had been plagued with thoughts of Mydei and half-twisted nightmares of things he’d rather not remember. It’s always been like that when it comes to sleep -

Mydei, strong and beautiful until he’s not, mixed in with the terror and morphing into something else he can’t recognise along with his parents and sister that pop up during the night.

Phainon clears his throat, the sound too loud in the quiet flat, and gives his head a sharp shake as if that’ll dislodge the thoughts clinging stubbornly to his brain. There’s no point dwelling on fantasies and what-ifs - not when he’s got more pressing things to stress over. Like the far less hypothetical, very real question of how he’s supposed to look Mydei in the eye this morning without spontaneously combusting.

He cringes at the thought, lips tugging downward in automatic distaste. It’s one thing to roll around in bed like some lovesick fool, grinning into his pillow and reliving every second of that kiss - but it’s a completely different thing when he remembers he has no idea what Mydei’s perspective is of last night. He has nothing, *nada*, not a single gauge, hint or suggestion apart from the anxious tension lining his body as he walked away. Mydei had pulled away before anything substantial could be discussed about what just happened, leaving Phainon alone with nothing but his own thoughts.

Phainon’s known Mydei for two years - lived with him for nearly one - and still, right now, he feels like a stranger trying to read a language he’s never studied. But that’s not true because ever since they met, Phainon’s done nothing *but* study Mydei. That’s what rattles him the most as Mydei has always been familiar. Predictable, even. And now? Now Phainon doesn’t know where he stands - where their friendship stands - or if he’s even standing at all in the same play park as Mydei at all.

He slaps his cheeks, allowing the sting of skin hitting skin to wake him up even more and snap him out of this downward spiral. Phainon walks to his

bedroom door, opening it to the sounds of Mydei puttering around in the kitchen, just like always. It eases something in his heart, his fingers relaxing on the door handle as he lets go and makes his way over.

The hallway feels longer than usual. Every step of bare feet against the wooden floor echoes just a little too loudly. He rounds the corner into the kitchen like someone expecting to be ambushed - and maybe, emotionally, he is. Mydei’s already there, standing at the counter with his back to Phainon, leaning slightly as the kettle rumbles quietly towards a boil. His posture is easy, unguarded in the way he gets when he doesn’t realise he’s being watched: shoulders relaxed, head tilted ever so slightly to one side like he’s still waking up.

He’s wearing one of Phainon’s hoodies - a pastel pink one that’s seen better days, its cuffs fraying and seams soft from years of wear and too many washes. It hangs loose even on Mydei’s big frame, sleeves bunched at the wrists, the fabric swallowing him whole in a way that makes something ache in Phainon’s chest. His hair is all down this morning, not even hastily tied back like he does sometimes in the mornings to get it out of his face. It falls in soft waves across his shoulders, a few strands flicking into the hood, some caught and tucked in awkwardly like they’ve been there all night.

Phainon notices with a small smile that the hood is inside out. Of course it is. Without thinking, he crosses the room. There’s a quiet fondness blooming in his chest - gentle, familiar, warm. He huffs a soft laugh, mostly to himself, and reaches out to move Mydei’s hair with careful fingers, brushing it aside so it doesn’t get caught as he begins turning the hood right-side in.

Mydei jumps slightly, startled by the sudden touch, and Phainon feels the jolt of it in his own skin. He doesn’t move away, though, not yet. He’s got a job to do. His hands linger on the ends of Mydei’s hair for a second longer than necessary. Mydei glances over his shoulder, eyes wide in surprise, cheeks slightly flushed as their gazes meet. Phainon grounds himself in the simplicity of the gesture - offering Mydei a grin as he finishes pushing the hood inside with a flourish - and almost drowning with the weight of wanting someone he can’t have as Mydei smiles back at him.

“I made you tea,” Mydei says, his voice slightly scratchy from disuse after sleeping.

“Thanks,” Phainon replies, eye twitching minutely at how hot Mydei sounds so early in the morning. It’s another thing that he’s had to get used to after living with him - but it still doesn’t make it any easier.

“Do you want me to grab the milk?” Phainon asks, peering over Mydei’s shoulder to watch him pour the hot water into their mugs. “Wait, how did you know I was awake to even want tea?”

Mydei shoulders him out of the way and gets the milk from the fridge, setting it down next to Phainon to pour himself. “I could hear you being stupid in your room.”

“What!” Phainon exclaims, almost overflowing his mug with milk until Mydei snatches it away from him. “I wasn’t - that -”

“You were giggling to yourself,” Mydei clarifies as if Phainon needed to hear confirmation that Mydei *had* heard him being an idiot earlier.

“Shut up,” Phainon says without any heat behind it, trying to will the blood in his cheeks to cool off.

They stand in silence as Phainon watches Mydei top his mug off with milk before grabbing their pot of sugar, piling in at least 5 teaspoons worth into the drink.

“Gross,” Phainon comments, face scrunching up.

“You’re gross,” Mydei shoots back, gesturing to Phainon’s mug. “Your tea is almost as white as you are.”

“Hey!” Phainon is really pouting now, cradling his mug in his hands almost protectively. “Just because I can’t tan during the summer…”

“You turn into a big red lobster instead,” Mydei replies, putting the milk away and wiping down the counter free of sugar granules. “It’s cute.” He finishes, far too offhandedly.

“*Stop*,” Phainon groans, dragging the word out dramatically. He wants to hide behind his hands but instead, he hides behind his mug, taking a pre-

emptive sip knowing it hasn't cooled down properly yet. He winces and holds in a curse. Deserved.

For a moment, it's quiet again - just the faint clink of the spoon against the side of Mydei's cup as he stirs, slower than necessary. Phainon's eyebrows furrow as he feels the silence thicken, his shoulders rising to his ears as he takes another gulp of his tea to help settle the funny feeling in his stomach at the sudden change in atmosphere. He thought they were okay - the relaxed feeling he gets while being around Mydei hadn't gotten up and disappeared, instead it'd simply proven itself by sticking around as soon as he laid eyes on Mydei in their kitchen.

Then, Mydei speaks: "Can you sit down for a sec?" He asks, not looking up as he sets the spoon aside. "There's something we need to discuss."

Immediately, Phainon feels uneasy. He feels sick, hot and then cold, sweaty and clammy, faint and dizzy all at once. That's never a good thing to hear, is it? If they were dating - which to Phainon's dismay, they're not - this would definitely lead up to a breakup. When does hearing anything along those lines of '*we need to talk*' lead to anything good?

"Uh, yeah, sure," Phainon stutters, going to put his mug down but then deciding against it, bringing it with him as Mydei leads them over to their dining table.

As Phainon sits down, he notices that Mydei's notebook and pencil case are already laid out on the table, spread across the surface like he's been studying since some godforsaken hour of the morning. Everything is neat -

too neat. The notebook sits squarely in the centre, pages already turned to a blank spread, pencil resting perfectly parallel to the spine. His pencil case has been unzipped and rifled through, pens organised by colour like Mydei had been fidgeting for something to do with his hands.

Phainon watches him for a moment, full of trepidation. Mydei doesn't meet his eyes. He's standing stiffly by the other chair, shifting his weight from foot to foot like he's working up the courage to deliver bad news. Phainon opens his mouth to speak but then closes it again, his teeth clacking together as Mydei finally moves, joltingly pulling the chair out and sitting down far too carefully, like he's hyper-aware of every movement. Everything about this puts Phainon more and more on edge. Mydei is many things - blunt, strong, and sharp-tongued when he wants to be - but *nervous* isn't usually one of them. Phainon can't even recall Mydei acting nervy before big rugby matches against other universities, instead basking in the excitement of a potentially good match. He's never been like this - and certainly not around Phainon.

The quiet clink of Mydei's mug meeting the table startles Phainon out of his thoughts. He flinches slightly, eyes snapping to where Mydei is already moving - gathering up his notebook and pen with a kind of focused urgency, flipping past one page, then another, until he lands on whatever it is he's been meaning to show.

Phainon swallows hard. His heart is thundering in his chest, an erratic rhythm that's all wrong - too fast, too heavy. It echoes in his ears, pounding so violently that for one terrifying moment, he's convinced it might either stop entirely or crack straight out of his ribcage and splatter itself across the table. He grips the edge of the chair to ground himself, knuckles white, trying to prepare for whatever is about to come. But Mydei says nothing yet, his focus finally locking onto a single page. He clears his throat, sitting

up straighter in his chair. Phainon's dread tenfolds as Mydei opens his mouth.

"I have a list -"

Phainon's mouth drops open, a rush of emotions overflowing so much he can't tell them apart. "Ah! Why is it okay for *you* to make a list, but it's embarrassing when I do?! Not fair!"

Mydei levels him with a venomous glare, "Shut up and listen."

Phainon holds his hands up in surrender.

"I have a list -" Mydei ignores Phainon's scoff. "Of *boundaries*."

"Oh," Phainon says simply, guilt creeping back up on him. He supposes it makes sense after he *definitely* crossed the boundaries of what was okay last night.

"Are you going to listen or do I need to bribe you with a treat?" Mydei asks.

"I'm not actually a dog, y'know," Phainon sniffs haughtily, "But… if you could make protein waffles for breakfast, I'll do the dishes?" He throws in

his best pleading look after to hopefully sweeten the pot.

“You’d do the dishes anyway,” Mydei says, flicking at his nose. Phainon pouts and rubs the sore spot. “Fine. I’ll make waffles after this.”

Phainon fist pumps the air, much to Mydei’s dismay, and quickly settles down again, realising that this conversation they’re about to have is important. The weight of it dawns on him quickly, replacing his brief triumph with a flicker of nerves. He clenches his hands into fists on the tops of his thighs to give them something to do, nervously shifting in his seat to try and get comfortable again. Phainon doesn’t even know where to look or how serious his face should be, and no matter how much he tries to make his expression fall neutral, he can’t help the pinch in his brow and the subtle downwards turn of his lips.

“Okay, so, rule number one,” Mydei begins, voice clear and slightly raised in volume. It makes Phainon sit up even straighter, shoulders pushed back as though he’s about to be called upon during a lecture. “Keep any kissing in private. That means nothing happens outside of this flat, got it?”

Phainon salutes, “Got it.”

Mydei nods once, going back to looking at his notepad. “Rule number two. If you want to stop, you have to tell me immediately.”

Phainon’s head jerks back slightly, the thought of *not* wanting to kiss Mydei seems impossible. Ridiculous. Preposterous, even. “Same goes for you,

too,” He tags on.

Mydei blinks at him, “If I want to stop kissing?”

“Yes…?” Phainon says slowly, gesturing to the list. “If I can say no, so can you. We need to be on the same wavelength at all times when doing this. Plus, *you’re* the teacher, so if you don’t wanna teach anymore, you gotta say something.”

Mydei mutters something under his breath that sounds suspiciously like the word *unlikely*, but he shakes his head and his eyes are back on the notebook before Phainon can question it.

“Rule number three…” Mydei trails off, his voice quieter now, eyes glued to the page as though he can’t bring himself to look up. A flush blossoms across his face, starting at the tip of his nose before spreading outwards until his cheeks, ears, and even the slope of his neck are tinged with red. He presses his lips together, clearly debating whether to say it at all.

Phainon watches it all, spellbound and unbearably warm. There’s something about seeing Mydei flustered like this that makes his stomach twist in ways that he’s not prepared to deal with. It makes him want to reach over and feel the heat beneath his palms, under his lips and below his tongue as he tastes the flushed skin for himself.

“No hands under clothes,” Mydei finally finishes, sounding firmer than before, although the embarrassment of the statement clearly still clings to

every syllable.

Phainon feels like the floor should open up and swallow him whole. His entire body tenses, like if he holds still enough, he might actually manage to disappear into the grout between the tiles under him. His face burns hotter than the tea he nearly scalded himself on earlier, and he's not sure if the heat in his chest is shame or something far more dangerous. Probably both. It's obvious they're both remembering last night. How could they not? It's undoubtedly fresh, the feeling of Mydei's hardness at his fingertips makes them tingle, his entire hands turning to static as he wishes he could've had more.

"Sure, easy, I can do that," Phainon replies because he is *stupid* but wants to respect whatever Mydei is saying to him. If it's a boundary - one he's guessing sparked this entire list to begin with - then it's a serious one that he won't cross.

Should he apologise for last night? That'd be the correct thing to do, right? It'd at least soothe something in his soul if nothing else, but deep down, past all the guilt and shame and other tangles of feelings he doesn't want to go into, he doesn't regret it. If anything, he's been thriving off the small touch he got; the peek of Mydei's strong thighs, how they feel, how his touch makes Mydei react, how -

"Rule number 4," Mydei's voice jolts him out of his reverie.

"There's more?" Phainon asks dumbly before he can think twice about it.

“Only this one and the next,” Mydei replies, tapping on the page. “Rule number 4 - ask me before you try something new so I’m prepared.”

“Of course,” Phainon nods solemnly, “A teacher must have a class plan in place.”

“Are you even taking this seriously?” Mydei snaps at him, a little too harshly to be a joke.

“I am,” Phainon replies, making sure his tone is genuine. He reaches out, hesitantly at first, but then gains confidence when Mydei doesn’t flinch as he cups his hands beneath his so they’re both holding up the notebook together. “I promise, I’m listening to every word you say. I’m joking, but not about *this*,” He nods his head towards the list which he can now see.

Its title - ‘*Boundaries for Kissing*’ - is written in loopy, slightly uneven cursive with a red felt tip, the rest of the list carefully penned in neat lines of blue ballpoint ink. Phainon stares at it for a long moment, heart squeezing so tightly in his chest it’s almost painful. It’s just a list - words on a page - but it feels like so much more than that. It’s proof that Mydei thought about this, took time with it, and cared enough to put his feelings and comfort into something tangible. He trusted Phainon enough to sit down and listen, to take him seriously and agree to the terms so they could continue. And he so desperately wants to - he’d agree to just about anything Mydei laid down so he could carry on kissing him.

It’s sweet in a way that catches him off guard, the list so *Mydei* that it nearly knocks the breath out of him. He squeezes Mydei’s hands where they’re

still linked, slow and deliberate, trying to pour every ounce of his sincerity into that one small gesture. He wants Mydei to feel it - that he sees this for what it is. Not a limitation, not a wall, but an invitation to do this right. Together. This isn't a sign that Mydei is giving up on him and shutting him down, this is a sign that Mydei wants it, too.

"Fine," Mydei says, voice rough before he clears his throat. He still doesn't shake Phainon off, but he lets go anyway, returning his hands to his thighs. "The final rule is that if this ever begins to stop feeling like practise, we stop immediately and talk."

"Huh? What do you mean?"

"I mean…" Mydei places his notebook back on the table carefully. "If we begin to develop feelings past friendship, then the deal is off."

Oh, Phainon thinks. The word hits like a pebble dropped into water, rippling out, echoing endlessly in his mind until it drowns out everything else.

Then: *Oh dear*.

And finally - *it's already too late for that*.

It settles over him like a weight, slow and crushing. Mydei says *if*, like it's some far-off possibility, like it's avoidable, like the edge they've been skirting for weeks isn't already miles behind them. But Phainon? He's been there for a while now. Tripping into it without realising since the day they met, then trying to claw his way back up once he did figure it out - only to find himself falling again every time Mydei smiled at him, or helped him with whatever he needed, or went out on a limb over small things. And now: kissing him with so much intent that it feels impossible to have *not* fallen in love with him.

Mydei is that kind of person - the rare kind. The kind so quietly full of love that it leaks out in everything he does, not loud or boastful, but constant. It's in the way he adores animals, especially cats, crouching low to talk to strays like they're old friends and carrying treats in his bag just in case he runs into one. He never walks past them like they're a nuisance or invisible. He sees them - he always sees what other people ignore.

It's in the way he takes care of people without making it a big deal - how he cooks meals for Phainon without asking if he's eaten, just knowing. How he brings entire trays of snacks to group meet-ups like it's nothing, like it isn't the kind of thing that knots something tender in Phainon's chest every single time. Mydei is the type to remember everyone's favourites, sometimes without even being told, he just picks up on it naturally. He makes extras, always, in case someone new joins their group for the night. He hands things over with a quiet '*here*' and never waits for thanks.

It's in the way he listens - *really* listens - without interrupting or trying to fix things that aren't his to fix. The way he puts others first, not because he wants praise, but because that's who he is. Endlessly patient, quietly present, and never lashing out unless someone truly pushed him too far. He doesn't explode - he withdraws, thinks, and responds with a sharpness that's always earned.

Mydei is *proactive*, not reactive. That's something Phainon noticed early on, maybe even before he realised he was paying attention. And maybe that's what shook him the most - how easily Mydei slipped under his skin, how naturally he made space in Phainon's life without ever demanding it. There's something so inherently *good* about him, something calming and rare, and Phainon has cherished that from the beginning. Still does, and he always will.

Far too many have seen Mydei only from the outside: some type of *gym bro*, gruff and blunt, but Phainon knows differently. Those lot haven't seen the way Mydei will kneel down to be on the same level as kids and offer them a hair ruffle after they apologise for misbehaving in the nearby park. They haven't seen the way Mydei offers his module notes out to people who ask nicely, making sure they come with extra post-it notes attached to explain theories further. They haven't seen the way Mydei gives and gives and gives and rarely takes, sometimes having to be forced to sit down and *rest* so Phainon can take over.

Those feelings Mydei is so clearly drawing a line under - so matter-of-factly marking as off-limits - Phainon knows he won't be able to express them now. Not when the line's already been drawn in red felt tip and blue ink. Not when revealing the truth would mean risking what little closeness they're still allowed to share. So Phainon sits there, stock-still and forcing his twitching lips to form the shape of a smile, all while pretending his heart isn't shattering to pieces.

Moving into his university dorm is already far more annoying than Phainon expected it to be. The lift's been packed since seven in the bloody morning - overflowing with boxes, people, and at least one kid dragging in a full-sized keyboard - rendering it completely unusable for him. So he's had to lug his bags up the stairs instead, one at a time, sweat sticking to the back of his shirt by trip two despite it being the start of the autumn months.

Thankfully, his dorm's on the first floor, which means only two winding flights of stairs between him and a place to collapse and catch his breath. *Not* so thankfully, his room is at the absolute end of the corridor. A long stretch of identical beige doors and scuffed skirting boards blur together as he trudges past, his suitcase bumping along behind him and his head spinning slightly with each step. It feels like the hallway goes on forever, not unlike a cursed hotel maze where he's never entirely sure he's already passed the same door twice that he sees in some horror films.

Phainon is thankful to the taxi driver who's stuck around the entire time, helping him by half-heartedly passing things out of the backseat and boot so he can drag it the rest of the way. He's down to the final boxes now, a couple of cardboard ones that hold his stationary and extra bits that he'll inevitably shove into his desk drawers to be forgotten about.

"Wait there, lad," The taxi driver says, jogging around the taxi to place his favourite plush of Bubbles the chimera on top of the already precariously balanced boxes he's holding. "This was in the footwell. I don't do lost and found, alright?"

Phainon nods, blowing a stray piece of hair out of his eye. It doesn't work. It sticks to his sweaty forehead, making him twice as irritable as he was just moments ago.

“Thanks,” Phainon replies, hip-bumping the back door shut until it softly closes. The taxi driver clicks his tongue and immediately rips it open again and slams it shut. That’s what Phainon gets for trying to help, he guesses.

Whatever. It’s all done now, one last trip and he can finally sprawl across his tiny single bed and catch his breath. Maybe even take a quick shower before the shared bathrooms fill up with guys he doesn’t even know yet. With that, he follows the cobbled path up to the dorm entrance, scanning his key fob to get in before entering. He casts a glance at the lift but it’s still full, the doors barely closing on the amount of people in there. Phainon shudders at the thought of being trapped in there - it’s probably sweltering with everyone pressed so close and gladly takes the stairs one last time.

It’s a pain to get the double doors to open for him, the heavy wood creaking on the hinges as he shoulders through, looking up at the stairs with dread. Suddenly, they seem miles long, and even though he frequents the gym and works out regularly, his thighs are starting to ache. With a sigh, he begins the long climb once again. Phainon wonders what he’s going to have to eat after all this - if he should go to the cafeteria or order something instead. Both would require him moving again from his room, so maybe he’ll just rest for now and think of something later when he doesn’t feel like his legs are about to fall off.

Phainon approaches the second flight when, with a surprised shout, Bubbles falls onto the floor and tumbles down, hitting every step on the way. He gapes, unable to process what he’s just witnessed, when someone else enters the stairwell, immediately reaching down to pick Bubbles up off the dirty carpet.

“Oh, hey, that’s mine!” Phainon calls, jogging down the stairs to reach the stranger.

It’s not until he’s about three steps away that he finally looks up at the person holding his plush, and the second he does, Phainon almost falls flat on his ass.

The guy standing there doesn’t move, doesn’t speak - he just watches him, eyes warm and steady, the colour of golden syrup catching the light that filters through the tiny window in a way that makes Phainon’s brain briefly stop working. There’s something about the calm way he holds Bubbles - cupped carefully in both hands, like he’s holding a delicate and important item - that makes the whole thing even more surreal. He gently sets the plush back on top of Phainon’s stacked boxes without a word, as if this is all perfectly normal. As if he isn’t casually reordering Phainon’s entire concept of beauty in the span of thirty seconds.

Calling the guy handsome would be criminally inadequate. He’s stunning. Gorgeous in a way that doesn’t feel entirely fair - like someone crafted him from every one of Phainon’s daydreams and set him loose in the hallway to ambush him. His hair is a mess of soft waves except for the thick braid that drapes over his shoulder, golden blonde at the crown and fading seamlessly into deep red at the ends, as though he’s been dipped in sunset. His frame is tall and broad - almost the same as Phainon’s but a little stockier - biceps stretching the sleeves of his t-shirt. And then there’s his *mouth* - full, slightly pouty, caught in a tiny frown that pinches at his brows and reflects in the curl of the ends of his lips. Phainon has to physically force his gaze to not linger there.

Instead, he gapes. Full-on, unapologetic staring. No subtlety whatsoever. His face burns hot, his tongue stuck to the roof of his mouth, because *what the hell*? How is anyone allowed to look like *that*? That *good*?

“Um, thanks,” Phainon says, voice breaking on the words like he’s a teenager all over again. It makes him flush hotter, especially considering the guy still hasn’t said anything yet.

“No problem,” The man of Phainon’s dreams says, and *oh* - his voice is even hot, too. It’s low, deep, but not gravelly. It’s just set at a nice, masculine timbre that sends a shiver down Phainon’s spine.

“Are you… moving in?” Phainon asks, desperate to know more and to keep the conversation going.

“Yes,” The guy says, reaching up to pat Bubbles on his little sun hat-covered head. “I have one of these, but in red.”

Phainon wants to drop the boxes in his hands and scream to the heavens. He wants to fall to his knees, grovel at this man’s feet and beg him to - well, he’s not entirely sure what, exactly. Kiss him? Step on him? Marry him on the spot? Maybe all three. Yeah, definitely all three, in any order the guy wishes. Maybe Phainon just needs to *do* something, anything, to release the sheer emotional chaos spiralling through him like a tornado in a glass cup.

“Cool,” Is all Phainon says, nodding his head along like a muppet.

“Do you want any help with your boxes?” The guy asks.

“Um, sure,” Phainon stutters, offering him the top box with Bubbles on to carry. “Take care of my son, okay?”

The guy laughs. It’s more of a snort, really, a rough chuckle that shakes his shoulders and makes his eyes curve up at the corners and shows a flash of teeth before it’s gone as quickly as it came about. It makes Phainon *ache* to do something again to make him laugh. Suddenly he wishes he watched more comedy films or stand-up shows to practise the art of on-the-spot jokes.

“I only live on the first floor,” Phainon says as they both begin to walk up the stairs, to which the guy only replies with a quiet hum.

Phainon bites his lip, wanting to glance over his shoulder at him just because he already misses those amber eyes. He doesn’t, focusing everything he has on his shaky knees holding up enough to make it back up the two flights of stairs to the landing. Phainon scans his fob again and pushes open the door, allowing the guy to go ahead of him. He gets a firm nod in thanks and then he catches up.

“I’m right at the end of the hallway,” Phainon says, gesturing with his free hand to the long expanse. “It’s a bit of a pain, right?”

“I’m down this way too.”

“No way,” Phainon perks up immediately, all fatigue washed away. “We’ll be dorm neighbours then!”

“Guess so,” The guy replies.

“Do you, uh, have a name?” Phainon asks, cringing at how badly that came out.

The guy gives him a side-long glance before focusing again in front of him, “Mydeimos.”

“Mydeimos?” Phainon repeats, blinking a few times as it settles in. It’s a strong, powerful, almost regal name that feels good to say. He grins, “I’m Phainon.”

Mydeimos hums again and doesn’t say anything else, which Phainon doesn’t know whether to count as a win or not. They travel to the end of the hallway, finally reaching Phainon’s door that’s already open.

“Just chuck that on top and I’ll leave you to it,” Phainon says, jerking his chin towards the box and plush still in Mydeimos’ hands.

Mydeimos places the box on top of Phainon's one, hands hovering a few inches away to make sure it doesn't suddenly fall. It's strangely thoughtful and it makes Phainon's stomach flip again. He wants to ask Mydeimos out on a date despite only just meeting, but who knows the next time they'll meet? Even though they're in the same dorm building, there's not always a guarantee that they'll bump into each other very often, or enough to get to know each other to warrant Phainon's confidence in asking him out.

"Thanks, Mydeimos," Phainon says, holding back a sigh at the thought of them parting.

"It's fine," Mydeimos waves him off. "Good luck with settling in."

"Yeah, you too!" Phainon replies, entering his room backwards so he can keep Mydeimos' eyes on him for a bit longer.

Mydeimos turns around, though, cutting the contact off quicker than Phainon expected. He takes two steps away, and then rifles around in his jean's pockets, pulling out a set of keys.

"Wait! You live right opposite me?!" Phainon exclaims, eyes wide and hope rising in his gut.

"I said I was down this way," Mydeimos says, not even looking over his shoulder as he unlocks his door.

“True,” Phainon replies, shrugging. He wants to creep up behind Mydeimos and get a look inside his room, but he refrains and stays put. “I’ll see you around?” Phainon tacks on, his voice going higher towards the end of the question.

Mydeimos pauses, turning around with one hand on his door handle. He looks at Phainon, amber eyes flickering from his face to his hands to his legs and then back up again. “Yeah, see you around.”



It turns out that Phainon *does* see Mydeimos around. Quite a lot, in fact. As in, way more than what should be normal, even considering that they live very close to each other. They somehow always leave their rooms at the same time in the morning, playing the game of ‘*no, you go first*’ and ‘*no, you*’ until one of them cracks and pushes past the other and then they realise the hallway is wide enough for both of them.

If they’re not dancing around each other in the corridors, then they’re bumping into each other in the shared kitchen at some ungodly hour of the morning. Phainon is almost always craving instant noodles, but Mydeimos is almost always there before him, standing guard next to the boiling kettle like someone’s going to steal it away from him. It took a few times of them doing this before Mydeimos would fill up the kettle with enough water for the both of them, wordlessly offering it to him after he filled his mug of tea so Phainon could fill up the plastic noodle cup he was holding.

Most of their conversations fizzle out quickly, Mydeimos preferring silence over Phainon's incessant chatter. Every response he gets is measured, brief, like he's rationing his words - and it leaves Phainon floundering more often than he'd like to admit. He'd always thought of himself as somewhat easy-going, or at least laid back enough to befriend practically anyone with ease. It's awkward, kind of humbling, and mostly grounding as Phainon realises this isn't going to be a walk in the park. Befriending Mydeimos won't be instant or easy - it'll take time, patience, and effort. But Phainon isn't a quitter. If anything, the challenge only sharpens his focus. He's going to get what he wants, no matter how many quiet stares or half-shrugs stand in his way.



Then it becomes a thing where even in the laundry room, they meet.

Phainon waits until the last minute to wash his clothing, lugging down a giant bin bag full of it. He knows it's unsightly doing such a thing, but the amount he needs to wash never quite fits into those baskets that everyone else uses. It's his own fault, of course, and it's a habit he has yet to change even after a few months of starting university. This time, the machines are mostly full and already running, and Phainon is bracing himself for defeat when he rounds the corner and finds Mydeimos standing in front of the last available washer, slamming the lid closed with his knee and sipping a carton of some sort of red coloured juice. The art on the side of it looks like a pomegranate split open.

Mydeimos turns around and freezes, catching sight of Phainon.

“Rough morning?” Mydeimos asks, nodding toward the overstuffed bin bag that Phainon is very pointedly not looking at.

“It’s… efficient,” Phainon says defensively, setting it down with a soft thud that feels far too loud even above the rumbling of washing machines.

“They sell laundry baskets at reception,” Mydeimos says, taking a sip from his carton. Phainon can’t help but watch the way Mydeimos’ lips curl around the tiny straw, his cheeks hollowing out as he sucks up the pomegranate juice.

“They’re too small,” Phainon replies belatedly, wrestling his eyes to meet Mydeimos’ - whose eyes are already watching him, one eyebrow raised. Phainon clears his throat, looking away completely and down at his bag of shame.

“There’s washers and dryers at the campus gym if you’re in a pinch,” Mydeimos suggests, taking a seat on the plain wooden bench in front of his machine.

“There are?” Phainon takes a seat beside him, quickly abandoning his bag. They’re not sitting close enough to touch, but Phainon can just about feel the warmth radiating off Mydeimos’ body.

“Although…” Mydeimos trails off, leaning forward to look at the discarded bin bag. “I think dragging that thing with you would pose a problem.”

“Are you questioning my strength?” Phainon says, puffing up his chest. He makes a show of lifting up his arm, pointing to his flexing bicep. “I could totally get all my stuff there, no problem.”

Mydeimos’ eyebrows shoot up. “Maybe you could, but I think your pride would take a hit.”

“Now the man is questioning my *pride*!” Phainon wails, throwing his hands up in the air dramatically.

It gets him a tiny scoff, which he counts as a laugh, which means that he’s *won*. Mydeimos looks good - *too* good, honestly - even now, clearly dressed down in a loose-fitting tee that hangs soft on his frame and worn tracksuit bottoms that sit low on his hips like he’s barely put any effort in. His hair is pulled back into a low, lazy bun, though several strands have escaped, curling at his temples and the nape of his neck in a way that makes Phainon’s fingers twitch with the ridiculous urge to reach out and tuck one behind his ear.

They’re still technically strangers, right? Despite the run-ins, shared boiling water, and the way Mydeimos always welcomes him like he’s not a stranger at all even with his slightly icy demeanour, they barely know each other. That’s what makes it worse - how badly Phainon wants to touch him, and how stupidly aware he is that he doesn’t have the right to.

“Let’s make a bet,” Phainon challenges, a sly grin appearing on his face. He leans into Mydeimos’ side, taking advantage of playing around to get up all

in his space. There's a waft of cologne - something sweet and slightly spiced and entirely mouth watering that almost pushes him off track, but he stays true to his crusade.

Mydeimos looks at him, eyes narrowed. "Go on."

"I bet that I *can* bring my bag to the gym, and beat you in weights afterwards."

Mydeimos gives him a slow once over, the weight of his gaze making something fiery sizzle underneath Phainon's skin.

"And what do I get when you lose?"

"My, my, how forward of you," Phainon leers. "Already thinking you're going to win? I don't think so." He taps his finger on his bottom lip in thought. "When I win… you'll let me call you *Mydei*. How about that?"

Mydeimos' face scrunches up in confusion, "That's it? That's all you want?"

"Sure, why not?" Phainon shrugs, "Your name is nice but kind of a mouthful. Mydei sounds way cuter, don't you think?" He laughs.

“You still haven’t told me what I’m going to win.”

“Whatever you’d like,” Phainon replies, tilting his head to the side to peer up at Mydeimos.

“I’ll think about it,” Mydeimos says vaguely, but it’s enough to make Phainon agree.



The issue isn’t dragging his bin bag full of dirty clothes to the gym. In fact, that’s the least of Phainon’s worries now because he’s currently watching Mydeimos absolutely crush him at weightlifting.

“Shit, fuck, damn it!” Phainon yells, watching with dawning realisation that Mydeimos has well and truly *beaten him*. “How can you lift that much?!”

Mydeimos doesn’t reply just yet, focusing on placing the dumbbell back down on the rack safely, arms trembling under the weight.

Phainon had endured the curious looks and whispers he’d gotten as he made his way to the gym, ignoring them and letting everything roll off of him like water on a duck’s back. But this? *This*? Is an attack on him personally - to his pride, his worth, his assurance that he’d win over Mydeimos.

“Told you so,” Mydeimos taunts, sitting up on the bench and wiping his sweaty face off with a hand towel.

“I can’t believe it, man,” Phainon says, offering him a fresh bottle of cold water. Mydeimos takes it easily, gulping down over half of the contents in one go. “I thought we were evenly matched!”

“We are,” Mydeimos replies, wiping his mouth with the back of his hand.

“That was an entire 20 kgs heavier than my best,” Phainon explains in awe, holding his hand out for Mydeimos to grab and assist, pulling him up onto his feet. Mydeimos stumbles a little, their shoulders bumping, and Phainon has to clutch him by the biceps to steady him. “You pushed yourself too much!”

“I still won,” Mydeimos says, a devastatingly handsome grin tugging at his lips.

Phainon sighs, letting his head hang between his shoulders as he prepares to admit defeat.

“But you also won the first half of the bet.”

Phainon looks up again with glee, “Does that mean I can call you Mydei?”

“Sure,” Mydeimos - *Mydei* - says, shrugging. Phainon realises he’s still holding him up and lets go quickly, taking a few giddy steps back. “Although, if you’d just asked me, I would’ve said yes. No need to embarrass yourself in front of the entire university.”

“Ah, but it’s so much sweeter this way, *Mydei*,” Phainon coos. “I get clean washing and to call you a nickname. It’s a win-win for me!”

“You still don’t know what I want for winning the second half of the bet,” Mydei says, taking another swig of his water.

“Oh, yeah,” Phainon droops, reality sinking in fast. His stomach twists into a tight, nervous knot.

A thousand possibilities fire off in his head all at once, none of them good. What if Mydei wants him to do something humiliating? Or public? Or both? What if it’s something involving dancing in front of the main building’s fountain, or gods forbid, asking out someone on Mydei’s behalf? Phainon isn’t sure he could handle that. His brain spirals, conjuring increasingly absurd punishments with each passing second.

“I want you to test some of my cooking tonight,” Mydei says, bringing Phainon back down to earth.

“Test… your cooking?” Phainon grimaces, “Are you a terrible cook or something? I have a very delicate stomach, y’know!”

“Don’t be a baby,” Mydei says, shoving Phainon’s shoulder playfully. “I’m testing out a new recipe and need a guinea pig to give me an opinion.”

“Okay…” Phainon says slowly, breathing out as much trepidation as he can. “I’ll do it.”



“I cannot,” Phainon shovels in another mouthful of food. “Believe,” Another spoonful, barely even taking the time to chew as he’s already packing in more. “You’ve been keeping your talent away from me!”

“Slow down or you’ll choke,” Mydei says flatly, offering Phainon a tissue. He gratefully takes it, using it to wipe his mouth.

“It’s so good,” Phainon gestures to his plate. “I dunno many culinary terms, but everything just… blends in really well. Yet I can taste everything separately, if that makes sense?”

“It does,” Mydei assures, then lifts a hand to brush the corner of Phainon’s lips, the touch gone before he can fully even feel it. “You had a piece of rice

stuck.”

“Oh,” Phainon says, swallowing thickly past the rice and chicken filling his belly.

Something slow and warm trickles through his veins, so strong and sudden that it’s impossible to ignore, like sunlight seeping through cracks he hadn’t realised were there. His heart thuds, not frantically, but with a quiet insistence - just enough to make him feel it, to know something’s changed.

He gets it then, clear as anything - what he now understands are *feelings*. Not just a passing interest or curiosity, but something deeper. Budding, delicate things begin to stir inside him. They’re small, barely more than a murmur behind his ribs - but they’re *alive*. They feel like the first green shoots of spring breaking through the frost, tentative and undeniable, fragile and real all at once.

Phainon sits there, at the shared kitchen’s messy dining table, surrounded by everyone else’s unwashed plates and general mess, realising that this tight feeling in his chest and lungs is a *crush*. Because, sharing his space with Mydei who is still watching him so imploringly, waiting for more feedback on his food, that everything he feels right now is for him.

He shakes it off with a nervous laugh, the food in his mouth turning to ash as he tries to push past the dread of developing feelings for someone so unattainable.

“Phainon? Are you alright?” Mydei asks, waving a hand in front of his face.

Phainon jumps, plummeting back down to the present. “Yeah, I’m fine.” He lies.

“That was all I wanted to clear up with you,” Mydei explains, and it takes a few moments for Phainon to remember what was going on before he felt his heart shatter in his chest.

“Sure, no worries!” He says as cheerfully as he can, trying so hard to not let anything slip past. “So… waffles?”

“Waffles,” Mydei repeats, nodding his head as he stands up, grabbing their now-cold mugs of tea to dump them out into the sink.

Phainon waits, watching from the side lines as Mydei begins to work around the kitchen. He moves effortlessly, knowing where everything is from their mixing bowl to the bag of flour to the waffle maker, all stacked away in different cupboards and nooks of their kitchen. Phainon was so happy when they moved into their own place because it meant that Mydei could finally spread his culinary wings and buy all the gadgets he could ever need to create masterpieces. It also makes his chest ache, the domesticity of it all, and how much Phainon wishes they were sharing this space in another context.

Not just as roommates. Not just as friends who kiss sometimes. But as partners, lovers, *boyfriends*.

“I want blueberry waffles,” Phainon calls out, eventually gaining enough confidence to move again, immediately attaching himself to Mydei’s back.

“You’ll get what you’re given,” Mydei replies gruffly.

“Hm?” Phainon grins, realising that his situation isn’t *all* bad. He presses a quick kiss to the nape of Mydei’s neck, relishing in the little jump he gets in reply and fierce eyes glowering at him. “That was my plea for blueberries.”

“It was a shit attempt,” Mydei says, pausing in his motions.

“I see,” Phainon says slowly, processing. He grabs Mydei by his hips like he’s done thousands of times before, but this time, he uses his grip to spin him around, pinning him to the edge of the countertop. “What do I have to do to win you over?”

“That isn’t what I meant,” Mydei says through gritted teeth, eyebrows pulled as taut as his shoulders are right now.

Phainon knows Mydei enough to take a guess at what he’s feeling. It isn’t anxiety, no. It isn’t unwillingness, either. No, it’s none of that.

It’s anticipation.

Phainon pouts, making a show of trailing his fingertips up Mydei’s sides, eyes following his movement as Mydei shivers. The action pulls up his hoodie a little bit, and when Phainon’s fingers reach just below his armpits, he changes course. They splay across his collarbones, pushing outwards over the curve of his shoulders until he brings them inwards, cupping each side of Mydei’s neck, his thumbs pressed right over his Adam’s apple. He feels it bob under his touch, and then Phainon is moving again. Higher, upwards, until his hands are cradling Mydei’s jaw, thumbs now rubbing gentle circles across his reddening ears. He’s so sweet, so pliant, already relaxing into Phainon’s touch that it makes him want to *ruin* him.

That terrifying, gaping maw of want rears its ugly head, almost bursting out of him and pouring through his lips as he seals them together, instead focusing on licking across the waxy smear coating Mydei’s mouth. It’s his favourite lip balm, the one that tints his lips even more red than they already are, and tastes vaguely of pomegranate, too. What other flavour would he possibly have? Nothing else would taste this good, this delicious, this *right* against his mouth. Even inside, Mydei tastes faintly of mint, and of sugar that was in his tea.

Sweet, sweet, sweet.

Phainon holds Mydei still, not letting him budge and not willing to let go even when hands come up to his own hips, thumbing across his hip bones over his t-shirt that he so desperately wishes wasn’t in the way. To feel Mydei’s caress against his bare skin would be an entirely new world opened

up in front of him, one that he’s not sure he’ll ever be able to get enough of.

“Have I convinced you yet?” Phainon asks, mumbling the words across Mydei’s lips. He moves one hand again, fitting the swell of Mydei’s cheek into his palm, dipping the tip of his thumb into his mouth, tugging delicately at the corner of his lips.

Mydei swallows, “Of what?”

Phainon feels a flash of teeth against his thumb. They’re still so close, chest-to-chest, thigh-to-thigh, noses brushing and lips ghosting around each other.

Phainon hums, pressing a kiss to Mydei’s lips, then to the corner over his thumb, then to his uncovered cheek. He tilts his head to even press a kiss to the hinge of his jaw, nipping playfully at the skin before he pulls back.

“Blueberries, of course,” Phainon says, grinning when Mydei has to blink himself out of stupor.

“I said you’ll get what you’re given,” Mydei repeats, this time, his voice is thick.

“Sure thing,” Phainon grins, smacking a wet kiss onto Mydei’s cheek before he takes a step back. “Then the blueberries are already out on the counter for no reason?”

“Shut up and go sit down!” Mydei yells, and Phainon laughs loudly, doing exactly as he’s told for the time being.

Chapter End Notes

leave a comment and/or kudos if you enjoyed! thank you so much!!! each comment truly makes my day and motivates me to write more

-

a sneaky kiss right at the end... don't worry, i didn't forget what this fic is supposed to be about! the next chapter will have SO much kissing in it like it's actually driving me insane thinking about writing it lol /pos

i know this chapter was a bit different with everything & i am sorry for the lack of kissing, but i hope you all enjoyed it anyway and that i made it up with phaidei being sappy!

-

let's be friends on twitter/x

Chapter 4: chapter four

Chapter Summary

> “We’ll make our way through your stupid list, just be patient,” Mydei says.
>
> “Aw, you’re so mean to me,” Phainon replies, pouting.
>
> Mydei barks a laugh. “And yet you’re still here.”
>
> Phainon tilts his head to the side, “Well, duh. You’re my best friend.”
>
> “Mhm,” Mydei hums, voice soft, fading into a quiet that stretches for just a moment too long. He looks down at the floor, lashes casting shadows against his cheeks, before lifting his gaze again, steady and unflinching. Their eyes meet, tethered together, and there’s something new in Mydei’s expression that makes Phainon’s breath stutter. His smile is small, but real, curling at the edges like honey melting on a warm spoon. “You’re my best friend, too.”

Chapter Notes

> i'm gonna be real with you all... i barely edited this thing. it's almost 17k words. i ran it through a grammar checker and left it at that LOL T_T so there will be mistakes, errors, inconsistencies and repetition etc etc but i just need to publish this beast and REST!!!! hahahaha
>
> this chapter fought me every step of the way, it was actually unreal. i locked in yesterday and spent 9 hours writing the final scene with minimal breaks and i've still not recovered.
>
> just wanna thank chase atlantic my ultimate support band and fave music for getting me through this, and also to my oomfies who supported me and listened to me break down about this chapter on priv for the past uhhh 3 weeks... LOL

tags have been updated btw!

hope you all enjoy! (´▽`ʃ♡ƪ)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“Do you have the lunch I packed for you?” Mydei asks, poking his head around the kitchen doorway and into the living room.

Phainon glances up and rubs at his eye with his fist, “I think it’s still in the fridge.”

Mydei sighs, rolling his eyes before disappearing back into the kitchen without another word. Phainon shrugs him off easily and turns his attention back to the far more pressing issue: cramming an unreasonable amount of crap into his bag. He shuffles his textbooks around to try and fit alongside his bulky laptop case. Still, it’s nearly impossible as every time he gets everything to sit flat, he realises he can’t zip it up. Not to mention he still has to fit in his pencil case and, thanks to Mydei’s not-so-helpful reminder, his lunch box too. Phainon stares at the pile of stuff grimly, wondering if he could get away with not showing up to his lectures today so he can avoid having to do all this when it’s not even seven in the morning yet. He’s not really a morning person, unless, of course, Mydei is making him breakfast. He’d wake up at whatever time needed to eat that.

“Why are you using that bag instead of your usual one?” Mydei’s voice suddenly asks from beside him, making Phainon jump.

“We need to put a bell on you. Why do you not make a sound when you walk?!” Phainon exclaims, clutching at his racing heart.

Mydei gives him a bizarre look and hands him his lunchbox. It’s cold to the touch, condensation already forming on it as the plastic begins to warm up from the air. Phainon places it down on the coffee table, putting his hands on his hips as he stares down at the mess.

“My backpack is almost falling apart,” Phainon explains. “This is the only other one I have, but as you can see…” He gestures to it.

“I’ll lend you my spare one. You’re embarrassing enough as is with your fashion sense to go around like that,” Mydei says.

Phainon gasps, eyes lighting up with an exaggerated glee as he flings his arms out wide and practically launches himself at Mydei, bundling him up into a hug. “I’ll ignore the jab about my fashion sense for now!” He declares triumphantly, grinning from ear to ear as he squeezes him tightly. It’s such a small thing, but it’s basically a *gift from Mydei*, which automatically means he’s overjoyed at the suggestion.

Also, his fashion sense has improved drastically since moving in with Mydei. If he needs to go shopping for things, Mydei always invites himself along, citing that he can’t be allowed to pick stuff out for himself. Phainon still has no idea what’s wrong with his usual attire and favourite colour combo of purple and yellow, but even Aglaea has passed comments on it whenever they meet up.

Mydei groans and starts shoving at him in protest, but there’s no real strength behind it - more a half-hearted push, like he’s already resigned to

the chaos. His hands scrabble uselessly at Phainon's sides instead, getting a grip on his waist to try and keep them apart that way. Phainon laughs loudly, the sound bright and unfiltered for how early it is in the morning.

Riding the wave of success, Phainon puckers his lips dramatically, aiming for Mydei's cheek with an obnoxiously loud *smooch* sound. But just as he leans in, a hand plants itself firmly between their faces, stopping him short.

Mydei glowers at him, unimpressed. "Don't you even think about it."

The warning is sharp, but Phainon can see the faintest quirk of a smile pulling at the corner of Mydei's mouth, and it makes the moment feel less like a rejection and more like a dare.

Phainon whines against Mydei's palm, half tempted to lick a stripe up it to make him let go. "Why not? I'm just trying to say thanks." The words come out mumbled, hushed against Mydei's hand.

"Kissing is only for practise. What is a kiss on the cheek going to achieve towards your goal?"

Phainon is a little confused by what Mydei means about his goal. As far as he's concerned, there's only one real goal here: to kiss his best friend and somehow get away with it without being called out on how hopelessly gone he is. A very simple, very basic goal, indeed. Does that make him deceitful? Possibly. Does it make him feel bad? Kinda. But does it also fuel him to get

better, to do more, to treat Mydei with every ounce of delicacy and kindness that he deserves? Absolutely.

Every playful nudge, every half-dare they toss back and forth feels like a lifeline, a way to keep pretending that for Phainon, this is all *just* practise. It's a distraction from every thought, feeling and moment between them in pretending that this isn't leading to something bigger, messier and far harder to hide. But he has to - it's the only way things can continue, the only way he gets the best of both worlds; Mydei, as his best friend, their dynamic unchanged while they also kiss. It's getting a taste of something that isn't really his, a decadent ambrosia that belongs to someone else, unclaimed and all for him to take.

"You never complained before," Phainon starts, eyebrows furrowing. Just yesterday, Mydei had allowed them to make out on the sofa without much reason. "Where's all this coming from, hm? It's not breaking any of your rules," He tries to reason, eyes zeroing in on the exact spot where he wants to kiss Mydei. It's not quite on his face tattoo. It's a little lower down, more at the swell of his cheek where he feels the softest.

"...Fine," Mydei says quietly, giving in quickly while his eyes dart to the side as he drops his hand down.

Phainon has to bite the inside of his cheek to tamper down the victorious grin threatening to split his face in two. Every inch of him buzzes with a reckless kind of giddiness, but he forces himself to move slowly, deliberately, as if he rushes too much, he'll scare Mydei off. With no hand left between them to block him this time, Phainon leans in, brushing a feather-light, chaste kiss against Mydei's cheek. It's nothing, really - barely a whisper of contact - but the effect it has is immediate and painfully sweet.

Beneath his lips, he can feel the skin growing warmer, a flush blooming under the surface as Mydei's body can't even pretend not to react.

Phainon pulls back just as slowly, enough to catch a glimpse of Mydei - cheeks, faintly pink, eyes still elsewhere, trying and failing to look unaffected. As usual, something tight and tender curls low in his chest, a whole hoard of butterflies exploding in his stomach.

Gods, he likes him. He likes Mydei *so much* it borders on ridiculousness, especially when he can feel those butterflies double in size when Mydei finally looks him in the eye. Seeing Mydei quiet, bordering on shy from a simple peck, all because of Phainon, feels better than winning any bet or landing any perfect joke. It feels as though he's being handed something rare and precious, something he wants to tuck away somewhere safe and never let go of.

It's like he's standing on top of the world, head held high as if nothing can touch him or bring him down.

"Get off me," Mydei says, genuinely shoving him away this time, but Phainon still laughs because he got what he wanted either way. "I'll go get my other bag."

"Thanks, Mydei!" Phainon calls after him as he walks off towards his room.

Mydei returns shortly after with a simple black backpack, the straps already long enough that they don't need adjusting. "Here," Mydei says, offering it

to Phainon.

“Thanks again,” Phainon replies, accepting the bag. It’s pristine, still completely flat from being unused.

The bag must’ve been kept inside Mydei’s wardrobe because even from a distance, Phainon catches the familiar scent of his fabric softener clinging to the fabric. It’s floral and light, something comforting and clean that wraps around him like a memory. He knows the bottle it comes from well - bright pink, unnecessarily massive, the same one that Mydei used to lug down to the shared laundry room in first year with a deadpan expression despite the shocked looks he used to get.

Now the bottle lives in their kitchen cupboard under the sink, tucked beside the bin bags and cleaning sprays. Phainon has borrowed it a few times out of curiosity, half-expecting his clothes to come out smelling the same. They never did, not really. The scent was there, sure - but it didn’t have that underlying sweetness to it that Mydei has, nor the slight musky notes that pair well with the floral. It didn’t wrap around him or linger on his sheets like it does when it comes from Mydei’s things.

There’s something painfully intimate smelling it now on Mydei’s bag - floral, sweet, musky - and a little worn from being stuck in the same place for so long. If Mydei wasn’t still standing beside him, Phainon would’ve pressed it to his nose already and taken a sniff. Instead, he just brings the bag closer, inhaling as deeply as he can while still being subtle about it.

“Come here,” Mydei says suddenly, the words catching Phainon off guard. Before he can even turn to face him, a pair of warm hands cups his cheeks and tugs him forward with unexpected firmness.

Phainon nearly stumbles, clutching the bag tighter to his chest in slight panic. His eyes go wide, breathing catching in his throat, startled into silence. “Wh -”

“You still have sleep in your eyes,” Mydei murmurs, gaze narrowing with a quiet focus as his thumbs move in to gently wipe at the grit clinging to the corners of Phainon’s lashes. “Did you not wash your face yet?”

The scrape is faintly uncomfortable - just enough to sting - but the touch itself is impossible soft, careful in a way that makes Phainon’s heart flutter. The air in his chest stutters, pulse jumping as Mydei continues, unbothered, completely unaware of the way he’s making it impossible to think straight.

Phainon gulps, the sound embarrassingly loud in the quiet between them. It echoes in his ears, sharp and unmissable, but Mydei doesn’t seem to notice - or if he does, he’s kind enough not to mention it. He wonders if Mydei can also hear his heart racing, *thud thud thudding* against the inside of his chest. They’re so close now. Close enough that Phainon can see the faintest scatter of freckles across the bridge of his nose, like a constellation mapped out in soft brown ink. He’s never noticed them before, now that he thinks about it, but now that he’s seen them, he can’t stop staring.

Mydei’s eyes are just as disarming. Up close, they’re not one colour but many - flecks of amber and gold, a touch of red near the centre, all softened

by the way his lashes line them, blonde and light. Phainon sees himself reflected there, small and wide-eyed, suspended in the middle of all that quiet intensity. The realisation makes something big and heavy weigh down on his shoulders, and there's a stillness to the moment he doesn't dare break. All he can think of, as his heart stumbles and his stomach erupts into butterflies once more, is how easy it would be to lean in and steal a kiss.

But it wouldn't be classed as practise, would it? No. It'd be something purely indulgent, selfish and cruel to his own heart. He wants Mydei in ways he isn't allowed, boundaries set firmly in place to make sure that his true feelings will never be allowed to come out. Phainon isn't even sure he cares about them being reciprocated anymore; he just wants to make sure that Mydei knows he is loved in so many ways. Ways that aren't just friendly and surface level, but something deeper, more passionate and romantic. Kissing is now the only way he can channel all of that into his actions, making sure that while his own thoughts are loud and clear, they are not able to be read.

It's hard.

It's so hard.

Phainon feels his will crumple, but he stands strong. "No, I still need to go brush my teeth as well."

"And you kissed me with that dirty mouth?" Mydei says, sneering as he finally pulls away. Phainon feels a piece of him tear off and drift alongside

Mydei’s hands, lingering on his fingertips before floating down to the floor to be forgotten about.

“I didn’t kiss you on the lips at least,” Phainon says, waggling his eyebrows. “Although that could be arranged?”

“Shut up and go finish getting ready,” Mydei snaps, shoving Phainon towards their bathroom without giving him a chance to defend himself.

His professor will *not* stop talking. Phainon knows it’s their job and all - he gets it, he really does - but when he’s only been half-listening since the second he showed up, he almost feels righteous in his growing annoyance at the endless noise. It’s like static at this point, words blurring into one long, tedious drone that grates against the inside of his skull. If anything, the lecture is just disturbing far more important things - things that matter infinitely more than sports medicine and biochemistry ever could.

Things like Mydei.

Phainon props his chin up in his hand, tuning out the professor entirely as his mind drifts back to the easy way he’d gotten Mydei to laugh yesterday while they ate their waffles; or the way his hair had slipped loose from its bun and curled against his jawline, practically begging for Phainon to reach out and tuck it behind his ear.

He thinks about how close they'd sat together on the sofa during the afternoon, enjoying the random documentary on television as his professor goes to the next slide. He thinks about how simple it had felt as they turned in towards each other, the gravitational pull between them becoming too much as Phainon cupped Mydei's cheeks while his professor called on one of them to answer a question. He thinks about how he'd listened to every word Mydei had said then, each direction, each teaching moment. *Go slow* ; or *you can press harder* ; or *be careful of your teeth* as his professor turns his back to the class to point at something on the board.

Every detail of him tugs insistently at the corners of Phainon's focus, sweet and stubborn just like Mydei, acting like an itch he couldn't reach even if he tried. He hasn't even started on how plush Mydei's lips are; or even begun to dissect the types of noises he makes, ranging from moans to whimpers, even whining sometimes when Phainon licks deep into his mouth and slides their lips together *just* right. That's not including the way Mydei grips tightly onto him: hands on his arms, his waist, fingers threaded through his hair that gently tugs at his roots.

Phainon jolts out of his own daydreams, his hairline slightly sweaty as he tries to reel himself back in. He's in *public* after all, and he can't afford to get a hard-on during a lecture. He has to eventually walk out of here in twenty minutes, and at the rate his brain is going, that won't be enough time to cool off if he doesn't stop right now.

Surprisingly, his phone buzzes in his pocket. His professor still has his back to the class, so he takes it out and hides it under the desk, peering curiously at the screen as he checks his notifications.

[9:49 am] Castorice:

Hello, Phainon. Do you want to have lunch together today? My classes finish at 1 pm (❁´◡`❁)

Phainon blinks in surprise at the message lighting up his lock screen, but the small smile that spreads across his face is genuine. He and Castorice hang out every couple of weeks, slipping it into their hectic schedules like clockwork, a quiet tradition they've built up since mid-way through first year. She always seems to know when he needs a break, even if he hasn't said a word about it.

As he types out his response, he wonders idly if she'd checked their shared calendar before asking. It wouldn't surprise him; Castorice was terrifyingly organised like that. He, Mydei, Castorice, Aglaea and Anaxa all input their classes into a calendar app so they can organise meet-ups easier without having to mess around too much in discussing when to do it. So it was no coincidence that his lectures also ended at 1 pm today, the exact window she's suggesting. It feels less like a casual invite and more like she's already decided, and honestly, Phainon's not all that inclined to argue against it.

[9:50 am] Phainon:

yeah sure! it's been a while

do you want me to invite mydei?

[9:50 am] Castorice:

He's busy until 3 >﹏< Everyone else doesn't finish until later. It's just you and me today.

Phainon knows he should feel at least a tiny bit guilty at the way his heart sinks with that knowledge. There's absolutely nothing wrong with it being just him and Castorice hanging out - it's normal. *Good*, even. After all, he lives with Mydei. He sees him more times in a day than he sees his own reflection, sharing breakfasts, late-night study sessions, and every other silent moment in between.

And yet here he is, feeling mopey about missing out on *one* shared lunchtime like some hopeless idiot. At this point, he could compare himself to a pathetic puppy - one that clings desperately to its owner's heels and cries the second they're out of sight, probably with a bad case of separation anxiety to match. The thought makes him groan quietly, still aware that he's in the middle of class right now, and he begins to type out his response. It doesn't do much to shake the feeling as it lingers, embarrassing and enlightening all at the same time.

[9:52 am] Phainon:

no worries! see you outside block c? :-)

[9:52 am] Castorice:

Perfect. See you then! o(*￣▽￣*)ブ

He locks his phone and pockets it, giving a quick glance at the front to make sure the professor didn't notice. By the looks of it, they didn't, going by the way they're gesturing furiously at the board with a detailed diagram of calf muscles plastered across the screen.

The walk to Block C isn't far once Phainon finally escapes the endless lectures and workshops that had been dragging the morning down. His bag bounces against his back with every step, and by the time the main courtyard comes into view, he's already scanning the area for Castorice. It doesn't take long to spot her - she's perched on the edge of a lunch bench, her long hair catching the breeze, half-braided and half loose, the sun glinting off the purple strands.

Phainon breaks into a jog without thinking, weaving through the small groups of students milling around. His heart lifts a little just seeing her there, a smile stretching across his face as he waves at her, hoping to catch her eye. Castorice turns at the sound of his approach, shading her eyes with one hand against the afternoon glare, a similar bright smile lighting up her face when she sees him.

Phainon skids to a stop in front of her, "Hey, Cas!"

"How were your lectures?" Castorice asks as she watches him sling Mydei's loaned bag carefully onto the bench first, handling it like something fragile before clambering over the seat to sit down.

The sun is warm on his shoulders, the chatter of students a low hum in the background. Castorice shifts to face him more fully, her legs swinging idly beneath the bench. "They were okay. *Super* long though. And I hate the jelly we have to use when doing ultrasounds, it's so… messy." He shudders.

Phainon wriggles around in his spot to try and get comfortable. He unzips his backpack and takes out his water bottle and lunch box, frowning slightly at how lukewarm they both feel now. The warm temperature inside the classrooms hadn’t helped, and being shoved into a bag definitely didn’t aid it either. The water would be fine, but he was more concerned that Mydei’s lunch would be ruined - not just by the temperature but by being jumbled around in his bag all day.

He unclips the four sides and lifts the lid off, immediately hit by a wave of mouth-watering scent that fills the air. The rich aroma of spiced, herby pork mingles with the warm, nutty smell of brown rice, all layered over the slight sweetness of charred, caramelised vegetables. As usual, it smells like something out of a fancy restaurant instead of a packed lunch, and Phainon’s stomach growls in eager approval before he even gets a proper look at it.

“Did Mydeimos prepare that?” Castorice asks.

“He sure did,” Phainon rubs his hands together excitedly and fishes out a small tub with utensils in it. He picks the spoon out and eagerly takes a bite, humming happily when the flavours all melt against his tongue. “Do you wanna try some?”

“No, it’s okay,” Castorice waves her hands in a denying gesture. “I packed my own lunch, I’ll eat it a bit later.”

Phainon shrugs and takes a sip of his water. “How about your classes? Did they go okay?”

“Mhm. We’re studying the fiction genre at the moment, and I decided to do my assignments on Ancient Greek romance.”

“Oh? Aren’t they all quite morbid?” Phainon asks, making sure to swallow his food before he talks.

She shrugs, rifling around in her bag for something. Eventually, she pulls out a purple water bottle, “Not all of them! Even if they are, they’re so romantic.” Castorice sounds slightly wistful as she speaks, a small smile on her face. It’s nice to see her smiling, and especially nice to see her so passionate about something. “My favourite one is about a young man who carved his lover’s name into a tree and told her it would outlive them both. Then, he swore he’d return every spring to kiss her beneath it.”

“Why does that still sound kinda… sad?” Phainon questions, twisting the cap of his water bottle. He has some powder electrolytes hidden somewhere in the front pocket that he wants to add. The sudden heat and exhaustion of the day are making him feel seriously dehydrated and slightly loopy.

“I suppose so, if you focus on the fact that the tree will outlive them,” Castorice says, tilting her head to the side thoughtfully. “But if you read the rest of it, the meaning is more that no matter how long they live, they’ll spend their most precious moments together under a blossoming tree.”

Phainon finds the packet and rips it open with his teeth, dumping it into his water. He hopes the lemon flavour will freshen it up a bit. “That does sound nice…” He trails off, absentmindedly shaking his bottle to mix in the powder.

Phainon can’t help but think of Mydei then - what it’d be like to spend all his time under the shade of a giant tree that protects them from the sun, but lets enough light through the leaves that it coats them in a tender warmth that they can bask in together. He pictures trying to carve their initials into the bark, snickering while he does. He knows for a fact that he’d begin the process, clumsily outlining their names until Mydei snatches the knife away from him and finishes it off perfectly.

“What about you? How are your classes?” Castorice asks, her voice breaking him out of his daydream. He really needs to stop drifting off so easily.

“They’re okay,” He takes another bite of his food. “Everything is so much harder now than it was in secondary school. I feel like I’m slacking even though all I do is live and breathe sports science!”

Castorice chuckles lightly, “You’re doing great, Phainon. I think we’re all more surprised you haven’t caved and changed majors to join Mydeimos in History class.”

“I wouldn’t do that!” Phainon sniffs haughtily, then stares down at his packed lunch. “I mean… I did think about it -” Castorice’s laugh cuts him off. “- But I decided against it! I love history, especially the antiques side,

but there’s so much *stuff* to remember.” He finishes, talking over her increasingly loud laughter.

“Oh, Phainon! Please, no need to lie to me,” Castorice says, waving her hands in front of her face as she tries to stifle her laughter still.

Phainon huffs, pouting sulkily. “No need to rub it in. I know I’m a *bit* pathetic.”

“You said it, not me, remember?” Castorice replies, finally calming down. Her humour remains only in the way it lights up her eyes and the slight twitching of her lips. “It’s hard to remember how much I actually love my degree when I’m swept up in endless assignments and exams, but when I really think about it, all the good feelings come back to me eventually.”

Phainon nods slowly, “I suppose you’re right. I really wanna graduate and use my degree for a career, y’know?”

“It’s only natural,” Castorice says. Then, her expression changes. It’s still mirthful, but there’s something else lurking behind her eyes now. “I do have a question, though.”

“...Go on,” Phainon says hesitantly, taking another quick bite of his pork and rice. It’s absolutely delicious, and he wishes he had a whole pot full of it instead of a tiny lunchbox.

Castorice looks down at the table, her fingers interlocked before her. “You’ve been glowing this entire time. Has something happened? Something… to do with Mydeimos?” She says his name quietly, as though she’s conspiring with him over something.

Phainon instantly thinks of kissing Mydei, and he laughs, soft and almost to himself, scratching at his cheek as heat rises there. The memories hit in pieces - Mydei’s breath hitching just before their mouths meet, the way his hands twitch slightly at his sides like he isn’t sure where to hold, the scent of whatever citrus shampoo he’s using lingering faintly in the air. Phainon can’t help but see more in his mind’s eye, carried away by the current of Mydei’s lashes fluttering when their noses bumped together, how his lips had tasted warm, familiar at this point, yet still hesitant in the first few moments.

“Not really,” Phainon finally answers, having to clear his throat a few times afterwards.

“You’re lying,” Castorice calls him out immediately, taking a pointed sip out of her water bottle. “I’m here to listen to whatever it is you’re hiding from me, though.”

“I’m not -” Phainon sighs, shoulders sagging. Mydei never said he couldn’t *tell* anyone, right? “We came to an… agreement.”

“Ah! To begin a relationship?” Castorice replies excitedly.

“No way, Mydei doesn’t want that from me,” Phainon shakes his head, swallowing a mouthful of his electrolyte water. “It’s… uh… well, kinda embarrassing. I think.”

Castorice perks up, her eyes bright. She gently clasps her hands together. “Did you confess to him?”

“No! I just said… Ugh, never mind. We’re…” Phainon trails off, suddenly feeling very silly about this whole thing. “We’re… practising kissing. With each other.”

Phainon watches all the joy on her face drain away, leaving her skin looking pallid and sallow. Castorice practically wilts like a dying flower, the smile on her face dropping off as her hands fall limply to the table. “And you haven’t told him how you feel?”

“It’s not like that. It’s just a thing we do,” Phainon explains, voice shaking a little, trying to defend himself.

“Phainon,” Castorice starts, placing her warm hands over his on the table. She squeezes, “Be careful, okay? I know how much you lov -”

Phainon blushes up to the roots of his hair, eyes widening into saucers as he shushes her quickly. He glances around to make sure no one else is near, and thankfully, everyone is spread out and too far away. “Okay, okay! You don’t have to say it!” He hisses.

Castorice offers him a tiny giggle and pats his hands, “I’m guessing it’s good, going by how red you are right now?”

“That’s because you’re embarrassing me!” Phainon retorts.

She pulls her hands away and places them in her lap. “Fine. I won’t badger you. Although if Aglaea finds out, I can’t promise you she won’t give you a good dressing down about it…”

Phainon shudders at the thought. Not just of Aglaea finding out and watching him with those haunting, misty-eyed stares of hers, but at the idea of his *thing* with Mydei spreading. The thought of it slipping out into the world and out of his control makes him feel sick to his stomach. Who knows what people would think or what they would say? He might be overthinking it, but the idea of people perhaps talking about it as the latest campus gossip in dorm kitchens or in whispered corners of seminar rooms makes his skin crawl. It feels *wrong*.

Not because he’s ashamed - he doesn’t think it’s that, not really, not when there’s so much else going on - but because what they have right now is fragile. Unspoken. Mostly unnamed. It’s something small and precious that only exists in the quiet moments between them, suspended in the space where practise kisses are the only thing Phainon allows himself to take too much of, greedy to his core. And the idea of all that being exposed - of people *knowing* - feels like being flayed open and strung up for display, his feelings dissected, his beating heart laughed at.

“Enough about this. It’s not that big of a deal, anyway. How are Aglaea and Anaxa getting on? I haven’t heard much from them recently.”

Castorice smiles, a tiny, slightly evil thing, and launches into her latest conspiracy theories about the two.

As soon as Phainon gets home, he shrugs off the weight of the day like a heavy coat. He clumsily kicks off his trainers in the entryway, staring down at them despondently before picking them up and shoving them onto the shoe rack. Everything feels so exhausting now that he’s done with his classes and catching up with Castorice. Phainon shuffles further into the flat, shedding his backpack by the coffee table while making sure not to let it hit the ground too harshly, before he collapses onto the sofa in a heap. The quiet hum of their shared space greets him: faint traffic noise coming through the slightly open living room window, and he can just about hear the ticking of their kitchen clock. Yet it all feels a little too still without Mydei taking up space here alongside him.

Phainon sighs, bottom lip jutting out as he lets himself collapse onto the sofa. He doesn’t even bother turning on the TV. He absolutely could - the remote is within reach, but he leaves it untouched, choosing instead to lie in silence and attempt to decompress. The room is quiet - *too* quiet - however, he still doesn’t move to change that. Phainon stretches his legs out instead, letting his feet dangle off the edge of the cushion while his head rests against the stiff armrest. The angle is awkward and will probably give him a crick in his neck later, but for now, he lets it be.

Pulling his phone from his pocket, he idly scrolls through social media, barely taking in the filtered photos and curated captions as the minutes tick on. The clock at the top of his screen reads past 3 pm. Mydei should've been home by this point. He should already *be here*, with tired eyes and a sigh, muttering complaints about disorganised seminars and how the researchers are late in getting back to him again. The flat always feels fuller when Mydei's around. More alive, more balanced. Less of Phainon having time to dwell on things he'd rather not remember, and more time focusing on his best friend.

Phainon had even dragged out his lunch with Castorice longer than usual, lingering until the conversation ran dry and his excuses ran out, all just to buy himself a little more time before coming back to an empty flat. He thought he'd timed it perfectly - arriving back a few minutes past 3, enough time to settle in and then before he could relax too much, Mydei would magically appear before him and distract him.

Being alone - *really* alone - is hard for him in a way he doesn't often admit. He thinks Mydei has a general idea of how much he hates it, but he's never said anything to him in regards to it. It gives his thoughts too much room to spread out, curling around the corners of his mind like smoke, clinging to things and dragging memories he thought he'd packed away into cardboard boxes inside his head. Because when the flat is too still, when the space beside him on the sofa is unoccupied, and the kitchen is quiet without the smell of cooking, Phainon is reminded of a time before Mydei. Before the warmth and the quiet understanding, before shared meals and gentle teasing, before having someone who simply *knew* him.

In those moments, it's too easy for old feelings to creep back in - loneliness, uncertainty, the ache of being surrounded by people and still feeling distant. Mydei changed all that without even meaning to, just by being there. Just by *staying*. And now, with only silence for company and a ticking clock,

Phainon feels it again - that quiet, clawing discomfort he never quite figured out how to deal with.

Phainon finds himself perking up at every sound - the rattle of pipes, footsteps from the floor above - but none of them are *him*. Then, just as he's starting to spiral more, he hears it: the familiar click of the front door lock turning, followed by the soft jangle of keys he knows as well as his own. He can practically see the massive group of charms attached, from a chibi lion's head to a soft red plush bunny that matches the blue one on his own set of keys. Phainon's heart leaps in his chest, and then he's leaping up from the sofa too.

He practically flies over to the doorway, socks skidding slightly against the hardwood floor. He doesn't even know why he's moving so fast, he only knows that he *has* to be there, has to see Mydei the second he steps inside like some overenthusiastic golden retriever. The moment the door swings open, Phainon is already there, waiting, chest heaving from the sudden exercise and adrenaline, and a grin starting to form on his face.

Mydei doesn't notice him at first. His eyes are fixed on the floor, the usual furrow between his brow suggesting he's deep in thought - or maybe just tired. The front door clicks shut with a soft *snick* behind him, automatically locking as he moves with his usual quiet grace, bending down to unlace his trainers. He slips them off one by one, nudging them into the cubby beside the show rack with his toes; always precise, always tidy. There's a slow, habitual rhythm to it that Phainon begins to think he shouldn't be here to witness.

On the other hand, Phainon is practically vibrating in place. It feels as though he's been waiting all day since they parted this morning to see him

again. Now that Mydei is finally home, he can barely contain the way his entire body seems to light up. He rocks on the balls of his feet, arms twitching slightly as he resists the urge to fling them around Mydei's shoulders the second he looks up. His smile is already there, wide and fully formed, stretching the corners of his lips with the kind of earnestness he can never quite hide when it comes to Mydei.

The anticipation builds with each second that passes - Phainon watching him, waiting to be acknowledged. It's ridiculous how giddy he feels over something as simple as Mydei walking through the door, but it feels like all those dark clouds that were beginning to loom over him have been chased away. After a day that felt like it dragged on for eternity, even though he had fun chatting with Castorice, and after sitting in silence and missing him more than he probably should, this small moment feels monumental.

He gets his wish soon enough, Mydei's amber eyes finally falling on him, widening in shock as he blinks a few times. "Why are you loitering in the doorway?"

"Welcome home!" Phainon exclaims, allowing himself one small gesture: a quick clap of Mydei's shoulder, hard enough to make the poor guy stumble forward a few steps into his space.

"Thanks," Mydei replies sceptically, eyebrows raised. "You didn't answer my question."

"I missed you," Phainon answers, trying to aim for a joking tone, but it comes out more serious than he expected.

Mydei doesn’t say anything at first. No biting response, no ribbing retort. He just looks at him, golden eyes flickering over Phainon’s face like he’s searching for something hidden beneath the surface. It makes Phainon squirm a little, nerves tightening in his chest as he’s being carefully unravelled thread by thread. Maybe Mydei will see right through him; maybe Mydei will figure it out without him having to say a word. He’s done it before.

“Alright,” Mydei acquiesces easily without pushing, lifting one of his hands to pat Phainon on the head a few times. “What a good boy.”

Phainon can’t help but preen at the attention, cheeks warm as he hums contentedly and leans into the touch. He butts his head up just a little, chasing after the affection. “Did you have a good day?”

Mydei scoffs, retracting his hand. Phainon feels slightly bereft without it. “If you count my lousy group not showing up for the presentation, then sure.”

Phainon huffs a laugh, “I’m guessing they all suddenly had something else going on?”

Mydei shrugs, brushing past Phainon to enter the flat. He hangs his hoodie up on the peg along with his bag before walking towards the kitchen. Phainon trots after him, following close behind so they can still chat.

“Not even that. They just stopped replying to my texts, but they emailed the prof to say they were ‘sick’ and that I’d handle everything.”

Phainon scrunches up his face in distaste, watching as Mydei opens the fridge door and begins searching for something. “Is that even allowed? Surely they won’t get any marks?”

Mydei grunts, gathering up an armful of fresh greens and a packet of cold-cut ham. “You know how my prof is. A complete pushover. I don’t see why anyone bothers, he’d just let everyone off if it meant less work for him.”

“Did the presentation go well at least?” Phainon asks hopefully.

“Considering I did all the work anyway, yeah,” Mydei mutters as he lays all the veg out on the countertop. “How was your day?”

“Good! I met up with Cas for lunch,” Phainon starts, dragging out one of the dining table chairs to sit down on. He sits on it backwards, facing Mydei as he crosses his arms over the top and rests his chin on his forearms. “We had a good catch-up and gossip. Apparently, Aglaea and Anaxa aren’t talking.”

Mydei turns around to face Phainon. “I didn’t know you were meeting her today.” He sounds strange, his voice flat.

“Neither did I,” Phainon replies, eyebrows arching. “I did ask her if I should invite you, but she said you were busy.”

“I would’ve come anyway,” Mydei says simply, as though those words don’t shoot straight through Phainon’s heart.

“Missed me, too, huh?” Phainon grins teasingly.

“Shut up, HKS,” Mydei gives him the middle finger as he swears, turning his back towards him again. It doesn’t matter, his hair is pulled up into a high ponytail, exposing his reddening ears.

Phainon sighs, almost dreamily. “Can I kiss you?”

There’s a loud clatter - a knife hitting the glass cutting board, or Mydei’s hands slamming down on the edge of the countertop. He throws his head over his shoulder, “Quit messing around!”

“I’m not,” Phainon whines, standing up from the chair. He doesn’t bother pushing it back into place just yet, favouring making his way over to Mydei. He’s fully turned around again, eyes narrowed and lips pursed in displeasure.

Phainon places his hands on either side of Mydei’s hips, grabbing onto the counter’s edge for balance, boxing him in. Mydei looks tired, worn around

the edges, soft in his flushed cheeks and hissy in demeanour. “Let me kiss you.”

“Not here,” Mydei replies, bristling. “Why are we always kissing in the kitchen?”

“We’ve kissed in the living room,” Phainon begins. “Are you suggesting we kiss elsewhere? We’ve not done it in the bathroom yet, or in our bedrooms -”

“I told you to shut up!” Mydei cuts him off, voice raised. It’s not angry, no, he just seems…

“Are you *embarrassed*?” Phainon asks, finishing his own thought. He gives Mydei a once-over, starting from his tight t-shirt that sculpts itself around his pecs, and he has to bite back another dreamy sigh at the sight. He drags his eyes upwards, across the low neckline that lends him a glimpse of Mydei’s prominent collarbones. Up higher to his throat, Adam’s apple bobbing with each swallow, to the curve of his chin, then to his lips. He stops there, unable to tear his gaze away. “I’ll kiss you wherever you want, Mydeimos.”

Phainon isn’t sure if he means kissing Mydei in a different room, or somewhere else, except his lips.

“We’ll make our way through your stupid list, just be patient,” Mydei says.

“Aw, you’re so mean to me,” Phainon replies, pouting.

Mydei barks a laugh. “And yet you’re still here.”

Phainon tilts his head to the side, “Well, *duh*. You’re my best friend.”

“Mhm,” Mydei hums, voice soft, fading into a quiet that stretches for just a moment too long. He looks down at the floor, lashes casting shadows against his cheeks, before lifting his gaze again, steady and unflinching. Their eyes meet, tethered together, and there’s something new in Mydei’s expression that makes Phainon’s breath stutter. His smile is small, but real, curling at the edges like honey melting on a warm spoon. “You’re my best friend, too.”

Oh.

Oh.

Phainon heart aches - tender and sudden. It swells and squeezes all at once, as if those five little words are too much for it to contain. His grip on the edge of the countertop tightens, knuckles pale as he anchors himself against the surge of emotion rising in his throat. There’s a lump there now, thick and impossible to swallow past, and he doesn’t trust himself to speak just yet. Mydei means it - Phainon knows he does. And that knowing, that absolute certainty, is what undoes him. It’s not just the words - it’s how

Mydei says them. It’s how he looks at him like he’s something precious, and maybe to Mydei, Phainon is.

It’s as painful to hear as much as it’s heart warming to know that Mydei feels the same. And that’s okay, that’s enough for now because even if Phainon can’t have Mydei in his entirety - the way he *wants* him so much, so ardently and so desperately - he can truly live with what he’s been given. If that’s just Mydei’s friendship: encompassing, caring, and loving all at once, then that’s what he’ll take.

Phainon finally swallows past the lump in his throat, fighting back tidal waves of emotion, a whole tsunami brewing in the pit of his stomach. He leans in, pressing a quick peck to the tip of Mydei’s nose.

“So what are you going to make us for late lunch?”

Mydei rolls his eyes. “You better cross off ‘nose kiss’ from your list.” Phainon backs off, taking a few steps back to put space between them. “Did you not already have the lunch I packed for you?”

“Obviously I did, but I’m never gonna turn my nose up at more of your cooking, am I?”

“It’s hardly cooking,” Mydei says, twisting around to grab a packet from the top cupboard. “I was just going to make wraps.”

“I want one!” Phainon says, trying his best not to crowd Mydei again.

Mydei shakes his head and sighs, but pulls an extra wrap out from the packet anyway.

Afternoon bleeds into evening like ink dropped into water, slow and seamless. The sky outside shifts in lazy gradients - vibrant orange softening into amber, a hint of rose blooming along the horizon. Golden light pours through the open window, diffused by the gauzy curtain fluttering in the breeze, painting the room in a soft palette of reds, yellows, and delicate pinks. Everything glows like the world itself is relaxing, just as they are in this moment.

Phainon sits tucked into the corner of the sofa, his side pressed just slightly against Mydei’s. It’s not much, but it’s enough to feel the warmth radiating off him, grounding and so very present. It’s enough to make Phainon’s heart beat a little too loudly in his chest. He doesn’t lean his head against Mydei’s shoulder, though he wants to. The moment feels too precious to risk disturbing like a snow globe he’s afraid to shake. Their laptops sit balanced on their thighs, the keys clicking now and then, a light soundtrack beneath the hush of an almost-muted television.

Mydei hasn’t stopped typing for the last twenty minutes, an occasional click of his trackpad the only thing disturbing that. His glasses have slipped low on his nose, and he hasn’t bothered to push them back up, his face pinched in concentration. His brows draw together every now and then, lips pursed, and Phainon is hopelessly, foolishly captivated. He can’t tear his gaze away,

no matter how much he *needs* to, considering this paper needs to be submitted before midnight tonight. However, the fading sunlight highlights the curve of Mydei's jaw and the faint shadow catching on the slight stubble regrowing there. Phainon swallows thickly, wondering how it'd feel underneath his fingertips if he brushed over the short hairs.

"I can feel you staring. Pay attention to your coursework."

"*Mydei*," Phainon drones, shoulders sagging. He kicks his feet out childishly, "We've been working for ages now! Can't we have a break?"

Mydei sighs and turns his head towards him, pushing his glasses back up to perch on the top of his nose. "*Phainon* and *breaks* should not exist in the same sentence. You'll never finish it on time if you don't crack on with it now."

"C'mon," Phainon elbows Mydei in the arm, "Just a quick ten-minute refresher?"

"To do what?" Mydei asks flatly, and then his face morphs into disgust. "You better not be thinking about kissing me right now."

"No," Phainon says far too quickly, practically talking over Mydei before he's even finished.

“You’re a terrible liar.”

“But I’m not a terrible kisser, yeah?” Phainon responds, batting his eyelashes in hopes of trying to win Mydei over. He closes his laptop lid and places it on the coffee table, taking Mydei’s away from him as well and placing it next to his own. Mydei, for some reason, doesn’t stop him.

“Now you’re fishing for compliments,” Mydei says, grimacing. “What kiss do you want to tick off next?”

Phainon has to bite down on the inside of his cheek to stop the rush of excitement bursting out. His whole body buzzes with a gleeful anticipation, the word *yippee*! racing through his veins.

“Um…” He mumbles, trying to sound casual, yet that one word betrays the excitement clawing at his chest. His brain scrambles, flicking back through the list he wrote weeks ago - the one filled with every kind of kiss he had the balls to write down. “A… hand kiss?”

Mydei blinks at him, then lowers his gaze slowly. “Right,” He replies, voice flat but not unfriendly. His eyes are focused down at his hands as if he’s just remembering they exist.

Phainon follows the movement, and his stomach flips. Mydei’s hands are beautiful - strong and certain, with broad palms and fingers that are just slightly calloused at the tips, a quiet record of all the tasks he tackles without complaint. But there’s something undeniably delicate about them,

too. His knuckles sit just beneath smooth skin, the fine bones and tendons shifting under every subtle movement. They're graceful in their own right - hands that move with intention, never wasteful or fidgety like Phainon's own.

He can't help but allow his mind to wander as he thinks about how those hands cook for him; how they type away endlessly during study sessions like they were just doing a moment ago; how they gently wiped the corner of his eye when he'd been half-asleep and didn't realise there was still grit lingering there. They're hands that *care*. And now they're resting there on his lap, palms turned slightly up, waiting - maybe a little hesitant, maybe a little curious.

Phainon's heart gives a strange flutter. He'd blurted out '*hand kiss'* because he felt it was the safest one to pick right now. Now, though, he realises how unbearably intimate it'll be to kiss someone's hand. It feels almost reverent, honest, and as he looks at them now, so familiar and yet freshly mesmerising - all he can think is: *don't mess this up*.

Mydei sticks one of his hands out, almost shoving it in Phainon's face. It's horribly earnest, especially paired with Mydei's determined face as he offers his hand up to be kissed. "Make it quick."

But Phainon can't do that. So he reaches out and takes Mydei's hand gently between his own, cradling it. His thumbs rest over the knuckles while his fingers curl softly around Mydei's palms. He brings them closer, lowering them to the height of his mouth with a patience he's newly developed. His thumbs trace slow circles over the ridges and dips of bone, feeling the way the skin ripples along with the action. He chances a glance upwards: Mydei's posture is straight, his shoulders squared, jaw firm. He looks

unreadable at first, but there’s something unsure in the way his brows draw together.

Phainon goes even slower then, leaning in to press a kiss to the line of Mydei’s knuckles, lips barely brushing at his own thumbs. He wants to convince him of something, yet he’s not sure what. The kiss is a soft, brief thing - almost ceremonial in its tenderness. For Phainon, it’s just the beginning.

“Done?” Mydei asks, his voice low.

“Not yet,” Phainon murmurs, the words breathing back at him from being pressed too close to Mydei’s skin.

As always, Phainon *has* to make the most of what he’s been given. For now, it’s a free run of Mydei’s hand. He doesn’t have to stay where he is, so he kisses Mydei’s knuckles again and begins to move. He flips Mydei’s hand over, thumbs settling in the centre of his palm. His eyes trace the lines - *palmar flexion creases,* his brain supplies. Their only purpose is to allow the skin to move and bend while flexing without being constricted, but the lines themselves hold so much more meaning. Life, heart, fate, *love*, all this destiny and knowledge rolled up into the indentations he can follow. Phainon doesn’t know much about palm reading or anything of the sort; his interest in the body ends at what he can do to help it medically rather than spiritually, but he still hopes that there’s a line here that suggests their entwining lives. He wants there to be something so deeply ingrained of him and Mydei’s existence together that it was formed at birth and is sprawled across his palm for as long as he lives.

He kisses the line that curves over the muscle for his thumb, slow and deliberate, before shifting lower, trailing his mouth to the base of his fingers. Phainon pauses there, lips barely touching skin, and he feels it: the flicker of Mydei's pulse beneath the surface. It's quick, too quick - *thump, thump, thump* - and it resonates through Phainon like a spark catching wood. He lifts his gaze steadily, looking up at Mydei through the silver veil of his lashes. Their eyes meet, and the air changes. It grows thick, viscous in his lungs as he breathes it in and exhales. Mydei's face is still mostly unreadable, unchanged in its sternness, but his stillness speaks for him instead, as though he's bracing for impact. Phainon swallows hard, heart thundering behind his ribs, then moves again.

His lips map a slow path across Mydei's palm, brushing over the fine lines and warm skin, venturing all the way to the dip where it meets his wrist and then back down again. He doesn't linger long in any one place, but the randomness is its own kind of maddening - each kiss a quiet press of meaning, soft and sincere, yet leaving heat in its wake. A kiss on the lifeline. A kiss near the base of Mydei's fingers. Another by the curve of his thumb again. It becomes a language of its own, a constellation of stars and feelings, each kiss a tiny ball of gas bursting with devotion.

Phainon loses count. He doesn't know how many kisses he's given, only that it's too many to pretend that he's not indulging himself. Mydei hasn't stopped him, though. Hasn't pushed him away or told him to knock it off and force them to get back to work. As his heart beats faster, his pulse racing in his ears, Phainon gets braver. Along with his lips, there's a flicker of tongue. Just a tiny touch, wet heat that is gone before he can even taste Mydei's skin.

It still makes Mydei jolt, eyes wide and flushing up to his ears. "Phainon -" It's a warning. But it's still not a *stop*.

“Tell me what you want,” Phainon mumbles against skin. He’s giving Mydei a clear way to end this.

Mydei clenches his jaw, the muscles jumping on the side of his face. “Keep going.”

Phainon smiles lazily, one hand wrapping around Mydei’s wrist, his fingers encompassing the entire width easily as the other cups beneath for support, giving him free reign of the entire span of Mydei’s hand. It’s all intuition, all craving and a search to quell his thirst. Phainon doesn’t feel an inkling of shame as he licks a stripe up the middle of Mydei’s hand, all the way from the tips of his fingers to the base of his palm, all while never looking away from Mydei’s eyes.

Mydei’s hand jerks slightly, possibly ticklish. There’s a faint, tasteless tang on his tongue now. Nothing offensive, nothing bad, just *Mydei*. It makes his mouth water, wanting even more. He mouths across the expanse, dragging his canines across the muscles and tendons, scraping against veins and creases. He doesn’t quite nip at the skin, too conscious it might leave a mark, but that thought makes something low and dangerous tug behind his navel.

“Yeah,” Mydei breathes, the word rasping out, raw. His voice is low - rough in a way that speaks of restraint fraying at the edges - and his lashes are still lowered, casting a delicate shadow across his cheekbones. His amber eyes are barely visible beneath the sweep of blonde fringe, but they glint with something molten. “Just like that.”

Phainon feels the words stab through him like a corkscrew twisting in his stomach. Something blazes open in his chest - heat curling up his spine and spreading across his skin in a slow, dizzy wave. Every nerve of his body pulls tight. He lets his eyes fall closed, surrendering to the moment, and lowers his mouth to Mydei's index finger. His lips trail over the length with care, the press of his mouth both worshipful and daring. When he reaches the tip, he parts his lips just enough to let his front teeth scrape gently against the edge of Mydei's nail, catching there with a tease that sends a jolt through him. Then, he closes his mouth around it - ever so slowly - and *sucks*. The silence that follows crackles with tension, so taut and fragile that it could snap with the wrong breath. And still, Phainon doesn't stop. He doesn't dare to because Mydei hasn't pulled away yet, because instead there's a hand coming up to cup the back of his head, fingers threading through his hair at the roots and *tugging*.

Phainon goes easily with the pull, releasing his grasp on Mydei's hand as lips slam into his. It hurts, their noses crushing against each other and teeth clashing, knocking Mydei's glasses askew. They both recoil, wide-eyed and shocked, lips thrumming from pain, but it dims instantly when Phainon dives in to try again. This time, it's not as crashing as before. Phainon raises his hands, clearly projecting what he's about to do before he does it and lifts Mydei's glasses off his face, folding the arms over each other before putting them on the coffee table. Before long, he's back again, Mydei's fingers in his hair like they never left, and his own tugging the hair tie away to allow Mydei's hair to flow free. It's grown longer in the past few months, his braid past his shoulder, the rest of it choppy and hanging between his shoulder blades.

He slots their noses together first, nuzzling slightly as his jaw tilts back, holding himself slightly out of reach. Their mouths don't touch - not yet. Phainon wants to savour the moment, to breathe Mydei in first. There's the scent of his citrus shampoo, fresh and familiar, and the faint trace of sweet

cologne lingering at his collar, warm and musky. It's enough to make Phainon have to swallow the saliva pooling in his mouth, throat clicking and stomach swirling. He closes his eyes, letting their foreheads brush, their breaths mingle - until finally, gradually, he leans in and pushes their lips together.

Instantly he can feel his cock twitch in his sweatpants, the dire need to touch Mydei becoming increasingly difficult to avoid. He has rules to follow, boundaries to adhere to - and that, he assumes, includes no touching below the belt.

Does Mydei know how hard he is to resist? How much Phainon wants to touch him *everywhere*? To feel his thick, strong thighs beneath his hands and trace the swirling red tattoos that disappear under the hem of his tiny shorts that he insists on wearing? It's torture - complete and utter *torture* - to try and keep his hands where they should be.

But *no hands under clothes* still leaves so much else to be explored. So much, such as Mydei's chest and stomach, where his hands twitch to visit next. Maybe one, tiny touch wouldn't hurt…

But just as Phainon is about to move his hands, a loud, startling blaring sound begins. They both jump, their lips parting with a faint *pop*, their attention now on Mydei's phone vibrating against the coffee table. Phainon watches as Mydei scrambles forward, grabbing his phone and silencing the alarm quickly.

“What was that for?” Phainon asks, needing to clear his throat a few times afterwards.

“My fucking *deadline*,” Mydei groans, falling back into the sofa and covering his face with his hands.

“Ah,” Phainon says simply, patting Mydei on the shoulder in sympathy.

“This is your fault,” Mydei accuses, sitting up straight again, shooting a poisonous glare at Phainon.

Phainon opens his mouth to protest and then stops short. “Yeah, I guess it is. I’m sorry, do you want any help writing an email to ask for an extension?”

“No,” Mydei huffs, grabbing his laptop and waking it up. “You’re lucky that alarm was set an hour *before* my deadline.”

“Oh, c’mon! Then nothing’s my fault at all!”

“Sure it is,” Mydei says, throwing him a snide look before he goes back to typing.

Phainon huffs, folding his arms across his chest and begins to sulk at the accusation *and* at their kiss being cut short.

Phainon knew falling asleep too easily was always a bad sign. It’s the kind of sleep that pulls him under too fast, and usually comes with strings attached - unsettling dreams he never fully remembers, only the way they make him feel. He jerks awake with a quiet gasp, a name caught on his lips yet one he can’t recall, disorientated and clammy. Sweat clings to the back of his neck, and his shirt sticks uncomfortably to his skin, the fabric damp and cold.

His chest rises and falls in short, uneven bursts as he blinks against the dimness of the room, the shadows unfamiliar for a beat too long. His heart hammers violently in his chest, each beat reverberating against his ribs like it’s trying to break out of him entirely. Phainon presses a hand against it, willing it to slow down, to not drag him back into whatever fragmented nightmare he’s just escaped from. The remnants of it linger: a battlefield bathed in golden blood, people he recognises yet doesn’t quite recall, his own self mirrored back in a blade with eyes that have known death.

Sometimes, in the delicate realm between sleep and waking, Phainon dreams of himself and Mydei living different lives - strange and unknown variations of the one they share now. They started ever since he met, beginning that same night. Lives tinted in soft sepia or streaked with the colours of another universe entirely. In these dreams, they fly by each other like meteors in slightly misaligned trajectories - close enough to feel the warmth of one another’s gravity, but never quite close enough to collide. Their fingers will graze, linger, almost entwine… but never fully grasp.

He’s dreamt of vast, quiet libraries with spiral staircases that reach into the clouds, where he’s always searching and searching, only to find Mydei in the silence between the shelves as if he’d been waiting for him. Once, he wandered through a world shaped like an infinity symbol, where the land sprawled out before him in endless fields of flowers, only to transform into a marketplace when he turned around. Mydei was there too, wearing a red costume of some sort that draped around his waist and shoulders, clad in armour and showing off so much skin, all while walking amongst bustling crowds, vanishing and reappearing like a flickering star.

In other dreams, they share the mundanity of a nine-to-five, exchanging glances across beige cubicles. Phainon’s even dreamt about running a coffee shop where Mydei frequents on a daily basis, always asking for the same order of pomegranate milk with a slice of apple cake.

No matter the setting - fantastical or painfully ordinary - Mydei is there. He is constant. A thread woven through every version of Phainon’s subconscious. Yet always, there is a cruel edge to the tenderness. A softness laced with an ache. In every world, they are tied to each other by something deep and invisible, something undeniably important. But they are always one breath apart, one moment too late, never quite able to close the gap between them.

It’s that feeling that makes Phainon wake up in a cold sweat; that feeling that makes him feel sick to his stomach. How can it be that in every universe they circle around each other so closely, yet they’re still so far away?

It’s not fair.

Phainon sniffles slightly, exhausted and overly emotional from another nightmare he can’t quite remember yet still *feels*, and digs the base of his palms into his eyes to staunch any flow of tears. They don’t come, thankfully, but the sting is still there. He has no idea what time it is, and he’s too scared to check. Instead, he clambers out of bed, the night air chilly in comparison to underneath his duvet. He’s moving on instinct, a line linking him and Mydei together tugging at him to come closer. Phainon doesn’t want it to be like in his nightmares, Mydei’s back always turned towards him, gaze lost on whatever lies in front of them. He wants Mydei to look at *him*, to see him and to touch him and to be able to bathe in the glow from those amber eyes, knowing that he has Mydei’s full attention and care.

He needs to see Mydei right now.

Their rooms sit side by side, so it only takes a few quiet steps for Phainon to leave his room and find himself standing outside Mydei’s door. He doesn’t know how late it is - just that it’s late enough for Mydei to be fast asleep by now. He should turn around, slip back under his covers and pretend the dreams never happened. They’re not real, just strange stories stitched together by his restless mind. Nothing more. Certainly not worth waking someone over.

He hovers there, hand halfway to retreating, heart unsure.

But then he remembers the battlefield. The golden blood on his hands, the same blood that Mydei was covered in. The golden blood sprayed across his

attire and dripped off his weapon.

So, against all logic, Phainon lifts his fist and *knocks*.

As soon as the sound echoes around the still flat, doubt creeps in like a draught beneath it. Phainon's hand lingers mid-air for a moment longer before he lets it fall to his side, guilt curdling in his belly. He knows Mydei values his sleep - knows he enjoys waking up early and knows the long days of seminars and research wear on him in ways he rarely admits aloud. Phainon holds his breath, leaning his face closer to the door to see if he can hear any noise coming from within. It's still silent, and he feels his shoulders droop in relief that he didn't wake Mydei up. He feels so silly now, however, his hands still shake from where they're hanging beside him, and the sweat on his brow still feels tacky.

"Phainon?" A sleepy voice comes through the door, muffled and whispered.

Phainon startles, but he opens the door with a quiet *click*, and he's already stepping inside before the sound fully registers. Mydei's room is quiet and dim, wrapped in a soft hush that feels sacred. Phainon rarely goes in here, he doesn't have many reasons to minus the few times that Mydei asked him to grab something for him, and that's about it. Even in the dark, Phainon can tell the room is well looked after. It's clean, everything neatly put away and in order. Mydei's red bed sheets take on the colour of the moonlight that slips through the gap in the curtains, slicing across the room in a cool, silvery beam while the warmth from a night light on the bedside table casts everything else in a yellowish tinge. The two lights clash gently, cool and warm, shadow and comfort.

At the centre of it all is Mydei - propped up on his elbows, eyes heavy with sleep as he blinks toward the doorway where Phainon is still lingering. He looks ethereal like this, like something from one of Phainon’s more pleasant dreams, blurred at the edges and bathed in glory.

“Mydeimos,” Phainon breathes, the name catching on something raw inside of him like he’s picking at an open wound. Just saying it brings the weight of the nightmare rushing back - its loneliness, its ache and its confusion. His voice wavers, cracking down the middle, and that single fracture seems to pull Mydei to full awareness.

He sits up properly, concern flickering instantly across his face as his gaze sharpens and focuses on Phainon. “What’s wrong?”

“It’s stupid,” Phainon replies, barely above a whisper.

There’s a pause. “Clearly not if you’re knocking on my door at 3 am,” Mydei says, his voice scratchy from being freshly woken up.

Phainon winces, guilt flooding his system once more. Mydei sighs, shoulders sagging slightly as he shifts over to the left. He grabs the corner of his duvet and pulls it back, holding it up. Phainon stares at him from the doorway, confused and silent.

“Come on then, get in,” Mydei explains.

Phainon blinks - once, twice, a third time - his brain buffering at the command. It sets in with heat rushing up his neck, flooding his cheeks and ears, seeping down to his chest until he feels entirely scorched by his embarrassment. Mydei's presence always affects him, but like this - half-awake, half-lucid and quietly waiting for him to *share a bed* - it's overwhelming. He lingers too long, caught somewhere between hesitation and awe.

Mydei sighs again, this time with more edge, a sharper exhale that cuts through Phainon's trance. That does it; he jolts into action, quickly closing the door behind him and crossing the room in hurried, uneven steps. He all but scrambles into the bed, limbs awkward in his rush, but Mydei does not comment. As soon as he settles, the familiar scent hits - floral, from the fabric softener and sweet, from Mydei's cologne. It wraps around him like a blanket, warm and grounding. There's an instant comfort in the closeness, in the hum of another person breathing beside him, especially considering that person is Mydei. Already, he finds it far too easy to forget his bad dreams and sink into something that feels like safety.

They both settle on their backs, arms folded across their chests as they stare up at the ceiling in silence. Phainon can see Mydei's side profile out of his peripheral vision, his nose striking and the curve of his lips even more so in the low light. Amidst the peace, there's also this buzzing underneath Phainon's skin now that he can't quite get rid of. He daren't move around too much, too scared to disturb Mydei even more than he already has, but something niggles at him. It almost feels like an electric current running between them, a magnetic push and pull that makes the hairs on his arms stand up from close contact. Phainon is nearby, sure, but he's still not as close as he wants to be.

This is far too much like his nightmares where they stand shoulder-to-shoulder, and yet never meet eye-to-eye.

“Do you want to talk about it?” Mydei asks quietly, breaking the quiet.

“Not really,” Phainon answers, and then he realises what this feeling is.

He rolls over onto his side, waiting briefly for Mydei to turn his head towards him in shock at the sudden proximity, and then he reaches up, grabs Mydei’s face and kisses him. It doesn’t last long, their lips barely meeting before hands wrap around his wrists and yank at him to pull back. Phainon doesn’t go far, he *can’t*, nor does he want to. So he stays close, waiting for Mydei to speak. The hands around his wrists tighten, not to a point of pain, just to a point of pressure.

“You’re shaken up,” Mydei says.

It’s true - Phainon’s hands are trembling, pinkie fingers barely steady where they cradle the edge of Mydei’s jaw. There’s a tightness in his throat, thick and immovable, like a boulder wedged between his ribs and his voice. Still, he forces the words out: “Then help distract me.”

For a moment, Mydei doesn’t answer. He just looks at him - his gaze dragging slowly across Phainon’s features like he’s trying to put together a puzzle where he’s found an extra piece he wasn’t expecting. His eyes flick over the mussed strands of hair stuck damp to his forehead, the flush on his skin and the wide, desperate eyes that hold so much and say so little. The silence between them stretches, heavy with unspoken things Phainon isn’t sure he’ll ever have the guts to say. There’s a clear questioning note to it - *why is Phainon here*? *What’s going on*? But Phainon doesn’t know how to

answer all that. He could tell Mydei about his dreams, tell him what happens in every universe that they cross, but he'll never be able to truly explain how they feel to experience. There isn't any string of words that would make sense, no amount of talking that would iron things out.

Phainon isn't entirely sure what Mydei is seeking out from him right now, only that the weight of being seen like this - vulnerable, shaken, *asking* - is almost too much to bear. He doesn't look away, though, and he doesn't pull back. He just waits, breath hitched, for Mydei to decide what comes next.

A soft sigh escapes - so quiet it barely stirs the air - but it carries something that loosens the lump in Phainon's chest. Then Mydei's hand is there, warm and steady, cupping his cheek with a tenderness that makes Phainon's breath catch. The touch trails upwards, feather-light, fingers slipping into his hair and combing through the strands with careful intent, untangling the knots left by restless sleep and anxious dreams. When those fingers settle at the nape of his neck, cradling the base of his skull, Phainon feels it like a tether - grounding, guiding and finally something he can hold onto to prove that in *this* life, he has this:

Mydei, watching him, eyes still searching, trading blinks with him like tiny kisses. Mydei, touching him, fingers so sweet and kind in their hold. Mydei, breathing with him, each exhale a promise that settles in the space between them.

His heart flutters against his chest like a moth against glass, frantic and dazzled all at once. The pressure at the back of his neck urges him forward, not demanding but sure and certain, and Phainon lets himself lean in. The moment just before their lips meet is achingly slow, suspended in what feels like reverence. Phainon gasps, caught off guard by how gentle this kiss is.

It’s not like their previous ones, where he feels possessed, consumed by his want and desperation. Instead, this one slowly trickles in, their eyelashes catching on each other, their lips ever so tenderly mouthing against one another. It’s almost chaste with how languid it is, not a touch of tongue just yet, both of them still content in not deepening it.

Phainon feels a warmth blossom inside, starting from the centre of his torso and flourishing outwards like blooming flowers. It starts as a gradual trickle, a gentle rain that has nowhere to be, until it becomes a torrential downpour that almost drowns him. The base of his spine tingles, a shiver going through him as he inches closer, pressing their chests and thighs together in need to feel as much of Mydei as he can. Only then does he dare let his tongue slide across Mydei’s bottom lip, catching it, dragging along it, asking for entrance without a word exchanged between them.

And Mydei, *his* Mydei, opens up for him almost immediately. Phainon sighs into the kiss, content as he licks into Mydei’s mouth, tracing his tongue and teeth and holding back a whimper when the grip on his hair becomes bruising. The cold shivers from his nightmare are gone, replaced with goosebumps of pleasure instead. It feels so good to be here, wrapped up under Mydei’s covers and lying in his bed next to the person himself. It feels so good to be kissing him, touching him, feeling him all at once, knowing that finally he’s beaten what his nightmares show him: a distant Mydei, someone who can only ever exist in theory and never in reality.

This is Phainon’s reality. One where he gets to kiss him under the guise of practise, yet he’s just grateful he gets to kiss him at all, regardless of his ever-simmering feelings that can never boil over.

Phainon feels a wave of confidence crest and crash over him, sudden and electrifying. He has boundaries to stick to, sure, but that doesn't mean he can't explore what he *is* allowed to do. One hand stays cradled against Mydei's cheek, the back of his knuckles resting against the pillow, while the other begins to drift. It trails down the line of Mydei's shoulder, entangling briefly with his hair and tugging at the ends as he laps into the other's mouth. It skims the curve of his bicep, fingernails scratching over the tattoos that he's memorised the shape of and can see so clearly even with his eyes closed. It glides over the length of his forearm, tracing the sinewy tendons and muscles that flex under his touch until finally, his hand settles at Mydei's waist. His fingers splay across the expanse, tentative at first. Only a thin veil of cotton from Mydei's loose tank top separates them, but if he focuses, *really* focuses, he can almost feel the warmth and give of skin beneath. It's enough to make both their breathing hitch at the same time, their kiss pausing briefly.

The darkness makes Phainon feel brave - like it's shielding him, like it's permitting him to *take*, to *push*. He digs his fingertips into Mydei's waist, the pressure turning into something needier, more desperate, until the fabric beneath his hand bunches and twists. He clutches at Mydei - at his face, thumb gently tracing the sharp cut of his cheekbone, at his waist, feeling the delectable inward curve of it - anchoring himself like he's afraid of floating away, of becoming a footnote in his own dreams. Mydei's warmth seeps into his skin, his steady breath brushing against Phainon's lips as they pull away briefly. It's dangerous, the way he wants more. The way he *needs* more. Not just the weight of Mydei's body against his, but everything - his closeness, his quiet, his trust. His gaze, his admiration, his time.

Phainon moves, just barely, and it's like gravity resets between them. Their legs brush, tangling together on autopilot, Phainon's knee coming between. Their chests align, each inhale and exhale brushing against each other, pushing into the other. And still, he finds himself drawing closer, trying to close a distance that doesn't exist anymore. The threat of exposing the hardness in his boxers dances before him, surprisingly tantalising, and he

finds himself not caring anymore when Mydei's hips jolt forward, his hardness grazing against the top of Phainon's thigh.

"Phainon -" Mydei says, *wrecked*, and Phainon breathes in his name like it's the most delicious thing he's ever tasted.

"Tell me to stop and I will," Phainon says, kissing Mydei again. He lands multiple kisses against his lips, some quick and short, others longer and lingering.

Mydei doesn't say anything, just gasps and wriggles against his thigh as though he can't make up his mind to pull away or push into it. One moment, they're lying on their sides, the next, Phainon is flat on his back again, Mydei looming over him with his legs straddling either side of his hips.

"You're so -" Mydei grumbles, beginning but not finishing, hands planted beside Phainon's head.

He looks *beautiful* from this angle, a whole new view that Phainon's never seen before. Mydei, hovering above him, his loose hair draping around his face, swishing from the movement, strands of pale gold catching the dim light. There's something unearthly about him in this moment, like he's been pulled from one of Phainon's dreams, ones that he doesn't dare to think about. Ones that are somehow scarier than his nightmares. His brow is furrowed in quiet concentration, swollen lips parted ever so slightly, and Phainon can't help but drink him in, heart thudding like a drum.

“Mydei,” Phainon calls out, unsure of what else to say. He doesn’t know where he wants to place his hands. He could easily trap Mydei’s face between them, feel the curve of his cheeks. He could easily rest them on his waist or hips, feel the muscle beneath. Or…

Phainon is still feeling brave. He wraps one hand around the back of Mydei’s neck, hauling him down as the other one rests on the swell of his pec.

“You -!” Mydei gasps, sounding affronted, yet he pushes his chest into Phainon’s hands.

“Yes?” Phainon replies innocently, grinning as he *squeezes*.

Oh, Phainon wishes he had photographic memory. Because if he did, he’d never forget the way Mydei’s expression turns slack, his eyebrows lifting and knees pressing into his sides as he drops fully to sit on Phainon’s lap. Actually, even without photographic memory, Phainon doesn’t think he’ll ever forget the feeling of Mydei’s ass coming into contact with his hard cock.

“You’re…” Mydei trails off, and Phainon is grateful for the night light being on because he can see so clearly the way Mydei’s flush deepens until he’s bright red, blinking down at him like he’s caught between conflicting emotions.

“Yeah,” Phainon says simply. “You too.” He can see it in the shadows, Mydei’s bulge poking up through his thin briefs, the shape alone making Phainon’s mouth water.

The silence is deafening. The only sound between them is their sharp breaths, but they’re not synced up. When Phainon breathes in, Mydei is already breathing out. It’s like a crashing of waves against the seashore, an uncontrollable orchestra with no conductor. For a moment, Phainon thinks it’s all over. And he’d be okay with that. But then Mydei moves, an infinitesimal grind of his hips, the tips of their cocks grazing each other through clothing, and now Phainon can’t even *dream* of stopping.

He chokes out a moan, shocked and caught by surprise, his whole body jolting like an electric shock has blasted through him. Mydei stays perched above him, still as a statue, as though he can’t believe what he’d just done. Phainon’s shaking, his hand dropping from Mydei’s neck to his waist, the other coming to mirror the action so he can hold onto him. He feels Mydei’s torso ripple under his touch, goosebumps erupting across both their bodies as Phainon watches them appear on Mydei’s bare arms.

“D- don’t start something you can’t finish,” Phainon warns, stuttering over his words. His teeth threaten to begin chattering, adrenaline crashing through him like a high he’s never felt before. His fingers flex around Mydei’s waist, loosening and tightening, unknowingly encouraging him to roll against his cock.

“Is that a challenge?” Mydei asks, a singular eyebrow raising.

Fuck. “If you want it to be.”

“It’s not like you to be so vague, Deliverer,” Mydei replies, using that damned nickname. It spills out of his lips like oil, shiny and slick, and Phainon can’t deny himself any longer. Especially not when he’s been given what he wants on a silver platter.

“You’re *on*,” Phainon says, a crazed grin spreading across his face as he bucks his hips up, jostling Mydei above.

They both moan, different pitches clashing against each other. Phainon’s is low and long, whereas Mydei’s is high and short. Hands come down onto his chest, nails digging into his pecs through his shirt. He can’t quite feel the sting of them, but the phantom sharpness still cuts through like a knife. Ten peaks of *painpleasure* spike through him, his cock twitching harshly enough that it makes Mydei notice, a bark of laughter echoing around the room.

“Come here,” Phainon begs, pouting and tugging at Mydei’s waist insistently to encourage him forward so he can capture his lips in a kiss.

“No,” Mydei replies sharply, back straightening as he arches his spine, pushing his chest out, all while rolling down. “You’ll cheat.”

Phainon laughs sharply. “Cheat? By kissing you?” His hands move, up over Mydei’s hips and down, grabbing handfuls of his ass. “I can think of other ways I can *cheat*.”

“HKS!” Mydei curses, whole body trembling.

Gods, Mydei’s ass feels fantastic, full and soft and muscly as he clenches and relaxes under the touch. Phainon’s eyelashes flutter, eyes rolling back slightly at the thought of how *tightly* Mydei is holding himself, all taut and wound up, shoulders hunched inwards and spine scarily straight. The nails in his chest dig in harder when he does the same, fingertips scraping along the hem of Mydei’s briefs. They’ve ridden up even more, hugging tightly across his ass, the fabric pulling tightly across the full expanse. Phainon wishes they weren’t in the way, but *rules* and *boundaries* are all screaming at him not to risk anything too far. At least Mydei is allowing him this, a clothed touch, especially when Phainon flexes his hips upwards, and the action makes Mydei *moan*.

“Now who’s cheating using weaponry?”

“Are you calling my dick a *weapon*?” Phainon asks, offering up a shit eating grin to accompany it.

He deserves the punch to the chest that he gets for that one.

“Don’t - *ah*, be so damn annoying!” Mydei says, all the while moving his hips in time to when Phainon bucks his hips up, their cocks dragging against each other.

Phainon’s cock is so hard, and he can feel his boxers sticking to it as he leaks precum. He feels hot, hairline sweaty. It’s a different type from when he woke up earlier, all shivery and freezing to the bone. Now, he feels like he’s boiling from the inside out, skin slipping and melting off as he desperately tries to keep up with how quickly Mydei is rocking against him. The pace changes - sometimes it’s sharp, quick jabs as Mydei ruts, eyes half-lidded and lips parted as he pants. Then it’ll be long, slow rolls of his hips that make sure that Phainon can feel each and every line and ridge of Mydei’s cock even through their clothes. In the lack of light, it’s hard to see fully, but it’s clear that there’s a damp patch growing on Mydei’s briefs, the restrictive, white material turning translucent. If Phainon really tries, he can see the colour of skin peeking through, and that somehow makes him even more feral than before.

“Grade me,” Phainon pants, eyebrows furrowing, his lips feeling bruised from how much he’s been biting down on them to replace the feeling of Mydei’s lips on his.

“Right now?” Mydei asks incredulously, the moonlight casting a faint, pale glow across his shocked expression.

“Yes,” Phainon grabs more of Mydei’s ass, palming and kneading it as he lines their hard cocks up together. “Tell me I’m - *oh* - I’m doing what you want, what you like - t-tell me I’m doing good -”

“You are,” Mydei cuts him off by rocking his hips forward, pace stuttering as his hair swings back and forth, catching in his eyes. “So good, Phainon.”

Phainon whines, the sound slipping out before he can stop it, raw and wanting. He throws his head back into Mydei's pillow, which sinks beneath the weight and sends a puff of air straight into his nose. It smells like comfort - fragrant and floral, with a hint of sweetness that clings to the fabric like a memory. Entirely, unmistakably Mydei. The scent wraps around him like a second embrace, and paired with the solid weight of Mydei on top of him: scorching hot, *real*, pressing into every inch of him that he can reach - it's almost too much to handle. It makes something in Phainon's chest crack open, a dizzy rush of affection and longing that threatens to swallow him whole. He could scream. He could sob. Instead, he arches up, changing the angle of his hips so every slide will be just *perfect*, greedy for more.

Mydei's presence above him is all-consuming. He's straddling him with a sureness, a confidence, all like he belongs there, in his lap, writhing and rutting. His knees are firm on either side of Phainon's hips, grounding him, pinning him. There's a warmth radiating off him in waves, heat trapped between them that feels thick and entirely intimate, the weight of his thighs around Phainon's hips making him feel vertigo despite lying down. His hair, dishevelled and loose from sleep, moves forward and backwards with each move in a thick golden veil as he falls closer and closer to Phainon. Their noses brush against each other, rubbing up and down as Mydei slides his hips.

"Do you want to kiss me?" Mydei asks, but it sounds like a challenge.

"No way," Phainon answers, a lie. He does. He totally, completely and utterly *does* want to kiss Mydei right now. He wants to kiss the smug grin off his face, to taste his lips and his mouth and to devour him whole.

“I bet -” Mydei begins, and now they’re chest-to-chest, lazily rutting against each other as Phainon uses his grip on Mydei’s ass to help him keep the pace up. Both of them swallow at the same time, so close that Phainon can hear their throats click with it. “I bet I’ll win.”

Winning in this context can only mean one thing. It means the loser is the one who comes first. Phainon doesn’t want to lose, but the cord behind his navel is tugging dangerously already, his boxers soaked through, and he wants to come as he feels Mydei doing the same above him. He wants to feel and see Mydei unravel, how much he wants to know what he’d look like, how he’d sound. Would he let Phainon taste him then, the phantom salty tang on their lips?

“I’ll be the winner,” Phainon retorts, almost snarling as his grip turns bruising on Mydei’s ass, nails so deep into the skin he knows he’s leaving crescent shaped dents behind.

Mydei shivers in response to the grip, pace faltering before it picks back up again. He’s practically riding him, and Phainon can’t even describe how much he’d want to experience that, too. Phainon can feel Mydei’s thighs clenching around him, his ass tightening beneath his fingers - it’s not that hard to stretch his imagination further. He shouldn’t, not when he’s got a bet to win and a point to prove, but he can’t help it. Phainon’s mind wanders, lost in the way Mydei’s cock feels against his, the chafe of their clothes almost too much as it overwhelms him to a point of overstimulation. But Mydei, on top of him, fully riding him would be an entirely different scenario. Phainon can almost feel it, can see it as clear as day in front of him, Mydei stuffed full of his cock, broken moans and unable to speak because he feels so good. He’s almost got that now, Mydei reduced down to whimpers and whines and moans, all coalescing into pure unadulterated heat that coils low in the pit of his stomach.

“You’re - you’re getting *bigger*,” Mydei murmurs, almost sounding like he’s in awe.

“Thinking about you,” Phainon answers truthfully. He can hardly hide anything now, can he? He’s sure that if Mydei decided to look close enough, he’d see the love and adoration on his face that screamed more than just *best friends*.

For some reason, Mydei groans at that, a pitchy, little thing. He bites down on his bottom lip, a face of concentration coming over his features, as if he’s holding back. His skin is flushed so bright, a thin sheen of sweat glistening in the gold and silver lighting in the room. Phainon has truly never seen anything or anyone so beautiful before.

“Kiss me,” Phainon pleads, practically whining. He hooks his index fingers underneath the hem of Mydei’s briefs, even though he knows he shouldn’t. “Please, please, I need -”

Mydei launches himself forward, cutting Phainon off mid-plea, and crashes their mouths together in a kiss that feels more like a collision than anything else. It’s open-mouthed, frantic, and achingly uncoordinated - like neither of them knows what they’re doing anymore, all that practise going down the drain. The only clear thing is that they *have* to be doing it. Their teeth clack once, awkward and too fast, but neither of them pulls away. Instead, it turns messier, needier, more desperate, just a dizzying exchange of breath and heat.

Their lips barely find purchase, slipping and sliding in the spit-slick space between restraint and hunger, mouths parting not in rhythm but in *need*. It's clumsy. Almost as intimate as the way Mydei rocks down into Phainon's hips, their cocks throbbing and painfully hard. It's so full of tension that Phainon is sure he's going to come any second now, his stomach like a rubber band pulled until its breaking point. Mydei fists a hand in the fabric of his t-shirt over his chest, bunching it tightly. His breath stutters in Phainon's mouth, and he swears he feels the tremble in it - the hesitation, the closeness, the *want*. Their noses bump, chins tilt, and for a moment they're only mouthing at each other blindly, breathing in short, frantic gasps between barely-there grazes, all while their cocks continuously find each other.

"*Fuck* -" Mydei says, breaking off immediately after.

For a split second, Phainon thought he was going to say *fuck me*. And it scares him how quickly he would've given it, not even needing to hear another word before rolling them over and getting Mydei out of these hellishly tiny underpants and flimsy vest top. He's barely covered, barely clothed, writhing on top of him like he's in *heat*, and every single sound, movement and sloppy kiss is going straight to his groin. Phainon isn't sure how long he can last out for now, every extremity tingling with pleasure, his blood rushing around his body like crazy.

"Come on, baby," The endearment slips out before he can stop himself. Phainon loosens his grip on Mydei's ass just so he can *feel* it, the cotton covered flesh pooling between his fingers as he squeezes. "Aren't you gonna come for me?"

“Shut - shut your mouth,” Mydei hisses through gritted teeth. He’s practically slurring, saliva coating his lips and smeared across his chin.

Phainon is going to *ruin* him.

“You wanna win that badly that you’re holding back, hm?” Phainon goads, grinning into another kiss when Mydei shoots forward again. His stomach swoops. “I wanna see you come, sweetheart.”

“How about *you* come already?” Mydei shoots back.

“You’re impossible to bargain with…” Phainon says, letting go of Mydei’s ass with one of his hands in favour of trailing his fingers upwards, over the curve and over the dip in his spine, just beneath the centre where he presses two fingers into the ridges there. Mydei’s reaction is instantaneous - he shudders, eyes and mouth wide, almost gaping, his thighs around Phainon’s hips becoming impossibly tight as his whole body tenses up.

Gotcha, Phainon thinks, raking his nails over the spot. It happens again, but this time Phainon knows he’s won. Mydei is shuddering, curling in on himself as his balls his hands into fists over Phainon’s chest, grabbing the material in his tight grip as he *comes*. Phainon can see it all, suddenly blinded by the sight as Mydei spills in his briefs, the viscous liquid oozing through the material and dripping onto his boxers. Mydei can’t seem to stop shaking, trembling even, panting and whining and arching into Phainon’s touch and his cock that pulses alongside. It’s enough to finish him off too, finally coming in his pants, hot spurts of cum drenching the material as his back bows on the bed.

Everything feels too much, yet not enough. Mydei's hips come to a stop where they were moving against his still, both of them riding out their orgasm in different ways and in shock waves. Phainon's hips twitch, their softening cocks brushing together. They both hiss in discomfort, and Mydei edges back so he's sitting on Phainon's thighs instead. His chest is heaving, and they are both gulp down long, deep breaths of air to come down from their high.

"I won," Phainon gasps out, a lazy grin spreading across his face.

"You cheated," Mydei responds, equally breathless. He smacks him on the chest, right over his nipple, which makes him jolt and cringe in pain.

"I used my knowledge about your weak spots," Phainon replies simply, shrugging. "I'm sure you know what you could've done to win instead."

"What, call you *good* again?" Mydei grumbles, frowning. Phainon shivers slightly, but it's enough that Mydei raises an eyebrow. He hums, thoughtful. "Maybe I should've used that to my advantage."

"Yeah, well," Phainon laughs nervously, gesturing down to their ruined underwear. "Kinda late for that now. We didn't decide on a prize, though…"

"The prize was *getting off*, you idiot," Mydei says, flicking Phainon squarely on the forehead.

“Why are you already being so mean to me?!” Phainon whines, rubbing the sore spot and bringing both his hands up to protect it from being flicked again.

“Because,” Mydei starts, quickly leaning in to kiss over Phainon’s hands, as though apologising for the flick. “I’m allowed to be since I lost.”

“Then my prize is that you stop being mean to me,” Phainon harrumphs, although his cheeks grow warm at the chaste kiss.

“Is that really what you’re going to waste it on?” Mydei asks, rolling off Phainon and onto the empty side of the bed. He stands up, albeit a little wobbly at first. “I need to clean up.”

Phainon’s heart sinks, knowing that the moment’s ended. Mydei has an en-suite, which is a fancy way of saying a closet with a toilet and sink in. Still, it helps during the busy mornings when they’re both trying to get ready for classes.

“Alright, me too,” Phainon says, grimacing when he stands up. His and Mydei’s cum have completely ruined his boxers, which means he’ll have to hop in the shower.

Phainon begins to leave the room when suddenly he’s stopped by fingers hooking around the collar of his t-shirt, almost choking him to a stop.

“Where do you think you’re going?”

Phainon peers over his shoulder, confused. “Shower and then back to my room?”

“No,” Mydei shakes his head and lets go of his collar. “Shower, and then you’re coming back *here*.”

Phainon fully turns around then. He feels stupid standing here in his sodden boxers and loose t-shirt, staring at Mydei like he isn’t sure what to make of him. “You… want me to come back?”

Mydei sighs, crossing his arms over his chest. He looks serious. “I’m not letting you go back to bed on your own with how you were earlier.”

Phainon had practically forgotten about that - his dreams, his nightmares, the way it’d shaken him up so badly that he’d ended up in Mydei’s bed in the first place. “I’m fine now.”

“Don’t make me worry about you,” Mydei says, the words as cutting as they are soft. “Go have your shower, I’ll be waiting.”

Phainon nods, half in a daze, and wanders out of Mydei’s room and down the hallway to the main bathroom. He keeps a spare pair of clothes in there at all times as well as a towel, so he peels out of his dirty boxers and t-shirt

and shoves them in the hamper for later. The shower is quick and efficient, and he's back out in no time at all and re-dressed again in a hoodie and joggers. He pads back to Mydei's room, raising his hand to knock once again. He doesn't feel guilty this time, just confused.

His mind was suspiciously blank in the shower, even as he washed off his own come and watched the water swirl down the drain. He feels fresh now, clean and wide awake despite needing to sleep some more before his classes later on.

"I can hear you loitering," Mydei's voice filters through the door, making Phainon jump. He pushes it open, eyes immediately focusing on Mydei, already back in bed.

He pats the right side, "We only have a few hours before our alarms go off."

Phainon walks quickly over, jumping onto the bed just to make a nuisance of himself as Mydei grumbles at him. It makes him laugh, at least, the unease and uncertainty about what they'd just done disappearing. They'll be *fine*, he's sure about it. Kissing hadn't changed their relationship, so why would this?

As they both settle into sleep, Phainon finds his eyelids growing heavier quicker than he expected. Maybe all the excitement from seeing Mydei come exhausted him, or maybe it was his nightmare that's finally coming back to bite him in the ass and drain him of everything he has.

Or maybe, it’s because he can feel Mydei beside him, breathing shallowing out as he succumbs to sleep himself, dragging Phainon along with it as he shuffles closer so their shoulders brush against each other, an easy comfort.

Chapter End Notes

leave a comment and/or kudos if you enjoyed! thank you so much!!! each comment truly makes my day and motivates me to write more

-

i did promise lots of kissing... riiiight... but i also threw in dry humping as an extra treat next chapter will be full of even more nonsense, kissing, hand holding and making out in places they shouldn't. hehe

-

let's be friends on twitter/x

Chapter 5: chapter five

Chapter Summary

> “Don’t you even think about it,” Mydei says suddenly, eyes narrowing as he disturbs the silence.
>
> “What?” Phainon thinks, then grins, slow and wicked. “You don’t wanna kiss me with morning breath?”
>
> “I don’t want to kiss you *full stop*,” Mydei deadpans, without missing a beat. His expression doesn’t shift an inch as he raises his hand and plants it squarely over Phainon’s mouth. “I can smell it already. Disgusting.”
>
> Phainon blinks once, as if weighing his options - and comes to the conclusion that there’s only one thing he can do. He promptly licks Mydei’s palm. Mydei doesn’t shriek, but it’s a very, very close thing. He jerks back with a noise that sounds like betrayal and outrage mixed together, and Phainon bursts into laughter, unrepentant and loud. The quiet, peaceful morning is officially over.

Chapter Notes

> i hope this absolute disgusting fest of domestic bliss for 14k words straight heals everyone after the 3.3 update sadly i didn't get round to them kissing in places they shouldn't or the hand holding... that's now for the next chapter and icb this fic is over 60k words now lol. insane
>
> thank you to midnight for feedback and sinn for cheering me on during the writing process! i appreciate you both so much
>
> as usual, this is haphazardly edited by me which means there will be mistakes! just ignore them pls and thank you (̀• ω •́)✧
>
> hope you all enjoy! (´▽`ʃ♡ƪ)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Phainon wakes slowly as though surfacing from beneath a warm, heavy tide. The world returns to him in fragments, ebbing and flowing in and out of focus until he hears soft birdsong filtering through the window. He notices through a lidded gaze the golden wash of morning sunlight spilling across the bed in long, dappled strokes, warming his exposed feet. It paints the room in a honeyed hue, everything touched by it seeming gentler somehow, suspended in the hush of the early hours.

The colour reminds him of something, something dear to him and important, something - oh well, he can't remember right now and he's too comfortable to want to strain his brain any more than he already is. His eyelids flutter open wider with reluctance, lashes sticking slightly. For a few lingering moments, Phainon simply blinks - slow and unhurried - as his heart begins to stir from its sleep-heavy rhythm. With each breath, his awareness sharpens, bit by bit. The weight of the quilt, the warmth pressed along his side, and the discontented hum of the world continuing outside their walls make it hard for him to find the energy to get up.

He lifts a hand to his face, rubbing his eyes with the back of his fist. The sting of dryness meeting moisture makes him wince, although he continues to withstand it to try and unclump his lashes. It leaves his vision momentarily blurred, eyes misting with involuntary tears as he grimaces and blinks them back. Everything feels hazy, delicate, as though the morning itself is asking him to please move gently, and speak softly, not to startle the fragile peace that's settled in the room. All Phainon can do is comply, listening to the lull of quiet that entices him to fall back asleep. He's not even sure what woke him in the first place or what made him stir from his dreamless sleep.

Something moves beside him, a rustling noise breaking him out of the final remnants of tiredness. Phainon realises he's *hot*, too warm to just be from the little rays of sun and half underneath a quilt. He stills, eyes snapping completely open as he sees what's been right in front of him this whole time.

Mydei's already awake, although looking as bleary as he did earlier, watching him with dewy eyes and a tiny lopsided smile on his face. "Morning."

"M-morning," Phainon replies, cheeks growing hot as the memories from last night come flooding back. He's slightly mortified, partly ashamed and somehow through all that he can still feel a twinge of heat in his stomach by the thoughts racing in his mind.

He needs to get himself together. *Now*. He needs to get out of this bed - *Mydei's* bed - before the reality of it sinks in too deeply and he's left with a hard-on he can't explain away. Phainon goes to turn over, to untangle himself and escape the warmth that suddenly feels far too intimate, but something stops him. His brow furrows, confusion flickering to alarm as he tries again and finds himself unable to move properly. His mouth opens and closes uselessly, brain scrambling to catalogue what's holding him back. It starts with the heat - thick and sweltering now that he's fully awake, sweat clinging to the back of his neck, behind his knees, everywhere. It feels like a furnace under the quilt.

Then he registers the numbness. His right arm is completely dead, tingling with pins and needles, limp and unresponsive beneath the weight of something - or *someone*, in this case. The static buzzing through his fingertips is the least of his worries once the full picture hits him.

Phainon's heart lurches with dawning horror as he realises exactly how they're lying: he's wrapped around Mydei like a limpet; one arm slung low around his waist, his hand pressed just above the dip of Mydei's lower back, skin on skin. Mydei's leg is hitched over his hip, anchoring them together with absurd closeness. They fit together *too well*, like they've done this before, like it's natural.

"Um…" Phainon says, voice barely above a whisper, unsure what part of this to address first. Mydei's already spoken, but he's not saying anything else and he doesn't seem to want to either.

He dares another glance at Mydei and instantly regrets it. Mydei's hair is a golden mess against the pillow, lips slightly parted, breath warm where it fans across his chin. His expression is serene, peaceful, completely unaware of the chaos currently going supernova inside Phainon's chest. Phainon has to bite down on the inside of his cheek to hold himself back because while he can't move due to their current predicament, he also doesn't want to anymore. He tells himself it's because he doesn't want to disturb Mydei's early morning serenity, but the truth is far less noble: he likes it. Too much. The press of Mydei's thigh against his hip, the gentle weight of his hand curled just above his ribs, the steady inhale and exhale that somehow syncs with his own - it's all far too much and yet not enough.

Can he lean in for a kiss? It feels *right* like it's something natural that he can just do. They're already like this, tangled amongst each other, watching each other - perhaps waiting, perhaps just basking in each other's presence. Phainon can't tell because his heart is thudding so loudly against his chest and his stomach is tying itself in a multitude of knots at it all. He doesn't want to speak anymore, not yet. Not if it ruins the warmth creeping in through the anxiety, or the way Mydei's gaze softens when it stays locked

on his. Not if it risks losing this strange, intimate stillness where, for once, nothing feels like pretend.

“Don’t you even think about it,” Mydei says suddenly, eyes narrowing as he decimates the silence.

“What?” Phainon thinks, then smirks, slow and wicked. “You don’t wanna kiss me with morning breath?”

“I don’t want to kiss you *full stop*,” Mydei deadpans, without missing a beat. His expression doesn’t shift an inch as he raises his hand and plants it squarely over Phainon’s mouth. “I can smell it already. Disgusting.”

Phainon blinks once, as if weighing his options - and comes to the conclusion that there’s only one thing he can do. He promptly licks Mydei’s palm. Mydei doesn’t shriek, but it’s a very, very close thing. He jerks back with a noise that sounds like betrayal and outrage mixed together, and Phainon bursts into laughter, unrepentant and loud. The quiet, peaceful morning is officially over.

Fuelled by the reaction, Phainon leans in close - not for a kiss, oh no, that’d be far too merciful - but to suck in an exaggerated lungful of air and blow it straight into Mydei’s face with all the intensity of a leaf blower. This time, Mydei *does* shriek. A high, flailing sound of horror as he kicks wildly, arms smacking at Phainon in a mad scramble to escape the assault.

“You’re revolting!” He yells, voice cracking with genuine panic as he manages to somehow untangle their legs and shove Phainon halfway off the bed.

Phainon’s laughter echoes around the room the entire time, breathless and smug. “You *love* me,” He chimes airily, “You adore me. You couldn’t live without me!”

“Hardly!” Mydei grumbles, pinching his nose and covering his mouth to ward off Phainon’s morning breath. “I *tolerate* you. I can barely stand you.”

As if Mydei doesn’t have his *own* morning breath to deal with, Phainon thinks somewhat fondly. “That’s just Mydei speak for *you’re soooo right Phainon, I adore you to the moon and back*!”

“Get the fuck out of my bed,” Mydei swears, kicking Phainon’s shin with a surprising amount of force that actually makes him wince.

Phainon pouts, rolling around sulkily. “Your bed is way nicer than mine. Do we even have to get up yet?”

“That’s because *I* chose it,” Mydei scoffs, finally removing his hands from his face. “If you listened to me when we were picking furniture, you wouldn’t be complaining.”

“I couldn’t afford a brand new one!” Phainon exclaims, huffing and leaning up on his forearm so he can peer down at Mydei.

Mydei mimics him, raising up so they’re at eye level. “I said I’d pay for it.”

Phainon sniffs, “I’m fine with my squeaky bed and lumpy mattress, thank you very much.”

“Just don’t bring any girls home, please,” Mydei pauses. “Or guys.”

Phainon blinks at him owlishly, “Why would I do that?”

“Wh- *why*? Because… you want that?” Mydei seems genuinely confused, and although Phainon had been excitable earlier and wide awake, suddenly he feels a little hesitant.

“Why would I bring anyone home when I have you?” Phainon says, voice serious, his expression pinched with something that doesn’t quite read as teasing.

The words slip out too quickly, too easily, before he can think better of them - but they’re *true*. So true, in fact, that they hit him directly in the chest as soon as they left his mouth. Because really - *why would he*? Why would he bother chasing after anyone else when he already has Mydei? Mydei, who cooks for him, checks his deadlines, reminds him to take his vitamins, and

knows exactly when he’s in need of a cup of tea before he even does. Mydei, who kisses him now and then - not seriously, of course, but enough to make Phainon wonder why it couldn’t be.

Mydei is already his favourite part of every day, already steeped into every corner of his life. No one else could possibly fit, even if they squeezed in between the cracks, because they’re full of Mydei too. The smaller things live there, like how he smiles and laughs, each one a well-earned gift. How he talks in that dulcet, slightly gruff tone that sends shivers down Phainon’s spine every time. How he hip-checks Phainon out the way instead of just saying *excuse me*.

So no, he *hasn’t* brought anyone home. He hasn’t wanted to. Not when the bar is set so impossibly high by the man lying in front of him, sleepy and startled all at once. Phainon watches as Mydei’s eyes go wide, the words landing visibly across his features like a pebble dropped into still water, rippling outwards. And then, there it is - that tell-tale flush rising from the collar of his t-shirt, dusting his cheeks and the tips of his ears in the softest, sweetest shade of pink.

It’s unbearably cute. Phainon’s fingers twitch with the overwhelming desire to pinch his cheeks, just a little, just to see if the colour would deepen. But he holds back, barely. He’s not sure he’d survive the retaliation - and even more than that, he’s not sure he’d survive the tenderness of it all if Mydei let him.

“My dear Mydeimos,” Phainon begins, a little wry and a little playful. “They’d have to get past you first. And I fear they’d give up at the first glare you shot them.”

Mydei's face twists into a poisonous glare, lips turning downwards into the exact expression that Phainon was describing. "See! If you pulled that face at them, they'd run for the hills. How do you survive looking in the mirror?"

"HKS!" Mydei curses, shoving Phainon fully off the bed.

"Ouch!" Phainon whines, hitting the floor with an extraordinary *thud*. "You absolute brute!"

"You deserved that and you know it," Mydei says sourly, getting up from his side of the bed *gracefully*, because he wasn't shoved off like Phainon, and walks towards his en-suite. "Go and get ready for your classes."

"Mydei!" Phainon leaps up and crawls across the bed to try and chase after him, but before he can stand up straight the bathroom door has been slammed shut and the sound of the lock echoes around the room.

"And don't forget to brush your teeth!" Mydei calls through the door, slightly muffled.

Phainon gives the door the middle finger and storms out of Mydei's room, heading for the main bathroom to do just that.

They both step out of their rooms at the exact same time, as if summoned by the same invisible thread. Phainon freezes mid-step, as does Mydei, and they stare each other down like it’s a duel at dawn; both poised and both glaring from afar. Phainon thinks with a fraction of amusement that this is the kind of synchronised irritation only roommates - or something more complicated if you add in their mess of kissing - could master.

“Does your breath still stink?” Mydei asks, tone flat but eyes gleaming with something sharper, almost amused.

“Why? You still wanna kiss me that badly?” Phainon shoots back immediately, a smug grin already tugging at the corners of his mouth as he leans casually against the doorframe, arms crossed.

Mydei’s eyes narrow, his brows knitting together, lips pursed. He crosses his own arms over his chest, mirroring the stance with slow, deliberate defiance. “I was more focused on the question of whether you deserve breakfast or not.”

Phainon gasps, not with offence but with glee. His stomach suddenly responds to the suggestion with a loud gurgle, making Mydei huff a laugh. “I brushed my teeth *twice*! Can we have pancakes? Do we have time? Please?” He babbles, practically bouncing on the balls of his feet, every word tripping over the last.

Mydei, still standing his ground, doesn't respond immediately - but there's the faintest twitch at the corner of his lips like he's trying not to smile. He gives in though, the smile flourishing into something small yet precious as he rolls his eyes and loosens his arms.

"Fine. But you're mixing the batter this time. I'm not doing all the work just because you fluttered your eyelashes."

Phainon beams like he's won the lottery. "You say that like my eyelashes aren't *incredibly* effective." He spins on his heels before Mydei can reply, already heading for the kitchen.

Mydei follows him with less enthusiasm but a noticeable lack of protest, brushing past Phainon to open the cupboard and pull out the mixing bowl. It's the one Mydei always uses, the one Phainon accidentally dropped in the sink and chipped the rim. He insisted they throw it away and replace it after a rather lengthy apology, but Mydei had only waved him off and kept using it after that. Phainon isn't entirely sure why, yet he has no desire to truly dig into it.

"Flour," Mydei says, sliding the bag across the counter with a sureness that makes Phainon panic that it's going to slide right off. He catches it quickly, putting it to a stop, and notices it's left a dusting of white behind it. "You know where the rest is."

"Of course I do, I literally live here," Phainon mutters, yanking open drawers for utensils and pretending to search for the baking powder like Mydei didn't already organise the cupboard alphabetically last month. It's

right where he knew it’d be, but he can see Mydei out of the corner of his eye getting more and more impatient at his delay.

“Why don’t you go grab our aprons? I’m not changing again before class if I get flour on my shirt…” Phainon suggests, pointing toward the wall next to the light switch where their aprons hang side-by-side.

His is a soft, powdery blue with a tiny embroidered egg on the chest - sunny side up, his favourite - while Mydei’s is a pastel pink with a stitched cat curled up in a teacup in the centre. They’d bought them on a whim during a late-night online shopping spree, half-joking and half-serious. Now, they wore them more often than they cared to admit.

“Bossy,” Mydei says under his breath but grabs them anyway, tossing the blue one so it lands over Phainon’s head, making him splutter in surprise and yank it off so he can turn and glare.

“You’re in such a mood today,” Phainon replies, hooking the strap over his head before tying the ribbons around his waist, doubling over so it sits nice and snug. He waves Mydei over, who’s already turned around so Phainon can do his up in a big bow.

“Try waking up with someone’s stinky breath in your face,” Mydei says flatly.

“I *did*,” Phainon pokes Mydei in the back, laughing when his whole body jolts and a small noise escapes him. “Your breath stank too.”

“Shut your mouth,” Mydei says back, elbowing Phainon out of the way so he can get the rest of the ingredients out of the cupboards. Phainon rolls his eyes, already used to this sort of stuff happening. Mydei will tell him to do one thing, then moments later just do it himself because Phainon ‘wasn’t doing it right’, or ‘you’re not doing it fast enough’.

After that, they fall into a rhythm quickly. It’s not quiet - Phainon chatters constantly, debating whether chocolate chips would ruin the integrity of the pancake, and Mydei grunts in response while measuring out milk with the precision of a chemist. It works for them; it always does. Mydei cracks the eggs and Phainon whisks. Mydei flips the first pancake with an unnecessary flourish, to which Phainon claps mockingly while secretly being impressed.

The kitchen fills with soft sounds: the low hiss of batter hitting the hot pan, the occasional clink of cutlery, and the roiling boil of the kettle going behind them. Phainon’s content enough to remain in silence now, working in tandem with Mydei to get their breakfast plated up as quickly as possible as his stomach continued to growl. Their shoulders brush, feet bumping as they move around each other in a seamless to-and-fro.

Phainon holds the serving plate steady, tilted slightly so the next pancake can slide right off the spatula. His eyes are fixated on the golden brown discs, wide with excitement as Mydei just flicks his wrist with expert ease and lets the pancake land with a light *thump* beside the others. Steam curls upward from them all, warming Phainon’s face as he leans in to sniff them. They smell fantastic: warm, sweet and delicious. Even without cutting into them, Phainon knows they’ll be fluffy and pillowy inside too.

Mydei's acting far too serious for someone flipping pancakes. His brow is furrowed in what Phainon can only assume is determination. Mydei's lips are thinned out ever so slightly, and - he swears the universe is mocking him - his tongue pokes out just a little from the corner of his lips as if the culinary stakes couldn't be higher and this level of concentration is needed.

He's so focused, so unaware of what he's doing to Phainon by simply *existing* in the same room like this, wearing a ridiculous pink apron over his rugby uniform and looking unfairly beautiful in the morning light streaming in through the kitchen windows. He must have practise today, considering he's wearing those insanely tight t-shirt and tiny shorts combo, his muscles on full display and tattoos almost glowing in the sun. The uniform is red and black striped with golden thread embroidered through the hems. It clashes awfully with his apron, but it's still the cutest thing Phainon's ever seen. And the hottest.

Phainon swallows hard, the motion rough and catching in his throat. His grip on the plate wobbles slightly before he manages to set it down on the counter, trying to pass it off as nothing when Mydei glances at him out of the corner of his eye. But his hands feel clammy now, and there's a sharp, fluttery panic pressing against his ribs - an ache that has nothing to do with hunger, and all to do with Mydei.

It's only the tip of his tongue. A sliver of pink, harmless in theory, yet somehow enough to send Phainon spiralling. He has the sudden, reckless urge to reach out, grab Mydei by the front of that silly cat-covered apron, and kiss the concentration right off his face. Long and deep, messy and wet, all until that furrow smooths out and Mydei's hands aren't on the frying pan anymore - they're on *him*. Just like last night, where Mydei was everywhere. On top of him, hair falling around them like a golden curtain, his face slack with pleasure as saliva trailed down his chin. His hands,

desperate and flighty, needing to hold onto Phainon as they rocked their hips together until -

Phainon’s stomach gurgles loudly, snapping him out of it. Startled, he slaps a hand over it, as if he can physically silence his body’s treasonous impulses. His face burns hotter than the hob’s flames, and he’s glad that Mydei hasn’t seemed to notice his odd reactions. He forces himself to look away, just for a moment so he can gather himself. But then Phainon catches sight of Mydei’s expression deepening even more than before. He knows what it means before Mydei can even open his mouth, and he’s sliding the butter over towards him.

“The pan was going dry,” Phainon explains as Mydei looks at him in shock.

“I know,” Mydei replies. “But I never…”

“You got this look on your face,” Phainon chuckles, a low, breathy sound that barely masks the way his heart’s going off like a drumline. He lifts his hand and presses a single finger right between Mydei’s eyebrows, smoothing out the tense little furrow there. “Right here.”

It’s meant to be light and playful; a teasing gesture to keep things from boiling over inside of him. But the second his finger makes contact, something shifts in the air between them. Mydei freezes, eyes widening slightly, watching Phainon like he’s trying to decode him. Like he doesn’t quite understand how they got here after last night, from a tangled mess of

limbs to being tangled up in the kitchen while sharing gentle touches in matching aprons as Phainon tries his best not to kiss him.

But Mydei can’t know all that from a single touch. He’s not a mind reader. However, Mydei doesn’t say anything, just stares until Phainon can feel the weight of it in the pit of his stomach, heat curling there like smoke. He wonders if he’s finally crossed the line, that he’s broken out of their brief stalemate about *not mentioning last night*. He’s not stupid - well, not completely - it’s obvious they’re both avoiding bringing it up. Phainon’s not sure if he really wants to, or if he’d rather let it go and move on to focus on other things. Then Mydei’s nose begins to pinken, a slow flush blooming from the bridge outwards, followed closely by the unmistakable redness in his cheeks. He blushes so easily, so earnestly, that Phainon can’t believe he got this lucky meeting such a man.

Phainon sighs, almost dreamily, especially softly, and can’t help himself when he leans in to press a tentative kiss on the tip of Mydei’s nose as he drops his hand away from his forehead. When he pulls back, the blush deepens, spreading in tender waves like warmth creeping across frost, melting it all away. Mydei’s expression flickers - alarmed, flustered, maybe even slightly scared - before he smacks Phainon on the back of his head. There’s no force behind it, just enough to make Phainon instinctively yell ‘*ow*!’ and destroy whatever sweet cocoon they’d found themselves in.

“What was that?” Mydei asks, grabbing the butter and slicing a corner off straight into the pan where it hits the metal with a sizzle.

“What was what? You hitting me?” Phainon harrumphs, picking up the plate again so he’s ready for the next pancake.

“Don’t act coy, it doesn’t suit you,” Mydei responds sourly, pouring a ladle full of batter into the pan next.

“What, I can’t kiss you anymore?” Phainon asks lightly.

Mydei hums and doesn’t say anything else, his head tilted downwards to focus on cooking. Phainon watches him in equal silence until all the batter is gone and there are stacks of pancakes waiting for them both to delve into. They’d already prepared some fresh whipped cream and diced fruit, so all that was left was to make a pot of tea and settle down to eat.

It’s not until they’re situated at the dining table, eating their pancakes and sipping their drinks that Mydei finally speaks up again.

“What was that kiss practise for?”

“Huh?” Phainon says, swallowing his mouthful of food as he processes the question. “Nothing. No reason.” Then, he thinks some more. “Well, you were blushing and you looked cute. So I kissed you. Happy?”

Mydei nods slowly, setting down his knife and fork. “Would you kiss me now?”

Phainon splutters, shakily inhaling through the feeling of tea getting stuck in his throat. “Right now?”

“Do you think I look cute now?” Mydei fires back.

Phainon is completely and utterly at a loss. “I - yeah, you do. You always look cute. Can we stop saying the word *now*, now?”

Mydei raises an eyebrow, “I think you were missing some kisses on your list.”

Phainon matches Mydei’s expression, putting his cutlery down so he can turn to face him head-on. Their knees bump against each other, and without missing a beat, Mydei slots his leg in between Phainon’s so they fit together. “Oh yeah? Which ones?”

“A morning kiss, an afternoon kiss, a night kiss,” Mydei lists out, counting them on his fingers as he goes.

Phainon stares at him, dumbfounded, breath caught somewhere between his lungs and his throat. “Are you trying to ask me to kiss you?” He asks, his voice a little too high, a little too incredulous, his brain not caught up to the situation unravelling in front of him.

“Nope,” Mydei replies, maddeningly vague as if nothing about this moment is beginning to feel charged or stepping into unknown, dangerous territory. He leans in, slow and unbothered, until the space between them shrinks to almost nothing. His hands land on Phainon’s thighs, firm and calculated, the heat of his palms seeping straight through the denim.

Phainon freezes, and suddenly the pancakes in his stomach feel like piles of rotting wood. He can feel the weight of those hands - *every* point of contact - as Mydei’s fingers splay wider, possessive almost, fingertips digging in just enough to make his breath stutter. Mydei’s thumbs settle near the crease where thigh meets hip, and suddenly Phainon can’t think straight. His pulse is racing in his ears, fast and relentless, the rest of the kitchen fading into obscurity behind Mydei’s steady, frustratingly blank expression.

“I’m just simply telling you about the ones you’ve forgotten,” Mydei says like he’s commenting on the weather and not giving Phainon an unwarranted hard-on.

But past that, past the indifference and past the heated touch on his thighs, Phainon sees it for what it is. A challenge. A *dare*. A line drawn faintly in the sugar-sweet tension, one that could vanish completely if he leaned in just a little bit further. His mouth goes dry. His heart slams against his rib cage. Because if he kisses Mydei now, he’s not sure he’ll be able to put it down to practise, and he’s not sure if that’s what Mydei wants anymore, either.

“You’ve already had your morning kiss,” Phainon says.

“Really? Is that all you’ve got?” Mydei replies, cocking his head to the side. His hair swishes with the movement, his high ponytail dancing behind him.

“You -” Phainon cuts himself off with a laugh, jittery and almost furious with how much he immediately falls for the encouragement.

Phainon doesn’t think - doesn’t breathe - he just grabs Mydei by the collar of his stupid pink apron that he’s still wearing for some reason and hauls him in like he’s drowning and Mydei is the only thing tethering him to air. Their mouths collide in a mess of sugar and heat, the kiss instantly heated, sticky from syrup and tacky from the cream they hadn’t bothered to wipe away. It should be ridiculous, but all Phainon can do is focus on how it *feels* - how Mydei melts into him like butter with a soft noise, fingers tightening on his thighs like he’s afraid to let go.

The stickiness fades quickly with a few slow, purposeful swipes of Phainon’s tongue across their lips, clearing the tackiness and replacing it with something rawer, deeper. The flavour of Mydei lingers - sickly sweet and intoxicating as the vanilla cream, overripe strawberries and warm pancakes they’ve just eaten, coalescing into one unbearable, addictive taste.

He’s a feast, Phainon thinks wildly, hands fisting the apron fabric even tighter, not caring if he’s wrinkling it beyond saving. *A whole feast*, just for him, all for him, presenting himself willingly, and Phainon is starving for it.

“Breakfast is - *mmh* - gonna go cold,” Phainon manages breathlessly between kisses, the words breaking apart as Mydei leans in again and again, stealing another kiss before he can fully catch his breath. Mydei doesn’t give him more than a few seconds each time, lips chasing his like he’s desperate to feel the heat between them. Phainon can barely think, barely function with how fast his heart’s racing, his chest rising and falling like he’s just sprinted a mile.

He doesn’t know what’s gotten into Mydei today - he’s electric, unpredictable, veering between sharp teasing and soft touches that make Phainon’s skin burn. Hot, then cold. Steady, then sudden. And Phainon is caught up in the middle of it, unmoored and unsure, swept up into the storm.

“Let it,” Mydei says, voice low and hoarse, before he bites at Phainon’s lower lip, tugging at it gently. He pulls back just enough to look at him, eyes molten amber.

“But -”

Mydei then stands up so suddenly the chair legs screech against the kitchen tiles, the sound sharp and jarring after sharing another moment where the only sound was their spit-slick kisses and moans. Phainon’s pulse pounds in his ears, deafening. Mydei’s eyes are wild - ablaze with something fierce and determined. Phainon doesn’t need a mirror to know how red he is, he can feel it, the deep crimson colour reaching from the tips of his ears all the way down his neck like a sunburn. What he *can* see, though, is the way Mydei’s hands tremble slightly as he reaches behind him to fumble with the ribbons tied into a bow, yanking it loose with a sharp tug. Mydei unhooks

his apron from around his neck and with one swift movement, and without sparing it another glance, he throws it over the back of his chair.

The air feels heavy with Mydei's rugby uniform suddenly on display again. The collared t-shirt is so *tight*, taut around his chest and his abdomen, riding up slightly as he moves forward, the shorts sharing the same fate as the already tiny inseam catches higher and higher. Phainon doesn't have time to ask what's going on before Mydei is suddenly in his space; no hesitation, no pause, just *there*.

Phainon's heart skitters as he watches Mydei move with a calm certainty that steals the air straight from his lungs, and when his stance widens, it's with purpose. His legs part, moving either side of Phainon's knees at first, crowding him in further as he shuffles forward until the inner parts of his thighs are at Phainon's hips. There's no room to think, not even to exhale, before Mydei sinks down onto his lap with deliberate weight, acting as though he belongs there. And as Phainon's hands automatically come up to rest at his waist, steadying him, perhaps he *does*.

Phainon stiffens for only a split second, body going taut with tension, hands freezing on Mydei. But then the warmth settles in, Mydei's thighs pressed surely against his hips, squeezing tighter and tighter until there's no way that he can be moved. He's warm and solid, a heavy weight on top of him but a welcome one. Phainon tenses his thighs, raising his legs up onto the balls of his feet so Mydei isn't slouched backwards even as the dining table chair creaks ominously from two grown men sitting on it. Hands scrabble at his shoulders, fingers twisting and digging into the muscles before they're relaxing again, arms wrapping around his neck and bringing their faces closer to each other, forehead to forehead. Nose to nose. Lips to lips.

There’s nowhere to go, nowhere to move and nowhere to *look* that isn’t Mydei. He squeezes his eyes shut as Mydei slants his head to the side, slotting their lips together again as Phainon wills himself to remain as calm as possible. Having Mydei on top of him last night was one thing - a messy, charged, *beautiful* thing that he’s sure he’ll never quite move on from. But now, with this, he’s not entirely sure what he’s allowed to do. It’s clear Mydei is avoiding their hips touching, his ass balanced mostly at the edge of his thighs and almost over his knees, and Phainon wants to use his grip on his waist to tug him even closer. Let their chests touch, press into each other, feel just how *full* those pecs are against him. With one hand still on Mydei’s waist, the other rises higher, skirting up over the side seam of Mydei’s shirt until it’s between them, grasping at his chest. The black t-shirt material is thick and rough against his fingers, so much so that he can barely feel the muscle through it. It doesn’t deter him, only fuels his need to feel as he cups the underside of it, running a thumb over Mydei’s nipple that’s poking through the shirt.

“You -” Mydei breaks away, voice rough, breath ragged. His lips are swollen, glistening. He looks drunk, his eyes hazy and pupils so wide. He still doesn’t look like he’s had enough.

“Me?” Phainon smiles, gradual and dangerous, the kind of smile that’s all teeth and challenge. His hand is still on Mydei’s chest, fingers wide, palm warm against the fabric of his shirt. He pushes up gently, cupping the muscle to make it swell beneath his touch, all to feel the shape of him like he has a right to know.

Phainon doesn’t let his gaze falter - doesn’t dare to look down at the mess they’re making of each other, at where they’re pressed too closely now. His eyes stay locked on Mydei’s, burning with what feels like madness and terror. This is a game, that’s for sure, but it doesn’t feel harmless anymore. He’s pushing, teasing, dancing with fire all so he can see how far he can get

until Mydei's had enough of him. It scares Phainon how much he's already had, already taken, and yet it's still nowhere near what he *wants*.

Mydei jolts, hips twitching in his lap when Phainon's thumb brushes over his nipple again - just once, pressing in with his nail until the fabric gives, then letting go like a test, like a warning. Mydei exhales sharply, a sound caught between a curse and a moan.

"I can think of some other kisses I might've missed," Phainon murmurs, and it's not a suggestion. It's a promise. A threat, potentially. A line they're both already halfway over, ready to cross at any given moment.

"Like what?" Mydei asks through gritted teeth.

"I could kiss you here," Phainon pushes his thumbpad into Mydei's chest, barely missing the hard nub.

"Over my shirt?" Mydei says, sounding half aghast and half pleading. He's not sure whether it's a demand or a question.

Phainon moves his head closer to Mydei's chest, lips grazing over his nipple, "Yeah." Phainon looks up through his eyelashes, catching Mydei's wide gaze as his spine shivers. Phainon is definitely hard now, straining in his jeans, and even without looking he knows Mydei is the same. He can feel the heat radiating from between his thighs, hot and maddening as he leans forward to capture Mydei's nipple between his teeth.

“*Ah*!” Mydei gasps, fingers scratching at the nape of Phainon’s neck, surely leaving red lines behind. “Phainon, I -” He breaks off, voice cracking and streamlining into a moan as Phainon presses the breadth of his tongue against his nipple, feeling it concave beneath as he swipes up.

The t-shirt material is rough against his tongue, scraping along it as Phainon shuts his eyes, hands wrapping around Mydei’s waist and hugging him closer. His mouth is full of the strange tang of fabric conditioner now, floral and chemically, but it doesn’t do anything to make him stop. Nothing short of Mydei telling him *no* could do that now. He mouths against Mydei’s nipple, wetting the fabric beneath, tongue flicking out every so often and teeth worrying at it until Mydei’s trembling on top of him, whispery moans and litanies of whimpers all spilling from his lips.

An avalanche of wants crashes through Phainon’s mind, relentless and chaotic in nature, completely all-consuming. It’s not subtle, it’s not quiet, it’s a roar in his bloodstream - a clawing need beneath his skin, desperate to escape. He wishes - *aches* - for there to be nothing between them. No fabric, no barriers. Just skin on skin, unfiltered heat pressed tight, Mydei’s body against his in a way that leaves nothing to the imagination.

He wants to feel the slope of Mydei’s waist beneath his palms, feel the way his muscles shift beneath soft skin, and the heat of him where his t-shirt now clings. He wants to taste him - *not* through kisses smeared with sweetness and syrup, but where his mouth has never been allowed to go. His forehead, the hollow of his throat, his chest. Lower, lower - his stomach, his v-line, the inside of his powerful thighs. He wants to push up that stupid t-shirt and see how Mydei looks when *he’s* the one removing it, see how his breathing picks up when Phainon’s hands are *really* on him.

How would he react? How would he sound when Phainon's able to kiss him, to bite and leave marks and nip and taste and touch?

He's seen Mydei shirtless hundreds of times before: after training, after showering, even just lounging around the flat comfortably on a muggy afternoon. But it's always passive, always observational. There's nothing charged behind it, nothing more than a double take and a swallowing of desire. This though, this is different. This is '*want*' curling into something seething, dangerous, like a room full of gas waiting to be set alight. And it's almost worse being allowed this much - being allowed to touch and feel and tease - because it's still nowhere near close to *everything*. It's almost there, so unbearably on the precipice of what Phainon wants and wishes for, but it's still so far from the truth, too far from the depths of how deep his feelings for Mydei run. So he'll take what he can get, and allow Mydei to stick to his boundaries of keeping his shirt on, even though Phainon wishes it were different.

Fingers grasp at the short hairs at the nape of his neck, wrenching his head back. His tongue and lips are throbbing from the friction, even the tip of his nose feels a little sore. "Too - too much, you're going to make me -" Mydei pants, not finishing his sentence.

Phainon doesn't bother questioning what he was going to say, he only wishes they were still in bed. What he'd get away with then, he's not entirely sure, but he wants to find out. "We can stop."

"Yeah," Mydei nods, but he doesn't move. He looks to the side, stating: "Our pancakes are cold."

“That isn’t my fault,” Phainon says quickly, releasing his hold on Mydei to put both of his hands up in surrender. “You’re the one who came onto me!”

“Shut up,” Mydei retorts, and Phainon’s surprised he doesn’t get a flick on the forehead or a smack to the back of his head for that. Not like he deserves it, for once…

Mydei clears his throat, then places his hand gently over the top of Phainon’s eyes, blinding him. “Don’t look.”

“What?” Phainon starts, but then Mydei is moving off his lap and is already turned around when Phainon gets his sight back.

“I’ll pack up the pancakes for later,” Mydei says, and Phainon wishes he could see his face. Although, the sight of his broad shoulders isn’t a bad sight to behold. “We’re going to be late.”

“I say again,” Phainon shifts in his seat, crossing his leg over the other and tugging down his t-shirt over his erection. “This isn’t my fault!”

“I never said it was, HKS!” Mydei glares at him over his shoulder, grabbing the apron up from where it was slung over the back of his chair. He folds it over his forearm, holding it over his stomach.

Ah, Phainon finally clocks on. *He's trying to hide his reaction*. It's almost cute, especially after last night where he'd seen almost everything already.

"Alright, alright," Phainon acquiesces quickly, not wanting to poke any further and rile him up. It seems that he's still in a strange mood, after all. "I'll leave you to it and go brush my teeth."

"You've already brushed them earlier," Mydei says flatly. "Twice."

Phainon stands up quickly, smirking as he's already making a run for it. "I lied!"

"You let me kiss you when you hadn't -! *Phainon*!" Mydei shouts after him, but Phainon is already too far away for him to do anything.

After that, everything else seems dull in comparison - muted and washed out, like someone turned the saturation down on the entire world. Phainon's walk to class had felt like dragging himself through fog, each step heavy with the weight of his thoughts. The sky above mirrored his mood perfectly, a flat stretch of grey that bled into the horizon with no sign of blue. Even the flowers lining the pavement - bright daffodils and tulips that usually caught his eye - seemed faded today, their colours dulled by the overcast gloom or maybe just by the way he couldn't seem to see the beauty in anything that wasn't Mydei. He knows that sounds dramatic, but sadly it's true.

Especially after this morning. He keeps replaying it in his head - each kiss, each touch, each breathless moan against his mouth - and the echo if it only serves to intensify the grey around him. The world feels off-kilter now like he's floating half a second behind reality, stuck somewhere between memory and want. Phainon trudged on regardless, making his way into the classroom without much fanfare except for the embers burning in his chest.

Now, though, he's staring blankly at the whiteboard at the front of the classroom. *Carbohydrates are the primary energy source during high-intensity exercise*, it reads in bold font on the presentation being projected. It's underlined as if that'll somehow make it interesting. Below it, there's a graphic of a triangle split into categories, labelled 'The Nutritional Hierarchy', and his lecturer is currently explaining each part bit by bit in grave seriousness. The last time Phainon checked in, he was on about how insufficient glycogen replenishment leads to poor recovery outcomes. This is stuff he learned in *secondary school*, and he rolls his eyes at how he could be spending his time elsewhere instead of listening to this. Like being with Mydei, hanging out and watching TV, or cooking together. Even doing coursework together in the library sounds more intriguing than this.

Phainon's pen rests limp between his fingers, his laptop screen dark as he hasn't touched it in about half an hour since the class began. He hasn't written a single word in his notebook or on a word document, both sitting blank. Across the aisle, someone's chewing gum far too loudly. The projector hums overhead, and the guy beside him is doodling an almost grotesquely muscular cartoon leg in the margin of his notes. All of it blurs into background static as Phainon tries, and fails, to focus on anything other than this morning.

Specifically, *Mydei* this morning. He'd started off sleep-rumpled, gentle, as syrup-sweet as the pancakes they shared later on. Then, almost like a switch had been flipped, he'd ended up like lightning in a bottle, thunderous and charged beyond belief. His brain plays it on repeat: the curve of Mydei's lips after a kiss, the weight of him in his lap, the *look* in his eyes when Phainon began to match his pace. Phainon exhales through his nose, pointed and quiet, hoping to release this restlessness along with it.

It doesn't work.

His lecturer has moved on to hydration strategies now, rambling about electrolytes and water balance and something about sodium levels being important to avoid muscle cramps. Phainon tries to care, he really does, but then he remembers how Mydei had moaned softly into his mouth when he tugged on his apron, and his brain short-circuits again. He can't believe this is the second time he's wasting a lecture away thinking about Mydei, and he can practically envision a wad of cash being flushed down the toilet with his own hands. He sighs, shifting in his seat, uncomfortable and warm under the collar. His notebook still remains empty except for the date at the top. He stares at it, deeply unimpressed with himself.

Then, his phone buzzes quietly in his hoodie pocket. He jolts like he's been caught doing something illegal, eyes flicking up to make sure no one noticed. The guy beside him has shuffled further away, a big gap between them now marking an empty seat. His lecturer is now mid-rant about sodium again, this time how it decreases while sweating, and Phainon realises that no one's paying attention to him.

He assumes it's Castorice again, hopefully trying to make lunch plans for today but when he taps the screen and wakes it up, he sees that it's from

Mydei.

[09:27 am] Mydei:

Meet me back at home for lunch.

Phainon blinks down in shock at his phone.

[09:27 am] Phainon:

what why

did i forget smth?

[09:28 am] Mydei:

Yes. We have something planned.

Phainon looks up from his phone and glances around the room as if searching for an answer amongst the tables and students gathered here today. His lecturer is typing something on his laptop, gesturing to the presentation as he edits the slide they're currently on. Phainon immediately stops caring and goes back to his text messages.

[09:30 am] Phainon:

sorry i guess i completely forgot :-(i'll be there for 1

[09:30 am] Mydei:

Sure.

Phainon reacts to the message with a heart emoji and pockets his phone again, slightly confused but also intrigued about whatever he forgot.

The front door shuts behind him with a *click*, the lock flipping into place. The flat is quiet, so Phainon takes his time in toeing off his shoes and kicking them over into the cubby before he speaks.

“Mydei, are you home -?”

He doesn’t finish the sentence.

Because Mydei is *already there*. There’s a blur of motion and warmth, a sudden rush of air as someone collides with him, and then he’s being pushed. Not hard, but with enough purpose that he goes with it easily, allowing himself to be shoved and moulded into place with his back against the door. His bag hits the floor with a dull thud, landing in a heap by his socked feet. Before he can blink, before he can even begin to utter another word, Mydei’s mouth is on his - feverish, needy, stealing the oxygen straight from his lips.

Phainon makes a soft, surprised sound and clutches blindly for something to hold onto. “Mydei?!”

“Be quiet,” Is all he gets in return. His fingers find fabric, the familiar cling of Mydei’s rugby shirt, and he grips it like an anchor, the only thing keeping him rooted. Mydei kisses him like he’s been waiting all day, behaving like they haven’t kissed in *years* rather than mere hours. He’s so hot, burning against him, lips pressed hard to his. It’s a little off-centre, a little messy like Mydei is too far gone to care about technique anymore.

He finds he doesn’t care. Phainon’s head spins, heart hammering as Mydei mouths at him, impatient and tense. It feels as though Mydei’s been tensely coiled while he was away, and now he’s finally letting everything loose. He tastes faintly citrusy, and Phainon can’t help but smile into the kiss at the thought of Mydei sneaking in those lemon sherbets between lessons. Phainon leans in further, chasing the taste, licking and biting and swallowing it all down until there’s nothing left.

When they finally part for air, it’s barely a second - just the space of a breath, a single heartbeat caught between them - before Mydei dives back in like he can’t stand the distance. There’s no hesitation, no pause for thought. His gaze doesn’t lift, doesn’t stray even for a moment. It’s locked onto Phainon’s mouth, fixed and hungry, eyes tracing the curve of it, memorising it in all of its flushed and bitten-red glory.

Phainon breathes out, the sound sharp and soft all at once as he can’t decide whether to be annoyed or flattered by the onslaught of attention. His lips are swollen and tingling, slick from where Mydei’s teeth and tongue had

claimed them seconds earlier. His eyes flutter shut automatically, practically muscle memory now, his body already knowing what to do and settling into the rhythm.

There's something frantic about it this time. Mydei's hands come up to cup Phainon's cheek, a leg bullying its way in between his thighs, making Phainon jump with the sudden contact. He wants to grind down so badly that it almost hurts, his cock stirring in his jeans as Mydei's entire body is flush against his. There's no space between them, not even an inch, and all he can feel is *Mydei Mydei Mydei*. The kiss is almost ferocious, like he's being attacked by a lion, all teeth and fangs and claws and nails.

The floral scent of his fabric softener, his shampoo and his sweet musky cologne all blend in, swirling around Phainon like a physical mist he's getting drunk off of. It's addicting, cloying and treacly, each inhale dripping through his pores like golden syrup.

"Hello to you too," Phainon says when they pull away again, voice lilting and slightly rough.

"Hi," Mydei replies slowly, although he's still not looking directly at Phainon.

"My eyes are up here," Phainon drawls, tucking a finger underneath Mydei's chin so he can lift it up until they're at eye level. "Not that I didn't enjoy that immensely, but what was all that for?"

“I told you earlier,” Mydei begins, a slight grin on his face that makes him look even more handsome than usual. His eyes are narrowed, brows drawn as though he’s plotting something. “You need to catch up on your practise. Morning, afternoon, and night.”

Phainon’s jaw drops, “You were serious? Is *that* why you called me all the way back home?”

“Complaining, are you?” Mydei asks, voice smooth as silk as he moves his knee higher between Phainon’s thighs until it comes into contact with his half-hard cock. “This part of you isn’t.”

“Yeah, well,” Phainon starts shakily, his breathing pitchy and uneven at the touch. “When a very beautiful man starts kissing you like that, maybe you’d understand.”

“I do understand,” Mydei says, arching his back so they’re even more closely packed together, and that’s when Phainon feels it.

Mydei is hard too.

“Oh,” Phainon lets out, the word strangled. “Oh! Oh, okay, I, um - I see.”

Mydei snickers. “You look like a tomato.”

“Don’t tease me,” Phainon whines, hands falling to rest on the curve of Mydei’s ass. He doesn’t use the leverage to push or pull them away, just lets them rest there, enjoying the feeling of it under his palms.

Mydei hums, his arms coming up to wrap around Phainon’s neck. “Wouldn’t dream of it.”

“You’re a lying liar,” Phainon says. He tilts his head to the side and kisses Mydei’s equally warm cheek. “You’re just as red as me.”

“Your score for today,” Mydei says loudly, clearly discarding Phainon’s attempts at getting him back. “Is a D.”

Phainon snorts, “What, for dick?”

“No,” Mydei rolls his eyes. “For *decent*.”

“Decent?! But I’m - *you’re* -” Phainon glances down between their bodies where they’re both still hard.

Mydei shrugs, bottom lip jutting out ever so slightly. “Looks like you’ll need to come back for your nightly practise.”

Before Phainon can say or do anything - no clever remark, no teasing comment, not even a breath to chase after him - Mydei is already pulling away. The absence is immediate as cool air slips into the space Mydei's body had occupied, curling around Phainon's chest like a taunt. Goosebumps rise in waves along his arms, a shiver stealing down his spine in Mydei's wake. The contrast is so stark it almost feels cruel, like being thrown into water after basking in the sun too long. The material of his hoodie hugs his skin, still faintly warm from where Mydei's hands had touched him, but it's fading too fast for him to cling onto.

The entire front of his body feels exposed, cold in the worst kind of way because he knows how it feels to be warm in that type of way. To be wrapped up in Mydei - breath, hands, mouth, all of it. Phainon's fingertips twitch at his sides, bereft without Mydei to hold, aching to reach out again and take him into his arms. It doesn't even matter about the kissing anymore, or the urge to get off like what happened last night. He just wants *Mydei*.

"I've gotta get to practise now," Mydei says, nudging Phainon out of the way so he can grab his trainers.

"What?" Phainon blinks back into existence. "We're not -?"

"Nope. Payback." Mydei looks up at him as he ties his shoelaces, smirking. "You can go back to class and think about what you did."

“What I did?” Phainon freezes, mind skidding to a halt. “Is this about me not brushing my teeth?”

Mydei laughs, a sound that’s both melodic and just rough enough around the edges to be unmistakably *him*. It’s warm in tone, the kind of laugh that’s thick with fondness. Phainon’s heart flutters wildly, doing little somersaults like it’s trying to chase after the sound and wrap it up deep inside his chest to keep it safe.

“Maybe,” Mydei replies, standing back up again so he can grab his duffle bag. “I’ll see you later.”

“Wait!” Phainon grabs the back of Mydei’s shirt and hauls him in, landing a kiss squarely on the centre of Mydei’s lips. “A goodbye kiss just for you.”

“That wasn’t on any of the lists,” Mydei mutters, although his eyes are focused on a spot on the floor and his cheeks are tinted pink once more.

“Get to rugby already,” Phainon chuckles, smacking Mydei on the shoulder a few times to usher him out of the door.

As soon as he’s gone, Phainon’s smile drops and he’s left with overwhelming silence and his still way too hard dick that hasn’t gone down yet. Maybe skipping his next class wouldn’t be such a bad idea…

Phainon doesn’t skip his next class. He goes, sits through the entire thing, and even manages to take a few notes - although what they say and what they’re about, he’ll never know until he eventually rereads them for studying. There’s a low thrum just beneath his skin, an itch he can’t quite place, and a restless sort of buzz that no amount of pacing, fidgeting or calm breathing can help. It doesn’t hurt, at least not physically, but it’s *persistent*. Unshakeable. The kind of tension he’s sure that only Mydei will know how to handle.

Either way, after all that, he doesn’t run home, not technically. But the second his professor dismisses them, he’s shooting up out of his seat, running down the aisle’s steps to the door all while practically tripping over his own feet. Outside, the world has shifted once again. The dull, grey haze of this morning is long gone, replaced by chirping birds and soft sunlight that filters through the trees and warms his cheeks as he walks along the pavement. Even the lining flowers that had looked lifeless on his way to campus now seemed happy to see him - their bold and vibrant petals swaying in the gentle breeze as if saying hello.

Their block of flats is modest, tucked between larger buildings and hidden mostly out of the way by passers-by. Just three storeys high, it’s nothing fancy, but it’s *theirs*. They live on the first floor, which only means one flight of stairs to reach their door, but today it feels like scaling a mountain. Phainon takes two steps at a time, heart hammering - not from the climb, but from the anticipation tightening in his chest like a coiled spring of seeing Mydei again. The second he reaches their floor, he fumbles for their keys, nearly dropping them twice before finally jamming them into the lock and throwing the door open with a little more force than was technically necessary.

He practically launches himself inside, keys clattering into the trinket bowl by the entrance alongside a bunch of random coins and tat that's never found a place elsewhere. Before the door's even fully shut behind him, he's already tugging at his hoodie, overheating with impatience and nerves. The cool breeze from outside is gone, completely replaced with a stifling heat that makes him nervous. The hem catches under Phainon's chin, and then he's stuck - arm halfway out, head twisted, the fabric trapping him in some type of cotton straightjacket.

"Ugh!" Phainon exclaims, twisting in place and kicking his foot out in an attempt to free himself from both his hoodie and his trainers at the same time. It goes about as well as expected; which is to say, not well at all. His laces are stubborn, double-knotted things that refuse to budge.

Phainon stumbles forward, off-balance by being tangled up and sweating from the sudden onslaught of physical activity to try and get himself out of this mess. "Shit -!"

"What the fuck are you doing?" Two warm hands catch him before he can trip over his own feet for real this time. Phainon freezes, almost accidentally jerking out of the hold by accident in shock at the scent of Mydei's shower-fresh skin hitting him instantly. He smells so *good*, sharp, clean and faintly citrusy.

"Mydei!" Phainon brightens up immediately, but then realises he can barely see the other considering his awkward position. He stands up, wobbling a little as he finally gets his hoodie up and over his head, letting out a sigh of relief once he's free. "You're…" Phainon trails off.

“Hopeless?” Mydei finishes, taking every chance he can to lay in a jab at Phainon. He rolls his eyes, hands moving to help get him out of this damned hoodie. One settles on his shoulder while the other tugs at the material bunched over his head. With practised ease, Mydei peels it off of him, guiding his trapped arm out of the sleeve, fingers brushing over skin as he does.

Phainon feels hot all over, sweat prickling at his hairline and upper lip at the touch. The air feels static, charged from one mere brushing of skin alone. It’s *embarrassing* how quickly he’s affected by Mydei now. He blinks as he’s freed from the hoodie, the rest of it slipping off him easily and his eyes adjust to the light once again - only for his gaze to land on Mydei standing in front of him in nothing but a towel. The vision hits him like a punch to the gut, his cheeks reddening and something tugging behind his navel at the sight.

Mydei’s still damp from the shower, that much is obvious from the way his hair is dripping in uneven strands and water trailing in rivulets across his body. Phainon can’t help but follow one specific drop from the tip of Mydei’s chin to where it lands in the divot of his collarbone, sinking down further over his chest and over the ridges of his abs until it disappears unceremoniously into his towel that’s slung dangerously low on his hips. His skin glows faintly in the hazy lighting coming through the windows, the last bit of the day slinking away slowly into the sunset. More and more droplets trickle off his hair, off his eyelashes, catching and sliding across his body until Phainon doesn’t know where to look.

His gaze flits from Mydei’s face - *dangerous*, with the way it’s still pink from the heat - to his torso, broad and bare and right there, his glorious red tattoos swirling across the expanse. Phainon’s mouth goes dry and then it waters, and everything in him goes still, except for his heartbeat which is thunderous against his ribcage.

“Go get ready,” Mydei’s voice cuts through the silence like a knife through silk. “We’re going food shopping.”

“Are we?” Phainon asks faintly, only listening to about half of what Mydei said.

“Yes,” Mydei says bluntly, then proceeds to *thwack* Phainon in the face with his own hoodie. “Stop staring and get moving!”

Phainon bats at the material in self defence and then promptly proceeds to run away, heading straight for the bathroom.

The bus ride into the town centre isn’t long, thankfully. However, as soon as they settle into their seats, time feels suspended between them, wrapped in the quietness of the early evening. The interior of the double-decker is packed, warm with the body heat of strangers and the scent of worn coats and fast food. People from every walk of life fill the seats and aisles - students with headphones clamped over their ears, workers still in uniforms, an elderly woman reading what Phainon recognises to be some shady, smutty book that was popular a decade ago, her bag tucked beneath her feet. No one speaks above a murmur, the atmosphere taking a subdued turn, like everyone’s too tired to push their voices beyond the low hum of the bus’s engine or the rustle of pages being turned.

Outside, the sky has melted into a smoky blue, the last streaks of sunlight retreating behind the buildings as twilight creeps in. Street lamps flicker to life in clusters, their golden light casting gentle reflections onto the bus windows. Phainon presses his forehead against the cool glass, eyes flickering over familiar shopfronts and lit windows glowing as soft beacons in the dusk. His breath fogs up the pane, spreading in a misty cloud that takes a while to dissipate. With a faint smile, he lifts a finger and draws a quick smiley face into the condensation. It's a simple, wonky-looking thing that disappears almost as fast as it appears. He nudges Mydei excitedly with his elbow, catching his attention to gesture to the face before it's gone for good.

Mydei looks at it blankly until it's gone, then he huffs a quiet laugh and rolls his eyes, his mouth twitching like he's trying not to smile but losing the battle. The bus rumbles on beneath them, the world slipping by in blurs of orange light and cool shadow, pressed together from shoulder to thigh until Phainon decides to break the silence.

"Did you bring a list?" Phainon asks, huddling in closer next to Mydei as the old lady in front of him knocks her knees into his. He winces, shuffling his feet back until he can't make himself any smaller.

"I have it all memorised," Mydei says simply, tapping the side of his head.

"Show off," Phainon mutters. "I thought we'd be fine until the weekend?"

"Turns out we've run out of fruit," Mydei sighs, sitting back in his seat and crossing his arms over his chest. Thankfully, now, he's fully dressed in

jeans, a turtleneck jumper and a coat. “And we have no bread or eggs left either.”

Phainon presses the button for the bus to stop, and they get off with minimal stepping on toes as they shuffle through the throng of people who have to stand up.

The cool evening air hits him, and he’s grateful for the crispness of it after being cramped up in a small space for twenty minutes. “Did you bring -”

“The shopping bags? Yes,” Mydei finishes. “Don’t worry your pretty little head about it.”

“You think I’m *pretty*?” Phainon repeats as they grab a trolley, batting his eyelashes with an over-dramatic flair.

“I think you’re annoying,” Mydei replies and doesn’t elaborate.

“Always a charmer,” Phainon mutters, leaning in so he can tug at Mydei’s braid playfully.

Mydei gives him a long glance and doesn’t say anything as they begin to wander around the shop. Phainon is more than happy to walk alongside Mydei, their shoulders bumping occasionally as he puts items in the trolley until there’s a small pile of food and packets built up.

“Wait, just get the cheaper one,” Phainon says, picking up another box of cereal that’s a knock-off brand of the one in Mydei’s hand. “They taste the same.”

“No, they don’t,” Mydei replies, putting the more expensive one in. “Put that back.”

“You never listen to me when we go shopping,” Phainon scowls, plucking the box out of the trolley to give it him back and dumping his in instead.

“Because you’re *wrong*,” Mydei responds, sighing gruffly. “And I’m paying, remember?”

“Yeah, I know. I’m just trying to save you some money!” Phainon says while he watches Mydei swap the cereals again, the expensive one now in place. “You -!”

“*Yeah*, well,” Mydei pushes off, leaving Phainon standing a few steps behind with the cheap box still in hand. “These are your favourite, so stop whining.”

Phainon bristles, face scrunched up in annoyance as he huffs and slams the cheaper box back onto the shelf. “For the record, I think *you’re* annoying too.”

“You won’t be saying that when you’re eating your fancy little cereal shapes tomorrow,” Mydei retorts, silencing Phainon. It’s true, he knows it, they both do.

“In that case -” Phainon cuts off when Mydei places his hand on his lower back, nudging him into his side to avoid an oncoming customer who’s not paying attention.

They stand still for a moment, pressed flush together in the narrow aisle as the customer finally notices their existence and bows her head in apology, squeezing past them with her trolley until the space finally clears. Phainon’s breath catches, the press of Mydei’s chest against his own sending a jolt of awareness through him. Mydei’s hand still on his lower back feels protective, firm, and *close*. The lingering pressure of the touch burns, a phantom weight even after Mydei drops his arm to rest beside him again.

Phainon blinks slowly, his stomach flipping at the sheer strength behind the gesture. It wasn’t demanding or pushing, but guiding instead, a reactive touch that’s born out of care. It’s a kind of unthinking move that sends Phainon’s brain into a tailspin. He’s not a small guy, either. Stocky and well-built from years of football, his shoulders were broad and solid as well as Mydei’s. But right now, with Mydei this close, this still, he suddenly feels smaller, like he’s being protected. He swallows thickly, and it takes longer than it should for his brain to catch up. When it does, he realises Mydei hasn’t stepped away. He’s just watching him, amber eyes dark and unknowing, his gaze fixed intently on Phainon’s face as if he’s memorising every detail.

His gaze drifts - slow and purposeful - from the slope of his cheek, the arch of his brow until finally it settles on his lips. Phainon's breath stutters, his heartbeat jumping as though he's got palpitations. It's then that he realises how close they are. Their faces are inches apart, the scent of Mydei's skin clean and fresh in the confined air between them. Phainon's entire world sways slightly, and he sways with it, falling more into Mydei as though he'd been knocked over by the passing woman. He wants to say something, *anything*, to break this tension that's taut like a rubber band about to snap. He's not even sure why Mydei is looking at him like that, why he's waiting and watching and his head is dipping forward like he's about to -

"We need milk," Phainon says, his voice barely even a squeak.

Mydei jolts back, eyes going from fuzzy to clear within a matter of seconds. He nods, clearing his throat. "I'm not getting almond milk again."

"Sure, sure," Phainon laughs, albeit a bit nervously. He scratches his cheek, "I'm pretty sure they sell that goat's milk that you like here."

Mydei isn't looking at him anymore, jaw firmly set and eyes focused ahead. It's almost as if Phainon isn't there, like Mydei has shut him out completely and he's here alone. He instantly misses the weight of Mydei's honeyed eyes on him, that syrupy, saccharine gaze that was so *soft*, so gentle, watching him like he was something precious.

"Let's go," Mydei says briskly, and Phainon has a hard time catching up after him.

Once they're home, things still feel tense. It sets something off in Phainon's stomach, squirming and panicked. Mydei didn't say a word on the way back after the shops, even when Phainon accidentally stepped on his toes as the bus jolted to a stop at some traffic lights; he didn't even bother to throw him a glare or a snipped *watch it* in retaliation. Nor did he speak whenever he tried to encourage him - blathering on about the weather, his lectures and how excited he is for the sports day that's coming up in a few weeks' time. Mydei barely glanced at him, looking away until Phainon slowly trailed off into silence, consumed by his feelings.

Mydei remains silent, clearly lost in his headspace as they kick their shoes off and dump their jackets onto their allotted pegs, moving through the flat with nothing but tension between them. Phainon doesn't know what happened - one moment, Mydei was fine, they were bantering back and forth like they usually do and then that *thing* happened where it looked like he was going to kiss him in public. Is that what this is about? *Kissing*? Perhaps almost breaking the rules he'd set for himself? Phainon huffs, puffing out his cheeks and folding his arms over his chest as he glares daggers into the back of Mydei's head.

They're in the kitchen now, organising the shopping out of the bags and putting it all away. *Two can play at that game*, Phainon thinks as he knocks shoulders with Mydei on the way to the fridge, huffing and sighing loudly as he goes.

"What's wrong with you?" Mydei asks, his voice on the sharp edge of actually being pissed off.

“I dunno,” Phainon replies snarkily, “What’s wrong with *you*?”

“You’re the one who knocked into me,” Mydei points out.

“You’re the one who’s been ignoring me!” Phainon replies, almost shouting. He slams the carton of stupid goat’s milk into the tray on the inside of the fridge door. “It was like I was talking to a wall the entire way home!”

Mydei sighs and it sounds tired. Exhausted, actually. The tautness in Phainon’s shoulders holds only for a moment more before he sighs back and turns around, shutting the fridge softly behind him as he reluctantly lets go of his anger. He can never stay mad at Mydei for too long, always too afraid of what’ll happen if he *does*. Phainon doesn’t want Mydei to get mad back, shout at him earnestly or even worse, *leave him* completely. He already deals with that enough in his nightmares - Mydei so close and yet so far, Phainon always one step behind and never able to fully catch up no matter how hard he tries. He wonders if that happened in his real life… well, he’s not sure how he’d react or cope. It isn’t worth thinking about, he supposes, because it’ll never happen anyway. He won’t let it, won’t allow it, will never just sit back and watch Mydei slip away through his fingers.

“It doesn’t matter,” Mydei says, rubbing the bridge of his nose between his thumb and forefinger.

“Make me dinner and I’ll forgive you,” Phainon replies, sniffing haughtily and sticking his nose in the air. He slides a glance over to Mydei who is looking at him now, *finally,* his entire attention all on him. There’s still

some fraughtness in his expression, the way his eyebrows are knitted together and the downward turn of his lips that causes a small dimple to appear on his cheek. Phainon wants to grab him by the shoulders and kiss it, making this entire thing go away, but he holds firm for once.

“I was going to make you dinner anyways, fool,” Mydei says but the insult doesn’t sound anywhere near as harsh as it usually does when it’s thrown his way. “But you’re folding our laundry afterwards.”

“No, please, anything but that!” Phainon whines, running over to Mydei and wrapping his arms around him. He brings their foreheads together, squeezing his eyes shut as he nuzzles into Mydei’s face intending to anger him so badly he’ll take it back.

Hands land on his hips, shoving him away. “Then no dinner for you.”

“Mydei!” Phainon drags out the name, his voice pitching high the longer it goes on until he’s making unintelligible noises.

It doesn’t matter if he’s embarrassing himself, all that matters is that Mydei is looking at him again, a small smile on his face and his eyes gentle and fond as he watches on.

“I can’t believe this.”

“It’s your own fault.”

“It’s my own fault that I’m -” Phainon hesitates, holding out the piece of washing in his hand. “Folding your underwear?”

“Yep,” Mydei replies simply, focusing on his pile. “And I’m folding your socks. So it’s even.”

“Not even *at all*,” Phainon mutters, but he carries on anyway as he folds Mydei’s already tiny white briefs into even tinier squares, pressing them down so they lay flat on his knee.

They sit in companionable silence, folding each other’s clothing and separating them into small piles. It’s nice, being like this, doing stuff that’d be classed as *domestic* together. Phainon’s never really thought about it before, but he thinks he enjoys doing these activities more than he originally assumed. Obviously doing the dishes, washing and cleaning the flat isn’t his idea of ‘fun’, per se, but doing it with Mydei always seems to bring a smile to his face. Like right now, there’s a small one tugging at his lips as he ducks his head down and tries to work faster, wanting to catch up to Mydei. He’s already almost done, folding Phainon’s clothes with an authoritarian level of concentration and neatness. Phainon bites down on the inside of his cheek to keep a laugh and a jab at bay, not wanting to mess with someone who’s got a hold of his clothes. Mydei’s concentrated face is so *cute*, all pinched and determined and overly serious.

“Right, these are for your top drawers,” Mydei begins, dumping a load of folded-up clean washing on his lap. “And the rest you can organise yourself.”

Phainon blinks down at the stacked-high piles now neatly sitting on his thighs. He points to the piles on the coffee table, “I also organised your stuff by drawers. I think you’d wanna put that jacket into your wardrobe though or it’ll never hang right…”

Mydei stands up, dusting off his hands before ruffling Phainon’s hair. “Thanks.”

“Not like you gave me a choice in the matter,” Phainon grumbles, but nudges his head up into Mydei’s touch regardless, feeling warm.

“I was sick of looking at it cluttering up the living room. We are *not* slobs, got that?”

Phainon sarcastically salutes him, “Of course, captain.” Then, he sobers up. “Wait, actually, I think you’re forgetting something.”

“Oh?” Mydei raises an eyebrow.

Phainon taps his cheek, “A thank you kiss to go with it?”

Mydei hums, watching him intently. Then, he swoops down and presses the quickest of kisses against Phainon’s cheek. He bristles, barely even having felt a thing. “Is that it? I’ve been a good boy, right?”

“Phainon…” Mydei breathes out and then shakes his head, a tiny smirk on his face. “You have been a good boy.”

“See,” Phainon cheekily grins up at Mydei still looming over him. He gently places his washing next to him on the sofa and stands up, now almost nose-to-nose with how close they are. He tilts his head to the side, looking at Mydei imploringly. “Plus, you did promise me extra practise.”

“I did,” Mydei says quietly. “But what are you going to do about it?”

“Hmm,” Phainon is still grinning, his cheek muscles twitching with how wide it is. He curls his arms around Mydei’s waist, tugging him in closer until their chests are flush against each other. “I could kiss you right now and be done with it?”

“Where’s the fun in that?” Mydei asks, eyes going between Phainon’s and then his lips as he winds his arms around Phainon’s waist as well.

“I think all our kissing is pretty fun,” Phainon starts, nudging their noses together, lips brushing. He starts to speak again, making sure that every

single word is plush against Mydei's mouth: "Especially when you make those cute little noises."

He doesn't give Mydei a second to berate him, swooping in the last few atoms between them to capture Mydei's lips. He doesn't deepen it just yet, wanting to thrive off the feeling of Mydei's lips along his for a few moments longer, Mydei's pomegranate lip balm smearing all over him. It tastes faintly sweet and mostly waxy, but knowing it's from Mydei makes him groan deep in his chest as he tightens his grip around his small waist, pulling him impossibly closer. Phainon tugs at Mydei's bottom lip just to make him whine, and it works, that tiny sound tumbling straight out of him.

"Told you," Phainon murmurs, his hands moving, moving, moving until they're grabbing at Mydei's ass, groping and testing. That makes Mydei moan, and the loose grip around Phainon's waist becomes like a death knot, tight and inescapable.

"I'll rate you an F if you keep messing around," Mydei says, glowering. His eyes are so bright this close, his golden eyelashes framing them like a portrait in an art museum.

"That'd -" Phainon kisses Mydei again, swiping his tongue to taste more of his lip balm. "Be -" He goes again, kissing the side of his mouth, trailing his lips up to Mydei's cheek. "Awful." He finishes, landing another chaste kiss against the swell, leaving a smudge of translucent red behind.

Mydei looks taken aback, breathless and slightly impressed all at once. “And yet you’ve stopped again?”

“You’re not teaching me anything, what am I supposed to do?” Phainon replies, putting on a drag to his words to sound bored.

“Kiss me again,” Mydei instructs. “Hard.”

Phainon laughs, slightly hysterically, his cock twitching as he dives right back in, pushing their lips together so hard that their teeth clack. It doesn’t deter him, instead encouraging him to draw back slightly to do it all over again. Mydei shifts in his stance, leaning more into him, his entire body weight counting on Phainon to keep him up. He sighs happily through his nose as Mydei unravels one of his arms to cup Phainon’s jawline and angle him just slightly to the left, taking and taking and *taking* all that he wants along with it. He goes willingly, not fighting against the demand as he goes. Phainon feels dizzy, overwrought and overly warm, pushing and pulling against Mydei’s lips until they’re spit-slick and swollen from how long they’ve been kissing.

“Is it still an F?” Phainon asks, nosing at Mydei as he speaks.

“U for ungraded,” Mydei replies, voice velvety smooth. “Now get your paws off my ass.”

“*Woof*,” Phainon imitates and lets go of Mydei’s ass, waiting for Mydei to let go of him. “Are you going to keep clinging onto me all night?”

“*You’re* the clingy one,” Mydei scowls and lets go, immediately grabbing his pile of laundry, heading off and taking it with him into his room and leaving Phainon on his own. He’s fighting off a smile and the urge to kick his legs out at the kissing, but he barely reels himself in when he remembers how Mydei heard him before doing nonsense like that in his room. He doesn’t need any more embarrassment added to his plate. He stands up and balances all his washing on top of each other, blindly making his way back to his bedroom so he can dump it on his desk to deal with later. He was *not* in the mood to put it away right now, even though Mydei had already sorted it out into which drawers it needed to go into.

Instead, he grabs a fresh pair of joggers and a worn band tee from the pile and changes, settling into bed and scrolling on his phone. He sighs, already tapping on Castorice’s text chat to message her.

[08:49 pm] Phainon:

i really am in love with him

[08:52 pm] Castorice:

Mydei? ヽ(。> ᵕ <)ノ♡ Yes, we all know.

[08:52 pm] Phainon:

but does he know???

[08:53 pm] Castorice:

I’m not sure… Your secret is safe with me though. (ㅅ´ ˘ `)

But what brought this on?

[08:54 pm] Phainon:

did you know that i fold his underwear and he folds my socks

and he always puts my favourite cereal in the trolley even when i say not to bc it’s expensive

it’s kinda creepy actually kinda scary but wow

i like him so much.

[08:54 pm] Castorice:

Oh, Phainon… (,,>﹏<,,) I can’t speak on his behalf, but I truly know he cares for you. A lot.

Phainon sighs, his heart crumpling in his chest and a lump in his throat appears. He turns over in bed so he’s facing the ceiling, staring up at it for a moment to gather himself. Of course, he knows Mydei *cares* for him, but it’s merely just as a friend. A friend who kisses him. Who takes care of him, who matches him with every step and isn’t afraid to set him back into place if he feels like he’s losing himself. Seriously, where would he be right now with Mydei? He isn’t sure and he isn’t sure he wants to find out, either. So it’s easier to keep these feelings bottled up, allowing them to fizz and boil in his stomach until he feels like he’s going to explode with them. Because he’d rather explode than tell Mydei how much he adores him and get nothing back in return, except maybe losing him along the way.

Instead, he'll show it in subtler ways. And there's one way he knows that'll shoot him directly into the centre of Mydei's heart.

[09:02 pm] Phainon:

are they still selling those cinema tickets for the rerelease of city of warriors?

[09:04 pm] Castorice:

They are. I'll send you the link now. I checked and there's only one show left on Saturday at 10 pm.

…I'm not sure what you're planning, but I'm sure he'll love it (ノノ> ᴗ•ノノ)

Saturday is *perfect*. It's still a few days away, which means he has time to buy the tickets and plan out his outfit for the occasion. *Don't call it a date*, his brain supplies, even though he really wants to call it a date.

"I'm going to ask Mydeimos out on a date," Phainon whispers to himself, just to hear it become *real*, and then proceeds to roll around in his bed for the next five minutes, thrashing around in a mad panic.

Chapter End Notes

leave a comment and/or kudos if you enjoyed! thank you so much!!! each comment truly makes my day and motivates me to write more

-

we're getting closer to the end now wwaaaahhh... T_T i think there will either be 6 or 7 chapters, depends on if i can split up the rest of the plot or keep it into one chapter. so who knows, maybe the next one will be the last... sniffles cries sobs

-

let's be friends on twitter/x!!

Chapter 6: chapter six

Chapter Summary

> "*Go on a date with me*." He wants to say. "*Let me kiss you and let me mean it properly*." He wants to say. "*I love you*." He wants to say.

Chapter Notes

> oh my dear god... long time no see everyone... nervous laughter..... life got in the way, but i'm back now and hoping to finish this thing!!!! :3
>
> just wanted to thank everyone for being so patient and sticking with me throughout this process, i really appreciate every single one of you truly means to world to me and motivated me to finally getting my ass into gear lol
>
> as usual, this is haphazardly edited by me which means there will be mistakes! just ignore them pls and thank you (̀• ω •́)✧
>
> hope you all enjoy! (´▽`ʃ♡ƪ)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Except, asking Mydei out on a date sounds easier in his head than doing it in real life.

Phainon doesn't have much time—just a few days before the film starts showing—but every ounce of confidence he's built up seems to vanish the moment he tries to speak. He rehearses lines in his head, imagines the conversation going smoothly, but when he's actually standing there, in front of Mydei, words fail him. More than once, he opens his mouth with a hesitant "*Hey, Mydei*—" only to falter halfway through. The air always feels too heavy with his own expectations, the silence of his fumbling too sharp

for him to handle. So with a laugh, he changes the topic and says something safer instead: weather, schedules, anything but what he actually *wants* to say. Each time the words get caught between his heart and his throat, and each time Mydei gives him a sharp glare that is all too knowing for his liking.

As much as Phainon wants to forget about it after all his mess-ups, he stays awake at night replaying them, thinking of how close he finally got before he chickened out. Because that's what he's doing—being a *chicken*. He's so caught up on it being a 'date' that nothing else seems to matter, completely losing every bit of his rationality and confidence.

So by Friday, the day before the showing, his chest feels stuffy and his stomach is in knots. The thought of never asking, of letting the chance he has slip through his fingers completely, aches more than the fear ever does.

It's Friday evening now. Classes have been attended, dinner has been eaten, and now they've been left to their own devices. He *should* be studying, but he's so restless with these burning questions that he can't settle. Instead, he chooses to track Mydei down. He's not in his room, nor in the living room, but he hears the quiet *tac tac tac* of fingertips on a keyboard coming from the kitchen. He wanders over, clearing his throat when he reaches the doorway.

"Hey, Mydei," Phainon begins. It should sound like a greeting, but his voice tilts up at the end into a question.

He only has today and tomorrow left to ask him out. The tickets are already booked—the confirmation email sitting pristine in his inbox, still unopened. Mydei looks up from his laptop, his eyebrows furrowed and mouth pinched and—

Oh.

He's wearing *glasses* tonight. Just like that, Phainon's thoughts derail completely. Whatever thread of courage he'd been clinging to unravels in an instant. The words he means to say dissolve on his tongue, replaced by something helpless and dizzying. There's something so unfair about it—how Mydei can look so effortlessly good, how the glasses soften his face and draw attention to the small details Phainon never lets himself linger on for too long in fear of being disarmed: the curve of his mouth, the crease between his brows, the way his eyes—sharp, thoughtful, slightly irritated—catch the light behind the lenses.

Phainon tries to look away, but his chest tightens. It's ridiculous how one simple thing can undo him like this. He should be used to seeing Mydei in glasses by now, but he doesn't think he'll ever get used to it. He's supposed to be asking Mydei to the cinema, not staring at him like some lovesick fool—no matter how much he *is* one. Gods, he can't help it. There's a warmth blooming behind his ribs, spreading through him like sunlight and static. He forces himself to breathe, to think of the tickets waiting in his inbox, the countdown ticking away in his head. Two days. Two days to stop tripping and blustering over his feelings long enough to just *say something*.

Yet right now, with Mydei sitting there—glasses perched high on his nose, looking up at him with that sliver of curiosity mixed in with annoyance—Phainon can't remember what words are supposed to sound like.

"What?" Mydei finally says, breaking the silence between them. He's clearly irritated at being disturbed, which should make Phainon feel bad, but it doesn't. He's just happy he gets to see Mydei like this—dressed down in nothing but a loose t-shirt and boxer shorts.

"Nothing," Phainon replies hastily, and then chuckles nervously as he glides over to the fridge to open it. He stares into the shelves and the food, eyes ghosting over the tubs of leftovers and the carton of milk that's going to go off soon, and finds himself spending far too long looking inside, considering he's not hungry or thirsty.

"What on earth are you doing? You'll let all the cold air out!" Mydei snaps at him.

Phainon startles and slams the fridge door shut. "Sorry."

"Something's wrong," Mydei accuses, turning around in his chair so he's facing Phainon fully.

"Nothing's wrong!"

"You're a shit liar, Phainon."

"Rude, I'm not *that* bad…"

"So you admit that you're lying?" Mydei asks, eyebrow raising.

"I did no such thing!" Phainon retorts, scoffing.

Mydei rolls his eyes and pushes his glasses up his nose. "Either tell me what's going on or go away. I'm trying to concentrate."

Phainon rests his hip against the counter and folds his arms over his chest, trying to appear as nonchalant as he can. It doesn't help the stirring in his chest nor the nerves that wrap around his ribcage like vines. "Do you want to—" *go on a date with me* almost spills out, but he chokes on his own spit instead and ends up practically hacking up a lung with how startled he is.

Mydei watches him for a few moments before he gets up and rushes over, patting (read: smacking) him on the back to help him catch his breath. *So much for nonchalant, huh?* He thinks.

"What the hell is wrong with you?!" Mydei exclaims when Phainon finally calms down, his choking simmering down into small huffs of breath that occasionally hitch. His throat feels tight and sore, and his chest is faring any better.

Phainon's eyes are watery, and his lungs are constricting like he's just run a marathon, so he blurts out: "Go see a film with me."

"Are you fucking serious? That was it?" Mydei asks incredulously.

"Is that a yes or a no?" Phainon replies pitifully.

"It's a *yes*, you dolt. Obviously, I'll go see a film with you. What one is it?"

"Um," Phainon stands up straight again, his back aching from where he was hunched over for so long coughing. He winces slightly, embarrassment colouring his cheeks. "City of Warriors."

Mydei's face changes then—just moments ago, it had been pinched and confused from the choking debacle, but now it softens, opens. His lips part slightly, his eyes go wide, and for a second, it's as if all the light in the room has gathered there, glinting in those amber eyes. "You got tickets for it?" He breathes, voice somewhere between disbelief and delight.

Phainon blinks, momentarily forgetting how to function again. He hadn't expected *this* kind of reaction—not the sudden brightness, not the way Mydei's whole face comes alive with it. He knew Mydei liked the film, sure. It was his favourite, of course. But this—this is different. This is pure, unguarded joy. And *damn*, is it beautiful. He's never quite seen him like this before—except maybe when they pass a stray cat on their walks and Mydei crouches down, voice soft and coaxing, eyes full of quiet wonder as he's

always bestowed the chance to pet the cats. There's something so disarming about it, this childlike spark that slips past all of Phainon's defences.

He can feel his chest tightening, warmth blooming where nervousness used to sit. For a fleeting moment, he forgets about how he just humiliated himself over asking Mydei out (although he *technically* didn't state that it was a date…), but at least Mydei had said *yes*. Seeing Mydei this happy makes all his earlier turmoil and fumbling totally worth it.

Maybe he underestimated how much the film means to him. Or maybe, he just underestimated how much *he* loves seeing Mydei light up like this. That's why he booked the tickets, right? To see Mydei hopefully smile at him, regard him warmly and with fondness that he can see from a mile away.

"Yep, I bought them the other day."

"When? What time?" Mydei asks in a rush.

"Saturday at 10 PM. I know it's late, but…" He shrugs.

"Don't care," Mydei replies. There's a small smile playing at the corner of his lips. "I thought something was seriously wrong then. You almost scared me."

Phainon laughs, each *ha ha ha* coming out stiff. "I just… I dunno, I was thinking of something else."

"Oh?" And there it is again—that pinched look, almost sour.

"Doesn't matter," Phainon says quickly. "Anyway, I'll see you then?"

"You'll see me before that, silly," Mydei chides softly, flicking Phainon gently in the forehead. Then, he leans in, pressing a kiss right over the spot he just hit. "Thanks."

"F-for what?" Phainon stutters, reaching a hand up to block off his forehead in shock.

"For getting me tickets."

"I got *us* tickets, I'm coming with!"

"I know. But why? You hate City of Warriors."

"I don't *hate* it…" Phainon bites down on the inside of his cheek. Now, *that* is a lie. He thinks it's the most boring thing on the planet—just a bunch of sweaty, grimy men in sparse military outfits running around declaring war

on different nations with some haphazard romance plot chucked in mid-way through. Phainon's sure it's only so they can meet their 'hot female lead' quota in what would be a sausage fest of a film. But *Mydei* likes it, and he always gets teary-eyed at the end when the main character loses his best friend to an arrow through the heart because he didn't have armour on that time. So, it's not all bad, he supposes. It's quite cute, in fact.

"Liar," Mydei says quietly and then presses another kiss over Phainon's hand, which is still on his forehead. It tickles, making tingles go up his spine and down his arms. He shivers a little. "Are you cold?"

"No," Phainon answers. "It's ticklish when you kiss me there."

"Really?" And even behind his glasses, Mydei's eyes are alight with mischief.

"Don't even think about it—"

Mydei cuts him off before he can say anything more, leaning in to press another kiss to Phainon's hand—right over his knuckles this time. The touch is soft, delicate. It sends a flicker of warmth up Phainon's arm, settling somewhere deep in his chest where it begins to glow. Then, Mydei's lips wander lower, brushing over the arch of his brows, then down across his lashes. The sensation is so light, so impossibly careful, that Phainon doesn't dare to breathe. Each kiss feels like it could shatter him at any moment if he decided to move too quickly—like the fragile beat of a butterfly's wings against his skin that'd decided to trust him.

By the time Mydei reaches his cheekbones, Phainon's pulse is a drumbeat in his ears. Mydei pauses there, close enough that his breath fans against Phainon's face, warm and trembling. Then he presses a smattering of feather-light kisses along the curve of his cheeks, each one slower, surer, until Phainon's whole body feels caught between wanting to melt into the touch and wanting to move closer.

It's almost unbearable. It's so gentle, so delicate, so sweet and kind that it twists everything up inside of him, his heart straining against his ribs. Every breath catching, awe and longing, words right on the tip of his tongue that he wants to speak into existence, but even now, being disarmed like this, he still can't risk it.

"*Go on a date with me*." He wants to say. "*Let me kiss you and let me mean it properly.*" He wants to say. "*I love you*." He wants to say.

Instead, a giggle escapes him at the ticklish sensation, and then it's all over. He's laughing, wriggling around from being pinned by Mydei against the lip of the counter top. It digs in uncomfortably into his back, but he doesn't mind, too caught up with *Mydei Mydei Mydei* to really care. Phainon moves his hand from his forehead and grabs Mydei by the waist, digging his fingers in and scratching over the thin t-shirt he has on. That makes Mydei yelp, his body angling sideways to get away from him, but now it's *payback* time.

The room fills with laughter and half-formed protests, their words lost in the chaos of a full-blown *tickle war*. Mydei tries to dodge away and take a step back, but Phainon is quicker; he catches him around the waist, pulling him back just as Mydei squirms and twists in his arms. They're both laughing so hard it's difficult to breathe, their movements clumsy and

desperate as they paw at each other. Phainon's face aches with his smile, his chest feeling concave with how little air he's breathing in. He loves being like this with Mydei; he adores it, where there are no barriers between them and nothing stopping them from laughing until their sides ache and they're lightheaded.

Mydei's laugh is deep and rich—full-bodied, the kind that warms his chest from the inside out. It reminds Phainon of slow mornings and coffee that tastes a little too good to rush. There's something so *alive* in it, something effortless and unguarded. His face glows with it, his glasses knocked askew, eyes crinkled, and mouth curved in pure, unrestrained joy.

And gods, is it beautiful.

Phainon can't remember the last time he'd seen Mydei like this, so unselfconsciously happy. The sight hits him in an almost physical way—like his heart has stumbled over itself, thudding unevenly in his chest, beating away like a drum. For a breathless moment, he forgets to laugh along. He just stares, caught in that light, grateful beyond words that he's allowed this close to witness this version of Mydei that the rest of the world doesn't get to see.

He doesn't even notice how the tide has turned until the laughter from Mydei fades away too, and begins to narrow down to the sound of their breathing. Somehow, in all the movement and chaos, they've shifted; Mydei's back pressed against the counter top, and Phainon's hands braced either side of him.

The realisation washes through him, slow and electric. Mydei's still smiling, though softer now, his eyes glistening from unshed happy tears that have gathered at the corners. His eyes meet Phainon's, flickering up to catch his gaze. In there, Phainon can only assume he's seeing a mirror of himself, because all he can see is *want*. His pulse stutters, and every inch of him is suddenly aware of the space between them—or rather, how little of it is between them. The air feels heavy, sodden and damp, like each breath is pure moisture with the way his mouth waters and his throat clicks with a swallow.

He should step back. He knows he should. But the warmth of Mydei's laugh still lingers between the atoms of the air he breathes, still wrapped around his ribs like vines, enticing him to come closer, to lean in and see what happens. It's like a spell has been cast upon them—deafeningly quiet, yet no less potent. Phainon wants to stay here—close enough to feel that laughter tremble through Mydei's chest, close enough to imagine what it might feel like if he leaned in just a little more.

But he doesn't have to imagine. That's the whole point of this *thing* between them, the thing that burns and toils and rumbles through him like thunder. He places his hands on Mydei's waist, this time firmly to not evoke another ticklish reaction from him, and he leans in. Phainon captures Mydei's mouth quickly, not giving him any time to think or to breathe or to chase him away. With his grip, he slowly slides his hands up and over Mydei's waist, taking in the contours of his body beneath the clothing. It's intoxicating, the way Mydei arches up into him as his hands land on his ass, fingers grabbing and kneading until they're at the tops of his thighs. His fingers spread like a bird's wings, clutching at Mydei until he has a good enough grip to pick him up and plonk him on the counter top.

Mydei reacts immediately, a cut off moan echoing throughout the kitchen as he wraps his legs around Phainon's waist, pulling him in closer until his

pelvis bumps against the edge.

"I need to get back to work…" Mydei says, trailing off as Phainon kisses a line down his neck, fingers now splayed on the tops of his thighs, his fingertips toying with the hem of his boxer shorts.

"Yeah?" Phainon asks breathlessly, licking and nipping delicately to not leave any marks. Even though he wants to—he'd love to leave Mydei a rumpled mess of *red*, from his blush to the hickeys scattered all over his body. Love marks, everywhere, anywhere, all to show that Mydei is *his*, all his. He wants people to see them, wants to allow their gazes to linger on the marks that couldn't be hidden, all left wondering what type of person did that to Mydei.

Him, he would want to say proudly. *It was me*.

Phainon licks a stripe up Mydei's neck until he reaches his jawline, where he presses another open-mouthed kiss there. He's breathing hard, practically panting, their breaths in sync with each other as his heart pounds.

"You—*mmh*, are distracting me!" Mydei chastises, however, his voice is as flimsy as a piece of tissue paper in water.

"Tell me to stop and I will."

Mydei exhales softly, then reaches up to catch Phainon by the back of his hair. His fingers slip through the strands, firm but unhurried, tugging just enough to pull Phainon away from his jaw. The sudden space between them feels sharp, like a gaping maw has opened up and he's standing on the precipice of it.

Phainon blinks, dazed—half-lidded, breath shallow. He feels drunk on the nearness of him, on the faint warmth of Mydei's freshly showered skin and the ghost of citrus still clinging to it. His lips tingle where they'd just pressed against him, and the ache of wanting hums low in his abdomen.

But Mydei doesn't move. He doesn't pull him back in like Phainon wishes he would, and he doesn't push him away either like Phainon wishes he wouldn't. He just looks at him—steady, searching. The light catches on his glasses, obscuring his eyes for a moment, and when it fades, Phainon finds himself caught in their focus. Mydei's gaze drifts over his face with quiet precision, like he's trying to map every contour, every flicker of expression. It feels like being seen and studied all at once, and Phainon isn't sure which is more dizzying.

"I wish I could," Mydei murmurs, and Phainon barely catches it. He wants to ask for more information, like what did he mean by that? But Mydei is leaning in again, lips on lips, descending upon him like a sunset.

The day of the 'date'—or *not-date*, depending on how charitable the universe is feeling—arrives far faster than Phainon is ready for. He's spent

the entire morning convincing himself it isn't a big deal, that it's just two friends going to the cinema. Nothing more. Nothing less.

But the moment he opens his wardrobe, that fragile lie falls apart completely in his hands, shattering like glass.

He has no idea what to wear. *None*. Every shirt suddenly feels wrong as he tries them on—too casual, too stiff, too obviously *trying*. He cycles through combinations until his room looks like a battlefield: drawers pulled open, clothes strewn across the floor, the bed, the chair that long ago stopped being a chair and became a laundry monument.

He stares at the mess, eyes wide as he runs a hand through his dishevelled hair. "It's fine," He mutters to himself. "Just a film. Just Mydei."

Except it isn't just anything, and he knows it. His stomach's been a tight knot all morning, the kind that comes with waiting for something you both dread and absolutely want. It's making him feel even more restless than usual, picking up pieces of clothing to look at them again before dropping them almost immediately.

A knock at his door makes him jump so violently that he nearly trips over a heap of jeans. His heart stutters, breath catching in his throat as he tries to upright himself. He's *way* too aware of the possibility of who that might be.

Phainon hesitates for a second, then cracks the door open just enough to peek through. "Yeah?" He manages, voice coming out a little higher than

he'd like.

Of course, standing in front of him is Mydei, who looks less than impressed even from the tiny sliver he can see through the door. "You're being noisy. What's wrong?"

"Oh, uh, nothing…"

"HKS, you're lying. *Again*."

"No, I'm not! I just, uh, need to clean—"

"Let me in." Mydei demands, and at the same time starts pushing against the door.

"No!" Phainon wails, pushing back. They engage in a back-and-forth of pushing either side of the door until Mydei finally wins, Phainon's bare feet slipping on his carpet. "You totally cheated," Phainon grumbles.

"I did no such thing," Mydei says, waltzing into Phainon's room like he owns it. He stops abruptly, his feet catching on the pile of jeans that almost ended Phainon's life. "What… the hell happened in here?"

"I… uh…" Phainon stutters.

"Did you lose something?" Mydei asks, turning to face him with a shocked expression plastered on his face.

"No," Phainon replies, scratching the back of his head. He suddenly feels nervous, letting the boy he likes into his messy room. He's *shy*. "I don't know what to wear tonight." He admits.

"It's nine in the morning?"

"So?" Phainon counters.

"…The showing isn't until ten at *night*. You have eleven hours to get ready. Why are you rushing?"

Phainon crosses his arms over his chest and sticks his chin in the air, faking bravado as he says: "Hmph, can't I be excited to hang out with you? We barely do anything outside of the flat together, so…"

Mydei looks at him and sighs, reaching out to ruffle his hair. "Well, first of all, you're not going in *that*." He says, gesturing to Phainon's bright blue boxers with slices of cheese pizza printed all over them.

Phainon flushes up to his ears. "Obviously! I've been told off enough by Aglaea to have a semblance of fashion sense now."

"Right," Mydei says, but he sounds highly sceptical.

"Shut up, not all of us can look like runway models."

"You do know you're extremely handsome, right?" Mydei says nonchalantly.

"What?" Phainon bursts out, blushing again, this time even harder.

Mydei looks unaffected, like he's talking about the weather and not complimenting Phainon on his looks. He almost looks bored, glancing around the room. "Wear a pair of jeans. And that nice turtleneck sweater that I bought you. The cashmere one. Then wear your blue jacket, which is —" He pauses to look around again. "—Somewhere around here… you know the one. Then your white trainers. There, easy."

"I'm not a doll to dress up," Phainon grouses, but he dutifully goes around his room picking up the clothing that Mydei had listed out. It's pretty hard to find some of the pieces, considering they're buried under mounds of other clothing, but he eventually picks out every item until they're all in his arms. "Are you going to tell me what socks to wear, too?" He asks sarcastically.

"Your thick white ones. They should still be in your top left drawer. Also, roll up the cuffs of your jeans. It looks good that way."

"I don't know why I bothered asking," Phainon mutters under his breath.

"Because my opinion is always right."

"Be quiet!"

"Whatever, you're the one getting ready *now*. If I didn't help, you'd still be here hours later, fretting. Or you'd wear your banana print shirt… *again*."

"Hey, what's wrong with that one? It's abstract!"

"It's about as ugly as those stupid boxers you have on."

"*Then take them off yourself*." Is what Phainon wants to say, but he doesn't dare. After the other night of kissing while Mydei needed to finish his homework, he'd gotten an earful about never doing that again to distract him. Mydei still handed it in on time, so Phainon doesn't see the big deal about it, but he'd been fascinated by how red Mydei's neck was the entire time that he was barely listening anyway.

Instead, he scoffs. "I think they're cute."

"Your idea of 'cuteness' isn't to be trusted."

"But I think *you're* cute," Phainon shoots back, not caring if it exposes his true feelings too much. Surely calling your best friend in the entire world 'cute' isn't all that bad, right?

Mydei stares at him, completely deadpan. "Exactly. You can't be trusted."

"Hey! That was a compliment, the right answer to that is to say *thank you, you're cute too*."

"Thank you," Mydei replies completely flatly, ignoring the latter half of the sentence. "Now get dressed and clean this shit up." He finishes, pointing around the room like a nagging parent.

"Rude! I'm super cute!" Phainon yells as Mydei walks away, leaving him alone in his room, surrounded by mess.

The day slips by faster than Phainon expects, losing himself in studying and eating whatever Mydei puts in front of him at lunch time. Every hour folds

into the next until, at exactly 9:15 pm, there's a knock at his door. This is it. Whatever happens next—whatever *this* turns out to be—he's ready for it.

Phainon takes one last glance in the mirror, smoothing down his jumper and forcing a slow, steadying breath. Confidence—fragile, but real—flickers to life inside of him, so before he can second-guess himself, he grabs the handle and opens the door.

And then everything stops.

Because standing there is Mydei, not just any *normal* type of Mydei, but one with slicked back hair. It's neat and deliberate, a clear show that he'd studied himself in the mirror for who knows how long before deeming himself presentable. Even his braid is immaculate, swishing slightly as he shifts from one foot to another. The sight steals every word Phainon can possibly think of, and all that nervous energy he's held inside all day finally simmers to a close.

Mydei's wearing a black shirt, the first few buttons undone to show off his clavicle and red tattoos, and a pair of matching black slacks. He looks… "*Incredible*," Phainon breathes out. Then he snaps out of it, blinking and shaking his head as he comes back to himself.

"You look great!" Phainon says cheerfully, trying not to let his voice tremor.

Saying Mydei looks 'great' feels like an understatement. He looks *incredible* —effortlessly composed, every detail perfected. It's almost unfair how good

he looks, how natural elegance seems to come to him in the way the terrible hallway lighting casts shadows across his features, only emphasising his strong nose and pouty lips. Phainon's seen him in every state imaginable—half-asleep, alert, sweaty and turned on, even covered in flour from late night baking experiments—but this is different. This is *breathtaking*.

His pulse stumbles. Mydei isn't just handsome, no, that word doesn't do him justice: he's stunning in a way that makes it hard to think straight. The kind of beautiful that could turn a simple night out into something more, something that feels significant. Like this could actually mean *more* than just a casual outing with a friend.

And gods, does Phainon want that. He can't help but wonder if Mydei's excitement matches his own. Because no one dresses like this for a simple trip to the cinema, right? The crisp line of his shirt, the faint cologne that lingers in the air between them, the careful neatness of his braid—it all feels too intentional, too intimate.

For a dizzy moment, Phainon lets himself imagine that this isn't a '*not-date*' at all. That maybe, just maybe, Mydei dressed up because he wanted it to feel like a real one too.

Or maybe he just really, *really* loves City of Warriors and is treating it like some kind of red carpet event.

Mydei's lips lift into a small smile, and he looks down at the floor, which then, as Phainon follows his gaze, he realises Mydei is wearing *dress shoes*, not his usual trainers. He's even got a watch on, one that glows gold and

black. His strong forearms are on show too, his sleeves rolled up to his elbows to give a more casual, laid-back vibe that is sorely missing from the entire ensemble.

Phainon has to swallow when he realises he's *this* close to drooling quite literally over his best friend. Just to be safe, he wipes his hand across his mouth, relieved when it comes back dry.

"You look good, too," Mydei says softly, looking back up at him. "Glad to see you took my advice." He finishes, stepping into Phainon's space suddenly. Phainon's eyes widen as hands come up to his chest, but they don't go any further as Mydei smooths over some wrinkles in his jacket.

Phainon breathes in, and the world narrows to the scent of Mydei's familiar cologne—sweet, musky, warm with that quiet spice that clings to his skin. It's dizzying. It's addictive. It seeps into his lungs like a thick fog he can't see past until it feels like he's breathing in *Mydei* instead of air. He wants to sink into it completely, to melt into him, to dissolve in the heat and weight and gravity of his presence.

He wants the space between them *erased*—wants to close it, crush it, *consume* it—until there isn't even an inch left separating one heartbeat from the other. It's a dangerous thought, greedy and unrelenting and so unlike Phainon's daily thoughts that it throws him off. Because Mydei is brilliant. Blinding. The kind of beauty that shouldn't exist without a plethora of guards protecting it. Every line of him, every measured breath, every flutter of his eyelashes as he blinks makes something dark and twisted inside of him want to worship Mydei.

Phainon's chest tightens. The thought of others seeing this—of anyone else catching even a fragment of this version of Mydei, dressed and shining for *him*—fills him with a sharp, jealous kind of panic. He knows it's selfish. Possessive, even. Bordering on madness, completely. But he can't help it. He wants to keep Mydei—the one who smells of citrus and cologne and warmth—all to himself. Phainon wants to take this moment away somewhere safe, somewhere hidden, where no one else can touch it.

Where no one else can touch it but *him*.

"C'mon, we'll be late if we don't catch the bus now," Mydei says, stepping away from Phainon as quickly as he came, taking all his thoughts with him.

Breathing a sigh of relief, Phainon trails after Mydei to the front door.

The bus ride to the cinema is short—barely twenty minutes—but to Phainon, it feels like the longest twenty minutes of his life. The quiet hum of the engine fills the spaces between them, the low rumble beneath their feet mixing with the soft rhythm of the city passing by outside the window. He can feel the warmth of Mydei beside him, close enough that their shoulders brush whenever the bus jolts. Each accidental touch sends a spark through him that he tries (and fails) to ignore.

He's irritated to realise, with a kind of petty vindication, that his earlier thoughts were absolutely correct—people *are* staring. A group of girls

nearby, probably seventeen years old at most, keep sneaking glances in Mydei's direction. They giggle behind their hands every time he moves or speaks, like the very concept of him is forbidden.

Phainon feels his jaw tighten. Of course they'd notice him. Who wouldn't, when he's sat there so prettily, smelling amazing and looking even more amazing. Still, it doesn't stop the faint spark of jealousy that flares in his chest. He crosses his arms over his chest and puffs out his cheeks in quiet protest, trying not to look as sulky as he feels.

The rational part of him knows there's no point being annoyed—short of staying at home, there was no avoiding this. And there's no way he'd have cancelled their 'not-date' over a few stares. Mydei's voice, him beside him, the simple fact they're here together—it's all worth it.

Besides, the girls will leave eventually. And when the night's over, Phainon's the one going home with Mydei. So, technically, he's already won the war.

"Why are you sulking, hm?" Mydei asks, poking him in the cheek, causing it to deflate.

"I'm not," Phainon replies, clearly doing so.

"If I have to call you out on a lie *again*…" Mydei threatens.

"You look so good that everyone's staring," Phainon says quietly, leaning into Mydei to whisper it against his ear. Mydei flinches back, eyes wide in shock.

"They're looking at *you*," Mydei says, eyeing up Phainon.

"No way! They're looking at you!" Phainon retorts, harrumphing.

"So? Let them," Mydei replies. He hums, wrapping his arm around Phainon and pulling him in for a one-sided hug. "Who cares what they think?"

Phainon's mind goes blissfully quiet. He snuggles into Mydei's side, totally taking advantage of the situation, but he can't find anything in himself to care. But when the girls turn around to look again, shock painting their features as they take in their position, Phainon can't help but smirk at them victoriously.

The cinema is practically empty when they arrive. He's not surprised, considering the showing is so late, and it makes Phainon have hope that they'll have the entire screening to themselves.

"The popcorn is *ridiculous* here," Mydei grumbles, eyeing the concession prices with a narrowed look. "Six thousand credits for a large bucket? No chance."

Phainon raises an eyebrow, already reaching for his wallet. "Alright, moneybags, simmer down. It's not the cinema if you don't have popcorn. Ooh, they have salty and sweet!"

"It's daylight robbery."

"It's not even daytime," Phainon retorts, sticking his tongue out at Mydei before going up to the counter to place an order. Mydei follows him, looming behind him. "Plus, it's tradition."

"You can fund the tradition yourself," Mydei says, peering over Phainon's shoulder.

"I'll have one large sweet and salty popcorn and two large sodas, please," Phainon says, smiling at the cashier.

A hand places itself on his waist, making him jump. He turns around to face Mydei, who isn't looking at him but at the cashier.

"Sure thing!" The cashier says, getting to work immediately on fulfilling Phainon's request.

Soon, he's got an armful of popcorn and a drink, having already pawned off the second one to Mydei, who takes it without much fanfare other than a 'thank you'. As they walk towards their screen, Mydei reaches over without a single word and grabs a handful of popcorn anyway. Phainon hides his grin behind his drink, savouring the small victory—and the even smaller thrill of Mydei eating beside him, crunching away on the popcorn just like he knew he would. It's why he got a large size, after all.

To Phainon's joy, they are the only ones in the theatre when they get there.

"Where are our seats?" Mydei asks, looking around.

"Right at the back, to your left," Phainon replies, gesturing to the area with his hand.

Mydei nods and walks up in front of him, taking a few steps at a time until he's reached the back. "Why did you get seats so far away?"

"I like sitting at the back, it's the best view!" Phainon replies, sliding into his seat next to Mydei.

Mydei sighs but doesn't argue further. Instead, he shoves his hand into Phainon's box of popcorn and takes another handful. "Ugh, this stuff is awful."

"Then stop eating it," Phainon replies simply, getting an eye roll in response.

Before Phainon even realises it, they've demolished the entire box of popcorn. Mydei's hand dips into the tub one last time, coming up empty except for a few lonely kernels rattling at the bottom. He scowls, brushing the salt from his fingers.

Phainon snickers. "I knew I should've gotten another one. The adverts aren't even over yet."

Mydei grumbles something in reply—half-hearted and muffled beneath the booming sound of another over-dramatic trailer—but the fondness in his voice is unmistakable. Phainon's laughter fades into a quiet smile as he glances around the theatre. No one else has come in. No whispers, no footsteps, no rustling of jackets or crinkling of sweet wrappers. It's just them.

The realisation settles slowly, sweet and thrilling.

It's just the two of them. Alone.

Excitement bubbles up in his chest, bright and restless, a feeling that feels suspiciously close to joy. The low vibration of the speakers and the soft glow of the screen make everything feel cocooned and private—like the world outside doesn't exist for a little while.

Phainon leans back in his seat, stealing a quick glance at Mydei beside him. The light from the advert plays over his face, sharp one moment and then soft the next, painting him in shifting golds and blues. It feels unfair, how something as ordinary as this can feel so impossibly charged, even if it's just Phainon feeling it.

He swallows, forcing himself to look back at the screen. He tells himself to breathe, to stay calm. But his heart refuses to listen, beating away quickly in his chest without a care in the world. He sneaks another look at Mydei, who is already looking at him. Phainon jumps in his seat.

"What is it?" He asks.

"Nothing," Mydei replies, taking a long sip of his drink as his eyes trail over Phainon's body. Then, he says: "I really like your outfit."

"Because you chose it?" Phainon says, chuckling lightly.

"No, because you're wearing it. It looks good. Nice to see you out of joggers for once."

"T-thanks," Phainon stutters out. He gestures to Mydei, who still looks blindingly handsome even as shadows and lights play across him. "You look good, too."

Mydei smiles, no, it's more of a smirk. His lips curl and widen around his straw as his teeth worry at the tip of it. Phainon's eyes immediately drop down to watch, wishing he could lean in right now and steal them away from the straw.

"You already said that earlier."

Phainon sniffs, "So I can't say it again? You look very handsome. Dressing up for your warrior boys?" He jokes.

"No," Mydei says, taking another sip. "I dressed up for you. Couldn't let you outshine me, right?"

Phainon grumbles, knocking his knuckle into the base of Mydei's cup just to see panic flare across his face as the drink sloshes around dangerously inside. "You're so mean. Now watch the film, it's starting."

They settle back into their seats easily enough, eyes fixed on the screen as the opening credits roll. There's a roar of noise from the speakers as the actors all begin yelling over each other, cheering and shouting as their first victory is secured. For a while, Phainon tries to focus, he really does—but it's impossible to ignore the person beside him.

Out of the corner of his eye, he can see Mydei leaning back, sipping from his drink, lips pursed around the straw in a way that makes concentration a

losing battle. The faint, rhythmic sounds of him gulping seem louder than the film. It's maddening how something so small can pull at his attention like gravity pulling him down, not allowing him a moment to float in the air for a while.

The theatre is still empty, the silence between them stretching out comfortably as the film continues to play. Phainon is already lost; they're talking battle strategy now in a tent, fingers pointing at maps as they discuss tactics. And look, Phainon hadn't booked the back row with *ulterior motives*—at least, that's what he tells himself—but now, with the soft glow of the screen washing over them and no one else around… Well. It's hard not to think about what it means to be *alone* here, together.

He knows the rules. He has them memorised. But they've already broken so many without issue, so maybe…

Phainon starts off small. Mydei's hand rests casually on the armrest between them, so he lets his own drift over—just enough to brush against it, a small, accidental nudge. Mydei doesn't react at first; he simply shifts, placing his drink into the cup holder to his right.

Phainon swallows, licking his dry lips for some moisture. Then, emboldened by the lack of resistance, he moves again—this time slower, more deliberate. He slips his hand beneath Mydei's, their fingers aligning, fitting together as if they were always meant to. *That* gets a reaction.

Mydei stills, the tension sharp and immediate. His breath catches—a small, startled sound swallowed by the booming yells from the film. For a

heartbeat, Phainon thinks he's gone too far. But then Mydei's fingers curl back, just slightly, holding him in return.

"What are you doing?" Mydei asks, practically hissing at him despite their mutually joined hands.

Phainon grins at him and dares to do more: he rests his head on Mydei's shoulder, inhaling his cologne and natural scent. "Watching the film," Phainon whispers back.

He can feel Mydei's glare, but he decides to ignore it. He hasn't been shoved off, and their hands are still together, even more so than before as Mydei clamps his fingers down around Phainon's. Just to be extra annoying, Phainon snuggles into Mydei's shoulder, making sure that his hair tickles his face. He hears a grumble, but nothing more. Phainon smiles to himself, his stomach feeling as though he'd drunk litres of soda, bubbles popping and shimmering with joy at their position. It really feels like they're on a *date,* all curled up together as they watch a film on the big screen.

As time goes on, though, Mydei doesn't seem to settle. He's completely rigid and not a very comfortable pillow if Phainon is being honest. Worry starts to bubble up in his stomach, replacing the joy, and his leg jiggles up and down nervously as he begins to rethink their position. Maybe he has pushed too much, and Mydei is just humouring him to not disturb the rules of the cinema. Not like he could get up shouting and cursing like the men on screen, after all. With a small sigh and smile dimming, he sits up straight and goes to drag his hand away from Mydei's. Yet before he can, Mydei clings to his hand, not letting it go even as Phainon tries to shake it off.

"What are you doing?" Mydei asks again quietly, but this time his face is creased in what Phainon assumes is confusion.

"I thought you were uncomfortable," Phainon admits, stopping his struggling and letting their joined hands fall back down to the armrest again.

"I'm not," Mydei replies. "I just want you to be quiet so I can hear what they're saying."

"I wasn't even talking!"

"Your thoughts are extremely loud," Mydei says nonsensically.

"My thoughts are very quiet, thank you very much," Phainon replies sulkily, lips pouting as Mydei rolls his eyes and focuses on the film again, leaving Phainon alone to his 'loud thoughts'.

He knows he should've gotten more snacks. At least then he'd have something to do except from sitting here and non-stop thinking rubbish like: *oh my gods, we're holding hands. His hand is so soft, does he use moisturiser? I can't even feel the callouses from rugby anymore*.

His attention and thoughts drift again, and he finds himself watching Mydei once again. He looks different now, more subdued, comfortable, more…

less, as little sense as that makes. But it's true—even dressed to the nines in his black shirt and trousers, his hair loose and slicked back, he seems so comfortable in himself that he might as well be at home in his loose t-shirt and a tiny pair of shorts.

Phainon knows he's thought it a thousand times already, but Mydei really is beautiful—even more so as the shadows and lights casting from the screen dance across his features, brightening them and throwing them into darkness all at once. He's a film himself, a set of moving pictures that evoke a response in Phainon's heart that he can't just shift and get rid of. He's a film Phainon could watch forever, from the beginning credits til the ending ones, Phainon will dutifully sit and watch no matter what. He's so desperate to not miss a thing that he doesn't even want to blink, even as his eyes sting and well up with tears to compensate, just in case he misses something and the film of 'Mydei' ends.

So Phainon savours as much as he can, not caring that he's being so brazen, not caring that he's missing whatever's actually going on the screen right now, not caring that Mydei is now looking at him with a confused scowl. *Gorgeous*, Phainon thinks, all to himself. He gobbles it up, eating as much as he can see of Mydei up in his head and swallowing it down to keep for later. He never said he wasn't greedy, because he *is*. Horribly, irrevocably, entirely *greedy* for the man before him.

He wants to kiss him so badly he feels his chest ache.

"Quit looking at me like that," Mydei mutters.

"Like what?" Phainon throws back, a little too loud.

Mydei bites his bottom lip, and Phainon's eyes immediately zero in on the action. He finds himself mimicking it without really thinking, chewing on his lip, wishing that it was Mydei's instead. Phainon wonders what he'd taste like today—whether it'd be saccharine, as usual? Or maybe slightly salty from the popcorn he stole. Maybe, even, lemony as the sherbet sweets he's probably got stashed in his trouser pockets, hidden away so Phainon can't steal one for himself?

"Remember rule number one."

Phainon gasps dramatically. "Are you suggesting that I want to kiss you in *public*, my dear Mydeimos?"

"Don't play stupid. I know that dumb look on your face."

"Oh yeah?" Phainon challenges. "What do I look like?"

Mydei holds his gaze before dropping it, his eyes landing on Phainon's lips. "Like you want to kiss me right now."

Phainon gulps, "Would you let me, if I did want to?"

"No," Mydei replies back quickly. Then he sighs. "Yes, no, maybe. I don't know."

"We don't have to," Phainon reaches out with his free hand to cup Mydei's cheek, relishing in the softness beneath his palm as Mydei leans into it like a cat, his eyelashes fluttering sweetly.

"I want to," Mydei admits, so quiet that the film on screen almost swallows it up completely.

"You do?" Phainon breathes out, and suddenly their faces are close, closer than before, their noses brushing and foreheads knocking gently against one another.

"Yes." Mydei answers, and it's all it takes for Phainon to close the distance between them, pressing his lips against Mydei's.

Mydei's grip tightens around his hand—hard enough to almost hurt—but Phainon doesn't pull away. He doesn't dare to. He doesn't *want* to. If anything, the pressure grounds him, keeps him tethered while everything else feels like it's spinning out of control.

Their kiss is clumsy at first, as if all their practise has gone out the window. There's too much urgency, not enough breath, just a smashing of lips and a wildness behind them both. Their lips move together until the rhythm finally settles, until their heads tilt just right and the whole world falls away in shattering pieces. Every press of Mydei's mouth against his feels like a

spark caught between them, something impossibly vibrant and bright that Phainon's eyes squeeze shut in fear that it might blind him.

Phainon can't think. He can only *feel*—the heat of it, the sweetness as he licks into Mydei's mouth, the way Mydei opens up so easily for him, like he was waiting for this moment too. Phainon feels *wanted*. It's a dizzying rush, one that makes his cock twitch in his jeans, one that makes his delicate hold on Mydei's face turn feral, his nails sinking inwards only a fraction as to still them both in time. Something vast has bloomed in his chest, a whole new cosmos, spinning wildly where his heart should be.

They're in public. They're kissing—in *public*. They shouldn't be doing this, no matter how alone they are right now. Someone could still walk in, even though it's been almost an entire hour since the film started. He knows that, and the thought flickers like a candle in the wind at the back of his mind, faint and useless. Because right now, none of it matters—the empty theatre, the *rules*, the risk. The only thing that exists is this: Mydei's hand in his, the taste of his breath and the feeling of courage racing through his veins.

Phainon doesn't stop kissing him. He can't. Mydei tastes sweet *and* salty, exactly like the popcorn. It's delicious, and he can't get enough, especially when Mydei starts making those breathy little sounds that turn him on immediately. Heat begins to pool in his gut, low and boiling and dangerous, and he really wishes they were at home, maybe in bed or on the sofa, so Phainon could lay Mydei down. He wants to be horizontal with him, over him and under him, all over him, hands in his hair and on the nape of his neck and passing down over his shoulders to reach his tiny waist. He wants so much, *so much*, that it takes his breath away even more as they kiss and kiss and kiss, lips swollen and sore and his heart about to beat out of his ribcage.

When Mydei pulls away, it's as though Phainon's heart follows him, out through his mouth and splattering into a puddle on the floor. He wants more already, needs to keep kissing him until his lips hurt and his lungs ache. He needs—

He stops. He looks at Mydei. He looks…

Mydei looks… *wrong*. All jagged and broken, his face scrunched up into something that Phainon can't quite pinpoint. Disgust? Uncertainty? Distaste? He's not sure, and he's also not sure if he wants to know either. But he can't help but ask:

"What's wrong?" Phainon asks tentatively.

Mydei swallows, and then their hands are pulled apart, and Phainon's hand is left cold and clammy. "We shouldn't have done that."

"Mydei?" Phainon asks faintly, the name on his lips feeling like a plea.

"We—" Mydei gets up suddenly, and he's storming down the steps of the cinema, taking a few at a time.

"Wait! Mydei!" Phainon yells, not giving a shit anymore about keeping quiet. He doesn't care if the clerk above them streaming the film hears him,

or sees him frantically chasing after Mydei down the stairs. He also takes a few at a time, trying so desperately to catch up.

Once they're out of the theatre, Mydei seems to slow down, but then he speeds up again. Phainon keeps going after him, frantic and panicked, not knowing what to do except to keep running.

"Mydei! Slow down!"

Then, they're outside, the cold air hitting Phainon in the face like a ton of bricks. He's cold, shivering, suddenly too warm and too freezing at the same time as his teeth chatter, and he's still trying to catch up to Mydei, who's way ahead of him again. It's like a storm has broken out, a tornado of emotions and feelings twisting up inside of him.

Mydei only stops once they reach the bus stop.

It's stupid, there are no buses for ages this late at night. Phainon jogs up behind him, panting and wheezing as his heart feels like it's going to give out at any second.

"Mydei— what—"

"We shouldn't have done that," Mydei repeats.

"I'm sorry," Phainon says. "Mydei, I'm sorry. I shouldn't've—"

"It wasn't your fault! It was— it was *mine*."

"Why are we blaming ourselves over something like this? It's— it's fine, right? We're fine?"

Mydei nods sharply.

Phainon breathes out a sigh of relief. "Let's get a cab home, okay?" His voice is gentle, coaxing, trying to sound normal even though his pulse is still all over the place. He reaches out, slow and careful, meaning only to rest a reassuring hand on Mydei's shoulder.

But Mydei steps out of reach.

Oh. Phainon thinks, the simple action hitting him like a punch to the gut. The air leaves his lungs with it, and for a moment, he just stands there, his hand half-raised, stupidly frozen between them. Mydei won't meet his eyes, instead looking at the ground. His shoulders are drawn tight, his jaw set, and Phainon can see the tremor in his hand as he runs one over his braid, a nervous tic he's never quite managed to hide.

Guilt floods Phainon's chest, thick and heavy. He wants to say something—to apologise, to explain, to take it all back if it would stop that look on Mydei's face—but the words tangle in his throat.

"Mydei," He starts softly, but the other only shakes his head.

"It was—" Mydei cuts himself off, shakily exhaling. "We shouldn't have… not there. Not like that." His voice is raw, quiet but sharp around the edges, each word cutting like little knives into Phainon's skin.

Phainon swallows hard, forcing a smile on his face that doesn't reach his eyes. "Yeah. Yeah, you're right." He laughs under his breath, brittle and small. Because it's true, Mydei *is* right; however, it's still hard to fully grasp. "Guess I got too caught up in it."

A beat passes. The sound of the city echoes around them—the distant whoosh of cars, the low murmur of people spilling out of late-night shops. The world moves on, uncaring, while Phainon feels like his has just cracked down the middle.

He doesn't feel so wanted anymore.

But he wants to reach out again, to bridge that tiny, impossible gap between them. To tell Mydei it meant something—that for him, it wasn't just the heat of the moment, it was *everything*. He wants to explain that he wanted this to be their first proper date, that he got all dressed up for Mydei and no one

else. That he went through all the planning, the painstaking deliberation to muster up the courage to just *ask*, all for him.

Yet Mydei is still holding himself so tightly, and he doesn't dare push. So instead he exhales, long and silent, and nods towards the street. "Come on," He says, barely above a whisper. "Let's get home. It's cold out," Phainon shrugs off his jacket and hands it over to Mydei, who takes it without a word and puts it on over his shirt.

Phainon shivers despite still wearing a thick cashmere jumper, but it's not the cold air that's affecting him. It's the coldness from Mydei that is. He grabs his phone and dials a local taxi place, explaining to them where they are and nodding along when the guy says that they'll be there in ten minutes.

"Ten minutes," Phainon reiterates.

Mydei just nods.

The ride home is silent.

Phainon kicks off his shoes the moment they get in, and Mydei carefully puts Phainon's jacket up on the peg to the side. The silence is *deafening*, so much so that it's almost painful. They head into the kitchen, side-by-side, their shoulders knocking as Mydei immediately heads to the kettle to put it on.

The silence… the quiet…

"Mydei," Phainon says, and Mydei turns around to look at him. He looks exhausted, eyes worn, and lips curled down into a frown. "I need to tell you something."

"What is it?" Mydei asks, and he sounds as tired as he looks.

"I wanted today to be a date," Phainon admits, his hands shaking as he clasps them together in front of him, just to try and keep them steady. "I wanted… today to be special. That's why I was so scared to ask you out."

"A date…?" Mydei repeats, as though he's not understanding. He shakes his head, "We're not dating, though."

"I want to be," Phainon says in a rush. His heart is beating wildly, his palms clammy, and he can't quite pick a spot to keep looking at, his eyes all over the place as Mydei stays in the centre of his field of vision. "I want to date you."

Mydei looks at him, shocked, eyes wide and mouth open. There's a flush on his ears, on his cheeks and dusting over the bridge of his nose. Hope fills Phainon, then, irreversible and stupid.

"Those rules we put in place? I've practically broken all of them," Phainon swallows past the lump in his throat. "Rule one, rule three, and five."

Mydei blinks at him, head shaking to and fro as he processes. "Five?"

"When it stops feeling like practise," Phainon steps forward. "And we… *I.*.. develop feelings."

"You think you have feelings for me?"

"I *know* I have feelings for you!" Phainon says, putting one hand over his chest. He can feel his heart beating rapidly. "I know I'm in love with you."

"You're confused," Mydei says flippantly, and all the hope Phainon was feeling recedes like the ocean tide withdrawing.

"I'm not! Don't tell me how to feel when I've been in love with you since the first time we ever met!"

"You're just— you're—"

Phainon cuts off his stuttering. "What, Mydei?" He takes another step forward and grabs Mydei's hands, gathering them up like a lifeline. He tries to catch Mydei's gaze, tries to lock their eyes together and to make him physically *see* and not just hear how sincere he is. "I've loved you for a long time," His voice breaks. "Please, Mydei— Mydeimos, please, I don't know how else to say it to make you believe me."

"Do you not feel anything for me? Is that it?"

"No!" Mydei shouts, then his eyebrows furrow, and he's biting his stupid bottom lip again, and even more stupidly, Phainon wants to kiss him again.

"No…?"

"No, I— yes, yes… I feel… things for you, but I just…"

"Just what?"

"I need… space. I think we need time apart."

The whole world tilts on its axis then. "What do you mean?" Phainon asks faintly. He feels like he's going to pass out.

"I meant what I said. We need space. Then— then you'll see that you don't know what's going on, and then we can go back to the way things were."

"What? Before we started kissing? Before I felt you on top of me, before I saw you cum because of *me*?"

"You're so—!" Mydei sounds frustrated, his blush deepening.

"That all meant nothing to you? All our kisses, all the time we spend together, all the things we do for each other. *Nothing*?"

"That's not what I'm saying!" Mydei yells. He yanks his hands away from Phainon's. "This whole kissing thing was a bad idea. It's gotten us all confused and— and I don't want our friendship to be ruined because we got too carried away."

"It won't— it hasn't— ruined our friendship! I just… I'll admit, I want more, Mydeimos. I always want more. But it's not anything you have to give to me, it's just things that I wanna do for you. Do *to* you. I wanna, I dunno, be able to hold your hand in public and call you *mine* and be your stupid fucking boyfriend, yeah? That's not ruining our friendship. We'll still be *friends*, just with more."

Mydei looks at him, and there's nothing there. Nothing in his expression to show delight, happiness or joy at his confession. He just looks… sad.

"I got it all wrong, didn't I?" Phainon asks, putting his hands over his face.

"That's not what I'm saying," Mydei replies.

"Then what *are* you saying? I'm so confused right now, I don't understand what's going on. I thought we were fine, *better* than fine, I thought—"

"You thought wrong."

"Right." Phainon says. His heart feels like steel. "Fine." He storms past Mydei, knocking their shoulders together roughly as he heads straight for his room.

His room is still somewhat of a mess with all the clothes everywhere, but he knows vaguely where everything he wants to grab is. He yanks his duffel bag out of his wardrobe and shoves whatever clothes he can fit into it, not caring if they make any sense or if they're just random odds and ends he can find. He tears into his drawers, filling the rest of the space with underwear and socks. Underwear and socks that *Mydei* folded for him.

How could he be so dumb, so silly, so caught up in his own little world that he didn't notice how Mydei was feeling the entire time?

"What are you doing?" Mydei asks from his doorway.

"Why don't you use those assuming skills you've suddenly developed and take a wild guess?"

"Phainon—"

"No," Phainon zips up his bag and hitches it over his shoulder. "You don't get to dictate everything, Mydei. You won't accept my feelings, fine. Just say that. But I know you're lying to yourself, too. I can tell. But I'm not going to *force* you, so you can deal with your shit and come back to me when you're ready."

"Phainon— Wait, wait—"

Phainon barges past him again, ramming his feet into his shoes and not even bothering to get the backs of them over his heels. He grabs his jacket, folding it over his arm to put on when he's fucking *out of here*. He doesn't want to stay in this place for a moment longer.

"Where are you going?!"

"Away from you!" Phainon shouts, spinning around to face Mydei. He looks *wild*, hair in disarray and eyes so impossibly wide as his mouth opens and shuts, at a loss for words. He looks panicked, scared and shocked all rolled into one.

"Phainon, *please*, just wait, I—"

"I'm going to Cas's." Phainon cuts him off again. He opens the door, not before grabbing his set of keys from the side counter and shoving them in his jeans pocket.

"Why?"

"Why?!" Phainon hates—*hates*—that he's yelling at Mydei, but he can't help it. Not as tears well up in his eyes, blurring his vision and leaving hot trails behind on his cheeks as they seep downwards. "Because the man I love doesn't love me back, okay? That's why."

He ignores the rest of Mydei's pleas and slams the door shut behind him. He can barely see through his tears, searing and hot as they continuously fill his vision, but what he can't get past is seeing the devastated face of Mydei alongside it.

Chapter End Notes

i'm sorry. HAHAHAHAHAHAA

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leave a comment and/or kudos if you enjoyed! thank you so much!!! each comment truly makes my day and motivates me to write more

-

let's be friends on twitter/x!!

Chapter 7: chapter seven

Chapter Summary

"Gods, I'm so stupid."

"No, you're not," Castorice says. "You're human, and you love him. That's not being stupid."

"Feels like it," Phainon sighs, dropping his hands back onto the table. "I don't know what I'm supposed to do. Do I just move on? Can we go back to the way things used to be? I don't— I don't think I can pretend not to be in love with him anymore, Cas."

Chapter Notes

:(the finale is here... waaaahh cries sobs whimpers... i wanted to make sure i didn't leave everyone hanging again for months on end (especially after the cliffhanger last chapter lol...) so i really knuckled down and churned this beast out in FOUR DAYS. i was in a crazed state of mind i tell ya lol

thank you again for everyone who stuck with me throughout this incredible journey of writing this! i sincerely appreciate you all and i've re-read everyone's comments a million times atp - they've made me laugh, cry, blush, the works...!! they mean the world to me honestly

special thank you to X by close your eyes for hyping me up enough to get through not one, but TWO smut scenes that are in this.
EVERYONE GO STREAM RN

and i can excitedly report that this chapter has been EDITED! AND NOT BY ME! tysm to the lovely nina for doing an amazing job of editing this monstrosity lol

enjoy (´▽`ʃ♡ƪ)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The walk to Castorice's feels endless, hours long rather than the actual measly fifteen minutes that it actually takes to get there. Every step drags, heavy and clumsy, like he's wading through something thicker than rain. And the rain currently drenching him really doesn't help. It comes down in sheets, cold and merciless, soaking him to the bone until he can't tell where the water ends and his tears begin. They slide down his face together, indistinguishable, just more proof that the universe has some sort of cruel sense of irony.

He almost laughs at the thought—how ridiculous he must look right now. A drenched, miserable mess, wandering through the streets like the lead in some cheap rom-com's third-act heartbreak montage. Except this isn't a shitty film he'd watch with Mydei, snuggled up on the sofa, but his actual *life*, real and true. There's no melancholic music swelling, no cinematic lighting to make his pain look poetic. Just the rain, the cold, and the dull ache in his chest.

And the worst part? There wasn't even a breakup. There never could be. You can't break what was never whole to begin with—and he supposes that's true for him and Mydei now, so close and yet so far from what he truly wanted. He really had gotten it incredibly wrong, something he never thought would happen has happened and now he has to deal with it. So, he walks alone—soaked, shivering, and silently wishing the world would just *stop* for a moment so he could catch his breath.

The thoughts make his heart hurt even more, and as he knocks on Castorice's door, he finds himself sniffling and trying not to bawl his eyes out again. It only takes a few moments before Castorice is answering the door, pulling it open with a confused look on her face until recognition clears it.

"Phainon? What are you doing here? It's so late…"

"Cas— I—" Phainon stutters, bottom lip trembling as his hair begins to plaster itself to his forehead from the rain still pouring down.

"Oh my, never mind that, come on in!" Castorice says, grabbing Phainon by his hand and guiding him inside.

His face scrunches up almost immediately, trying to hold it together, but the effort is useless. The tears come hot and fast, cutting through the rain still clinging to his skin. His breath catches in his throat, and all at once the sound that escapes him isn't really a cry—it's a broken thing, torn out from somewhere deep. Castorice's hands are on his cheeks immediately, wiping away the tears as they come. Her face is creased in worry, eyebrows furrowed and lips pursed as she clearly wants to ask or say something, but she keeps it to herself.

Phainon can't take it anymore. Overwhelmed by his best friend's care, he doubles over, not caring how dramatic it may seem, and Castorice exclaims in shock. Her hands immediately drop from his face and come up to rest on his shoulders, ever so delicate but ever so warm, steadying him.

"Hey, Phainon, hey— look at me. What happened?" Castorice coaxes gently, her voice soft and panicked at the same time.

He doesn't know how to answer. Not yet, not right now. The words won't form. His throat is tight, his chest hurts, and his mind is a blur of Mydei's face—his voice, his eyes, the way he looked when everything fell apart.

"I messed up," Phainon chokes out finally, shuddering with the words. He barely speaks above a whisper. "I thought— I thought he… I thought Mydei…" He can't even finish the sentence. The sobs tear through him again, harder this time, but he stands up straight to look Castorice in the face.

Castorice doesn't say anything after that. She pulls him in, arms wrapping around his shoulders as she stands on her tip-toes to reach him. She holds him close despite how soaked he is, and even as her clothes darken with dampness, she doesn't seem to care. Castorice just rubs slow, careful circles on his back, murmuring phrases and soft sounds that are meant to keep him anchored.

It works, at least for the moment. Phainon buries his face into her shoulder, breath shaky, the smell of rain and salt and despair thick in the air. His heart feels split open, raw and aching, but at least here, right now, he doesn't have to hide it. He clutches at her, fingernails scraping over her shoulder blades as he scrabbles to try and gather her into his arms even harder. She's in a nightgown, clearly having just woken up, and he feels so bad that she's here comforting him like this when she should be sleeping. *He* should be sleeping too, not crying all over one of his best friends.

"I'm sorry," Phainon slurs out, his tongue heavy in his mouth. "You were asleep. I—"

"I wasn't," She assures. "I was watching TV and then I heard you knocking. It's fine, it's okay, don't worry, alright?"

He nods into her shoulder.

"It's okay," Castorice says again in a soft whisper, voice steady and sure even though she doesn't even know what happened. "Whatever went down, you'll be okay. You both will."

Phainon breathes out a laugh, more a huff of air than anything, but it's a laugh nonetheless. He shrugs in her hold, but he wants to believe her. Gods, does he want to. But all he can do is shake his head, the words tumbling out between his shivering: "It doesn't feel like it."

And then he just cries again—loud, messy, unguarded. The sound fills the entryway, echoing against the floorboards and walls, until all that's left as he calms down is the quiet patter of rain on the window and the low hum of Castorice's voice telling him, again and again, that it's all okay.

After a while, once the tears stop and he's worn out, he withdraws from her hold. It's cold, so cold, and he shivers, teeth chattering from adrenaline and the temperature.

"Oh, Phainon… Let's get you into something warm, okay? You can go shower and I'll put your pyjamas on the radiator for a bit."

Phainon nods simply and trails along behind Castorice, making sure the front door is firmly shut and locked before doing so. She leads them further into her house, hand in hand, and guides him to her bathroom. She flicks on the light and gently pushes him towards the shower cubicle.

"I'll get you some spare towels, just wait here," Castorice says as she scurries off, leaving Phainon alone.

He feels it all at once—the weight of being alone. It's heavy, suffocating, pressing down on his chest until he can barely breathe. He fears he might start hyperventilating at this rate, so he closes his eyes and breathes in through his nose deeply, counting a few seconds before letting it out slowly through his mouth. It helps, at least a tiny bit, and his heart rate returns back to normal in a few measured breaths.

He's always hated it—the silence. It crawls into the cracks of his thoughts and fills them with every awful thing he tries not to remember. Every nightmare, every fear, every moment that he's been left behind.

Phainon hates it. He despises it. He wishes he could claw his way out of it by sheer willpower alone.

Castorice means well, of course she does. He knows that. She's opened her door to him, offered him comfort and safety, and he's grateful for it, he really is. But this isn't how things were supposed to be. He shouldn't even *be* here. He should be at home—with *him*.

It's all his fault. If he hadn't kissed Mydei—if he'd just kept it together, hadn't given in to that selfish desire of his that's always nagging at him for *more*—they wouldn't be here. Mydei wouldn't have looked at him like that, like he'd just broken something sacred between them by his words alone.

They should've been on their way back home by now, full of soda and popcorn, half-arguing over the film. Mydei would've been denying crying at the ending—again—and Phainon would've been teasing him over it. Maybe they'd stop for food on the way, maybe laugh about the silly parts of the film like the terrible CGI lions they brought out during a pit fight. *That's* how the night should've gone.

Instead, there's this. The quiet. The echo of raised voices still in his ears, the ghost of what they'd said—what *he'd* said—clinging to him like smoke. The silence feels like a punishment, and the emptiness of being alone again gnaws at him in ways he can't stand to name. Phainon rubs his face with both hands, but it doesn't help. The loneliness doesn't fade. It never truly does, it's only masked when he's with other people, but Mydei—*his* Mydei, his dearest Mydei—is the only one where it truly goes away. However, this time, the feeling just settles deeper, like a shadow that knows its way around his ribs too well, invasive and heavy.

"Here you go!" Castorice chirps, interrupting his thoughts as she dumps two towels into Phainon's arms. "Take as long as you need, okay? I'll be in the kitchen, and I'll make us a cup of tea. How does that sound?"

Phainon nods numbly, forcing a shaky smile on his face as Castorice's own brightens at it. He rifles through his duffel bag and pulls out a worn t-shirt and joggers and hands it over to her.

"I'll sort this out," Castorice says, patting him on the shoulder before she leaves, closing the door behind her.

Phainon sighs, his shoulders sagging under the weight of the cold and wet clothing he's in, and the pressure of being alone again. Before getting undressed, he turns the shower on in hopes it'll warm up quickly. The spray comes out hot and strong almost immediately, which he's grateful for.

He shrugs out of his jacket, pulling his sodden cashmere jumper over his head and listening to them *splat* on the floor as he drops them. He can't bring himself to care anymore, only focusing on one thing at a time. Phainon unbuttons the fly of his jeans and shimmies out of them, cringing as the thick material clings to his legs. He fishes his phone and keys out of his pocket and puts them on the side counter, not bothering to check for any messages. He doubts that Mydei's messaged him. Next, his socks, then last of all, his boxers, until he's standing there naked and shivering.

It doesn't take long for him to warm up under the hot spray, and as he scrubs himself down and washes his hair with Castorice's floral shampoo, he's reminded of the citrus scented stuff that Mydei uses instead. He sniffs sadly, eyes drooping and lips curling down as he washes the suds out of his hair.

Stupid, stupid Mydei and his stupid sweet citrus shower routine. Stupid, stupid Phainon for thinking about it when he's supposed to be trying to move on. Well, that's what he assumes he's supposed to be doing right now, at least. He can't stay in the past, dwelling on his unrequited feelings no matter how much he wants to roll around in self pity for a while. He imagines that as he washes off the bubbles, every piece of him connected to

Mydei is going down the drain, spiralling and spinning out of control then disappearing.

It doesn't work, but it lifts his shoulders a little as the metaphorical weight of everything begins to shift. It's not *all* his fault, is it? Mydei was there as well, confusing him and making half-hearted comments that made no sense. Does he truly not feel anything for Phainon, was it all his wishful thinking the entire time? Or is what Mydei was saying—or at least, *trying* to say—was that he did have feelings, but just didn't want to be his boyfriend?

Phainon grumbles, scrubbing his nails into his scalp in the hopes that'll help iron things out. It doesn't, all it does it make his skin throb and sore. He sighs again, the sound getting lost in the steam, and decides it's time to get out.

He finds Castorice exactly where she said she'd be, in the kitchen, sitting at the dining table and sipping away at her cup of tea. She perks up when she sees him, her eyes sleepy and mouth pulled into a small smile as she greets him.

"Hey, Cas," Phainon replies, only clad in a towel wrapped high around his waist. He's fully dry, except for his hair which is still slightly damp. "Are my pyjamas all warmed up now?"

"They should be," Castorice replies, getting up and walking over to the radiator in the adjoining living room. She pats over them delicately, smiling, and then hands them over to Phainon. He takes them gratefully, giving her a quiet 'thank you' in response before going back into the bathroom to get changed.

He emerges again, fully clothed and nice and warm, hair mostly dry as he ruffled it again with one of the towels he was given. He doesn't care if it's sticking up in odd angles, it's not like Castorice is going to care, and it's not like Mydei is here to impress, either.

"Here, your tea. It should be cool enough now to drink," Castorice says, handing him over a small mug with flowers all over it. It's cute.

He takes a sip, eyelashes fluttering as the hot liquid runs down his throat, warming him up from the inside out. It's such a relief, and he takes a seat next to Castorice at the dining table. They sit in silence for a bit, but it's not a bad silence. It's clear that she's waiting for him to be ready to talk, but he's still not sure if he is. What would he even say? That they got into a fight over something that could've been avoided?

Phainon sighs, rubbing at his eyes with his fists as exhaustion sets in. "Is it okay if I stay here for a bit?" He asks.

"Of course it is!" Castorice replies. "Stay as long as you need, okay? I don't have a spare room, but my sofa is plenty big enough for your giant frame." She chuckles.

"I'm not *that* big!" Phainon opens his mouth to say more, to say that Mydei is bigger than he is, but he stops. Instead, he says: "Thanks, Cas. I really appreciate it." And for the first time, a real smile appears on his face.

She waves him off, taking a sip of her tea. "Do you want to talk about it?"

Phainon doesn't answer straight away. He hums, looking down at his drink and swirls it around a few times in the mug just to watch it move. Then he sighs and nods, shoulders slumping forward. "I confessed my feelings to Mydei—"

Castorice squeals, but then at Phainon's withering look, she mimics zipping up her lips and throwing away the key.

He huffs, the corner of his mouth twitching for half a second before he loses it again. "I confessed. It didn't go well. He didn't say he *didn't* love me back, but he also didn't say he *did,* either." His voice wavers, quieting on the last word. "He just said he wanted some space. Because apparently, I'm 'confused'." He lifts his fingers for the air quotes, shaking his head in dismay at repeating it all.

It all feels distant now—like it happened to someone else. The memory is blurred around the edges, smudged like ink dragged across wet paper. He remembers flashes, the sound of his own voice cracking mid-sentence, the way Mydei's expression had gone tight and unreadable, along with the space that'd never been there between them opening up and refusing to close again.

"I thought maybe if I said it…" Phainon begins. "If I got it all out there, it would stop eating at me. That I could fix things. But now it's worse, and I—I keep thinking about what he didn't say. How he just stood there and let me leave." He takes a shaky sip of his drink, the hot liquid now going down his throat like sludge. "I took him out to see City of Warriors, and I wanted it so badly to be a date. I told him that and he just said that we weren't dating and then he looked all confused and—"

"*Breathe*," Castorice reminds him, and he stops to take a gulping breath of air. "So you took him on a date, then what happened?"

"We… um…" He flushes bright red. "We kissed in the cinema…"

"Mhm," Castorice hums, but she looks like she's about to vibrate out of her skin.

Phainon sets his mug down and covers his face with his hands, feeling how warm his cheeks are. Even now, even after everything, the memory of kissing Mydei, feeling him whine and moan against his lips, still does something funny to his heart. "Gods, I'm so stupid."

"No, you're not," Castorice says. "You're human, and you love him. That's not being stupid."

"Feels like it," Phainon sighs, dropping his hands back onto the table. "I don't know what I'm supposed to do. Do I just move on? Can we go back to

the way things used to be? I don't— I don't think I can pretend not to be in love with him anymore, Cas."

A sniffle comes from his right, and he whips his head around in shock to witness Castorice beginning to cry. "I'm sorry," She says, wiping her tears before they can fall fully. "I just… I adore you both so much, and it hurts that you're both hurting. I wish I could fix this for you, but I don't know what to do either."

"Cas…" Phainon trails off, reaching over to grab her hand. He squeezes it affectionately, "I'm sure it'll be okay. It's me and Mydei, right? We always sort things out." He says, but he doesn't believe himself. "I guess we really did need space from each other. I know I won't change my mind about how I feel about him, but maybe he will. Then we go from there."

Castorice nods, giving him a watery laugh in return. "Mydeimos loves you, too. He just has a funny way of showing it right now. It's so obvious that he's always felt the same way, we all noticed immediately. So don't give up hope, okay?!"

"Okay!" Phainon replies, smiling the best he can. Her pep talks always seem to help, even if he still feels a little unsure around the edges. "I don't know how long I'll be here for, but I'll try and not make myself a nuisance."

"Don't be silly," Castorice says. "You're never a nuisance. You're welcome to stay for as long as your back will allow you to sleep on my sofa."

"Hah! I'll be fine, no need to worry about that," Phainon replies. He stands up, downing the rest of his lukewarm tea. He wipes his mouth with the back of his hand. "I think it's time for bed."

"I'm so glad you said that," Castorice says, chuckling lightly as she places their empty mugs into the sink. Before he can say about washing them up for her, she says: "I'll do them later. I'll go sort out your pillows and quilt for the night."

As she does that, Phainon fishes his phone out of his pocket. He stares at the blank screen for a bit before gaining the courage to tap on it, waking it up. He blinks in shock as there's a litany of notifications waiting for him.

Mydei

Missed Call [35]

Mydei

Text messages [4]

"What the hell…" Phainon gasps, swiping away the missed call notifications in favour of clicking on the texts.

Mydei [11:45 pm]

Phainon.

Please come home.

I'm sorry.

I don't want space from you.

Phainon swallows down the lump in his throat. His hands tremble as he stares at the screen, the soft blue light painting his face in a glow that feels far too gentle for how violently his heart is pounding. The words blur for a second before he blinks them back into focus.

Please come home.

Home. The word hits him harder than he expects. For a moment, he can't breathe again, his heart beating wildly in his chest while not bringing in enough oxygen to compensate. Phainon reads the messages again and again —each one cutting through the fog that's been smothering him since he left. *I'm sorry. I don't want space from you*. The words he'd stopped letting himself hope for. And now they're here, sitting on his phone, fragile and impossible, waiting for him to believe them.

"Phainon?" Castorice's voice breaks through the silence. She's watching him carefully, a pillow and duvet gathered in her arms. She looks absolutely tiny in comparison to it, and Phainon wants to laugh but can't bring himself to when he looks back down again at his phone. "What is it?"

All he can do is turn the phone toward her, staring down at the floor as he does so.

Her expression softens immediately. "Oh dear," She whispers.

"Yeah," Phainon says, voice small and uneven. "He… he wants me to come home."

Castorice hesitates, clutching at the bedding a little tighter. "Do you want to?"

Phainon stares at the messages again, thoughts and heart still racing. Does he want to go home? Of course he does, but his pulse is so loud in his ears he can barely think straight. Part of him wants to run straight out the door, to go back, to see Mydei's face and believe that maybe this time it'll be okay. But another part—the bruised, trembling, louder part of him—remembers all too well how it felt to be pushed away. How it felt to be *alone*.

"I don't know," He answers honestly. "I don't know if I can handle whatever he has to say right now."

Castorice places the bedding down on the sofa and reaches over, resting a hand on his arm. "Then take a second. You don't need to decide right now."

Phainon nods, but his eyes stay locked on the messages, the glow of the screen reflecting in the sheen of unshed tears. He places his thumbs on the screen, ready to type, but he's not sure what he could say. What he *should*

say. Does Mydei even deserve a reply right now? Should he leave it for when he's not feeling so emotional? He's already said enough—probably too much—and he doesn't want to make the same mistake again if he can help it.

He sighs, blowing a piece of hair out of his eye afterwards. He'll leave it for tonight, he won't say anything, and—

His phone vibrates in his hand.

Mydei [01:24 am]

Goodnight.

Phainon bites down on his bottom lip so hard he fears he's torn the skin, but thankfully there's no blooming taste of iron in his mouth. Just the sad feeling, the sad beat of his heart and the thickness in his throat he can't get rid of as he rereads the message.

With shaky fingers, he types:

Phainon [01:25 am]

Night.

Because he can't help himself. He can't *not* say anything, after all, not when Mydei is offering himself up like this. It's still too little too late, but maybe it's not as over as he once thought it was. Maybe they *can* fix this and get back to normal. But right now, he just wants to sleep.

"Thanks for getting me everything," Phainon says, putting his phone on do not disturb as he places it face down on the coffee table.

"No worries at all," Castorice replies, placing the pillow at one end of the sofa and fluffing it up before she flattens out the duvet over the top of the cushions. "I really hope you'll be okay sleeping there tonight…"

"I will, don't worry. Get some rest, I'm sorry for keeping you up so late."

"Good thing it's a Sunday now, hm?" Castorice replies, smiling at him. She pats him on the back and waves at him, "Goodnight, Phainon. Sleep well."

He nods in reply, "Sleep well, too."

His vision is dark, darker than black. It swallows him up whole, leeching into his skin and pores and into his organs, choking him. He's terrified, not knowing which way is up or down, not knowing how to get out of here. He tries to move his leg, but there's something wrapped around it, yanking it back into position without any give.

"Help—" He says, but it comes out garbled and *wrong*, like his voice is coming from behind him rather than in front. "Someone help me!"

Again, again and again he tries to move, but to no avail. To no avail his voice carries, getting stuck within the mass he finds himself in. He struggles, tugging and pulling, screaming and shouting until his throat is hoarse, all until finally there's a light ripping through the dark abyss, lighting up his way.

"Phainon," A voice says. It sounds like *Mydei*. All rough and deep and haggard around the edges, but still his Mydei. "Phainon." It says again, and he reaches out, desperately clawing his way out the remnants of darkness until he's fully in the light again, panting and soaked with sweat.

He looks up and finds Mydei standing there, but it's not *his* Mydei. It's someone else's, that he knows for sure. He looks like he's just stepped out of City of Warriors, all clad in red and bronze armour, golden boots and gauntlets that shine in the sudden sunlight that's beaming down on them. He squints against it, and that's when he realises he's on the floor, sprawled out and looking up in wonder at this Mydei before him.

"You have to go," This Mydei says to him, voice firm as he crosses his arms over his chest, glaring down at him. There's not an ounce of familiarity in his eyes, no warmth and no kindness. No nothing, and this solidifies the fact that this *isn't* his Mydei at all.

Even when his Mydei was mad at him, he still held *something* in those amber eyes for him. Something tangible, something he could latch onto and burrow away deep with.

"I don't want you anymore. You have to go."

"Mydei?" He questions, trying to move again to at least stand up so he's on the same level as this Mydei. It doesn't work, and he's left wriggling around on the floor, pinned down by something invisible. "Mydei?!" He says again, this time more panic in his voice.

"You have to go," Mydei repeats, and then everything becomes blurry, distorted and horrifying.

The scene melts away like wax, slurring and shimmering. Nothing makes sense, not as Mydei disappears into a blur and he himself becomes nothing more than a speck in the atmosphere. It's him that's causing it to burn, the heat coming off his limbs as wavering flames explode in front of him. It's him, it's him, it's…

"Mydei—"

His throat is full of ash.

"Mydei?"

His head hurts.

"Mydei!" Phainon yells, shooting up from the sofa, heart pounding like a drum. "Fuck…" He drops his head between his shoulders, shuddering as the waves of his nightmare come over him like the tide, ebbing and flowing until he stops shaking.

Phainon's covered in sweat, his fringe plastered to his forehead just like it was last night from the rain. He feels disgusting, clammy and cold all over. He grabs his phone from the coffee table, blinking at the time saying it's already gone well past 10 am. Castorice should be awake, but where is she?

He stands up, making sure to fold the quilt over neatly. He's still not sure how long he's going to be here. Phainon wanders into the kitchen, blinking in shock as he's suddenly hit with the smell of breakfast cooking: bacon, sausages, and eggs all fry away as the toaster pings up with toast.

"Cas?"

"Oh!" Castorice exclaims, jumping in fright as she turns to face him. She's fully dressed now, out of her nightgown and in a frilly shirt tucked into a skirt. "You're awake! I thought I heard you moving around."

"You didn't hear me yelling?" He asks in confusion.

"Yell—? No… did you have a nightmare?" Castorice asks, face creasing in worry.

"No, it's nothing. Don't worry," Phainon waves her off, taking a seat at the dining table.

She looks at him sceptically but doesn't push, of which he's very grateful.

"I bought you a toothbrush while you were sleeping," Castorice says as she plates up their food, graciously placing it right in front of Phainon. It smells *delicious*, and he digs in straight away, his stomach gurgling.

"Oh, thanks!" He forgot a lot back at home. He tries not to think about it, the raw sting of *home*, where Mydei currently is, as it still hurts.

But he can't help but wonder if Mydei is eating alone right now. They usually have breakfast around this time on Sundays—just something small, as they're both too tired to cook too much after a week of classes. Toast, maybe eggs if Mydei is feeling up for it, and a cup of coffee so strong that it wakes them both straight up. Phainon can picture it so clearly that it aches: the soft rumble of the kettle boiling, the smell of toast, the faint sound of Mydei humming under his breath as he drifts through the kitchen, his strong back on show as Phainon watches from the dining table.

Phainon places a hand over his chest, as if it can soothe the sting there.

Maybe Mydei's sitting at the table right now, stirring his tea or coffee for too long because he's lost in thought. Maybe he's not eating at all. Maybe he's sad that Phainon isn't there, or maybe he's relieved. Maybe he's still in bed, sprawled across the sheets, hair messy and face pressed into the pillow.

That thought makes his throat tighten and his cheeks warm. The last time he'd been in Mydei's bed was when he last had a nightmare, and then they'd… Well. He doesn't want to dwell on it, not when Castorice is right next to him digging into her breakfast. He clears his throat and tries to think of something else, but his thoughts bring him straight back to Mydei.

It's strange—how quickly a home can feel hollow depending on the people inside of it. How routines built out of love and comfort can collapse overnight, leaving nothing but ghosts behind. The kitchen table, their matching mugs, even the damn fancy cereal that Mydei always buys him despite him saying not to—they all feel heavier in Phainon's mind now that he isn't there to share them.

He wonders if Mydei misses him. If he's glancing towards the empty chair without meaning to. Whether he's up thinking about how quiet the flat must be without Phainon's chatter filling it up. It's not like he doesn't want to go home, he aches for it, especially if it means that he can see Mydei like he was before everything went wrong. He just wants to pretend for a while that it's all okay, that Mydei is here next to him.

But instead, he's here—staring down at his breakfast, suddenly not very hungry anymore, and even as he takes a swig of tea that Castorice prepared for him, it doesn't taste right. It doesn't taste like their tea bags at home,

doesn't taste like their water. Phainon pictures Mydei doing the same thing across the city, wondering if they're both just… lost, orbiting around each other from a distance that neither of them know how to close.

"Do you not like it?" Castorice asks, her voice sounding small.

Phainon snaps out of it, turning to face his friend. "I was thinking of Mydei." He answers honestly.

She nods like she gets it, and perhaps she does. "You don't need to eat if you don't want to. But it might make you feel worse if you don't."

He nods, and takes a mouthful of toast with bacon on top. It does taste good, not ashen like in his dreams, but not as good as the smoked rich variety that Mydei cooks for him. However, none of that matters. What does matter is that he's still being taken care of wherever he is, even if it’s not with Mydei.

"I'll do the dishes," Phainon offers, not wanting to be a total leech while he's staying here. He's already intruded enough, and knowing he's going to stay here for longer makes him feel even worse.

"That's okay, we can do them together!" Castorice replies.

"Sure!" Phainon says, grinning at her.

They finish their breakfast in silence, the only sounds of them chewing and cutlery clicking against the plates. It's peaceful, and it helps settle the restlessness inside of him, even just a tiny bit.

With the dishes washed and stacked away, they collapse onto the sofa. The soft buzz from the TV fills the silence, muted to a little more than a whisper. Castorice shifts to face him, one knee tucked beneath her, eyes bright with concern and resolve.

"Alright," She says gently. "We need an action plan!"

"Can I at least brush my teeth first?" Phainon jokes, laughing when he gets a playful shove in response.

"Sure, go brush them. But when you're back, we're getting serious."

Phainon grabs the toothbrush Castorice got for him and rushes to the bathroom. He doesn't want to look at himself in the mirror as he goes through the motions of brushing his teeth, but it's hard not to when there's a giant one right opposite him. He glances up and catches his own reflection, squinting at it like he's staring at a stranger.

His hair is a mess—flattened in place, wild in others—and his eyes are red-rimmed and puffy. There's a faint salt stain on his cheek from where he assumes he was crying during his sleep. He feels a bubble of shame and embarrassment come up, knowing that Castorice had seen it and hadn't mentioned anything. All in all, he looks exhausted in every sense of the word. Hollow. Like someone who hasn't slept very well. Which, he realises, after his nightmare, might be true.

He swishes the toothpaste around his mouth and leans over the sink, trying to ignore the lump forming in his throat. So many times he and Mydei had brushed their teeth side by side, elbows knocking and grins stretched across their faces as they try to finish brushing their teeth before the other. They'd always end up either in a draw, or even odds, so it never really mattered in the end. Even though Mydei has his own bathroom, he'd still join him to brush his teeth and wash his face on the occasion. Right now, that's all Phainon can think of, and it almost sets him off crying again as he spits out the remnants of toothpaste lingering in his mouth.

He grabs a wad of toilet paper and wipes his mouth, throwing it in the bin afterwards. He goes back to staring at his reflection for a little bit. The man in the mirror doesn't look like someone who used to wake up to laughter and warmth, but instead one who dearly misses it.

And gods, does he already miss it. Phainon misses *Mydei*.

He's not sure how long it'll take for him to fully adapt to his new reality—or if he ever will.

It turns out, he can only go just under a week before Castorice breaks.

He's spent the past few days in a fugue state. The sofa has become his entire world—his bed, his refuge, his prison. He barely moves except to eat or stumble to the bathroom, the cushions practically moulding to the shape of his body. His back is starting to ache now, just like how Castorice warned him it would if he continued sleeping there, but whenever he thinks of leaving and going home he starts to feel like he's going to throw up. Maybe he's left it too long now and he'll never be able to go back, doomed to stay on Castorice's couch and take up space. It's supposed to feel safe here, this little corner of stillness, but it isn't. Not really.

Not when the nightmares are so bad. They come every time he closes his eyes. They're relentless, clawing through the edges of his sleep until he wakes up gasping. They're worse now—worse than they've been since his parents and sister passed away in a house fire. Back then, the dreams were about loss; now, they're about *him*. About Mydei.

Except it's never *his* Mydei in these dreams. It's someone else's—always someone else's—and they all look at him the same way: with pity, with distance, with the certainty that he'll never matter the way he wants to. That he'll never be enough. He wakes drenched in sweat each time, shivering and breathless, clutching at his quilt like it's the only thing keeping him tethered to this world. Most of his clothes are damp from it now, dark patches sprouting around the neck hem and underneath his arms. Even sometimes on his lower back. It's proof of how far he's slipped, he supposes. Castorice never mentions it when she collects them for washing—she just gives him that soft, careful look that makes his stomach twist.

She never says she's worried. She doesn't have to. He can feel it in the way she lingers by the sofa a little longer each day, as if she's afraid he might fade away entirely if she looks the other way.

It all comes to a head on Friday, six days after he fled.

"I let you off earlier this week, but now I'm serious. We need an action plan. You're *moping*," Castorice says, hands on her hips as she stands in front of Phainon who's sitting on the sofa, trying to watch TV. "You haven't shaved in a week, barely eaten, haven't slept, and you're constantly checking your phone. He isn't going to text you if you don't reply!"

Phainon sniffs and nods, "I know…"

Castorice sighs, letting her hands drop down to her sides. "Don't make me the villain, Phainon. I'm just trying to help."

He sits up straight at that, distraught at the thought of Castorice feeling like that. "I know you are! And I can't thank you enough for taking care of me —"

"I've been so busy with coursework I've barely seen you for the past week," She says gently, coming to sit next to him on the sofa. "And I'm sorry about that. Mydei's been asking after you at uni, did you know? He—"

"Really?" Phainon asks too quickly.

"*Yes*," She stresses, patting him on the head. "So, I have an idea."

"Oh yeah?" Phainon asks. "Time to kick me out?"

"Absolutely not," Castorice guffaws. "I have a friend on my course who's holding a house party tomorrow. You're invited."

"Huh?" Phainon says, "But I don't know them."

Castorice rolls her eyes, "That's the fun about house parties. It's only going to be a small gathering, but I explained that you're staying with me and she said you can come. It'll get you out of the house, and maybe you can have some fun."

"I'm not sure I'm in the mood…"

"Then *get* in the mood. You're coming, alright? I won't take no for an answer! I need someone to come with me and hide away in the corner, okay?" She says conspiratorially, giggling at the end. "I'm bringing a book with me, and we're all pretty chill on my course. So don't worry too much."

Phainon slowly begins to nod his head, the idea washing over him in pieces until he's made up his mind. "Okay," He says. "I'll come."

Castorice claps and cheers, leaning over to give him a quick hug. "I'm so glad! Alright, okay, you still have those nice clothes you came in before, so you can wear them again. I've already washed and folded them, so they're ready to go."

Phainon grimaces at the thought of wearing the clothes that Mydei picked out for him. But everything else he bought was… Well, not wearable to a party. He'd been living in cringey graphic tees and loose joggers for the past week. Even his boxers weren't safe, most of them being of the brightly coloured variety that Mydei always used to scoff at and make fun of whenever he folded them for him. Phainon harrumphs to himself at that thought, crossing his arms over his chest as he sulks at the idea of being made fun of by Mydei.

Stupid, stupid Mydei.

And yet stupid, stupid Phainon for *still* being hung up on him.

He thought that, given enough time, his feelings would dull at least a little —that they'd fade into something softer, something easier to carry. But they haven't. If anything, they've only grown wilder, more unruly, sprawling through his chest like an untamed vine. He can't get over Mydei, and he doesn't think he ever will. He doesn't *want* to get over Mydei. He loves loving him, adores him, even, and it's made him into the person he is today; no matter how depressed that said person is right now.

Every attempt to suppress his feelings just makes it worse. The ache resurfaces in new ways—at the sound of a laugh that almost sounds like his, at the sight of an empty mug on the counter, at the ghost of Mydei's washing detergent that still lingers on his clothes. He thought love was supposed to fade with distance, but his love seems to thrive on the absence, blooming in all the quiet spaces Mydei used to fill.

And he knows it's pathetic. He even misses that look on Mydei's face—the one where it crumpled up his features into devastation, lit his eyes up full of something between heartbreak and disbelief at his confession. That look, those words, the entire situation has carved itself into him, for better or for worse. He should hate remembering it, but instead, it only twists his heart and stomach into an aching sort of affection that won't let go.

"I miss Mydei," Phainon admits, sitting back into the sofa, allowing the cushions to comfort him.

"I know you do," Castorice replies, sighing. "Do you think it's time you go back home?"

Phainon doesn't know. "I probably should."

"I think that might be for the best," Castorice says, reaching over to squeeze his hand that's placed on his thigh. "Not that I haven't loved having you here—I have—but I think if you have any more time apart from him,you'll waste away completely!"

Phainon chuckles, "You're right. I miss him so bad, Cas. It's like a hole in my heart."

She smiles at him, but it's still one lined with worry. "Well, focus on the party for now. Then you can go home, how's about that? Let your hair down for a bit, maybe have a few drinks, chat to some new people, refresh yourself and then go back."

Phainon hums, "Good idea. Thanks, Cas. I don't know what I'd do without you…"

"You'd probably have to camp out with Cipher, and no one wants to do that," Castorice shudders, laughing.

"Or even worse…"

They both look at each other, eyes wide.

"Stay with Aglaea and Anaxa!" They say at the same time, bursting into laughter afterwards.

I'll be okay, Phainon thinks as he laughs so hard tears well up in his eyes. This time, they're happy ones. *Just one more day and then I'm coming*

home, Mydei.

The day of the party arrives quicker than he expected. The past week has passed like molasses, slow and syrupy, until it's finally here. Castorice seems excited, flitting about her house like a butterfly, never quite stopping in one place for too long.

The last time he saw her, she was agonising over which book to bring. Now, she's suddenly in the kitchen making them cups of coffee and some bagels, telling Phainon *you can't drink on an empty stomach later*! To which he snickers, but gratefully accepts the bagels being practically thrown at him.

"I have no idea what to wear!" Castorice exclaims, standing in front of Phainon who is back sitting on the sofa. He feels like he's watching a fashion show, what with the way Castorice keeps coming in and out of her room in different outfits each time.

"I love this outfit. You should go with this one," Phainon says, trying to help. But as everyone knows, he's not exactly the best person to ask about fashion sense…

"You've said that about *all* the outfits, Phainon!" Castorice snips, but she's frustrated more than mad.

"Are you trying to impress someone?" Phainon asks, raising an eyebrow.

"No," She says too quickly. Then, she sighs, hands folding together in front of her. "Cipher's going to be there…"

"*Ooh*," Phainon croons, an evil grin spreading across his face. "Everything you've tried on so far is great, truly. But what about if you wear that purple shirt with your white skirt? A bit of mix and match."

"I don't want to hear *you* talk about mix and match, but…" She ponders on it for a bit. "Although, you might just be making some sense with that combo. Let me go try it!" Castorice says, running off to her bedroom again.

Phainon laughs and grabs his phone for something to do while he waits. He immediately clicks on his messages, heading straight to Mydei's contact. It sits at the top like it always has, his most used contact.

He hesitates. For a long moment, he just stares at the screen and wonders what exactly he was going to do. Text Mydei like nothing had happened? Share what he's doing right now for a quick laugh? He's so used to either being around Mydei or texting him when they're not together it feels weird to wait. He can imagine him typing out *cas is giving me a fashion show lol. idk what i'm doing*. To Mydei to see what he says in response, but he'd probably say something along the lines of: *Why would she trust you with fashion choices?*

Phainon sighs and puts his phone down again, resisting the urge to scroll up back through their texts. It'll only make things worse when he's so close to going back home anyway.

Castorice trots back into the living room, decked out in the shirt and skirt that Phainon suggested. He beams at her, straightening up as he claps when she gives him a twirl. "You look great!"

"That's more like it," Castorice agrees, giving him a curtsy. "Now, come on, we need to get you ready now. We need to leave in an hour and you're still not dressed!"

Phainon rolls his eyes playfully and heaves himself up, laughing as he's shoved into the bathroom to get changed.

Once he's out, Castorice is waiting with a comb and some hairspray. "I'm going to style your hair."

He raises an eyebrow, "What's wrong with my hair now?"

"It's…" She tilts her head to the side. "Fine. But don't you want to *wow* instead?"

"I'm not *wow*ing anyone there," Phainon says, but he dutifully sits down at the dining table and lets Castorice begin brushing his hair through. "I'm

going as moral support, remember?"

"I remember," Castorice says lightly as she twists and tugs his hair into place. He's not entirely sure what she's doing with it, but it's fun all the same. She begins humming a light tune, and he lets his eyes close as she plays with his hair. It's relaxing, calming, and very nice.

"There! Done!" Castorice exclaims, taking a step back as she hands him a mirror. He grabs it and peers in, eyes widening.

"I look like…"

"A fashion model! Seriously, Phainon," She smacks his shoulder lightly. "You should go all out more often. You'd have people all over you."

He pouts, putting down the mirror as he turns in the chair to face her. "But I only want *one* person all over me."

Castorice flushes slightly but still laughs, smacking him again. "Alright, lover boy."

"It's true! I just… I just want Mydei," He admits, wilting slightly. "I hope when I go home we can sort this all out."

"I don't doubt it," Castorice replies, now giving his shoulder a comforting squeeze. "Right, we've messed around enough now. Time to get going!"

The party is already in full swing by the time they arrive on Saturday night. The living room vibrates with low music and laughter, the air thick with the mingled scent of perfume, snacks and something vaguely acidic like alcohol. Castorice threads her arm through Phainon's and drags him through the room into the kitchen, weaving in and out of people as they go. It's a lot more packed than Phainon thought it'd be, but it's not quite overwhelming just yet to his relief.

They get into the kitchen where all the drinks are, cluttering up the counter top space. There's so much there that Phainon doesn't even know where to start.

"Actually, no drinking for you tonight anymore," Castorice says as she hands him a can of soda.

"What? Why not?" Phainon asks, eyebrows furrowing.

"Just because," Castorice says vaguely, not finishing her sentence. Phainon sighs and doesn't argue, popping open the can to take a sip. He cringes, it's lukewarm.

Castorice helps herself to the drinks, mixing up what looks like a fruity cocktail, and even garnishes it with a slice of lemon on the side. "Hey, no fair!" Phainon exclaims, pointing at it.

"I told you, you're not drinking. I didn't say that I couldn't," Castorice replies, giggling as she takes a sip. "Oh, don't look so much like a kicked puppy. You'll be fine."

Phainon can't help but pout, taking another swig of his horrid drink as they enter back into the living room where everyone else is. He doesn't recognise many people—probably because their classes are in different buildings—but he does recognise Cipher, Aglaea and Anaxa who are all huddled around each other, clearly gossiping about something.

"There's your girl," Phainon says, nudging Castorice with his elbow. She bats him away, but she's blushing.

"Let's go over there," Castorice says, dragging Phainon over without hearing his reply. He would've said yes, anyway.

"Hey guys," Phainon says as they approach, waving. He hasn't seen them in a while, so it's nice to be reunited, even if he still feels rough around the edges because of what happened between him and Mydei.

"Here comes lover boy," Cipher leers, "Heard there's been some trouble in paradise?"

"Cas!" Phainon exclaims, looking at her in disbelief. "You told them?"

She covers her mouth, "Well, I…"

He sighs. "It's fine, don't worry. I suppose it would've gotten out anyway."

"Especially with the little crown prince looking as miserable as he has been at uni," Cipher says, using his rugby team's nickname.

Weirdly, hope flutters in his chest again at hearing that maybe, just maybe, Mydei's been suffering without him too. "Really?" He asks, unable to help himself.

"Don't sound too happy," Cipher says, rolling her eyes.

"Yes, well," Anaxa begins. "If you two could sort it out promptly, we'd all much appreciate it."

Phainon nods, "Sure, I—"

The front door opens then, and the room shifts instantly. Phainon freezes, eyes wide as his shoulders stiffen. It's strange, how even without looking, he knows exactly who's standing in the doorway. He blinks, his breath catching and it's as if the entire universe has paused for breath too. He feels it—like gravity reorientating around a singular point. Phainon whips his head around, glad that he's taller than everyone as he can look straight over their heads, and there…

In the doorway is Mydei.

Phainon gasps silently. He looks… Well, if he's honest, he looks *awful*. His hair's a mess, braid unravelling at the ends. The collar of his shirt is uneven, his sleeves pushed up in a careless way that used to drive Phainon insane. It still does, going by the thud of his heart. He looks tired—no, *wrecked*—dark shadows under his eyes like he hasn't slept properly in days. Maybe he hasn't, just like Phainon. But even through the exhaustion, even through the slump of his shoulders and the uneasy flicker of his gaze as he scours the room, he's still the most heartbreakingly beautiful person Phainon has ever seen.

Suddenly, their eyes meet across the room, and for a single, dizzying moment, everything else fades around him. The chatter dulls, the music blurs into static. Phainon's breath shudders somewhere between his ribs, his pulse hammering like he's been caught doing something forbidden. He should look away, but Mydei's face morphs right in front of him, going from something that looks haggard to something that looks hopeful.

Even looking miserable, Mydei is *luminous*. He lights up the doorway, still rooted there as their eyes connect, and it hits Phainon all over again—the raw, unrelenting truth that he still loves him so dearly. That no amount of

distance or self imposed space has changed that. If anything, the time apart has only sharpened the edges of his longing.

Someone calls Phainon's name, and the spell breaks. He looks away first, trying to find the source of who called him, but his mind's a blur and he's holding onto his can of soda so tightly that the tin crinkles inwards, sloshing some liquid above the lip of the can.

"Yeah?" Phainon answers vaguely, still unsure of who called him. He looks back towards the doorway, but Mydei is gone and the door is now firmly shut. The room starts moving again, but he can't shake the feeling that the ground beneath him has shifted—and all it took was one glance to turn his entire world upside down.

"Phainon? Are you alright?" Aglaea asks, and it's her that was saying his name before.

He shakes himself out of it, "I just saw Mydei."

"Well, duh, I invited him," Cipher says, her grin almost predatory as he looks at her.

"You—? Wait, Cas, did you know…?"

Castorice hums and brings her drink up to her mouth, almost downing the entire thing in one go.

Well, that's definitely a yes then, isn't it?

"I've been set up," Phainon says to no one in particular.

"Don't be so dramatic," Cipher says. "If anything, we're trying to *help*, although where that little prince of yours has ran off to, I'll never know."

"Why don't we play a game?" Castorice says suddenly, and all eyes are on her.

"What kind?" Anaxa asks.

"They're playing spin the bottle. Why don't we join?" Castorice asks, clutching at Phainon's jacket as she guides him over, gesturing for him to sit down on the sofa in between a bunch of random people he's never met.

"Hey, Cas, c'mon—"

"Have a little fun, Deliverer boy," Cipher says, wedging herself next to him as Castorice takes his other side. At least he's not sitting next to strangers

anymore, but now they're more like *traitors*.

"Don't call me that," Phainon mutters. He doesn't say why—but it's because only Mydei usually calls him that, and hearing it from someone else feels strange.

The game starts with a burst of laughter, one of the girls Phainon doesn't recognise lighting up at the group's newest arrivals.

"Let's go!" She cheers, grabbing the green beer bottle in the centre of the carpet and giving it a hard spin.

It whirls in a blur of glass and light, circling around so fast that Phainon has to look away before it makes him dizzy. More laughter fills the room as more people join in, all gathering around to watch the bottle go around and around. The sound is bright with anticipation, the cheers and laughing increasing in volume as the bottle begins to slow.

When he glances back, the chatter has quieted. Every pair of eyes seems to be fixed on him. The bottle has stopped—pointed directly his way.

Heat creeps up the back of his neck. Phainon cringes, waving his hands in a quick, awkward gesture. "I can't—"

"Sorry, everyone." A deep voice comes from behind him, calm and unmistakable. Before Phainon can turn, a firm hand catches on the back of his jacket, tugging him upright from the sofa. "The only person this guy is allowed to kiss is *me*."

For a moment, Phainon can't breathe. All the air leaves him in a *whoosh*. His entire body goes still, his pulse hammering hard. He twists slightly, eyes wide, and there he is—*Mydei*.

He looks a little wild, a little unsteady, but his gaze is fierce and unwavering, fixed entirely on Phainon. There's a possessiveness there that makes something molten hot begin to bubble low in his gut.

The room bursts into teasing whistles and laughter, but all of it feels distant and muted. Phainon can't hear anything but the rush of blood in his ears. Mydei lets go, but only for a second to latch back onto his sleeve, giving it a few quick tugs as he guides Phainon out and around the sofa, until they're face to face.

"Come on, we're leaving."

"Leaving?" Phainon asks incredulously.

Mydei looks down at the floor, and shockingly, he seems… *shy*. "Don't you want to go home?" He asks quietly.

Home.

"I do," Phainon replies quickly. He turns around to everyone and waves, "Seeya later!"

More cheers and whistles erupt from everyone, but he doesn't care as Mydei leads him out the door, hand in hand.

"Hey, Mydei, wait— wait!" Phainon yells as Mydei storms ahead, still dragging him along by his hand. The pull on his wrist is starting to hurt as he stumbles to catch up.

"What?" Mydei stops and turns around, and Phainon goes straight into him, bumping their chests together.

"Ouch," Phainon winces. "What's with the rush?"

"I want to go home," Mydei says.

"And we will," Phainon begins. He grabs Mydei's wrist and gently tugs at it to let go of his hand, but a look so pained comes across his face that Phainon stops. He sighs, instead readjusting their grip so their fingers are fully entwined. "Happy?"

Mydei stares at him for a moment before nodding sharply once.

"Baby," Phainon chastises, but it comes out too soft, almost like a pet name rather than an insult. Mydei flushes with it, and Phainon has to bite down on the inside of his cheek so as to not kiss the look right off his face.

"Would you have kissed someone else?" Mydei asks suddenly.

"No," Phainon replies just as quickly. "No way, no, that's— that's just for us. Even… even if you don't want me anymore, I wouldn't ever kiss someone else apart from you."

"I do want you," Mydei says, sounding utterly broken. "I want you so badly that it scares me."

Okay. Alright. They're going to talk about this now, aren't they?

Outside, the world feels hushed and suspended. The night is pitch black except for the pale spill of moonlight and the uneven glow of flickering streetlamps that cast long, trembling shadows across the pavement. The air carries that sharp, late-night chill, curling around Phainon's exposed ankles and nipping at the back of his neck where his hair isn't quite long enough to cover it. It smells faintly of rain and something metallic, and it feels like everything is holding its breath for their impending conversation. Heck, even Phainon is holding his breath at this point, trepidation leaking into his lungs.

He shivers, although not entirely from the cold. Mydei's standing right in front of him, the dim lighting catching in his eyes and turning them into shards of gold. His gaze is steady, unflinching, so intense that Phainon feels it like a physical touch. The distance between them is small—too small—and yet it feels like miles.

Phainon's heart beats unevenly in his chest, staccato, and he opens his mouth only to close it again straight after. The night hums around them, heavy with everything unsaid and yet to be said.

"Okay," Phainon begins. "Is that it?"

Mydei scrubs a hand through his already dishevelled hair. "I *want* you. I wanted to ruin our friendship and take everything you were willing to give me, even if that was nothing at all. But then when you confessed, I realised that what if it all goes wrong and I lose you all together? And then you just *left*—I know I said I needed space, but I didn't think… I didn't think you'd actually go."

"I had to," Phainon says. "I didn't want to, but I had to. I couldn't… be around you and pretend nothing had happened. You *hurt* me, Mydei. Really badly."

"I know!" Mydei yells suddenly, and he looks torn up from the inside out, his face all crumpled and eyes dewy. He blinks in quick succession, as if trying to fend off tears. "I'll never forgive myself for it. I never want to see you cry again, not because of me, at least."

Then, Mydei's hands are on him—cupping Phainon's cheeks with a tenderness that makes his breath catch. The touch is soft, reverent almost, as though he's afraid Phainon might shatter if he presses too hard. His palms are warm against the coolness of Phainon's skin, thumbs brushing gently beneath his eyes, tracing invisible paths like he's memorising every curve, every line, just with his look alone and his touch.

For a second, everything narrows down to just them. The world around them finally, *finally* stops spinning, enough that Phainon feels rooted to the ground for the first time in a whole week.

Mydei continues to hold him like he's something precious—something fragile and irreplaceable. Like he's afraid to lose him again; and Phainon can feel it in the way Mydei's fingers tremble ever so slightly, in the way his own pulse flutters beneath that gentle hold.

It's overwhelming—how safe he feels in that touch. How utterly *known*. Warmth spreads throughout him, slow and aching, chasing away the cold in his bones that'd been gathering like cobwebs he hadn't bothered to clean. Yet beneath it all, there's a strange fragility, a shaky awareness that this moment could crumble at any second, that if Mydei moves too suddenly, it'll all vanish like breath on glass.

Phainon feels safe, yes—but he also feels entirely exposed. Cherished, but shaking. Warm and cold all at once, caught in that impossible balance between longing and fear.

"I love you, Phainon. I love you so much it terrified me so badly that I almost lost you."

Because if this is what being loved by Mydei feels like… he isn't sure he'll ever recover if he loses it again.

Phainon swallows thickly, tears welling up in his eyes as his emotions coalesce over him like a tsunami. He laughs wetly, unable to help it, and he can feel Mydei panicking without even having to speak.

"I love you, too," Phainon murmurs, taking one of Mydei's hands and moving it around so he can kiss his palm. "I adore you."

Mydei's bottom lip is trembling, and Phainon presses a lingering kiss to his palm again, as though signing his confession with his DNA.

"I adore you more," Mydei replies strongly, even as tears begin to slide down his face.

This time, it's Phainon's turn to cup Mydei's face, brushing away those tears before they can ever fall properly. "Don't cry, Mydei." He says softly. "I'm right here."

"I know, that's why I'm crying," Mydei says and chuckles lightly. He lets go of Phainon's face to reel him in for a hug, wrapping his strong arms around

his waist as he tugs him impossibly close. "I couldn't eat, I couldn't sleep… I don't even remember attending classes, but I did. I missed you so much."

Phainon goes with the motion, looping his arms around Mydei's neck as he gently encourages Mydei's face into the crook of his neck, one hand on the back of his head as he runs his fingers through his hair as he keeps talking.

"I'm so sorry, Phainon. I'm sorry."

His fingers keep catching on knots that he slowly works out, making sure not to tear the hair or tug too much on Mydei's scalp. He wonders if Mydei even brushed his hair before leaving, or if he was in such a mess that he didn't bother.

"It's not okay, but… I forgive you," Phainon replies, just holding Mydei as he shakes.

He doesn't know how long they stand like that, with the moonlight as their witness. He only knows that after a while, he feels kisses being pressed into the side of his neck—slow, dragging ones, and then quick, pulsing in succession ones.

"Hey, that tickles," Phainon giggles, wriggling around in Mydei's grip.

Mydei doesn't let him go though, only pulls back after another kiss to the side of his jaw where his sun tattoo reaches. "I love you." Mydei says again.

"I know that," Phainon replies softly, but he's grinning from ear to ear. "You don't have to keep saying it."

"Then…" Mydei hums, tilting his head to the side, looking at him imploringly. It's an innocent side of Mydei that Phainon rarely gets to see. "Will you be my boyfriend?"

Phainon freezes in his hold. Then just as quickly, he thaws out again. "Yes," Phainon replies. "Yes!"

Without thinking, Phainon pulls Mydei in and kisses him.

It's their first real kiss as *boyfriends*. Oh, Phainon doesn't think he'll ever get used to thinking about that being his new reality. The thought alone sends his heart into a mess of stuttering, a rush of warmth blooming through his chest, so bright it almost hurts. This time, there's no fear beneath, no anxious restraint or worry about revealing his feelings too much.

He can finally kiss Mydei as much as he wants, without pretending and without hiding behind *practise* as an excuse. He doesn't need a reason anymore to want to kiss his *boyfriend*. He can hold him close, trace the shape of his jaw, let his fingers wander in his hair all because he *can*. He can love him openly now—lavish him with all the affection he's kept caged for so long—and know that it's wanted in return.

Phainon tilts his head, slotting their noses together perfectly as he kisses, kisses, and *kisses* Mydei, until he can't breathe and his lungs ache with the need for oxygen. Even then, he only pulls back enough to take one gulping breath before he's leaning back in, capturing his lips in another long kiss. He doesn't deepen it, not yet, keeping it a chaste meshing of their lips. They're still outside, after all, and Phainon does have *some* shame left inside of him.

"You're my boyfriend," Mydei grins when they pull back, his eyes still closed as though he's lost in the sensation, but this time they take a lot longer to breathe.

"I sure am," Phainon says, nudging Mydei's nose with his own. "I'll be the best boyfriend ever, I swear."

"I believe you," Mydei replies. "I know you will. So will I."

"Yeah?" Phainon bites down on his bottom lip. "You gonna be a better boyfriend than me?"

"Mhm," Mydei hums, yanking Phainon in by his waist so they're pressed hip to hip. "I bet I will."

"I bet *I'll* be the better boyfriend," Phainon replies, tangling his fingers through Mydei's newly brushed through hair. This time, his fingers pass

through like silk. "You can't beat me."

"I can," Mydei laughs, dark and low. It makes something fizzy, popping and shimmering settle low in Phainon's stomach at the noise. He shifts his weight from one foot to the other.

"How?" Phainon asks, the words ghosting across Mydei's lips as they suddenly move closer to one another.

"Oh, I can think of a few things," Mydei says lightly, grinding their hips together. Phainon gasps, and he's very much aware of how hard he is in his jeans now. Mydei's eyebrows lift, "Already, Deliverer?"

The nickname tastes fantastic on his lips as Phainon leans in again to kiss Mydei. It's sweet, coursing through him like static as he drags his fingernails over Mydei's scalp just to feel him shiver in his arms.

"Home," Phainon pants when he pulls away, "I wanna go home with you."

"Now," Mydei replies surely, untangling them as he grabs Phainon's hand and pulls him along, surely guiding him back to their place.

They tumble through the door, half caught up in each other and half trying to get their shoes off. They're kissing, mouths fumbling and moans leaking through their lips as they blindly shut the door behind them, privacy finally descending upon them. Phainon pulls away with a wet *pop*, a sliver of saliva still connecting their lips. He doesn't bother severing it, keeps it there hanging as he leans in to press feverish pecks against Mydei's neck.

"Tell me I can leave marks, please— please, Mydei, please—" Phainon begs, hands scrambling across Mydei's waist just so he can hold onto something.

"Yeah," Mydei swallows loudly, so much so that Phainon can hear the click of his throat. "You can."

Immediately, Phainon sucks against Mydei's skin, dragging his bottom teeth over the mark to make it even redder. Mydei looks so pale in comparison, and it only eggs him on to make more as he litters them across his neck, Mydei tilting his head back further and further until he's being entirely held up by Phainon's arms alone. He's completely boneless in them, neck all the way on display and hair pushed back out the way for Phainon to get to work.

"Fuck," Mydei hisses when Phainon nips him, shivering and shuddering in his hold. "Stop, stop— I'm gonna—"

"Heh," Phainon smiles against Mydei's neck, leaving one last kiss there before pulling back. "Already?" Throwing Mydei's words from earlier back at him.

"Shut up," Mydei says as he shoves Phainon back, further into their flat and out of the entryway until he's pushed against a wall. He looks *incredible*, all flushed and neck covered in red bruises, all from Phainon.

Possessiveness flares like a firework in his belly at the sight. He reaches out for more, to bring Mydei back closer to him, maybe so he can leave extra hickeys down his collarbones, or maybe even leave some on his chest if he can unbutton Mydei's shirt, but instead, Mydei drops to the floor onto his knees. Shock takes over his emotions then, even more so when Mydei begins fumbling with his jeans fly.

"Wh— what are you doing?" Phainon asks, half in disbelief at how quickly this is progressing.

Mydei looks up at him in answer, flushed and panting, and leans forward to nuzzle against his hard cock. Pleasure zips through Phainon, making him swallow thickly against the lump in his throat. "You're—?"

"If you want," Mydei replies, hands stilling even though he already has his jeans' zip undone and his hand is halfway into his boxers.

"If *I want*," Phainon repeats incredulously. "I want— yeah, Mydei, *fuck*, you can do that. You can suck me off."

Mydei smirks, all feline and smarmy, and takes Phainon's cock out of his boxers, pulling his jeans down just enough to be comfortable. He pumps his length a few times, swiping his thumb over the head to make the slide wetter. Phainon's already leaking, his cock red and swollen and it twitches in Mydei's hold, excitement completely taking over.

Holy shit, Phainon thinks, threading his fingers through Mydei's hair gently, using it to get a better view of his face as Mydei leans in, holding the base of his cock with his fist as he laps up the slick at the tip. The feeling is immediate, and Phainon's head falls back with a groan as he already feels like he could come from that little touch alone. Mydei looks insanely good, all flushed and panting and dewy eyed, so pretty that Phainon wants to ruin him even more.

He doesn't have to wonder for long how Mydei would look like with a cock in his mouth—*his* cock, that is. Mydei looks up at him through his lashes, opening his mouth wide as he folds his lips over the tip, taking him down to where his fingers are in one go.

"Mydei!" Phainon moans, grip turning harsh in his hair as Mydei bobs his head up, tongue flicking and licking and mouth sucking. *Gods*, it's too much, it's too much—it feels so good that Phainon feels like he's floating, but then when Mydei does this *thing* with his tongue, he feels grounded to the floor once again.

"Have— have you done this before?" Phainon pants out, unable to keep himself from asking.

Mydei pulls back with a wet gasp, mouth still open as Phainon can see how wet it is inside. Fuck, shit, all the swear words under the world couldn't describe how that sight makes him feel. He can feel Mydei's breathing over his damp cock, and it makes him shiver. Mydei wraps his tongue around the tip, giving him a tiny suck before pulling back again.

"No," Mydei replies, and his voice is all deep and gravelly, just like if he'd been—

Well, Phainon almost laughs, as if he had just been sucking cock. And really well, at that. It's hard to believe that this is his first time. "You didn't do it with mystery man at New Year's?"

"What kind of guy do you take me for?" Mydei retorts venomously, squeezing the base of his length cruelly. Phainon laughs, shuddering. "I was so drunk I thought that guy was *you*."

"You— what?" Phainon asks, but then Mydei is back on him, throat convulsing around his cock like he was made to do this. "Fuck!"

Mydei's mouth feels *heavenly*. Wet, hot and tight all at once. He works over Phainon's cock, up and down, taking him almost down to the root before pulling off to give little kitten licks to the tip. It's driving him *crazy*, completely maddening, as he gets closer and closer to finishing. Mydei looks stunning on his knees, back arched with a singular look in his eyes when they're open that send spikes of pleasure through his gut. His eyes are so pretty, hazy and focused all at once on his task.

"You're so big, gods," Mydei says when he pulls off again for a breather, coughing lightly into his palm. "My jaw hurts."

"Come— come up here," Phainon encourages, leaning over to grab onto Mydei's biceps as he hauls him up. Mydei stumbles slightly, but he's immediately righted again by Phainon's hands. "I wanna kiss you." Phainon says and does just so, licking straight into Mydei's mouth to taste himself on his tongue.

It's vaguely salty, the tang exploding on his tongue as he laps it up until there's nothing left but the bland taste of saliva. Mydei mewls, moaning and whining, hips writhing against air.

"Lemme take care of you," Phainon pleads, hands already unbuckling Mydei's belt. He feels Mydei nod against his neck, wet panting creating condensation against the skin there as he gets his hands into Mydei's pants. He's so *wet*, the front of his briefs already sodden, that Phainon for a split second thinks he's already cum. But then he brushes against Mydei's hardness which is still there, thrumming away, boiling hot and searing as he takes him in his hand.

"*Ah*!" Mydei gasps, cock throbbing in his hand. Phainon mirrors the noise, mouth dropping open as he uses his other hand to push down Mydei's slacks and underwear, freeing him completely for easier access. "Stroke me, *ahh*, just— just like that," Mydei babbles as Phainon jacks him off, hand moving up and down, the slide so slick it makes wet noises that make him flush bright red. It sounds so *lewd*, what with the slide of his hand and Mydei's panting and words in his ears, Phainon shivers with it all, feeling like he's about to come from this alone.

He's strung so tightly that he almost shouts when a hand grabs his cock, forgotten but still damp with Mydei's saliva and his pre-cum. Mydei's wrist twists right beneath the crown, thumb swirling on the tip enough that Phainon's knees become weak.

They both work at each other's cocks, up and down, thumbs swiping and wrists twisting just in the right places until they're both shivering messes, thighs shaking and knees trembling, panting into each other's mouths as they press half-hearted kisses against lips. Phainon can barely breathe, can barely form words, but they spill out anyway:

"You're so— so *good*, Mydei, so perfect, beautiful—" Phainon slurs out as Mydei crowds him further against the wall, his fist tightening until it's almost painful.

"You think I'm beautiful?" Mydei asks, voice faint.

"Yeah, most beautiful man—*person*—ever," Phainon replies.

"You didn't think anyone at the party was cute?" Mydei questions, and Phainon's features crease in confusion. Why is he talking about the party?

"No," Phainon tries to remember the strangers that were there, but he can't picture any of their faces. "No, just you—"

"The girl who spun the bottle wanted to kiss you," Mydei says, this time against his cheek.

"Huh?" Phainon feels so good that his toes are curling in his socks, and his head thuds back against the wall.

Mydei kisses his neck immediately, licking and dragging his teeth across his tattoo. His tattoo isn't tender, it having long healed, but something about *Mydei* touching it makes him hyper-sensitive.

"She wanted you," Mydei carries on, and Phainon is trying really hard to listen but he honestly doesn't care about the girl at the party, or anyone else for that matter, who isn't *Mydei*.

"I only want you," Phainon replies honestly, squeezing Mydei's cock as he peers down between them, their knuckles bumping against each other from being so close. He can feel the heat coming from Mydei's length, burning hot, and it makes his brain fizzle out to a stop.

Mydei whines, "Yeah? Only me?"

"Only you," Phainon confirms, nodding, as if that'll help seal his words. "My *boyfriend*."

Mydei yelps, and then there's something hot and wet splashing across their fists, and Mydei is shaking and leaning even further into him as he *comes*, and comes, and even when his cock is finished spurting, he's still a shuddering mess. Phainon gulps, cock throbbing, and it's enough when Mydei breathes hotly against his ear and works his hand up his length one final time that he's coming too, making even more of a mess between them. They stroke each other through it, fingers loose and sticky, until they're both backing off with oversensitivity. Their hands drop down by their sides at the same time, both equally spent, Mydei's head in the crook of Phainon's shoulder as their chests are pressed together.

Phainon hums languidly, feeling like lava is flowing through his veins as he comes down from his high. Mydei snuggles further into him, his clean hand coming up to rest on Phainon's bare hip.

"So," Phainon begins, a Cheshire cat-like smile crossing his face. "Being called *my boyfriend* gets you off, huh?"

Mydei punches him squarely in the chest, his ears red hot. "Shut up."

Phainon laughs, bright and loud, and gathers Mydei up in his arms and smatters kisses all over his beet red face. Mydei splutters, trying to push him off, but Phainon doesn't stop, he just keeps going until Mydei is soft and pliant in his arms again, humming happily when their lips join again.

"Let's get cleaned up," Phainon whispers, kissing Mydei's temple before he stands up straight. He tucks his softened cock back into his boxers but

doesn't bother zipping his jeans back up again. He watches Mydei do the same, his hands still shaky.

They walk to the bathroom together, shoulders brushing as they move in quiet contentment. The sound of running water fills the small space, steady and familiar, as they wash their hands side by side. Phainon catches his reflection in the mirror, and this time he's not afraid to look at it as he stares into the mirrored image. He almost doesn't recognise himself; his cheeks are flushed, a soft radiant pink, and there's a glow to his skin that feels unreal—like he's been lit from the inside out. When he glances lower, he notices faint marks scattered over his tattoo, and it takes everything in him not to stop washing his hands and touch over them with wet hands, just to prove that they're real.

He looks to his side. Mydei's there, framed in the mirror's light, sleeves still pushed up and his hair is in complete disarray from all the touching Phainon did to it. There's a small, unguarded smile tugging at his lips—like he doesn't even realise it's there. His eyes are bright, warm, and full of quiet happiness that radiates outwards from him—complete *bliss*.

Phainon's heart stammers. Gods, he's so beautiful. So *stunningly beautiful* it almost hurts to look at. And he can't believe that Mydei is all his now.

"You're beautiful," Phainon says again before he can stop himself—no hesitation, no fear. Just the truth, spoken freely into the air between them. He says it because he can, because there's nothing he has to hide anymore; everything's out in the open, laid bare.

And the way Mydei looks at him in that moment—soft and a little disbelieving—makes Phainon feel like he's finally, truly home.

Mydei's hands are still under the tap, water is running over his fingers, but his gaze is warm on Phainon once the words settle in. For a heartbeat, he just blinks, like he's not heard him right, now that they're not caught up in the moment. But then the smallest, shyest of smiles curls at the corner of his mouth—slow and real.

"Really?" Mydei murmurs, voice barely above a whisper.

Phainon nods, a faint, breathless laugh escaping him simply because he feels so *free* being able to say that. "Yeah. You are."

Something flickers in Mydei's expression—something soft and overflowing. He turns, reaching out to brush his damp fingertips along Phainon's jaw, tracing the curve of his cheek where that lingering blush still glows.

"You're not so bad yourself, handsome," Mydei replies, and though the words are teasing, his tone is tender, reverent almost. His thumb lingers just a moment longer before he lets his hands drop, moving over to where the hand towel hangs on the wall beside him.

Phainon can't stop smiling. It's a loud, dizzying type of joy that makes him want to jump in the air and shout 'yippee!!!' to whoever will hear him. The world outside could crumble right now and he wouldn't care; right now, all

he cares about is *them*, bathed in soft bathroom light and accompanied by the steady hum of running water. Phainon turns the tap off, shouldering Mydei out of the way so he can use the hand towel next. Mydei grumbles at him, but doesn't say anything extra as he's still smiling.

They both are.

After that, they can't seem to keep their hands to themselves. Every brush of fingers, every glance across the room feels charged in a way that makes Phainon's heart twist and flutter all at once. What used to be casual touches: an arm slung around a shoulder, a hand on the small of a back—now hum with a quiet, unmistakable tenderness.

Phainon practically moves into Mydei's room without even meaning to. One night turns into two, then three, and before long his clothes are folded neatly beside Mydei's, their shoes side by side at the door rather than messily shoved into the cubby. They share a bed every night, falling asleep tangled up in each other, trading slow, sleepy kisses that taste like toothpaste and warmth and comfort and home all wrapped up into one. Mydei always runs a little hot, so Phainon takes advantage and presses himself close, fitting into every curve and hollow until he can feel Mydei's steady heartbeat against his chest. Like that, he lulls himself to sleep.

They become inseparable—more than before, somehow. Phainon didn't think it possible. Breakfast together, as usual, as well as lunches shared together on university grounds and dinner together at night when back at home. Even the quiet, ordinary moments like brushing their teeth and

folding laundry (which Phainon used to hate, now… not so much, even when he has to fold up Mydei's tiny white briefs) feel brand new. Everything feels tinged with golden light, gentle to touch, fragile and yet sturdy at the same time as they work in tandem together like they always have.

It never feels suffocating, like they're doing too much together and Phainon itches for some freedom on his own. If anything, it feels natural—like this is the way it was always meant to be, them together at all times of the day, trading goodbye and hello kisses in the entryway of their flat before and after classes. It's just them, orbiting around each other's gravity, two halves of something finally whole.

It's a lazy Sunday, and they're both puttering around the flat with not much to do. Phainon is lounging on their sofa, when Mydei comes and flops down on top of him.

"Oof!" Phainon exclaims, but his arms automatically come up to wrap around Mydei's waist, steadying him from accidentally rolling off.

"I'm bored," Mydei states, and then he's kissing Phainon like his life depends on it. Phainon's eyes widen before they flutter shut, and his hands move to settle on the curve of Mydei's ass instead of his waist, squeezing and kneading just to see if he can make his boyfriend moan.

It works, Mydei instantly whines—just like he always does whenever Phainon pulls this move; so easily, so quickly, and then they’re both melt into the kiss, lazily making out as the sun begins to set through their window; hues of pink and purple settling over them. Phainon smirks into their kiss, their teeth knocking together slightly as Mydei pulls back, wriggling.

"You're so annoying," Mydei accuses, but he's also smiling, albeit a smaller one.

"You're the one who loves me," Phainon retorts, grabbing handfuls of Mydei's plush ass into his hands, just because he *can*. He loves that excuse now, 'just because', as it makes everything feasible when it comes to teasing Mydei one way or another. Whether it's lingering kisses that last too long, playful nips across his neck, handfuls of his pecs and ass whenever he feels like it, Phainon thrives on it all.

Mydei sighs. "I do," He replies.

Phainon beams and pecks Mydei on the lips, both of them trying to hide their smiles before they burst into laughter. Mydei's hands, which were next to Phainon's head, begin to wander. They toy with the hem of his shirt, before his hands find themselves underneath, sliding across Phainon's abdomen and stomach, making his muscles jump and flex with the touch. Phainon stops laughing, suddenly serious, as Mydei watches him with hooded eyes and teeth biting into his lower lip.

"Phainon, can we—"

A knock at their door makes them both jump. Mydei grumbles and leans forward, capturing Phainon's lips for another kiss. Phainon gasps, hands unlatching themselves from his ass to come up to Mydei's shoulders, gently pushing him back.

"Someone's at the door—"

"Don't care," Mydei replies, pressing a lingering kiss to Phainon's mouth, enough that he forgets the knocking too.

The knocking gets louder and louder, more persistent until they're forced apart, both staring at where the hallway is as they hear: "I know you're in there, kiddos!"

It's Cipher's voice.

"What the hell is she doing here?" Mydei asks, getting up with a grumpy look not unlike a disgruntled kitten having his toy taken away from him. Phainon feels cold immediately without him on top to warm him up, and he sits up on his elbows to watch Mydei disappear behind the wall, opening the door.

"What do you want?" Mydei asks flatly, and Phainon is moving to join him, coming up behind him. He instinctively puts his hands on Mydei's waist.

"Oh, the Deliverer is here too, what a surprise." Cipher says, and next to her is Castorice, who waves at Phainon.

Phainon doesn't want to move his hands, so he smiles and nods once in her direction. "What are you guys doing here?"

"We're here to give you back your stuff," Castorice says, handing over Phainon's duffel bag that he'd left at her place weeks ago.

"Oh," Mydei says, grabbing the bag from her hands and holding onto it.

"Thanks, Cas. I totally forgot about it." Phainon says.

"We know, none of you have been answering our texts, so we decided to pay you a visit…" Cipher replies, sniffing the air. "It *stinks* in here. What have you two been up to?" She waggles her eyebrows.

"Enough!" Mydei exclaims, stepping back to shut the door on them.

"Hey, Mydei, don't be so rude!" Phainon says, pinching his hip. Mydei shivers with it, and suddenly Phainon is waving the two goodbye and thanking them profusely.

"You're so—" Phainon says, shoving Mydei into their front door so he can kiss him, arm propped up next to his head as he leans over him, crowding him into the door. "Are you really that sensitive?"

"Only because it's you," Mydei replies, and that just makes Phainon kiss him harder.

"We can still hear you, by the way!" Cipher yells from outside, banging on their door until it rattles, and it causes her to let out that terrible cackle she does when she's highly entertained.

"Leave already!" Mydei shouts back, grumbling when he hears them both giggling, but the sound fades out as their footsteps get further and further away.

Phainon pouts, "What were you going to say earlier?"

"Nothing," Mydei replies too quickly. Then, he sighs. "Your favourite football team is playing in a bit, should we watch them?"

It's obviously not what Mydei wanted to say, but Phainon lets it go for now. He brightens and nods, smiling, "Sure!"

The library is silent, the kind that settles heavy and soft, only punctuated by the faint tapping of laptop keys and the occasional rustle of pages. The late afternoon light filters through the tall windows in pale gold beams, dust motes drifting lazily in the glow.

Phainon sits hunched over his laptop, a half-drunk coffee cooling beside him, his concentration hanging by a thread. It's exam season, and he is slowly losing his mind. Mydei sits across from him, brow furrowed, one hand propping up his chin as he scrolls through something on his screen. They've been here for hours, cooped up in the corner away from prying eyes, the space between them cluttered with open notebooks, pens and the quiet comfort of shared focus.

Phainon zones out briefly, his eyes going fuzzy as he rubs them with his fist to try and get himself back into focus. He takes a sip of his coffee, grimacing at how bitter it is. It's a cheap one from the university canteen, one that he rarely ever goes to considering Mydei makes all his meals for him still, but it'd been the only quick way to get some caffeine in him.

Then, before he can properly look at his screen again, there's a soft bump under the table.

Phainon startles, his knee jerking before he realises it's Mydei's foot pressing lightly against his own. The contact is fleeting but electric, a tiny spark that jolts straight up his spine. He looks up instantly, and there's Mydei, eyes lifting from his screen, gaze meeting his. For a split second, everything narrows down to that look. The low hum of the air vents, the soft whir of computers, the distant shuffle of footsteps—it all fades into

nothing. It's just them, the space between their laptops, and the charged vibrations in the air as they breathe.

"Sorry," Mydei murmurs, though there's a hint of a smile tugging at the corner of his mouth.

Phainon shakes his head, maybe too quickly, too ramped up by that touch alone. "No problem."

Mydei's foot doesn't move away this time. It lingers, just a little, brushing against Phainon's ankle—a question more than a statement. Phainon swallows, heat crawling up his neck over such a small gesture. Mydei probably means nothing by it, but it's getting his heart racing and his cock stirring in his joggers for some reason. It's not like he's touch starved, all he and Mydei do is *touch*, whether above the belt or below it. But they've not gone very far, not since their first time after they made up, and Phainon's starting to become… Well. Maybe a bit pent up, to be bluntly honest.

Instead of moving away like Phainon half hopes, Mydei's foot lifts, the corner of his sole stroking against the inner part of his ankle. Phainon shifts, staring down at his laptop keyboard to keep himself occupied.

It doesn't work.

He adjusts himself in his chair, going to stand up but then he sits down immediately, and yet still, Mydei doesn't move. "Mydei…" Phainon says, half pleading.

"Yes?" Mydei replies, completely innocent despite the sparkling look in those amber eyes.

"Stop it," Phainon says through gritted teeth, his voice a whisper as he doesn't want to disturb other students.

They're all pretty far away, but still. He doesn't know how far his voice will carry at this point. Mydei tilts his head to the side, a lazy grin filling his face, eyes bright as he watches Phainon *suffer*.

"Stop what?" Mydei asks, his foot rising higher until it brushes his calf, even reaching up to his knee.

"*That*," Phainon hisses, jerking in his seat when Mydei's foot comes even closer, hovering on the inside of his thigh.

Mydei raises an eyebrow, "I'm not doing anything?"

"Playing coy doesn't suit you, Mydeimos," Phainon replies, sweat beading at his hairline.

"Sure it does," Mydei replies. "Means I can get away with all sorts."

Phainon reaches down between his legs and grabs Mydei's ankle, stopping him from moving any further. "What, like turning me on in the library?"

"You're turned on from just *that*?"

"W-well," Phainon stutters, very embarrassed as heat crawls up the back of his neck. "No…"

Mydei uses Phainon's lax grip to move his foot again, pressing his heel into Phainon's half hard cock. He whimpers pathetically, unable to do anything else but fold over so his forehead is resting on his laptop's keyboard, probably typing all sorts of nonsense into his empty word document.

"I said stop…" Phainon says feebly, and Mydei listens to him, pulling his foot away completely. He sighs a breath of relief, but it doesn't last long when there's fingers in his hair, twisting and pulling on strands. Phainon sits up, face creased, imploring.

"I want you to fuck me," Mydei says suddenly, and Phainon chokes on his own spit.

"Wh— Mydei!" Phainon exclaims too loudly, already hearing *shush*! and *be quiet*! coming from the other students dotted around. He leans in over the table, face bright red. "Right now?!"

"Yeah, sure, take me right here," Mydei says sarcastically, rolling his eyes. "I meant when we get home."

"And you just had to tell me this immediately?" Phainon grits out.

"Yep," Mydei replies, taking a sip of his own coffee. He doesn't grimace like Phainon did, having filled his up to the brim with extra milk and sugar. "Just wanted to let you know."

"Now you expect me to concentrate on my work?" Phainon asks, his voice taking a whiny tone.

Mydei shifts in his seat, "We can go now if you want."

"*If you want*, he says," Phainon scoffs. "Of course I *want*." He pauses, reaching over to grab Mydei's hand. "I didn't think you were ready."

"I am," Mydei says quickly, looking away as a flush begins to dust across his cheeks. "I was just waiting for you."

"Oh," Phainon says. "Oh, okay, well… I'm ready, too. But shouldn't I take you out on a date first?"

Mydei hums, giving Phainon a once over. His gaze is hot, sending zings of pleasure through him. "You mean wine and dine me?"

"Yeah," Phainon nods enthusiastically. "I wanna take you on a proper date."

Mydei nods once, "Pack up your stuff then."

"Oh!" Phainon slams his laptop lid shut, not caring about saving any of his work. He can do that later when he's not thinking with his dick. "Sure, right now? Seriously? Really?"

"Yes, you idiot," Mydei says through his teeth, already finished packing away his stuff like Phainon floundered.

It isn't as hard booking somewhere to eat as Phainon thought it would be—but that doesn't stop him from overthinking every single detail. He scrolls through endless lists of restaurants on his phone, thumb flicking across the screen as if the perfect place will somehow leap out and announce itself. Each photo and review lacking in some way: too casual, too expensive, too crowded at this time in the evening, too plain. None of them seem right enough for Mydei.

He wants it to be perfect, no matter how last minute it is. He wants it to be romantic without being pretentious, warm without being boring. He wants Mydei to smile when they walk in, hopefully hand in hand or arm in arm, and to think *this looks good*. Phainon can hear Mydei's voice in his head, that little grin when he joked about being 'wined and dined', and the thought alone makes him smile to himself.

So, when he finally lands on a place that feels right and is only a twenty minute drive away, he doesn't hesitate. It looks great in the photos: soft lighting, quiet booths, a cosy menu that sounds just expensive enough for his budget—and even though it means he'll be stretching his wallet thinner than it's ever been, he'll do it. Mydei's worth that. With a sure nod, he books a booth online, entering his personal information as well as his credit card numbers. With that all done, he sighs in relief and leans back into the sofa.

"Hey, Mydei," He calls out, and Mydei peeks around the corner of the kitchen.

"Yeah?"

"Better get ready for our date, it's in two hours. Dress nicely." Phainon grins.

Mydei goes warm, his cheeks and ears flushing a pretty pink. "Do you need help picking out what to wear again?"

"No way, I got it this time," Phainon says. It's a lie, he doesn't have it this time, but he's sure by the time he dives into his clothing, he'll figure it out.

Phainon decides to keep it simple. A crisp white shirt and pressed black trousers—clean, classic, impossible to get wrong. He even swaps out his usual cartoon covered socks for plain black ones, a small but meaningful sacrifice. He's sure Mydei will appreciate it, anyway. He doesn't own dress shoes like Mydei does, but his newer pair of dark trainers will have to do; they look neat enough to pass if you don't stare too hard at them. Which he's sure the host at the restaurant won't bother doing, considering there's not even a dress code. A black jacket goes on last, tying everything together.

He pauses in front of the mirror. For a long moment, he just stares, eyes tracking everywhere possible to make sure he looks his best. He looks… *posh*. It's not a word he's ever used for himself before, but there it is. The monochrome outfit sharpens his shape, accentuates his broad shoulders and slim hips, and even though the slacks are a little tight around his thighs, he still thinks it works. His hair is still a little unruly—no amount of brushing can change that—but somehow it completes the look. He runs his fingers through it anyway, watching the two strands at the top of his head ping straight back up again.

A small, nervous grin curls at his lips. He wishes he had Castorice's knack for styling hair or Mydei's way of effortlessly looking put together, but for tonight, this will do. He looks decent, at least. Presentable. Maybe even—he dares to think it—good enough for Mydei.

Excitement zings through him at the thought of going on his first, proper date. With the man he's been in love with for years. He makes a garbled sort of noise and hides his reddening cheeks in the palms of his hands, unable to look at himself any longer. He leaves his bedroom, closing the door behind him as he peers down the hall. Mydei's bedroom door is still shut, and as much as he is tempted to knock and see how he's doing, he decides to leave it for now and go grab a glass of water from the kitchen. He wanders through the living room and into the kitchen, filling his glass with water from the tap as he tries to quieten the rampaging thoughts in his mind about how Mydei will look.

He takes a sip, the cool water soothing his parched throat. He grabs his phone from his pocket and fiddles around with it, wondering if he should text Castorice and tell her that he and Mydei are finally going on a real date this time. He knows she'll be over the moon for him, and he smiles around the rim of his glass. Just as he's about to open their text chat, he hears the faint click of a door opening.

Phainon pauses, putting his glass down. "I'm in the kitchen, Mydei!" He shouts.

Mydei doesn't reply, but suddenly he's there, in the doorway, and everything in Phainon's chest just *stops*.

Mydei doesn't move closer as Phainon takes him in, both their faces equally shocked at seeing the other. Phainon's eyes are wide, eyes desperately taking in Mydei as he looks him up and down. He's framed by the warm light of the hall, dressed in a freaking *three piece suit* that fits him far too well. The dark fabric hugs the lines of his shoulders and waist like it was tailor made for him. Phainon swallows down the flood of saliva in his

mouth, and the thought about cancelling the date and making good on his earlier promise of fucking Mydei seems more like the better choice now.

He shakes his head, shakily placing down his glass so he doesn't drop it in shock. Mydei's braid, usually a little loose by this time of day, is perfectly redone—tight, neat, the blonde strands gleaming where they catch the light. It's almost like he's put some sort of oil or serum in it, all the fly aways flattened down as the rest of his hair curls outwards sweetly. Phainon well and truly forgets how to breathe. His throat goes dry again, and for a fleeting, helpless second, he swears the world is tilted on its axis as he tries to right himself.

"Mydei," He breathes out, the name coming out quiet and desperate. It's barely more than a whisper.

Mydei meets his gaze, adjusting his cuffs. "Is this okay? You said to dress nice, right?" His tone is casual, but there's a flicker of uncertainty in his eyes that makes Phainon's heart twist.

Okay? Phainon wants to laugh, or maybe grovel at his boyfriend's feet for a chance at… well, anything. Something. He looks like every wet dream and every wish Phainon's ever made condensed into one impossibly beautiful person. His brain scrambles for something to say—anything at all—but all that comes out is a strangled sort of sound, halfway between awe and disbelief.

Mydei raises an eyebrow at him, and he snaps out of it, walking over to Mydei to get a closer look. He's immediately met with Mydei's cologne,

sweet and musky and spiced. It's mouthwateringly good, so good that he nuzzles straight into Mydei's neck, pressing a chaste kiss right on the side where the scent is the strongest. He must've sprayed it there before leaving his room. Phainon puts his hands on Mydei's waist, squeezing it encouragingly.

"You look…" He shakes his head, pulling back so he can meet Mydei's amber eyes. "You look *unbelievable*."

A faint flush rises on Mydei's cheeks, and he looks away, straightening his jacket that doesn't have a single wrinkle on it. "You look good, too."

"Just good, hm?" Phainon says playfully, smacking a kiss onto Mydei's cheek.

Mydei grumbles, wiping the dampness off with the back off his hand. "You look *really* good." Mydei reiterates.

Phainon beams at him, unable to keep the smile off his face for too long. "I had to dress nicely for our first date, didn't I? Look, I even put on plain socks just for you!" Phainon moves backwards, hiking his trousers up to show his socks off.

Mydei scoffs, "If you'd shown up in your pink star socks, I would've cancelled."

Phainon drops his trousers legs and pouts, "Don't be so mean. You totally would've still gone out with me, don't even deny it."

"Fine," Mydei says, taking a step into Phainon's space. He rests his hands on his shoulders before leaning in and giving him a kiss, lingering just enough to make Phainon's eyelashes flutter shut. "I wouldn't cancel this date even if the whole world was on fire. Happy?"

"Very," Phainon replies, and he means it. He's not just happy to hear that, but so happy in general that he can hardly believe he almost lost this. It feels like a miracle that he's even here, with Mydei, standing in their kitchen dressed to the nines awaiting a proper re-do of everything.

"Come on, handsome. Our taxi should be here soon." Mydei says, grabbing Phainon's hand and enveloping it in his. "Do you have everything?"

"Just need to grab my keys and then we're set," Phainon says, grinning.

There's a small smile on Mydei's face that hasn't moved in about five minutes, and Phainon can tell just by that alone that he's just as happy as he is.

The restaurant is *stunning*—warm and golden, bathed in the soft glow of hanging lamps that make everything feel dreamlike. The light pools gently

across polished wooden tables, glinting off wine glasses and catching in the faint haze of laughter and conversation that fills the air. It smells faintly of roasted garlic, butter, and something sweet that Phainon can't quite place. All of it blends into a kind of scent that makes the world feel narrowed down to this room alone.

Booths are tucked into the corners, little private pockets of comfort beneath dim lights, each one promising a quiet space away from everyone else. He's glad that he booked one of them for him and Mydei, giddiness bubbling away in his stomach as he keeps looking around. Jazz plays from the hidden speakers, mellow and smooth, wrapping around the air like silk as Phainon bobs his head briefly along to it.

The whole place feels intimate without being overbearing, and romantic without trying too hard. He can already imagine them sharing lingering glances over half finished glasses of wine, and having conversations that stretch long into the night.

They walk up to the host who's tapping away on their tablet, head down, until they're close enough. Their face brightens into a smile, "How may I help you?"

"A booth for Phainon Khaslana," He says, showing his ID to the host.

They peer down at it and nod, going back to typing on their tablet for a brief moment. "Of course, sirs, right this way."

They follow behind the host, trailing through a bunch of tables and patrons until they're shown their booth, right at the back. It's hidden from the majority of the room, partially behind a wall, but there's a singular light hanging above them that lights the way plenty. It's perfect, exactly what Phainon was hoping for.

"Thank you," Both Phainon and Mydei say when they sit down, nodding in unison when they're handed menus.

"I'll be back in a minute to take your orders, but there's no rush," The host says, and then swiftly leaves them to themselves.

"You really went all out, huh?" Mydei says, raising an eyebrow at the menu.

"For you, obviously," Phainon replies. He stares down at the menu, eyes grazing over all the options. He's starving, but not quite enough for an appetiser and a main, especially since they'll definitely be getting dessert if Mydei's sweet tooth has anything to say about it.

Their host returns later, taking down their order for food and drinks, and then they're left alone again.

Phainon can't help it. He reaches across the table, grabbing a hold of Mydei's hand that's clenched on top. He entwines their fingers together, giving it an encouraging squeeze. "Are you happy?"

"I am," Mydei says softly, squeezing Phainon's hand back. "My cheeks ache from smiling."

"Who would've thought that the crown prince was capable of smiling, eh?" Phainon jokes, laughing when he gets a glare in response. "You're cute even when you glare."

"You're cute when you shut up," Mydei fires back, rolling his eyes when all it does is make Phainon laugh loudly.

"Such a lie! I'm always cute, thank you," Phainon replies, fluttering his eyelashes.

Mydei is clearly fighting back rolling his eyes again, but only holds out for a couple of seconds before doing it. "Alright, fine, you're always cute."

Phainon hums, his beaming grin dimming to something softer. He pulls Mydei's hand up to his mouth, pressing a kiss to his knuckles. His eyes glance up to meet Mydei's across the table, who looks partially shocked at the action. He goes pink, but doesn't pull away even as Phainon leaves another kiss there, then one more, then two, then three, until he's finally satisfied and places their hands back down onto the table.

"Thank you for giving us a chance," Phainon says quietly, looking down at the grain in the wooden table top. "I'm glad I'm here with you right now. And before, as well."

"Mhm," Mydei hums, and then he's tugging at Phainon's hand, bringing it up to his lips to kiss the backs of his knuckles. It's so gentle it tickles, and Phainon has to kick his feet out to try and keep calm. "You don't need to thank me. I'm still sorry for how everything went down."

"And you don't need to be sorry," Phainon replies, feeling warm around the collar as Mydei looks up at him, gaze half-lidded and molten hot. "It all worked out, didn't it?"

"Sure," Mydei says, gently putting their joined hands back down again.

"I suppose since it's our first date, I'm supposed to ask you a bunch of questions? Like, what's your favourite colour? Best animal in the kingdom?"

Mydei sighs and gives him a flat look. "You already know all that about me."

"I know! What else do we talk about, then? We see each other every second of the day, you already know everything."

Mydei shrugs, as helpful as ever. "Whatever you want."

Phainon groans, leaning forward over the table. Then, an idea sparks. He knows a quick sure way of getting a conversation going. "You secretly enjoyed watching my team play the other day, didn't you?"

"No way," Mydei shoots back immediately, arching an eyebrow. "I don't know what the appeal is."

"You say this as if we don't both chase balls across a field in our spare time," Phainon points out, chuckling.

Mydei's mouth curls into a slow grin. "Yeah, but in rugby, we actually have *contact*. There's danger, a thrill. A *real* sport."

"Oh, please," Phainon says, pretending to look scandalised. "You make it sound like football is all pretend. There's plenty of contact in it too!"

"Yeah, sure. If you call all that dramatic colliding and falling over *contact*—what would you actually call it? Tactical crying?"

Phainon laughs, the sound bubbling out of him like fizzy champagne. "It's called *flair*, actually. You wouldn't understand. It takes skill to fall gracefully."

"You mean to roll around in the dirt while pretending to have broken your ankle?" Mydei tuts, shaking his head, his braid swishing to and fro along

with the motion.

Phainon doesn't stop himself from leaning over and tugging playfully on Mydei's braid, like what a boy would do to a girl he likes by pulling on her pigtails. "Like I said, you wouldn't understand. It's part of the *plan*!"

They keep going, arguing back and forth until their food arrives, and even when they've finished it, they're still bantering.

"I will give you rugby lads one thing," Phainon begins, licking his spoon where his sticky toffee pudding had been. "I like the uniforms."

"Oh really?" Mydei says, eyes narrowing. "And just anyone in a rugby uniform will do for you?"

Phainon scoffs, scraping up the remnants of ice cream in his bowl. "I'm just a weak man, Mydei. The tight shirts and tiny shorts? *Yeah*."

Mydei truly glares at him then, sitting back in the booth as he crosses his arms over his chest. "Go ask one of them out on a date then."

"But none of them are *you*," Phainon replies, spoon clattering into his bowl. He licks his lips slowly, savouring the sickly sweet taste of the syrup and cake. Mydei's eyes zero in on the action, and he swallows. Phainon grins, "I

only care about seeing you in that cute little uniform." He hums, eyes raking over Mydei curiously. "Will you wear it for me one day?"

"HKS!" Mydei hisses through his teeth, kicking his shin under the table. He's bright red, which only means that Phainon has won.

"Hmm, yeah, I think I'd like that," Phainon's gaze darkens on Mydei. "I liked it enough when you wore it before for me."

"That— that wasn't *for you*, I just had rugby that day!"

Phainon smirks, "But you made all those cute little noises when I was sucking your ni—"

He's cut off by Mydei leaning over the table, plates clinking and glasses wobbling in his haste to place a hand straight over his mouth. "Finish that sentence and *die*, Deliverer."

Phainon cackles and licks Mydei's palm, already knowing it'll make him flinch back in disgust. He does, grimacing as he wipes his hand on one of the napkins provided for them. "You're disgusting."

Phainon sticks his tongue out, "You love me."

He expects Mydei to argue some more, but instead a helpless look comes over his face instead, softening his features—his eyebrows easing, his lips parting just slightly. Any sharpness melts away, replaced by something gentler.

"I do," Mydei starts. "I love you a lot."

"Sap," Phainon says because he's not sure what else to do when confronted with such a loving sight and words. It reminds him that this is completely real, his new reality and hopefully his only reality for a long, long time.

The ride home is quiet, but not the heavy kind that used to sit between them. It's soft—comfortable. The kind that settles in when everything that needed to be said already has been. They've been talking non-stop all night, so the silence feels welcomed this time. The tension in the taxi home from the cinema feels distant now, faded into something hazy and half-remembered, like one of the nightmares Phainon had before they found their way back together.

He leans his head against the window, watching the world streak past in ribbons of light. Streetlamps, headlights, and the faint glow of shop signs blur together in a daze, melting into the darkness beyond. Buildings flash by, people move like shadows at the edge of his vision, and it all feels dreamlike—gentle and far away.

Phainon blinks sleepily, his eyelids heavy after a busy night of talking and eating. His reflection in the glass is soft and unfocused. Beside him, Mydei's shoulder brushes his, warm and steady. And for the first time in what feels like forever, the silence isn't something to fill—it's something to rest in.

Yet, he can't help but feel *anticipation*; the kind where you know something good is going to come of it. Phainon is hyperaware of every tiny bit of contact from Mydei, from the way their shoulders bump against one another to the way the backs of their hands brush as they lay next to each other on the leather seat. It creates a fire burning low in his gut, one that only grows bigger with each touch. On the other hand, Mydei looks nonchalant, only glancing out of the corner of his eye to smirk at Phainon like he knows something he doesn't. Perhaps he does, and yet excitement bubbles up regardless, because Phainon has a feeling he's about to find out.

When they return home, it's perfectly normal. They both kick off their shoes, placing them next to each other before putting their keys in the pot on the side table. Then, they take off their jackets, putting them up on their pegs. It's weirdly domestic, especially as something charged is still running through Phainon's veins at the thought of what they're about to do.

"So, what now?" Phainon asks, nervous. He's never done this before, despite thinking about it a lot, especially within the past few weeks.

"So…" Mydei says, and approaches Phainon like a cat, hips swaying and a feline grin on his face. "You kiss me. Then, you take me to bed. Easy enough?"

"Have you— I mean, do you—"

"No, I haven't done this before," Mydei answers him without him having to ask the full thing.

"Neither have I," Phainon admits, playing with his fingers just to give his hands something to do. This is so *awkward*, he didn't expect it. He thought after their lovely meal together it'd be natural—where they'd just somehow fall into bed together, tangled up in a passionate kiss that solved all his worries. Maybe it just feels like that for him, though. Mydei seems confident enough. That is, until a shaking hand places itself over his chest where his heart is beating away frantically.

"I trust you," Mydei admits, voice low as he looks up at Phainon through his lashes. "But we don't have to do anything right now if you're not ready."

"I am ready! I promise, I just… I don't know what to do."

Mydei smiles, gentle and inviting. "I'll show you. I've been practising."

"Huh?" Phainon says dumbly, mind racing with all sorts of useless thoughts as he's dragged into Mydei's—*their*—bedroom. "Huh? What? Practising? How?"

"I'll tell you later," Mydei says and lies down on the bed, sitting up on his elbows. He crooks a finger at Phainon, "Come here."

Phainon gulps and clambers over Mydei, straddling him. "I thought I was supposed to kiss you first, then take you to bed?" He questions, albeit not seriously.

"Who cares," Mydei replies mindlessly, staring directly at Phainon's mouth like a zoning missile, and he loops his arms around Phainon's neck to drag him down, their lips connecting.

Phainon gasps at the first touch, his hips flexing immediately as he lowers himself even more, arms coming up beside Mydei's head to steady himself. He's already hard, achingly so, and probably has been since the taxi ride home when the silence became more and more charged as time passed.

"I want to take that damned waistcoat off you," Phainon murmurs, pressing kisses to the side of Mydei's mouth before licking into it, their tongues entwining as the taste of wine and something sweet lingers.

"You can," Mydei pants. "Take everything off me."

"Fuck, Mydei—" Phainon curses, sitting back up rather than lying down on top of Mydei. His thighs bulge in his trousers, and if he wasn't so sure on getting Mydei naked he might be scared of them ripping. Mydei's hands come up to his thighs, rubbing them up and down, kneading as Phainon

bites down on his lip, hands shaking as he painstakingly undoes the buttons on the waistcoat.

"Your *legs*," Mydei says, nails digging in as he speaks. "So distracting."

Mydei sits up when Phainon's finished unbuttoning his waistcoat, practically tearing out of it before he chucks it across the room. "Mydei!" Phainon exclaims.

"Be quiet," Mydei replies, focusing his attention on getting his shirt off next. "Take your shirt off, too."

Phainon nods, breathing in deeply before he passes out. He's watched Mydei undress before, but not when they're both hard in their trousers and he's so turned on he fears he might *die*. He wants Mydei so badly, so much, that he's ready for anything as they take their shirts off, both throwing them away for later them to worry about.

Phainon sighs, leaning down again so their chests brush, pushing their pecs together. He shivers, feeling the scrape of Mydei's hard nipples against his own. He feels so *sensitive*, like any more and he'll come in his stupid trousers right then and there.

Mydei doesn't seem to have that worry, his eyes misty and hazed over, lips parted as he breathes through his mouth. It's incredibly erotic just listening to him pant like that when they've barely done anything, but Mydei is flushed from the roots of his hair, down his face, and down, down, down to

his heaving chest. Phainon moves his hands to grasp at Mydei's pecs, squeezing them until soft flesh pools between his fingers. They both moan, breathy and gasping, into each other's mouths.

"Get on with it," Mydei demands, hips moving against his, up and down, left and right, like he can't quite decide which way to go to ease the ache between his legs.

"Let me take my time with you, Mydeimos," Phainon pleads, kissing his cheek, his temple, his lips and the tip of his nose. "Let me cherish you."

Mydei scoffs, but it's cut off with a whine as Phainon moves downwards, licking over his Adam's apple before softly scraping his teeth over it. "Fine!" Mydei says. "Fine, fine, fine—"

Phainon grins into Mydei's skin, lavishing it with bite marks for as far as he can reach in this position. Later, he's sure he'll leave more across Mydei's entire body, even down to his ankles. He loses himself in pressing long, open-mouthed kisses to Mydei's chest, tongue scraping over his nipples until Mydei is arching into him, hands fisted in the quilt above his head.

"Phainon, please— *ah*, *ah*!" Mydei shudders into him, wriggling.

"Too much?" Phainon asks, looking up through his lashes to see Mydei watching him, head bent forward at an awkward angle.

"Too *little*," Mydei replies, head flopping down onto the bed. "I want you to fuck me, do I need to say it again? Should I beg, Deliverer?"

Phainon hums, working his teeth over the tight nub of Mydei's nipple until he's almost *howling*, hands now in Phainon's hair, threading through the strands to clamp down on. "You can beg if you want, Mydei."

"*You*—" Mydei cuts himself off with a moan as Phainon flattens his tongue against his chest, licking a strip up to his collarbone. "Please." Is all he says, quiet and fragile, and the fire in Phainon's belly roars to life.

Phainon sits back on his haunches and looks down at Mydei, preening at what he's left behind. Mydei's chest is heaving, his nipples red and sore as a litany of marks create a constellation across his skin, some blending in with his crimson tattoos.

"Let's get you out of your trousers," Phainon says gently, shuffling off the bed so he can help Mydei undo his fly, shimmying them down over his hips, thighs, and calves until they're hanging onto the tips of his toes. Mydei whines, hips bucking into the air as he's almost freed.

Phainon's mouth simultaneously dries up and fills with saliva at Mydei on the bed, writhing around in nothing but a pair of almost translucent white briefs. The front of them are completely soaked through, his hard cock a solid outline in them. Phainon trails a finger down his length, heat radiating off of it so much that it makes his palms clammy.

"Mydei, you're so—" Phainon bites down on his lip when that little touch is enough to make Mydei *whine*.

Mydei doesn't stay still, lifting his hips as he grabs onto his waistband and tugs his briefs down, freeing his cock. It hits his abdomen wetly, and it's then that Phainon can truly see how desperate he is. Mydei's cock is swollen, so red it's almost purple, the tip beading with pre-cum as his shaft glistens in the low light.

Phainon grabs his cock through his trousers, shuddering at his grip as he tries not to come. It's too easy when he's so attracted to the man before him, lying down and craving for more. And who is Phainon to deny that? He rids himself of his own trousers and underwear, cock bobbing as he stands at the foot of the bed naked. The air is cool around him, goosebumps rippling across his arms and the hairs on the back of his neck stand up.

Mydei looks like a feast laid before him, arms above his head as he's completely naked, all on show for Phainon to look at. His red tattoos reach further than he ever thought before, swirling and curling around the ridges of his straining muscles. He's beautiful, stunning, gorgeous and everything else all rolled into one. His hair is splayed across the bedding like golden silk, his eyes even more shiny than ever, and his skin is so pink and pretty. Phainon freezes, locking up as he's suddenly at a loss of what to do.

"Tell me what to do," He says, voice cracking. He leans over Mydei, knees coming up beside his waist. "I wanna make you feel good, Mydei. I wanna see you come for me. Tell me— tell me how to do that."

"Kiss me," Mydei says. "Kiss me like we've practised."

"We've had plenty of that, haven't we?" Phainon huffs a laugh, leaning down to kiss Mydei long and hard. He lowers himself down slowly, plastering their entire bodies together as he wraps his arms around Mydei's shoulders, bringing him in even closer. Their cocks nudge against one another, but he's too busy kissing Mydei to pay attention to that right now.

He kisses him softly, sweetly at first. Chaste and delicate, just like how their first kiss went. It's not clumsy, nor awkward, because they *know* each other now. Like this, entwined, arms wrapped around each other as they kiss each other breathless. It feels so good, being here with him, naked and hip to hip, chest to chest, stripped down to his bare bones as Mydei carves a place for himself inside of his heart, fitting in like he always has done.

"I love you," Phainon says when he pulls back for air, nuzzling into Mydei's cheek. "Let me make you feel good, please?"

Mydei nods, "Get the lube from the drawer."

Phainon obeys, leaning over Mydei and opening the bedside table's drawer. There's a few things in there, but the small, blue bottle of lube is hard to miss. He grabs it, and his eyes widen when he realises how light it feels.

"Been busy?" He asks, eyebrows waggling cheekily.

"I told you—" Mydei smirks, eyes narrowing as his lips curl upwards. "I've been practising myself."

"Like—" Phainon swallows, images rushing through his head. "Like…"

"Hmph," Mydei grabs the bottle from Phainon and puts it down next to them on the bed. "I can see your brain going into overdrive from here."

"Because—!" Phainon splutters, covering his face with his hands shyly. He cracks open his fingers to look through them at Mydei, his cheeks pulsing with how red hot they are. "You've been… practising. On your own. With… your fingers?"

"I had to, considering how fucking big you are." Mydei almost spits out, glaring down at Phainon's cock which is still rock hard, curved up against his belly.

It's hard not to feel a sliver of confidence hearing that, so Phainon laughs weakly. "Yeah? Had to teach yourself how to take my cock?" Phainon asks, not caring how filthy the words are leaving his lips as he reddens even further just hearing himself say it. He trails the backs of his fingers over Mydei's cock, teasing and feather-light.

It seems to have an effect on Mydei, his hips jolting, cock bobbing, throat clicking with a swallow. "Every time I had a shower, I would—" He bites down on his lip, then soothes his tongue over it. "Practise. For you. Thinking of you."

"For how long?" Phainon questions hotly, stomach churning with blazing arousal at the thought of Mydei doing all that for *him* as he grabs the bottle of lube, squeezing a dollop onto his fingers. It's thick and silky, but cold as he works it into his skin, warming it up.

"Since—" Mydei stares at him, legs parting slowly as they watch each other, Phainon's hand coming up to cup Mydei's balls and the side of his cock. "Since… we…" Mydei clears his throat.

"I'm listening," Phainon encourages, hands beginning to shake as Mydei spreads his legs even further, hiking them up around his inner elbows to give Phainon the full view.

And what a view it is.

Mydei's hole twitches, his arms shaking as he holds his legs up, anticipation thick in the air that he almost has to chew it to breathe it down. Mydei is so *red*, from the blush staining his skin to his tattoos, it's all over him, sprawling and stunning. Phainon presses the tip of his finger against Mydei's rim, and he's burning hot here, but he keeps pushing, finger sliding in smoothly with the help of the lube until he's knuckle deep.

"— Since we met," Mydei finishes, and it takes a moment for Phainon to remember what he was talking about. When he does, his mouth falls open, eyes wide and round as he stares down at his boyfriend.

"You've wanted me for that long?" Phainon asks incredulously. "I thought…"

"I've *always* wanted you," Mydei says, voice strained as Phainon crooks his finger, clearly trying to find his prostate. "Ever since we met. Even when I first saw you in those god awful yellow and purple shorts."

"I still have those," Phainon taps over the slight bump, watching as Mydei's back arches. He feels *mean*, a little cruel, but it's all worth it for the way Mydei watches him through a lidded gaze, his eyes luminous and glowing so brightly, dewy and wet, lips parted. "Maybe I should wear them again? Would that get you going?"

"Fuck no," Mydei groans, hips bucking, cock twitching, leaking all over his stomach as it lies there untouched.

Phainon huffs a laugh. "Okay?" He asks, chewing on his bottom lip. He smooths a hand up Mydei's thigh, feeling it tremble beneath his palm. It's strangely endearing.

"Mhm," Mydei hums, nodding. Then, he sucks a deep breath in as Phainon curls his finger, eventually slotting in another one next to it. He scissors the digits, open and shut, stretching as much as he can without trying to hurt Mydei. It's delicate work, he realises, but he wants to make it feel *good*. So he asks: "Does it feel good?"

"Yeah," Mydei replies, "Feels—" He shivers. "Real good. Put… put another in, I'm ready, I've— I got up to four, on my own, but I don't need—"

"*Fuck*, Mydei, you can't just… say things like that," Phainon leans over and kisses Mydei hard, his wrist aching from the new position. He ignores it, wanting to kiss him more as he presses in another finger, three now stretching him out. He feels burning hot inside, silky and decadent, and Phainon shudders at the thought of fitting his cock in there soon. "You think you'd be okay right now?"

Mydei nods enthusiastically, his face all scrunched up as if he's stuck between *pain* and *pleasure* all at once. He gasps when Phainon widens his fingers, the lube making slick, lewd noises as he pushes them in and out until his wrist feels like it's going to go numb.

"I'm ready! Phainon, please— I can take you, I promise—" Mydei babbles, hands coming up to his hair, practically scrunching the strands up as he tugs at it.

Phainon kisses Mydei, hard and fast, a wet smacking of their lips as he pulls away, gently withdrawing his fingers from inside. He kneels on the bed, shifting them upwards until Mydei's head is cushioned safely on his pillows. He wants him to be comfortable, wants to do a good job, wants Mydei to feel safe and protected as much as he can. Phainon grabs the lube for the last time, slathering his cock in it before grabbing the base and tapping the tip against Mydei's loose hole.

It'd be so easy to slide in there in one go, but when Mydei nods at him for permission, he finds himself wanting to take it slow. Phainon pushes his hips forward, tip catching before it slowly, *slowly* eases in. They both moan at the same time, the sound echoing off the walls. Mydei's back curls upwards gradually, hips lifting, and Phainon has to grab a hold of his waist so he doesn't pull off completely. He's sweating, he realises, droplets sliding down his temple and pooling in the small of his back. His hands span across Mydei's stomach and around his back, and his skin is just as damp.

Phainon can't help but let out a breathless laugh, elation filling his veins. "You feel so *good*, Mydei." As he speaks, another inch slides in, and another laugh escapes him as disbelief overcomes him. He's *inside* Mydei, just like he never dared to dream.

Mydei feels incredible, tight and hot and so, so good, so, so addicting, and Phainon wonders how he ever lived without this. His cock thrums, having a whole heartbeat of its own, and as he eases himself the rest of the way, Mydei taking him so well, easily, *eagerly*, he knows he'll never stop thinking about this moment. Once he's seated all the way, pelvis pressed up against Mydei's ass, he takes the first full breath he's had in a long time. He feels weightless, like he's floating, even as Mydei clamps down around his cock, dragging him forcefully back down to earth.

Mydei whines, high and pitchy, and Phainon needs to kiss that sound right from his lips. He bends over, cock shifting even further deeper, and they both gasp, eyelashes fluttering and mouths gaping as pleasure overtakes them. Phainon doesn't waste another second, licking straight into Mydei's mouth, tasting him again and again, until there's nothing left but the sound of their harsh breaths and the wet slip of their lips against each other.

"*Move*," Mydei grits out through his teeth, breathing hotly into Phainon's mouth as he does so. Phainon nods, hair tickling against Mydei's forehead, and gently pulls his hips back, his cock dragging deliciously against Mydei's insides.

"Gods, Mydei—" Phainon gasps, fucking straight back into him without warning. Mydei yelps, eyes going round, drool sliding down the side of his cheek as he moans. "You feel so fucking *tight*."

Phainon licks up his cheek, only adding more mess, but he doesn't care, not when Mydei cries out in pleasure as his hips start to move properly—in and out, harshly, carefully, until he's set up a rhythm that fucks Mydei higher up into the bed, his hands scrambling for purchase on the headboard to stop himself from moving any further.

Phainon is everywhere; in him, on him, inside of him, outside of him, licking and kissing and nipping and tasting everything he can reach. Mydei is *gone*, unable to form words anymore, just babbling nonsense into his ears as Phainon kisses his ears, biting his lobe before sucking it into his mouth. That makes Mydei whimper, pathetic and small, all his earlier bravado fucked out of him.

He can't help but feel proud at that, Mydei reduced to pieces, to scattered atoms throughout, pleasure filling in the cracks as he carries on until the bed is squeaking, headboard thumping against the wall. Phainon knows the neighbours won't be happy, but he doesn't care, and as soon as that thought arises it's gone again, lost in Mydei's wanting and desperate mouth as he kisses him through it.

"Phainon—" Mydei sighs, so dreamily, so happily, like he's getting everything he's ever wanted. Phainon's stomach lurches, his thrusts maddening and breaking the pace, skin slapping until they're red and almost bruised.

"Mydei—" Phainon replies, "*My* Mydei, my Mydeimos—"

"Yours," Mydei whispers, hands grasping at Phainon's cheeks to centre him again. Their eyes lock, wet and hazy, glowing, "I love you."

And *gods* if Phainon will never get tired of hearing Mydei say that to him. He says it like he means it with all his heart each time, full and overwhelming, brimming to the max, and he can't help it when he suddenly feels like he's going to cry. He sniffles, bottom lip wobbling, and then he's choking on sobs.

"I love you so much, Mydei," Phainon cries, nuzzling into Mydei's temple, kissing there and sniffing him just so he can smell the familiar cologne to help him breathe.

"Hey, hey, Phainon," Mydei says, gently encouraging Phainon to show his face to him again. He stops thrusting, even when his cock throbs painfully, and Mydei tightens around him again so much so that his hips kick up instinctively. "Look at me."

"Baby," Phainon whimpers, tears streaming down his face at this point, overwhelmed and overwrought. "My sweetheart. My darling," He doesn't

even know what he's saying anymore—just that he wants to call Mydei all the sweet pet names he can think of.

"I'm your baby, your sweetheart, your darling," Mydei repeats, swiping away Phainon's tears with his thumbs. He sounds so *soft*, so tender, that it almost shocks Phainon.

He's seen a lot of different sides to Mydei since they became official—but nothing quite like this. Pliant, sweet, gentle Mydei, whose hair fans around him like a golden halo, skin flushed and sticky with sweat and pre-cum, watching him like he's the stars in the sky and the sun and the moon all wrapped up into one. He's looking at him like he's counting every eyelash, every freckle, every pore that he can see. Phainon feels and feels and feels, too much, so much, that he can't help but let out a broken sob again.

Mydei laughs, "You're more of a baby than I am, a cry baby."

Phainon huffs a laugh back, wet and throaty, and begins to move again. He's not fucking, not anymore, he's… as much as it sounds cringey to him, he feels like he's *making love*. He grinds his hips down, listening to Mydei mewl and gasp and whine and whimper at his movements, pressing himself so close that each thrust rubs Mydei's cock against his belly. It's the stimulation he needed, clearly, and Mydei is meeting each thrust with a rocking of his waist, wrapping his legs around Phainon's hips as his hands wind around his neck.

They're completely entwined, and Phainon isn't sure where he starts and Mydei ends, but as his orgasm approaches quicker and quicker, catching up

on him like a scare he wasn't ready for, his thrusts become more precise, harsher and harder, until Mydei is leaving scratch marks on his back and his tears are completely dry.

"Phainon, I—"

"I'm close," Phainon says, finishing Mydei's sentence for him. It's true, something behind his navel *tugs*, his stomach bubbling and spiralling, his muscles clenching and relaxing as he works into Mydei, cock twitching and throbbing as he gets closer and closer.

Phainon lifts up from Mydei a fraction, just enough to wedge a hand between them so he can grasp it around Mydei's cock. He's even wetter than before, hot steel sheathed in silk, and all it takes is one drag of his fist and then Mydei's back is arching, eyes wide and unseeing, mouth gaping open as he *comes*, spurting all over Phainon's hand and his stomach, some even reaching his chest. Phainon almost purrs, chest rumbling with delight as he laps up the come he can reach, sucking biting marks in their place. Its salty tang zips along his tongue.

Phainon isn't far behind, Mydei's hole becoming impossibly tight and lax as he comes, his muscles clenching and relaxing as his body convulses, moans broken up by pitchy whimpers until Phainon is coming alongside, cock pulsating. He shivers, shudders, leaning into Mydei as close as he can, feeling the heat and smear of his come and body against him.

"Fill me up," Mydei says, and Phainon double takes so hard he almost comes again from those words alone. "*Fuck*, yes, just like that—"

"Okay, baby, I will," Phainon croons, and feels more than hears Mydei huffing a breathless laugh, a broad smile stretched across his face as he tremors, eyelashes fluttering and eyes rolling back before coming back into focus as Phainon works him through their orgasms.

Moments pass and they're left boneless against one another, breathing hard and quivering as aftershocks go through them. Phainon sighs happily, nosing at Mydei's jawline, littering small and quick kisses there to bring them back down to earth. It works, as Mydei goes from shivering to still, but his arms are still wrapped tightly around Phainon like he might disappear at any moment.

"Kiss me properly," Mydei demands, pouting slightly. Phainon smiles into his jaw, chuckling as he pops his head up higher and places a smacking, quick kiss against Mydei's lips. It makes them both grin, and Mydei is pursing his lips for more.

And who is Phainon to deny him?

They eventually clean up, washing each other in the shower. Phainon might get a little *too* handsy, promising Mydei he can help get the cum out of him if he stands still. Mydei, for some stupid reason, goes along with it, and Phainon ends up on his knees in the shower cubicle, fingers inside Mydei and cock in his mouth, swallowing him down with little finesse but *a lot* of enthusiasm. They end up stumbling out of the shower later on, skin pruned,

giggling and laughing to themselves, trading soft kisses as they dry each other with towels. It's perfect, it's intimate and delicate and Phainon's heart feels three times too big for his chest. He feels like he's *glowing*, and as he catches himself in the mirror, he can see that much is true.

Once they're dry, they get dressed in loose pyjamas. Phainon doesn't care if his mismatching yellow and purple combo makes Mydei physically recoil, he likes it and it's *comfortable*, especially since his skin still feels too sensitive, his bones too big for his body after everything that's happened tonight.

Phainon clambers into Mydei's—no, *their* bed—he still needs to get used go that—and snuggles into him immediately, wrapping around him like an octopus with four limbs. Mydei doesn't seem to mind, patting him on the head like a puppy. Phainon grins, unable to help the joy radiating from within, and he's pretty sure he falls asleep still smiling.

"Come on, sleepyhead. Time to wake up."

Phainon blinks against the light flooding the room—bright and merciless, too sharp for someone who's just woken up. It takes a few sluggish blinks and a deep sigh before the world stops swimming. The duvet is soft and warm against his skin, but not as warm as he usually feels when Mydei is curled up beside him.

That's when he realises something's off—Mydei isn't beside him at all. In fact, he's standing at the foot of it, hands on hips, eyebrows raised in quiet amusement. His hair's still mussed from sleep, his braid leaving indentations in his hair from being taken out last night and practically left to air dry. The early light slants across his face just enough to make him look unfairly good at whatever hour it is right now.

Phainon blinks up at him, momentarily too stunned to speak. "Morning," He croaks, voice rough with sleep.

"Afternoon," Mydei corrects, tilting his head, that faint smirk tugging at his lips. "Planning to get up any time soon?"

Phainon groans and flops back into the pillows, half hiding his face from the sun and from Mydei, which to him, are practically one in the same. "Not if you're going to stand there looking like that."

Mydei laughs—low, warm and fond—and Phainon can't help but smile into the sheets, his cheeks aching with it, heart thrumming a little too fast already. Then, he pounces, leaping half out of bed to grab Mydei and manhandle him back inside the duvet.

"Phainon!" Mydei splutters, but he's laughing, golden and bright, and Phainon's heart swells with it as he joins him, peppering kisses everywhere and anywhere he can get to. Which is mostly on Mydei's face, leaving faint traces of smeared saliva behind that dries as quickly as it came. "Stop slobbering all over me!"

"No way," Phainon says, "It's my way of saying I love you."

"I love you more," Mydei argues, trying to get out of Phainon's grip so he can stand up again. "Now get your ass out of bed, I'm about to start lunch since you slept in so late."

"I was up all night pleasing my boyfriend," Phainon replies, winking salaciously at Mydei. "Doesn't that count for anything?"

"Absolutely not," Mydei retorts, trying to move again but Phainon pulls him down, hugging him tightly.

"By the way, I love you more," Phainon says.

"No way," Mydei replies, face creasing, looking like an angry kitten. "I love *you* more."

"Hah!" Phainon scoffs, and then they're shouting at each other, pushing and shoving until Mydei is on top of him, straddling his thighs, hands on his shoulders, kissing and kissing and *kissing*, putting all their good practise to use.

Chapter End Notes

> THE END!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!! 😭😭😭😭😭 gods. and they live happily ever after, adopt a bunch of cute kitties and get married!

next time on luffy's ao3... hopefully pool boy phainon will manifest lol

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